

Tim Clothier



Advanced Illusion Projects

Tim Clothier - Advanced Illusion Projects

Written and illustrated by Tim Clothier

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Tim Clothier - Illusion Projects
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This book is dedicated to my wife Holly.
She is the love of my life and my best friend.
Being with her is the greatest part of every day.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This book, and the work I do today would not be possible without the following people.
Thank you all of you for your encouragement .

Holly Clothier

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Philip and Francis Clothier

Bob, Shelly and Odie North (of Splashes Creative Services)

Dirk Arthur

Neil Roberts

Richard Cadell

Don Wayne

Willie Kennedy (of William Kennedy Magic Effects)

The Great Biscotti

Alex and Laura Parkinson

Karl and Jennifer Seymour

David Wood

June and John Lamb

FOREWORD By Dirk Arthur

I've had the pleasure to know Tim Clothier since he was two years old and performing incredible front and back palms with poker size cards, and doing an amazing eight billiard ball production, without using a shell!

Okay, well not really.

I have known Tim longer than anyone in our industry here in the US because his first job when arriving stateside was to work with me as my illusion technician and consultant. Believe it or not, he also worked as my a wild animal trainer (look for Tim working with the cats on my Animal Planet special, "Big Cat Magic"). Gratefully, I'm happy to report we are all still alive and well so I guess he did pretty good with my tigers and leopards. By the time you get through this book you'll know he also did great with the illusions. This is why I am excited and honored he has asked me to write this introduction to his terrific new book.

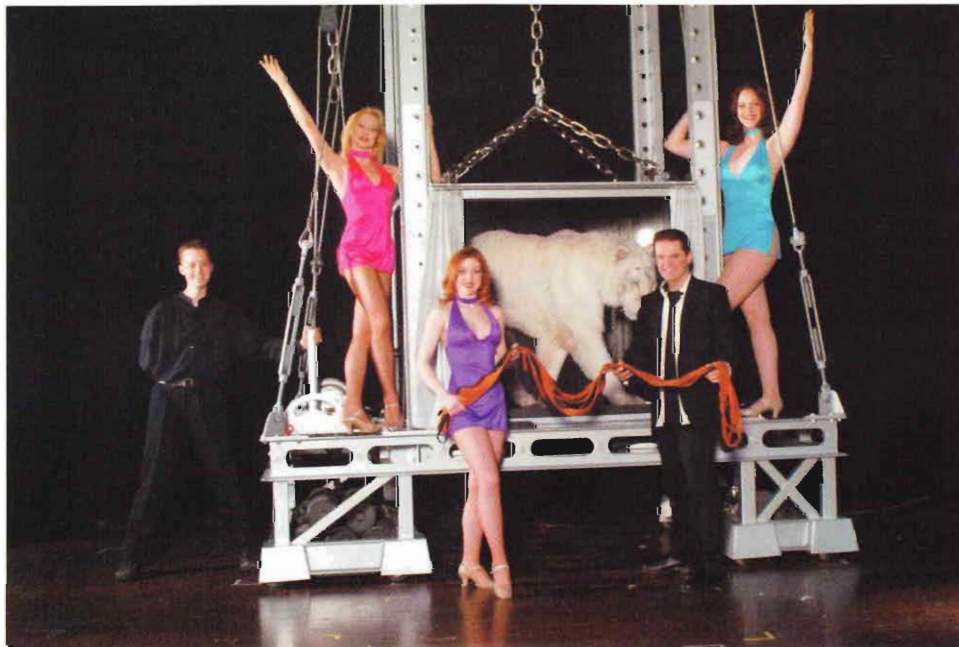
You are about to learn some amazing new original illusions which are not only extremely well thought out, but every single detail of construction is being given to you. Tim has chosen to explain how the top professional builders would build these effects. You can build them yourself to exacting professionalism or have an experienced builder construct them to Tim's specifications.

I feel these illusions are all very commercial and entertaining to today's audiences and have a fresh feel to them. I know you will have as much fun as I've had reading about them and maybe even performing them in your own show. I am personally fond of "Trapdoor" because of it's interesting plot and practicality, and the "R/C Car Vanish" is intriguing and will make an excellent 'in one' piece. By the way, if you get the chance to work with Tim on any of this material, you'll find him incredibly helpful and I'm sure he'll do his best to give you some great magic.

And, so, in closing, I'd like to wish you good luck with the book and the illusions.

Sincerely,

Dirk Arthur



Dirk Arthur with the 'Tiger Stripes' illusion
(2002 'Dirk Arthur- New Art of Magic' Las Vegas show).
Tim is on the left operating the illusion. Tim's wife Holly is far right in blue.
Snowmagic the tiger is in the box!

4. Tim Clothier - Advanced Illusion Projects

I have been lucky enough to have been involved in almost every aspect of stage illusion performances short of actually putting on a g-string and fishnets to do the assistant thing (despite those rumors). I have worked as a performer, stage manager, consultant, designer and builder - and loved every minute of it.

I grew up in a small town called Taunton in the southwest of England but I now live and work in Las Vegas. For five years I had my own small illusion show that toured the English seaside resorts, a very different situation for performing illusions compared to theaters and Vegas showrooms. I still remember bringing props in through corridors flooded in sewage and doing a show for an audience of six, but these were important lessons and experiences. I believe in the magic industry, experience is vital. I see far too many magicians today who think they can enter the business at a far higher level by buying expensive illusions and putting a show together when they have little or no actual on stage experience. It always shows.

For four years I worked as Assistant Stage Manager for the IBM British ring convention held once a year. For one week I'd work non-stop with Stage Manager Neil Roberts to put acts from around the world on stage in a smooth running show. With different shows each day, plus the competition, it was always a busy week. During these shows I had the privilege to see how a huge variety of magicians and illusionists handled a 'one nighter'.

I came out to Las Vegas as a tourist to see all the magic shows and to meet with some of the Illusionists performing there to discuss some original illusion ideas I had. During a breakfast with Dirk Arthur (who was the featured performer in 'Jubilee' at that time) we were talking about a new tiger illusion ('Tiger Stripes') he wanted to do. By the time I left Vegas I had begun working the designs for this illusion for Dirk. The new illusion was built (by William Kennedy) and Dirk needed someone to help integrate the illusion into an already complicated show. So, I took the job and moved to Vegas. I worked as Dirk's Illusion Director for four years. During that time I set up and worked the show at the Silverton Hotel, Animal Planet TV special, Plaza Hotel and 'Splash' at the Riviera. I also worked as illusion designer and consultant for Dirk, along with Don Wayne - who is truly an inspiration to work with.

I now work as a designer and builder of illusions for Splashes Creative Services in Las Vegas. Bob and Shelly North, who own Splashes, are two of the nicest people I know. During my time building illusions for Splashes, I've been lucky enough to work on projects for Magicians including David Copperfield, Criss Angel, Lance Burton, Penn and Teller, Rick Thomas, Dirk Arthur, Steve Wyrick, Tim Kone and Steve Wheeler. I'm not saying this because I work there, but if you are thinking of building one of the illusions in the book - consider taking your project to Splashes, I'll probably end up building it for you.

I have been designing illusions for many years and still have the ideas notebook from when I was eight years old. One of the biggest problems I find with new illusion ideas is explaining the illusion to a Magician. It wasn't until recently that I finally have a graphics program sufficient to generate full 3d views and story boards to explain my ideas. That is why I decided it was time to put this book together. I have tried to present props and ideas that are really designed - in that I have actually designed how it would be built and researched the necessary mechanics to make the prop work. Each of the illusions in the book contains drawings of all parts of the build process - I have done my best to take each design as far as I can on paper. These are the drawings I would want to build these props from. I believe that as an *Illusion Designer* this is my job.

I have noticed an interesting contradiction that Illusionists often show. They come to me and say, '*I want a brand new illusion that no one else is doing*' and then, almost in the same breath, '*I want to see the prop actually performed though*'. Now, I'm sure those of you paying attention will have noticed this is not possible. I know illusions are expensive and it's nerve wracking parting with money on an illusion that you have never seen before. However, if you want to stay original and ahead of the game, you have to make that first step - even a small one. Not all original illusions cost tens of thousands.

INTRODUCTION By Tim Clothier

On the subject of what has been built and what hasn't - I am not into lying or writing ambiguous statements about my work. So for the record - All the mock-ups have been built; Headz Up has been built by Splashes Creative Services; I'm in the process of building the R/C Car vanish (if I get it done before this goes to print I'll put it on the photos page) and I built the first Furnace illusion with my Dad when I was eighteen years old.

It is an unfortunate fact of our business that there are people who seem to think new ideas are worthless unless they can make money by stealing them for their own profit and gain. I am presenting new illusion ideas and designs to you at a price that I think is most fair. As owner of the book you may build (or have built for you) one of each illusion.

I also want to address the issue of photocopying. I have seen far too many illusion books photocopied. I assume the owner of the photocopy book was just too cheap to buy the book, yet has enough money to build the props from it. To me, this is just plain rude. I have not priced this book at \$1,000 or only released 100 copies - I want people to be able to buy this book and see my work. This book (and the rights to the illusions in it) cost little more than a good set of casters for any of the illusions described. So please don't photocopy the book - photocopies don't include rights. And if your casters cost a lot less than this book - consider buying better casters. You'll thank me for it in the long run!

Some of the illusions described in this book have their roots in earlier illusions. I have tried to reference my inspirations as much as possible. All the illusions in the book are, to my knowledge, original to me. If you have invented illusions similar to any of mine then 'great minds think alike!'. I did not knowingly take anyone else's original ideas.

As much as this book deals with new illusions for the future, we must never forget the great illusions of the past. I would have given anything to witness the first performance of 'Sawing in Half' or have seen the original 'Peppers Ghost'. Remember, there was a time when mirrors had never been used in magic and early mirror tricks were being invented. What a wonderful era of invention that must have been. Those early illusions have become such a base for everything designed today. The true genius was of those Magicians of the past who were not afraid to stick their neck out and try an original illusion idea. We are standing on the shoulders of giants - don't fall off.

Tim Clothier.

September 2005.

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1.



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PHOTOGRAPHS

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7.



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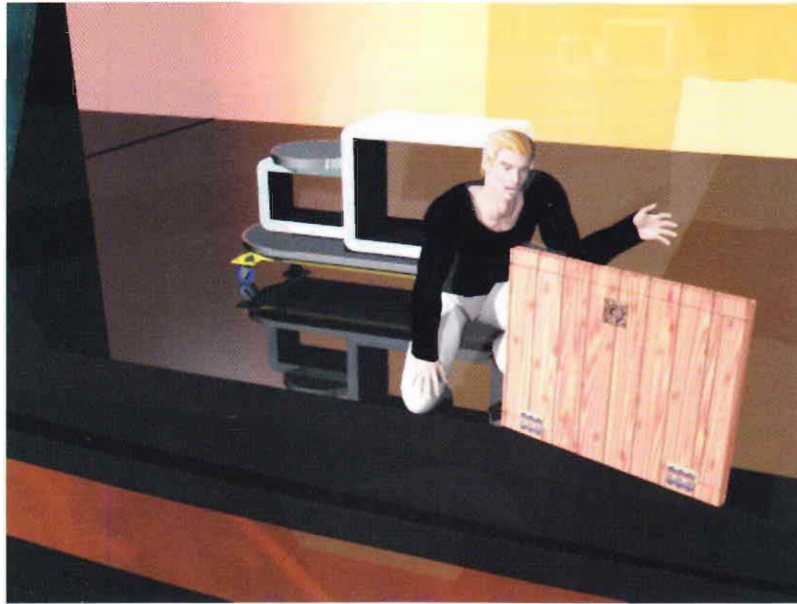
PHOTOGRAPHS

1. This is me doing the old 'Water Tank Escape' thing.
2. Me with Dirk Arthur and Dirk's 'Appearing Train' illusion. I worked on the original version of the Train with Dirk, Don Wayne and Willie Kennedy.
3. First 'Headz Up' during construction at Splashes Creative Services in Las Vegas.
4. Mock up of load space and CD player for Compact Deception. My wife Holly is actually inside, see the plans later in the book. CeCe the cat not included!
5. Holly gets cut into three in the Headz Up illusion.
6. Working on the first R/C Car vanish prop at Splashes Creative Services.
7. The first 'Furnace' illusion - this one was made in all steel and was quite heavy!
8. Completed R/C Car Vanish props.

10. Tim Clothier - Advanced Illusion Projects

TRAPDOOR

TRAPDOOR

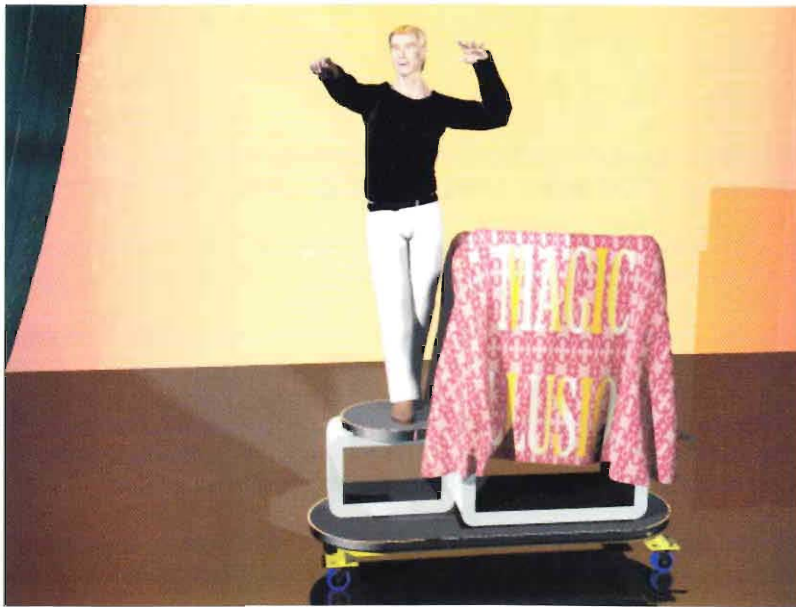


Most people think magic is done with 'Trapdoors'. The Magician explains this is not true anymore, however Magicians of the past had trapdoors. The Magician displays an old trapdoor he had rescued from an old Magician's theater that was being demolished. The Magician tells that audience things didn't come through the trapdoor, they were magically inside the trapdoor.

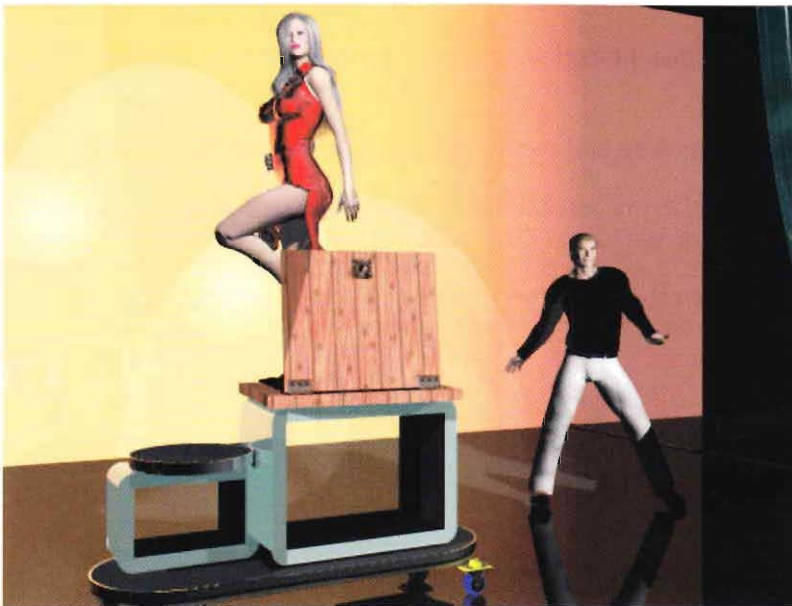


The Magician places the door on top of a modern looking table. Opening the trapdoor, the Magician first removes a poster from the old Magician's show. Next a full sized ladder is removed from the trapdoor. The audience still has a clear view below the table as the props are apparently pulled out of nowhere.

TRAPDOOR



Now the Magician pulls out an old ragged curtain from the old Magician's theater. Holding the curtain up, he explains that it used to magically display the Magician's name on the curtain. With a shake of the curtain the Magician's name magically appears. The Magician drapes the curtain over the trapdoor.



Finally, a shape begins to emerge from the trapdoor under the cloth. The Magician pulls away the cloth to reveal the assistant climbing out of the trapdoor having appeared from nowhere.

TRAPDOOR

METHOD

The assistant is hidden in the box/stool and table affair the trapdoor sits on. The trapdoor itself is a thin hollow box that contains the initial production items - the poster, the ladder and the curtain.

The poster is a printed vinyl banner that pleats up into the trapdoor. Rods in the top and bottom of the poster expand apart as it comes out because they are attached to either end of an appearing cane.

The ladder is Wayne Roger's Appearing Ladder. Based on the appearing pole, these are actually very convincing and a great idea.

The curtain is simply folded into the hollow box of the trapdoor. The curtain works like the old 'Goodnight Banner' effect (you may know it as another name). The material has a simple middle flap that starts up showing a blank, ragged curtain, then drops and flaps over to reveal the writing.

The assistant is lying in the base of the prop with her thighs in the upright space created between the two boxes (table and small box). Her shins and feet are in the top of the small white box and disc platform on top of it.

In performance the girl begins hidden in the table prop. The Magician displays the trapdoor and places it on the table. The Magician opens the door and produces the poster, then ladder, then curtain.

The Magician is standing on the smaller white box at this point. When the curtain is produced it is held out in front of the table, covering the table opening from view.

During the time the Magician is talking about the name on the curtain and producing the writing, the assistant climbs out of the base and through the table top, hiding behind the trapdoor.

At this point the Magician drapes the curtain over the trapdoor and the assistant. The audience can now see through the table again.

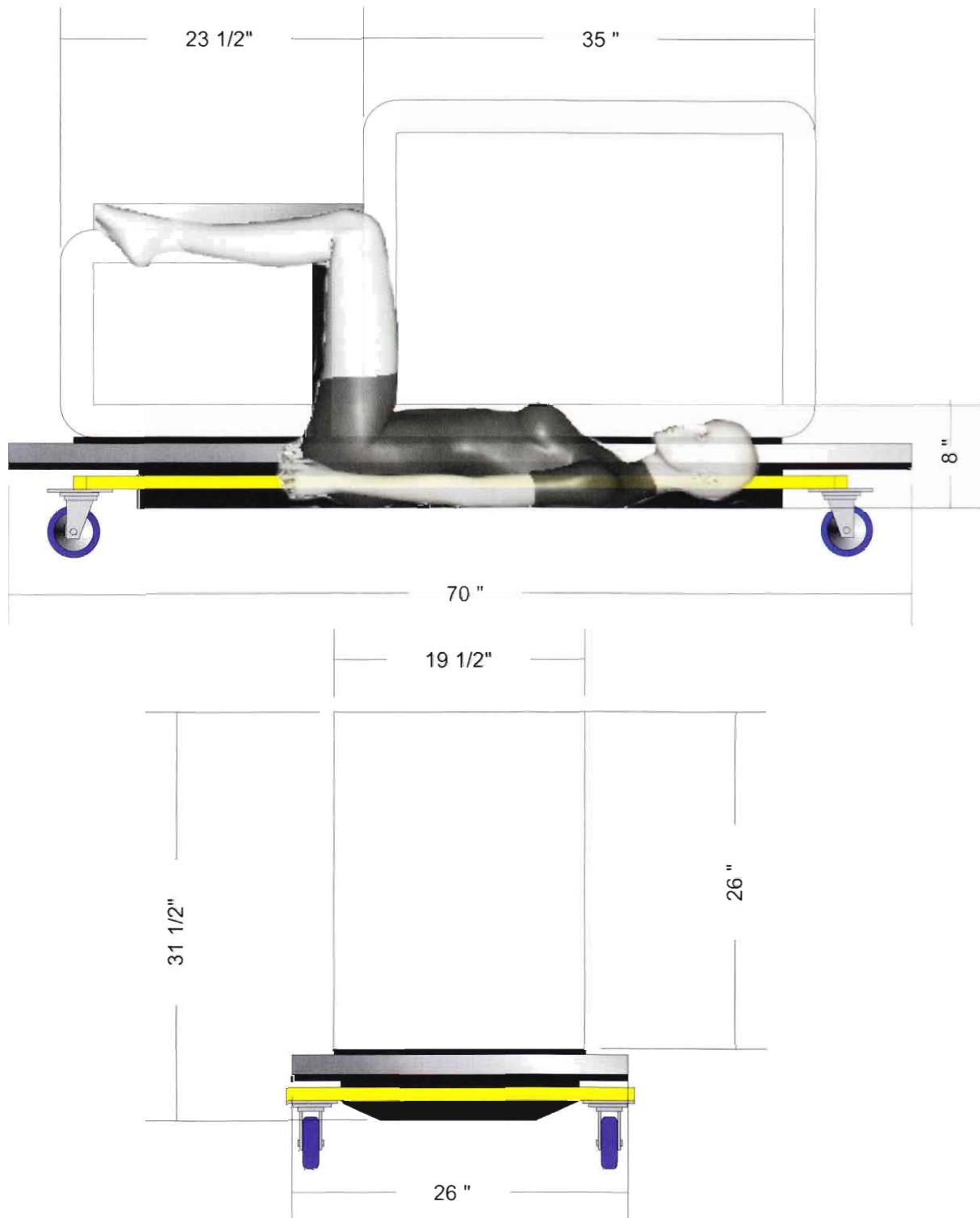
The assistant now simply stands up and the Magician pulls away the cloth for the appearance.

I have an old magazine article in my collection from 1896 describing a table appearance illusion by Buatier De Kolta (of the chair and birdcage fame). The assistant climbs up through a trapdoor to hide under a table as the cloth is held out in front of it. The cloth is draped over the table showing it empty underneath once the girl is in place (on a hidden shelf) she then pushes up under the cloth for the appearance. This was the inspiration behind the appearance of the girl for 'Trapdoor'.

TRAPDOOR

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

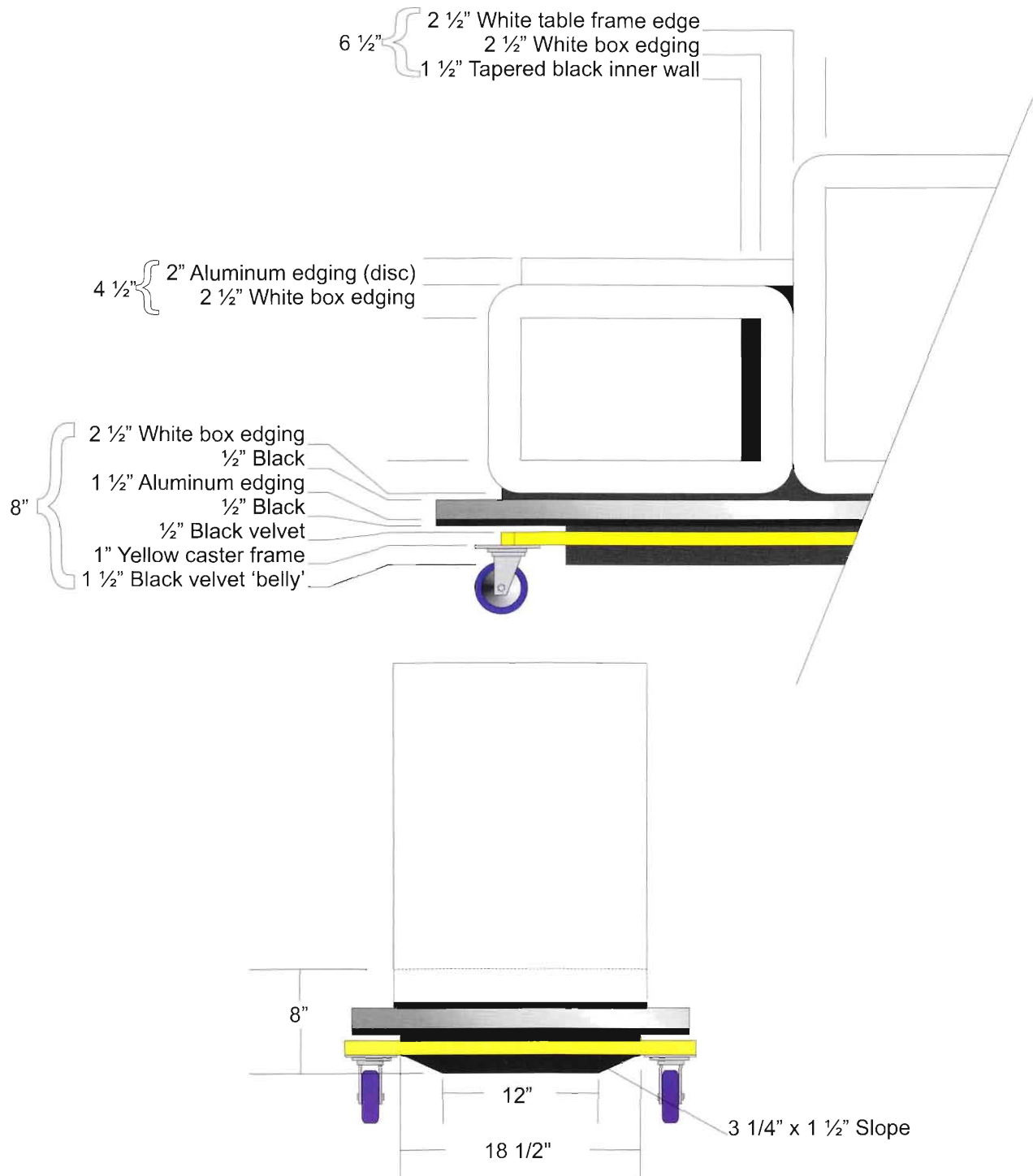
Scale 1" = 1'



TRAPDOOR

BASE AND LOAD SPACE DETAILS

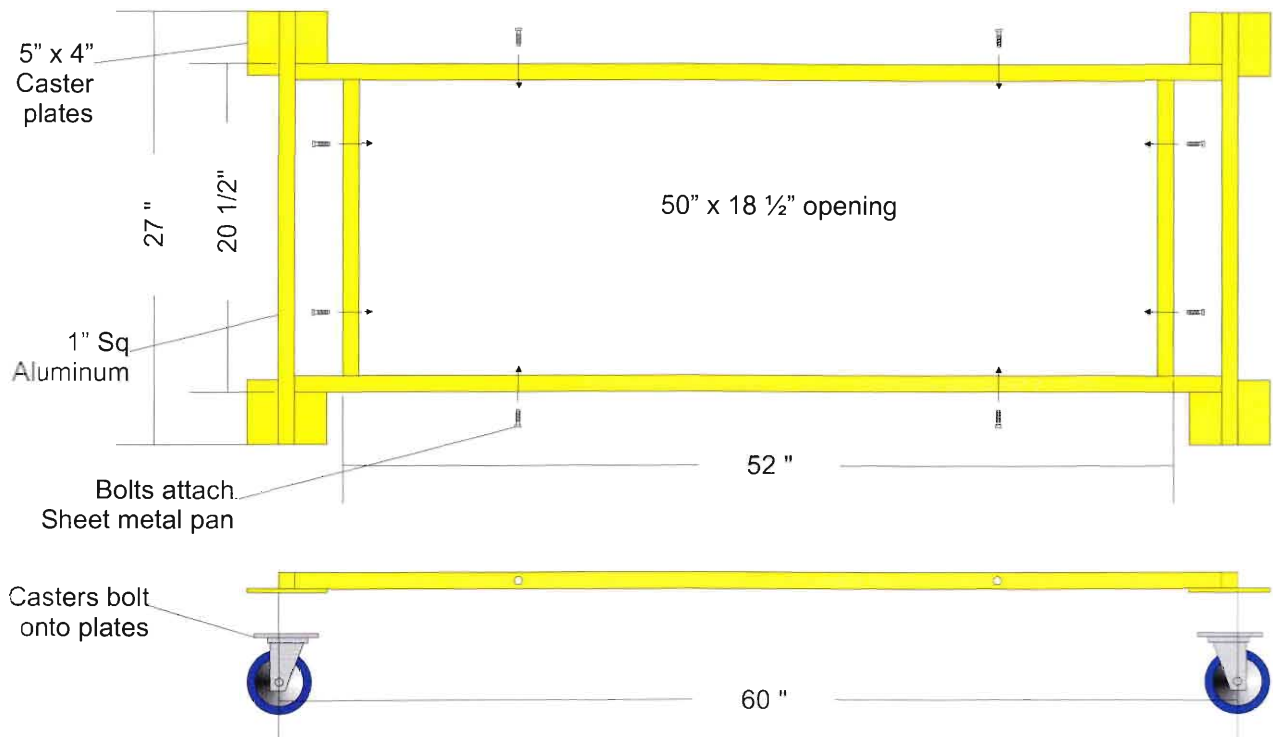
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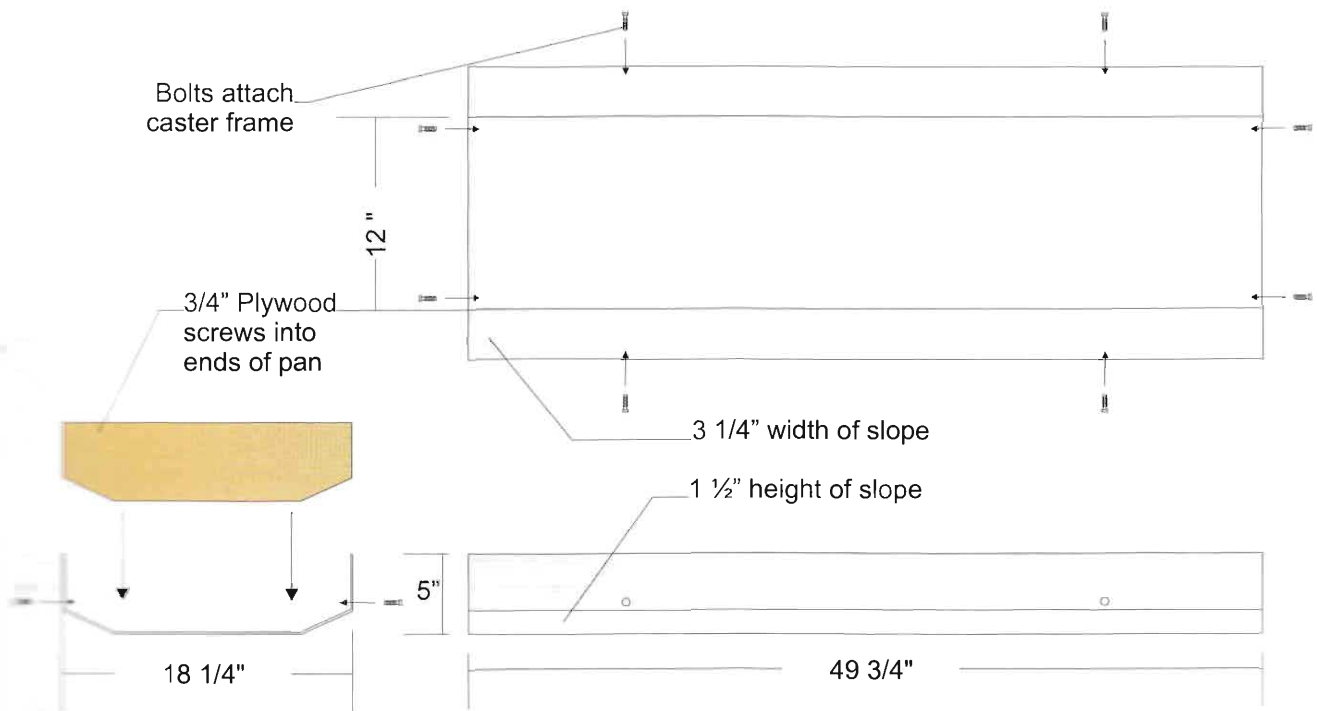
TRAPDOOR

CASTER FRAME

Scale 1" = 1'



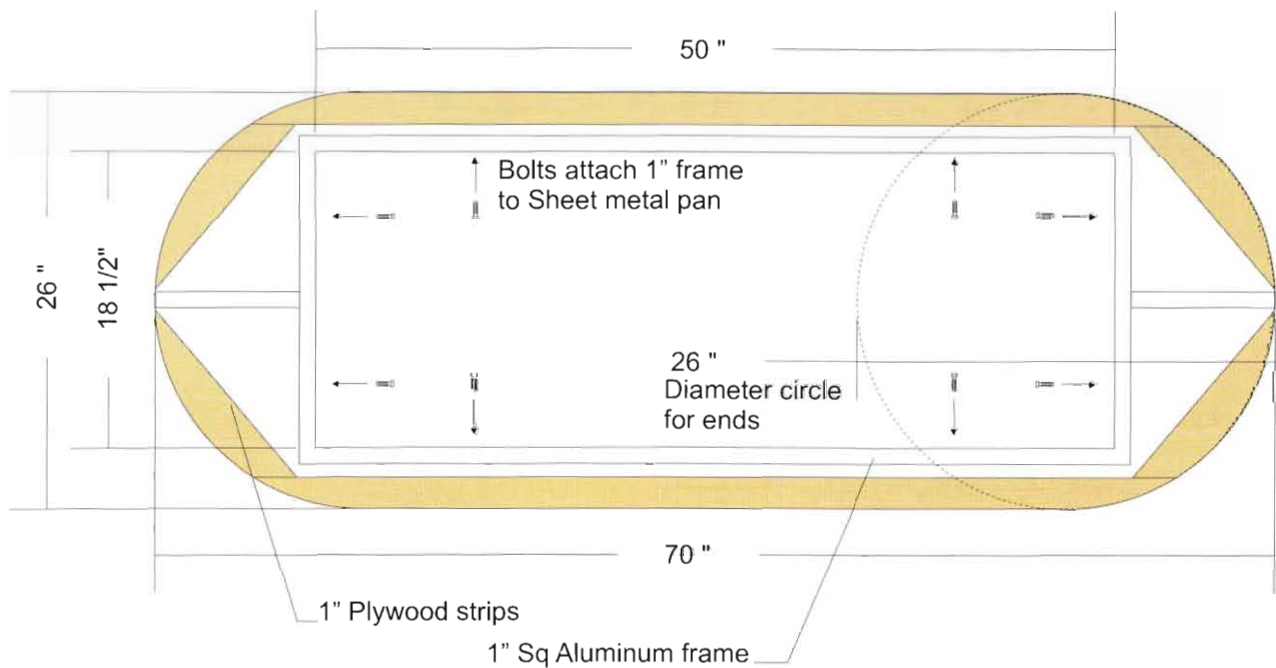
SHEET METAL PAN



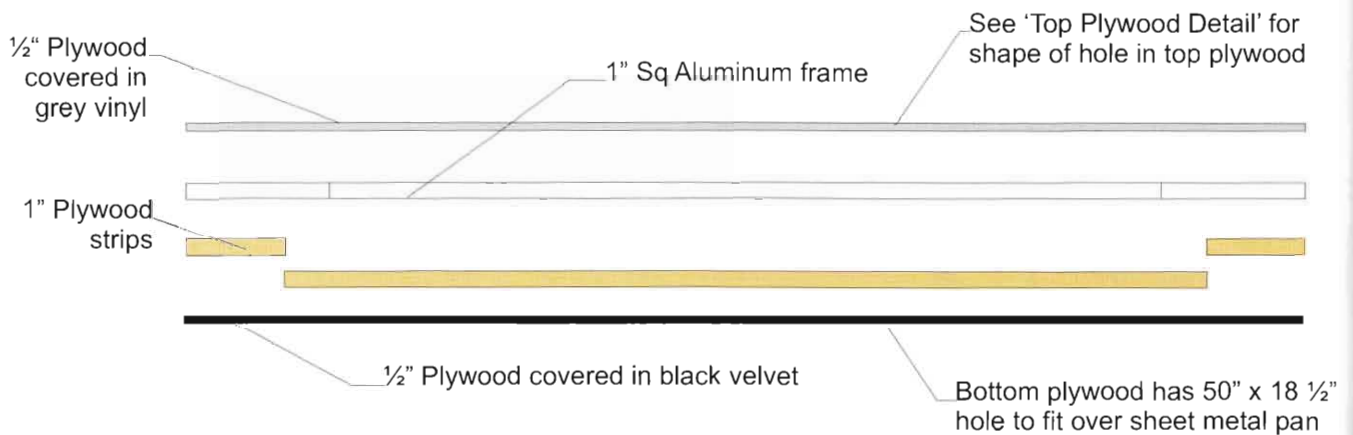
TRAPDOOR

MAIN BASE STEP

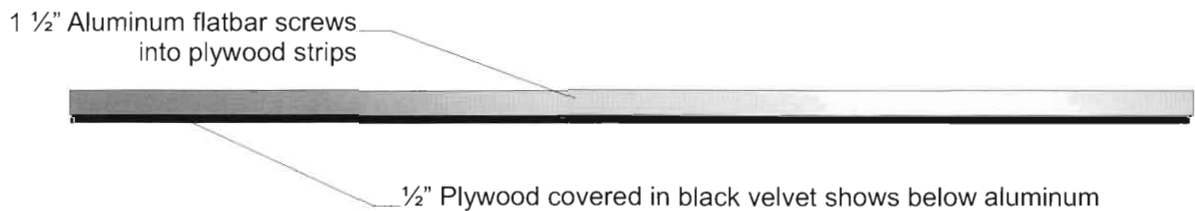
Scale 1" = 1'



*Plywood top and bottom screw into aluminum frame
Screws run through plywood strips into bottom piece before black velvet goes on
Use a router to trim plywood strips to match curve of top and bottom



ALL PIECES ASSEMBLED



TRAPDOOR

TOP PLYWOOD DETAIL

Scale 1" = 1'

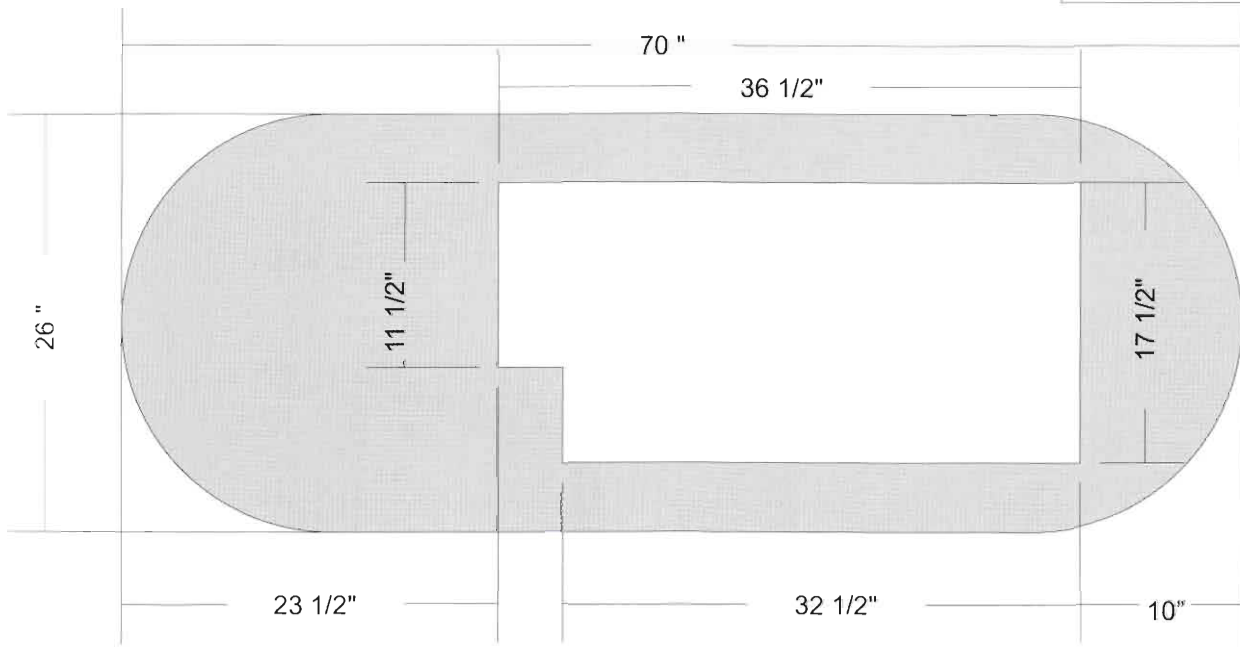
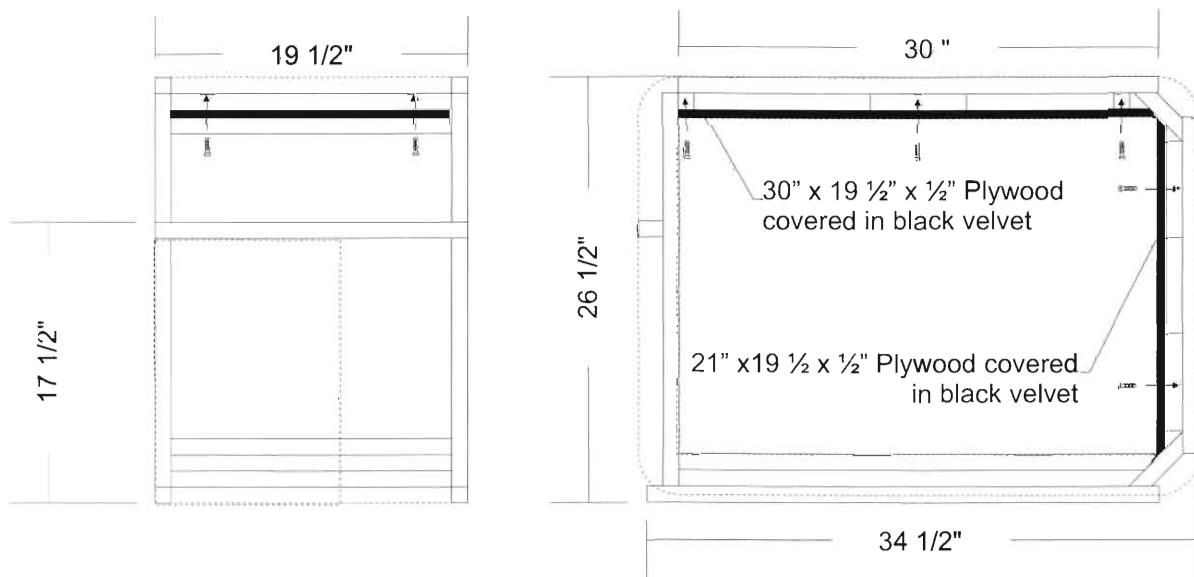


TABLE FRAME

1 1/2" x 1" Aluminum

1" Sq Aluminum

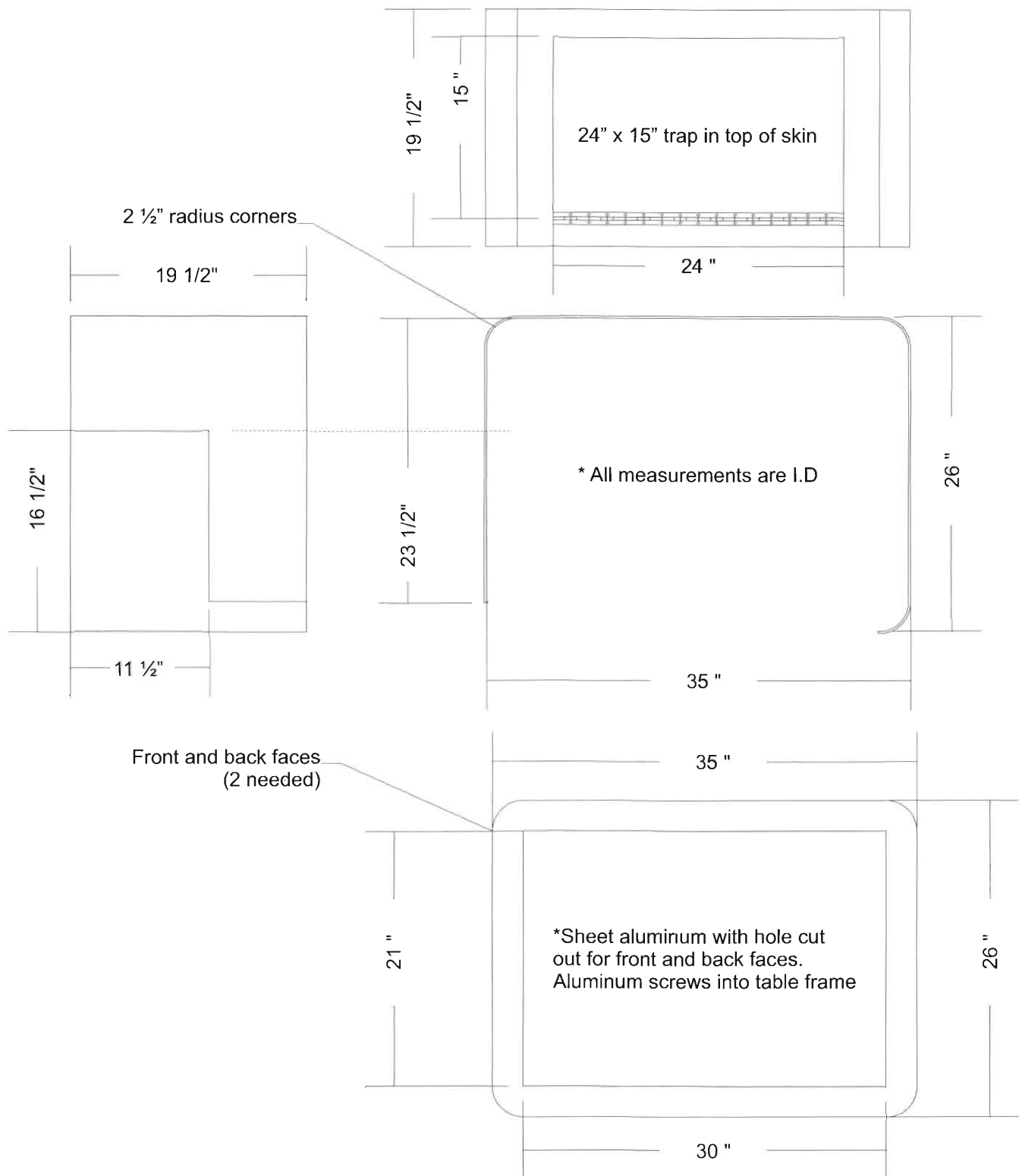
*Dotted lines show outside skin of box



TRAPDOOR

TABLE SKIN

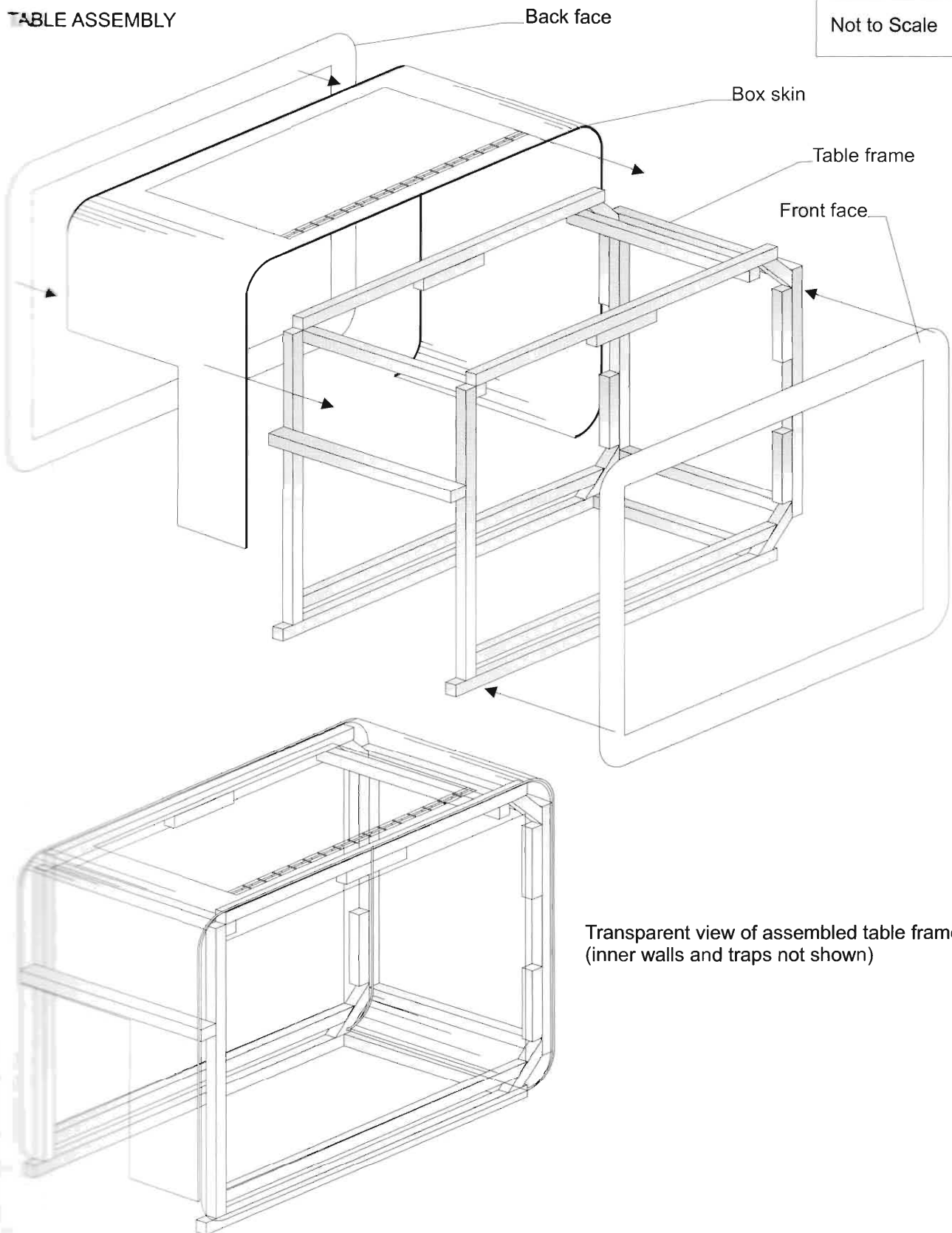
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TRAPDOOR

TABLE ASSEMBLY

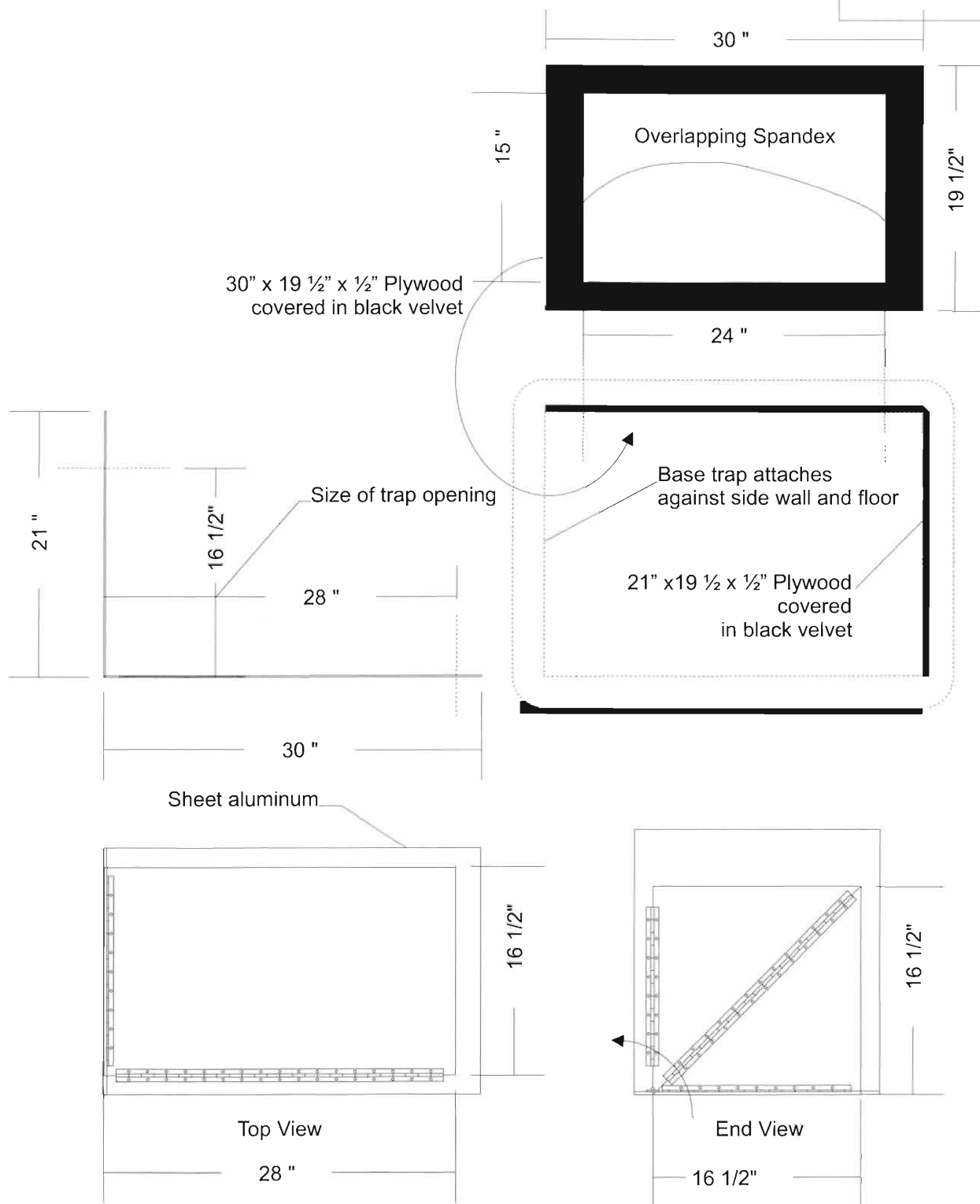
Not to Scale



TRAPDOOR

INNER TRAPS

Scale 1" = 1'

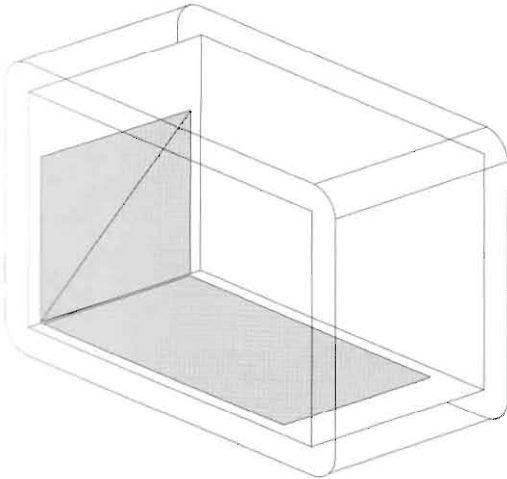


* All traps and hinges covered in black velvet

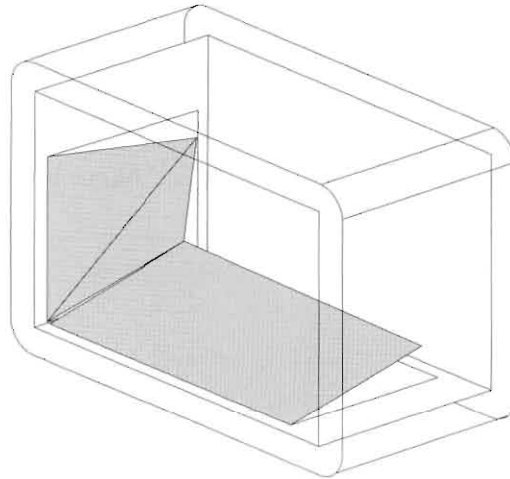
INNER TRAPS MOVEMENT (3D VIEW)

Not to Scale

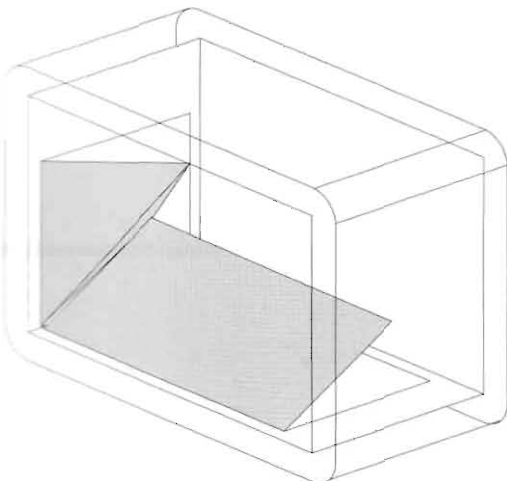
Pic.1



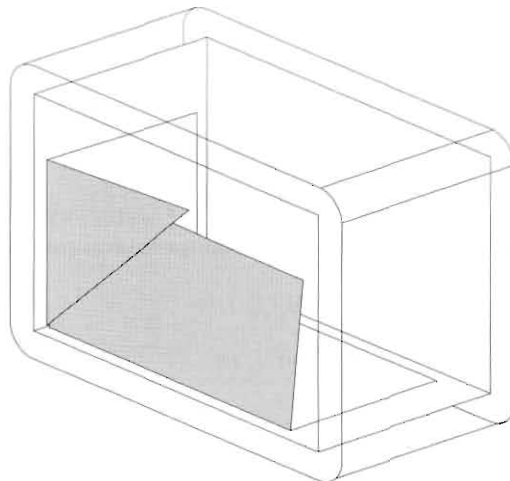
Pic.2



Pic.3



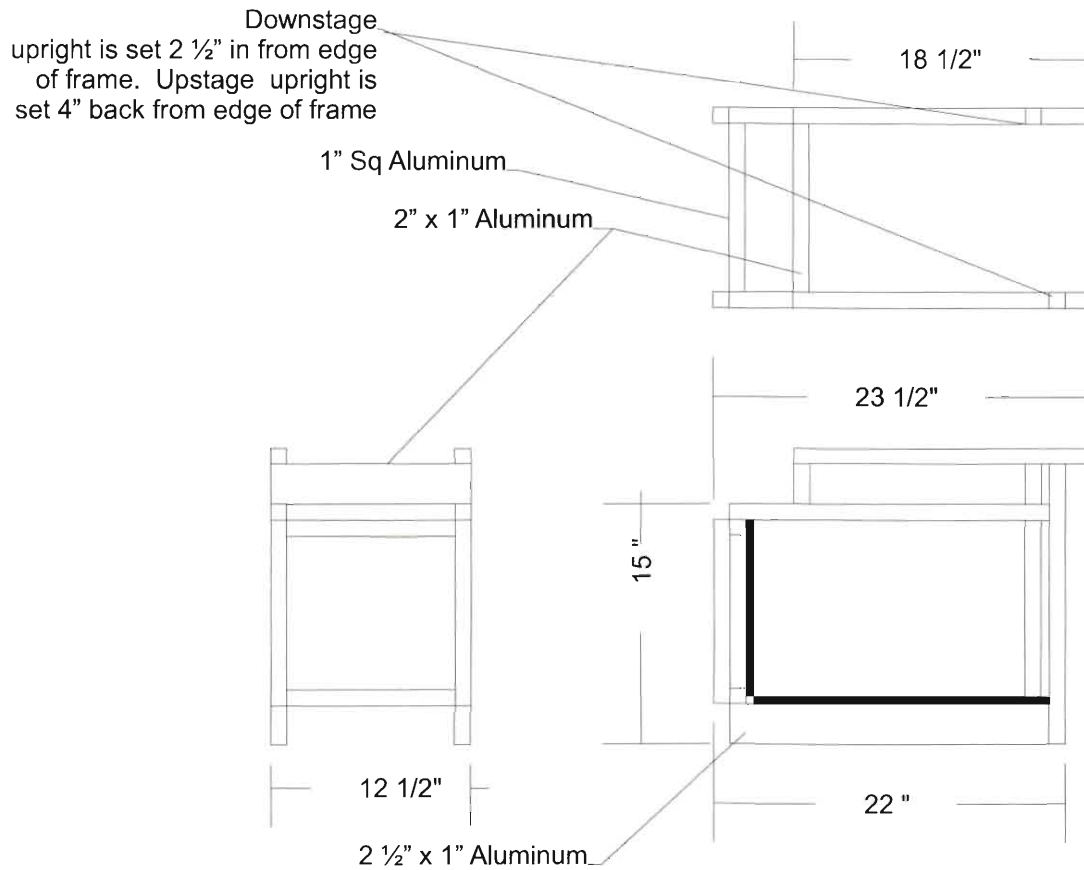
Pic.4



TRAPDOOR

WHITE BOX FRAMEWORK

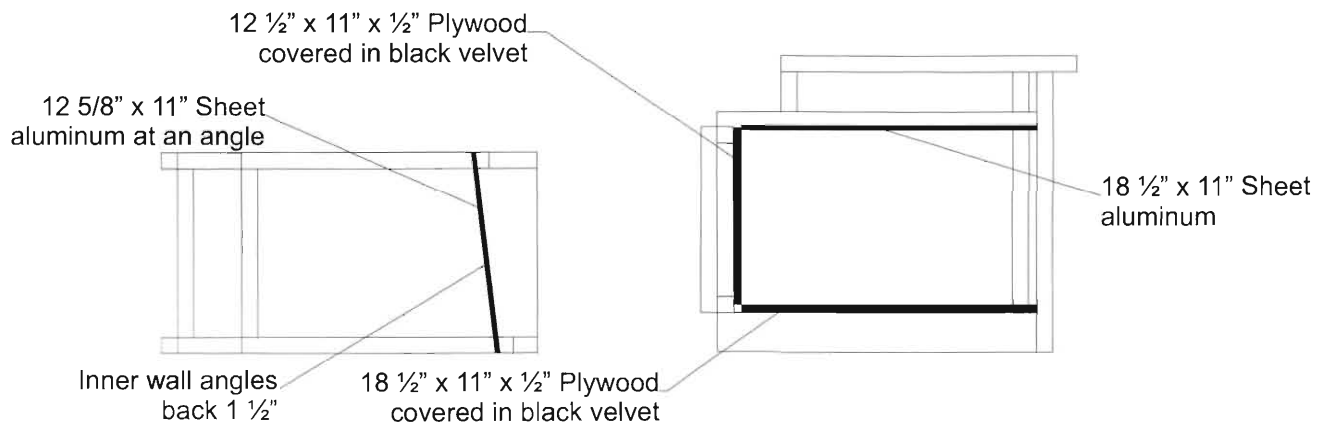
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WHITE BOX INNER WALLS

Top View

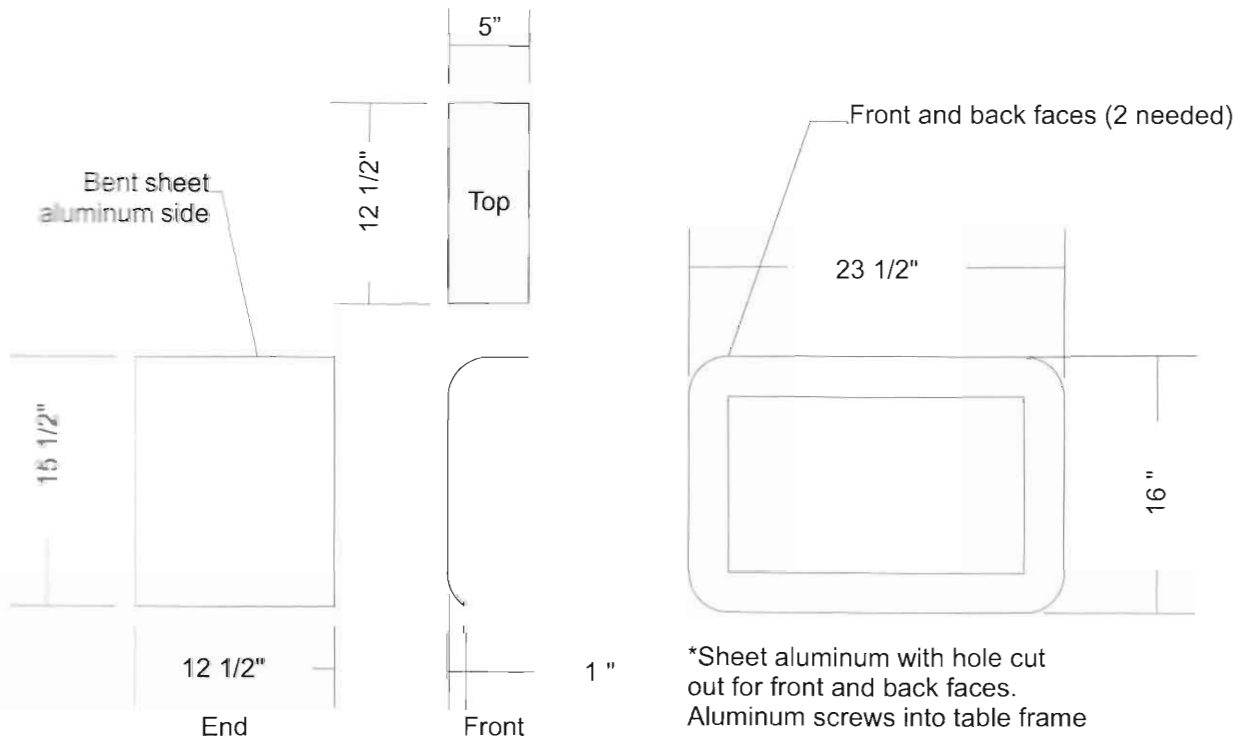
Front View



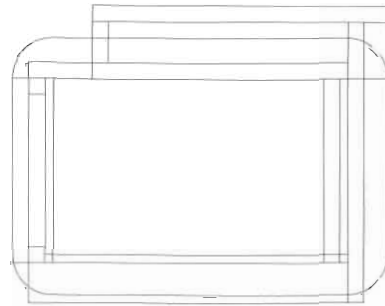
TRAPDOOR

WHITE BOX SKIN

Scale 1" = 1'



*Transparent view of framework with skin

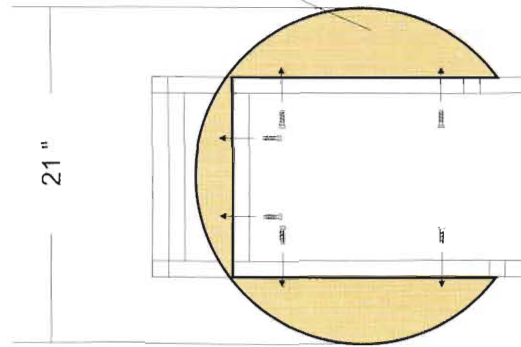


TRAPDOOR

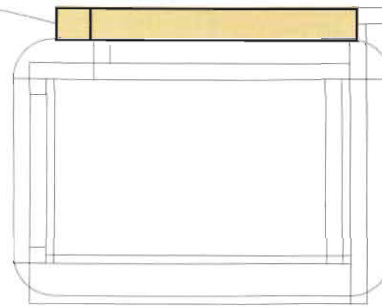
DISC

Scale 1" = 1'

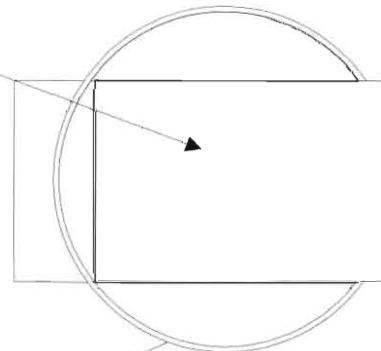
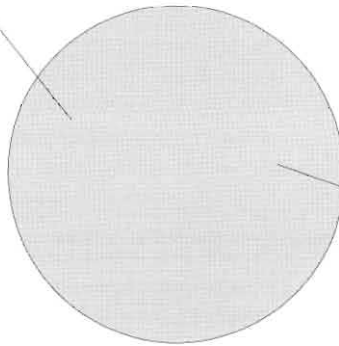
Disc is made from three sections
screwed onto the aluminum framework



Plywood laminated
together (3/4", 3/4", 1/2")



21" Diameter sheet
aluminum circle is
covered in grey vinyl
and screwed to top

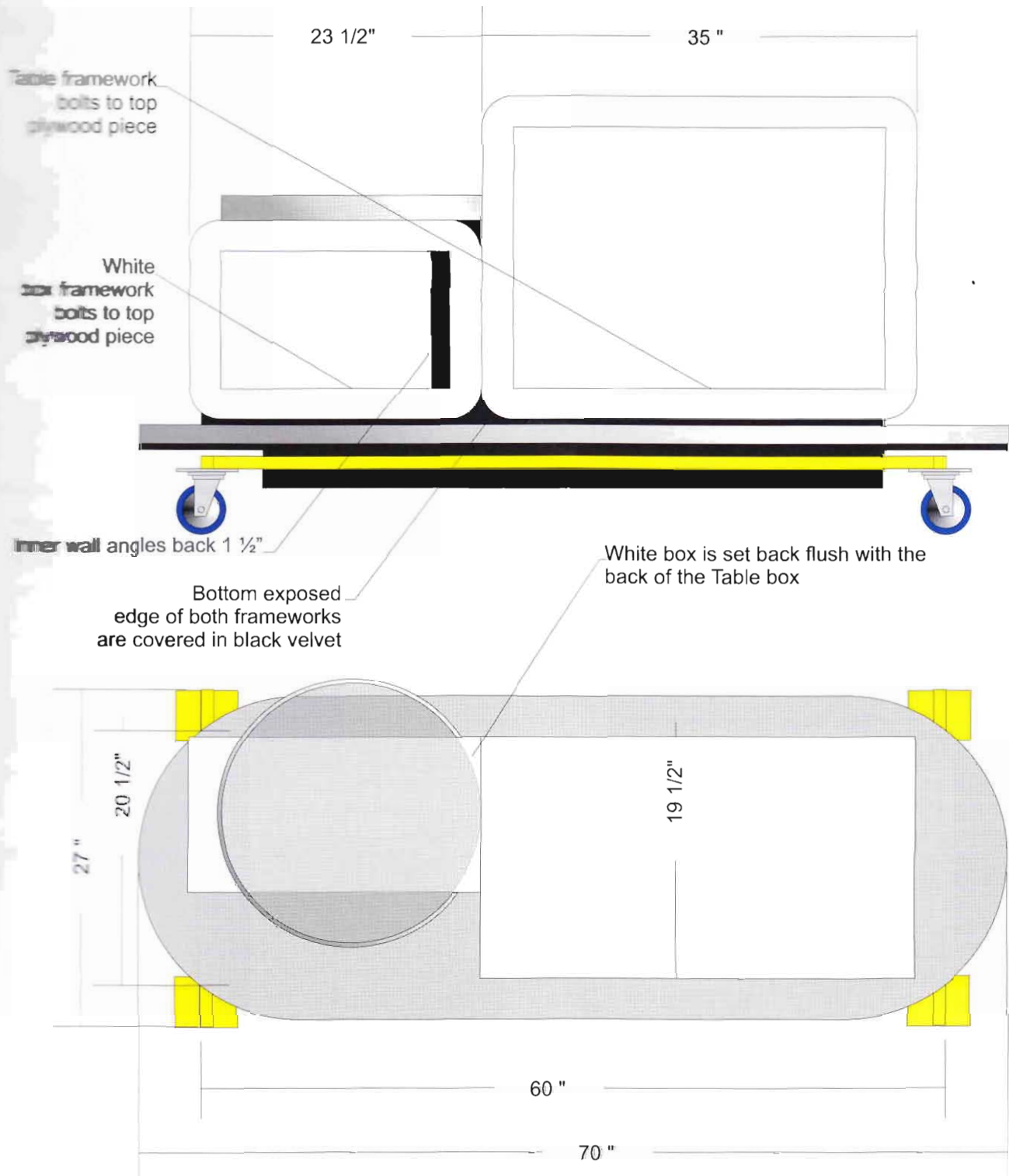


2" Aluminum flatbar trim is screwed into plywood

TRAPDOOR

ILLUSION ASSEMBLED

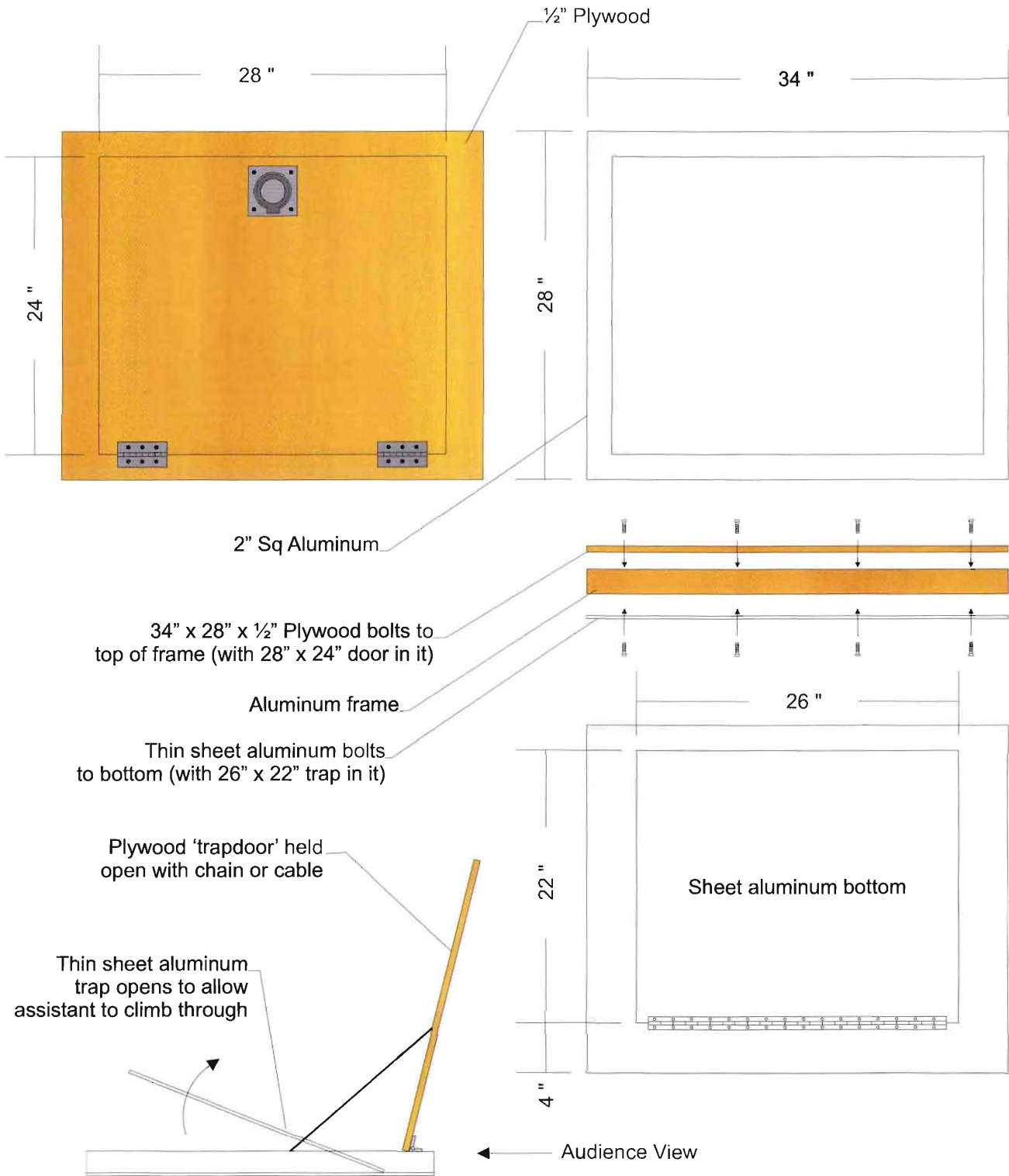
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TRAPDOOR

TRAPDOOR

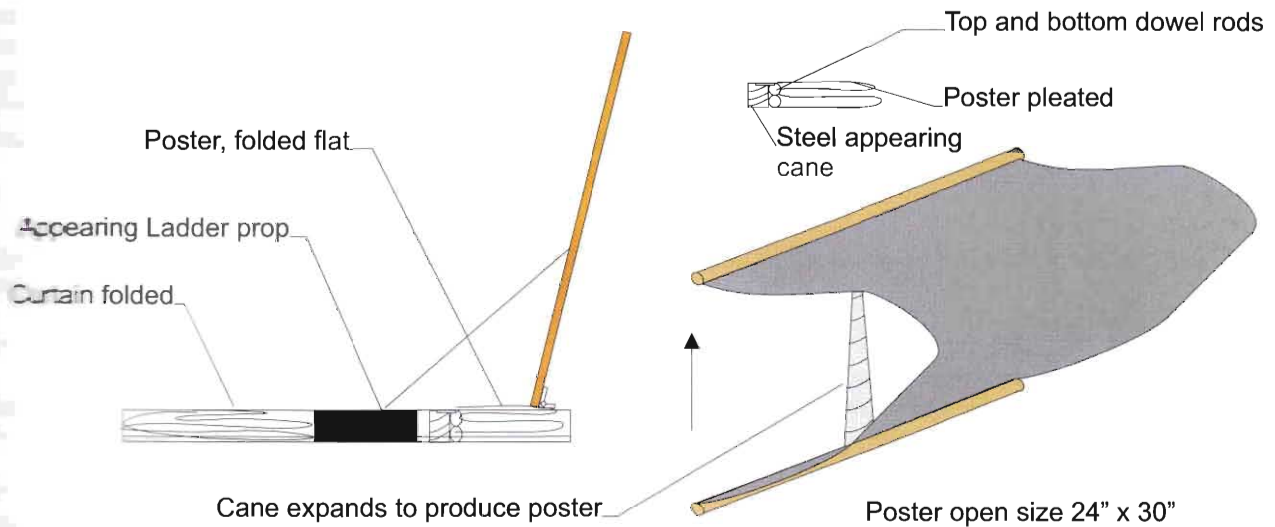
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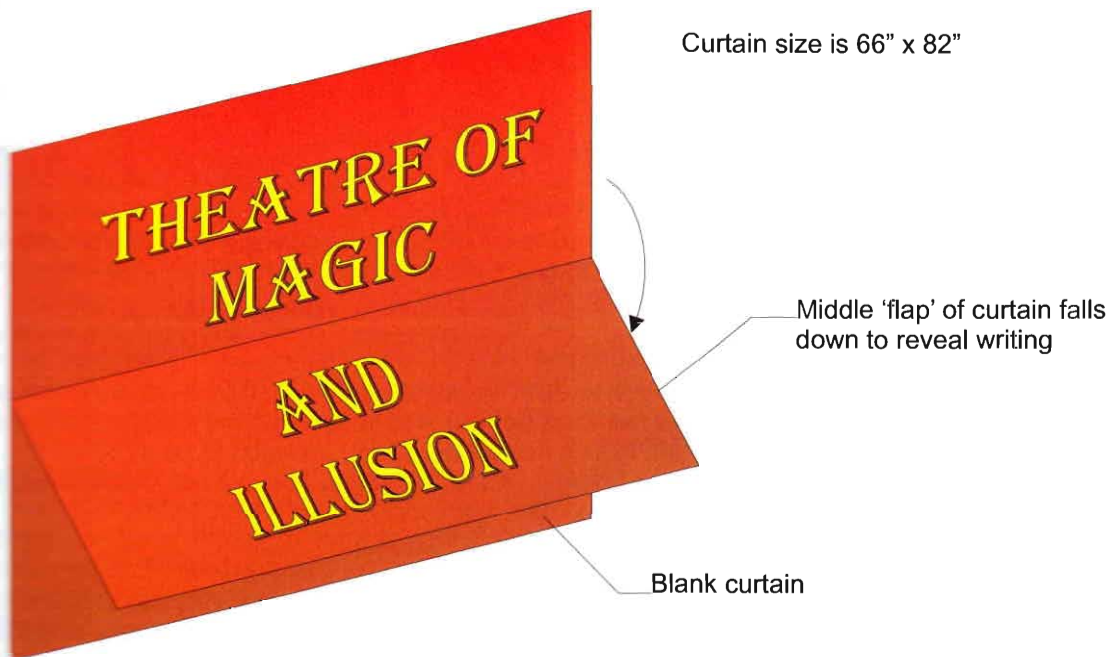
TRAPDOOR

PRODUCTION PROPS - LADDER AND POSTER

Scale 1" = 1'



CURTAIN



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

This diagram pretty much explains the hiding place for the assistant at the start of the routine.

BASE AND LOAD SPACE DETAILS

These breakdowns show how the thickness for the three load areas is broken up. The base, which is a total of 8" thick is a combination of the rolling base, platform and bottom frame of the table box. The upright thighs load space is made from the thickness of the edge frames of the table box and small box, plus an inner wall that is angled in to give a further 1 ½" of space at the back of the small box. The shins and feet are hidden in the top edge frame of the small box and the thickness of the disc that sits on top of it.

CASTER FRAME

This frame is finished in a yellow powder coat. The casters are 4" diameter and bolt onto the caster plates on the frame. The opening in the middle of the frame is for the sheet metal pan to drop into.

SHEET METAL PAN

I would have this bent from a single piece of aluminum. The ends are plywood screwed in. The whole piece is then covered in black velvet before being mounted inside the caster frame. The pan sits inside the caster frame so that the bottom edge of the caster frame lines up with the beginning of the slope on the underside of the pan.

MAIN BASE STEP

This is the main part of the platform. The inner framework attaches to the sheet metal pan. I would make the bottom piece of plywood (with its rounded ends) first, then use a router to duplicate the outline onto the top piece (the middle hole is different though). The 1" thick plywood strips are placed at an angle on the ends of the plywood once it is attached to the aluminum frame. Then a router is used again to trim the overhanging 1" plywood to match the curve of the bottom piece. At this point, the bottom piece of wood is covered with black velvet.

The top piece of plywood (with its different hole cut out - see 'top plywood detail') is covered in grey vinyl and attached to the top of the frame. A piece of thin 1 ½" aluminum flat bar is bent around the edge and screwed on - the flat bar sits flush with the top of the top piece of plywood, leaving ½" of black velvet (covering the bottom piece of plywood) showing at the bottom.

TOP PLYWOOD DETAIL

This shows the shape of hole cut in the top piece of plywood.

TABLE FRAME

The frame forms the structure of the table. It is designed to be sturdy for the assistant to climb onto during the illusion. Pieces of plywood covered in black velvet are screwed into the top and side inside edges (more on the top piece of plywood later).

TABLE SKIN

I wanted a seamless look for the exterior look of the table. The skin is made from thin sheet aluminum bent to the shape shown. The side that goes against the small box has a hole cut out of it (16 ½" x 11 ½") for the assistant's legs to pass through. The top of this skin has a hole cut out and a trap put in (24' x 15"). The front and back faces are made from a sheet of aluminum with the center hole cut out. All these parts are powder coated in bright white.

TABLE ASSEMBLY

To better show how the table fits together, this exploded view shows the skin and faces going onto the framework. The transparent view shows all the piece together. The framework is built in such a way that the 1" sq. aluminum does not interfere with the radius corners on the skin. The skin would be attached to the framework with rivets or small screws.

TRAPDOOR

INNER TRAPS

The top inside piece of plywood is covered in black velvet with a hole in the middle filled with overlapping spandex.

The traps that cover the assistant are made from thin sheet aluminum. The floor trap simply opens upwards towards the audience. The upright legs trap also opens towards the audience and is hinged to the floor trap. The legs trap is also split in half diagonally and hinged.

INNER TRAP MOVEMENT

This story board shows the movement of the inner traps.

Pic.1: The traps are closed with the assistant inside.

Pic.2: As the assistant begins to open the floor trap, the legs trap begins to fold together at the diagonal line and push open.

Pic.3: As the floor trap opens it continues to fold the legs trap in half diagonally, forcing it to open.

Pic.4: The floor trap and legs trap are fully open. When the assistant drops the floor trap the legs trap should automatically close with it.

WHITE BOX FRAMEWORK

This is designed similar to the table frame. The framework is designed to not interfere with the box skin, and also goes up inside the disc.

WHITE BOX INNER WALLS

Notice how the inner wall of the load chamber for the legs (made from sheet aluminum) angles back to give 1 1/2" more space at the back of the white box. This sheet aluminum is covered in black velvet, as is the other piece of aluminum that makes the inside top edge of the box (and bottom of the shin and feet load space). Plywood covered in black velvet is used for the floor and other inner wall of the white box.

WHITE BOX SKIN

The white box only has a small amount of bent sheet aluminum on the exterior. It attaches the same as the big piece on the table frame. The front and back faces of the white box are also the same as the bigger table box (only smaller of course).

DISC

The disc is made in three sections of wood that fit around the end, front and back of the framework that protrudes above the white box. The wood is 2" thick and made from laminating together two 3/4" and 1/2" plywood. A circle of aluminum covered in grey vinyl (to match the main base step) is attached to the top of the framework. Thin 2" aluminum edging is bent around and screwed into the plywood.

ILLUSION ASSEMBLED

I wanted to show all the pieces together. The frames of the white box and table bolt to the top plywood piece (which is attached to the sheet metal pan and caster framework). The white box sets back flush with the back of the table box.

TRAPDOOR

The trapdoor is made from an aluminum frame with plywood on top (with the trapdoor in it) and a sheet aluminum on the bottom (with another door in it for the assistant to climb through). With both doors closed there is a small amount of space inside the trapdoor for the production items. The bottom left drawing shows how the trapdoor opens towards the audience and the aluminum trap opens up behind it once the production items have been removed. The trapdoor is painted to look like an old wood door.

TRAPDOOR

PRODUCTION PROPS - LADDER AND POSTER

The ladder is Wayne Rogers' Appearing Ladder. You can purchase it from him, I've put the website address in the RESOURCES section. Wayne also has a number of other great products based on the appearing pole principal, such as Appearing Garden Shovel, Missing Spade, Pin Number and Appearing Broom.

The Ladder is in its 'hidden' configuration and stored in the middle of the trapdoor. The curtain is at the back of the trapdoor, possibly with some velcro straps over it to keep it in place as the trapdoor is being moved around at the beginning of the routine.

The poster is printed on vinyl - any Kinkos or copy shop can do this for you. Two rods are attached to either end of the poster. A steel appearing cane is attached to either end of the rods. The tip of the cane may need to be held to the rod with a ring to allow it to rotate within the ring as it expands.

CURTAIN

A simple trick with the curtain gives the assistant time to climb out of the load space and up behind the trap door. The curtain is made like a 'Goodnight Banner' (as I said in Method, you may know this as something else). The middle flap of material starts up. This shows the curtain as old and tattered, perhaps with rips and stains on it. When the middle flap drops over, the curtain is the same material, but clean and with the Magician's name on it. Could be your name or the name of the fictitious Magician in the story.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

I've covered most of the finishing in the descriptions. The caster frame gives a bit of color to the prop (in the words of Nathan Lane in Birdcage, "One does want a hint of color."). The table and white box are finished with bright white powder coat. I imagine the trapdoor to be scenic painted to look completely different and separate from the table. The trapdoor is old knotty wood with dark hammered steel hardware. Perhaps some talc (or other white powder you may have lying around) is preset on the trapdoor so you can do that classic 'blowing the dust off an old thing' routine at the beginning of the illusion.

ETC...

I have always liked the routine and plot for this one. It is one of those illusions I have picked up, worked on, then put away again for months. Each time revising the design and thinking behind it, but the main routine has always been the same. I originally had a huge table prop with a moving mirror, but it was complicated and almost 'over thought'. I really wanted this to be an illusion that can be practical to work in most conditions, be small enough to be suitable for a smaller or medium sized act that works ships, conventions, etc. - yet big enough to be suitable for a big stage show. I hope you agree this final version of the design meets those requirements.

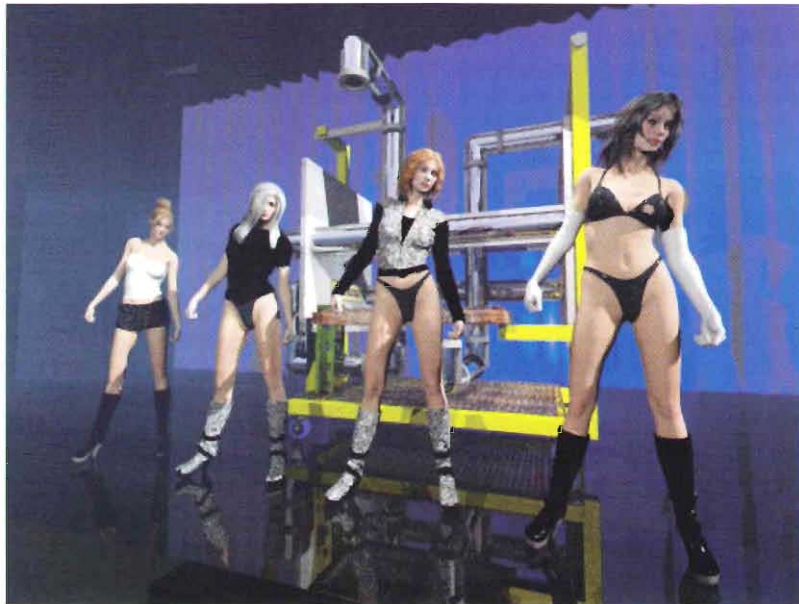
I chose to design the boxes to be built as a framework inside with a thin sheet aluminum skin on the outside. However, you could use a thicker aluminum sheet and weld the sheet together to make the boxes, adding angle to the inside to mount the wood and trap pieces.

I have never seen a trap mechanism like the one I am describing. I believe this is the first time a trap system like this has been designed into an illusion. It may need some small springs attached to the back of the legs door, or a spring hinge to ensure that door begins moving in the right direction. After that the traps will fold as illustrated.

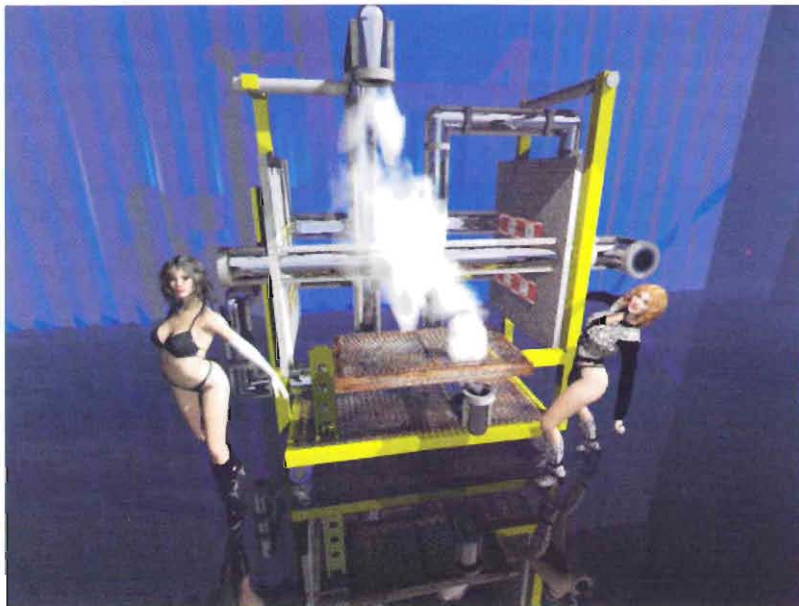
I have tried to present to you a prop that looks a bit different to the standard 'black bevel, aluminum stripes and square box' look. The square or rectangle box with the rounded corners appears to be quite popular right now - this design can be seen in furniture, store displays and graphics. The rounded platform ends seemed to fit that look. Therefore the whole table prop ends up looking completely different from the trapdoor, giving a feeling of separation. It's a look that suggests these two pieces were never initially intended to be used together, and they have nothing to do with each other.

My thanks again to Wayne Rogers (The Amazing Chicane) for allowing me to feature his Appearing Ladder in this illusion routine.

STEAM



The music begins and the curtains open to reveal a large framework of pipes on stage. There is a clear view through the pipes, above and below. The dancers perform an opening dance routine.



The music builds and jets of steam begin to shoot out of some of the pipes through and around the open mesh platform on the front of the prop.



The assistants hold a large plexiglass screen in front of the illusion. The steam ejects full blast, bellowing against the screen.



The assistants drop the screen and the steam clears. The Magician has appeared standing on the mesh platform.

METHOD

I've often heard the old Magician's saying - 'The best place to hide something is right in front of their eyes.' In this illusion that is true. The Magician is hidden in a load chamber right in the middle of the prop, the best way to describe it would be - an invisible deceptive base in which the Magician lies. Under cover of smoke, the Magician slides out the front of the load chamber and stands up on the platform.

The load chamber runs between the two end panels on the illusion and is hidden directly behind the center horizontal pipe (I'll be calling this the load chamber pipe from now on). The top and bottom of the load chamber is covered with mirror.

The pipes on the prop, although they look confusing and random, are all positioned so they reflect in the mirrors to give the illusion that the pipes pass through the space behind the load chamber pipe where the Magician is actually hiding.

A half pipe reflects in the mirror to complete itself and another pipe reflects itself to take the place of a higher pipe. Sound confusing ?? Hopefully the plans and explanations on the following pages should make it all clear!

In performance the Magician is in the load chamber lying on his stomach. The dancers perform their routine etc. Then the smoke machines in the prop shoot smoke against the plexiglass screen.

At this point the Magician slides out of the load chamber, bending his legs down onto the platform and stands up. The assistants quickly lower the screen. The air rush created from this move sucks the smoke forward away from the Magician.

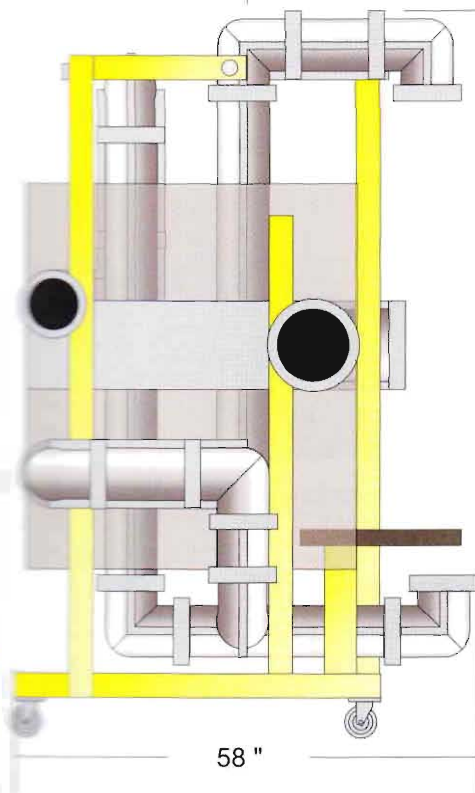
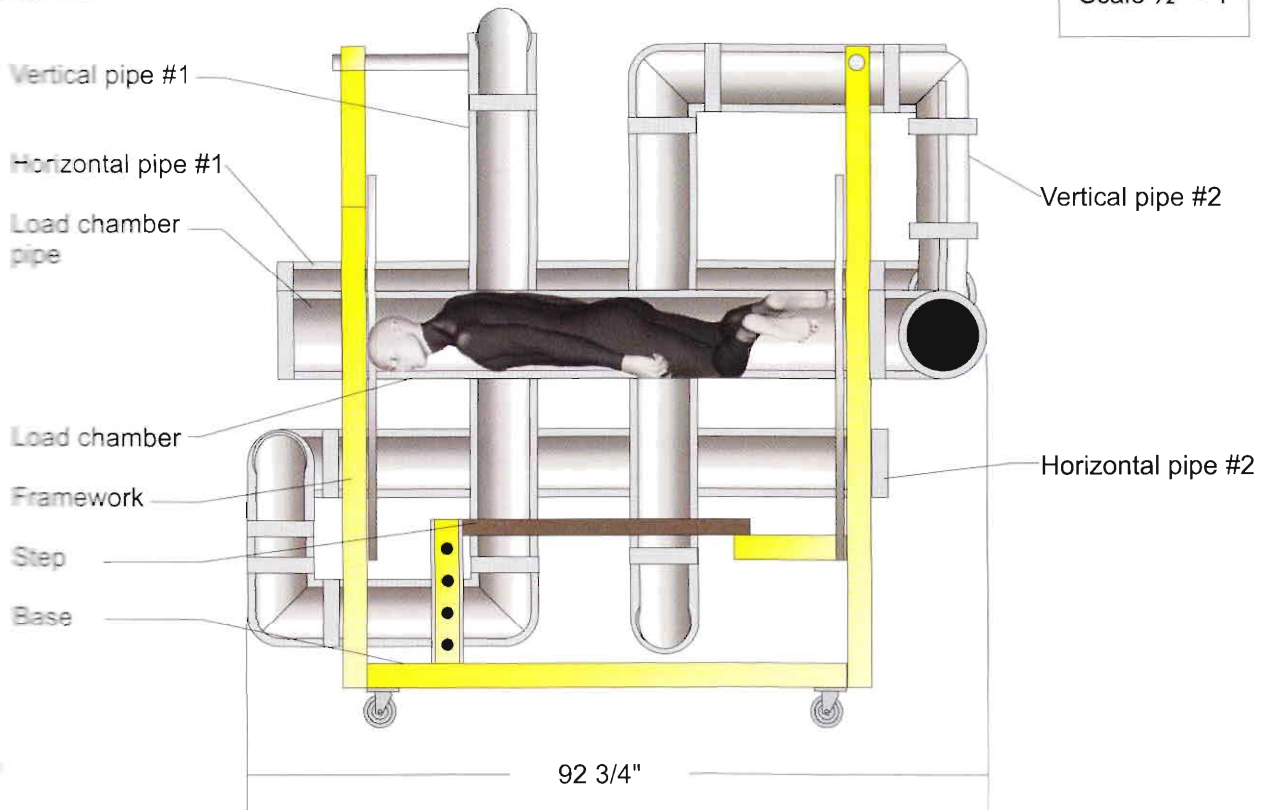
The Magician makes an appearance.

The drawings on the next page show front and side views of the illusion with the Magician shown in the load chamber.

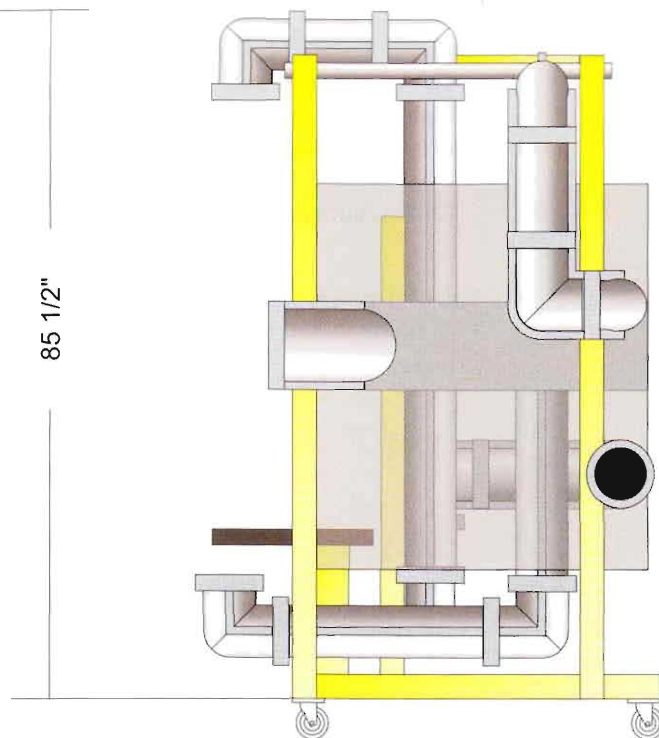
STEAM

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



Stage Right View

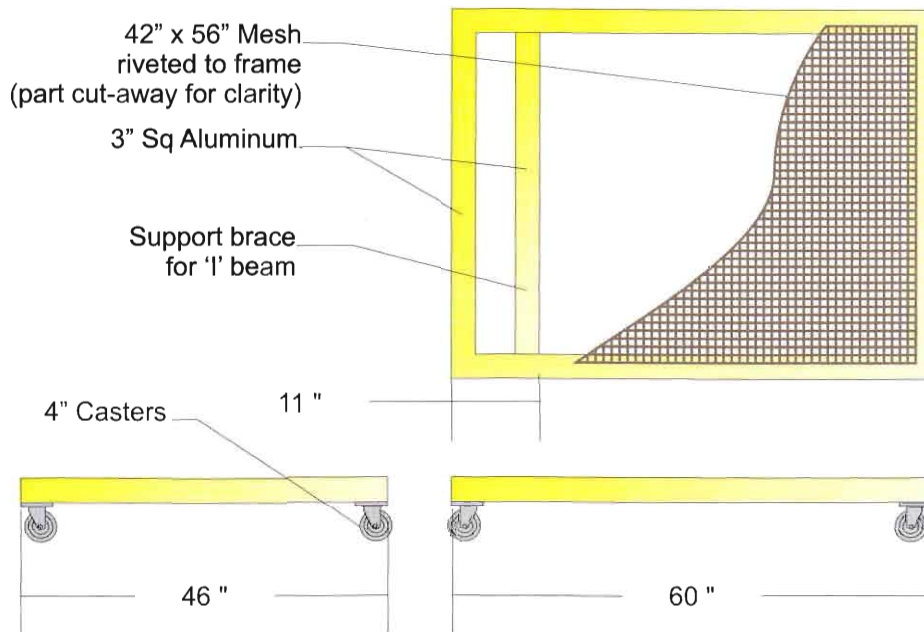


Stage Left View

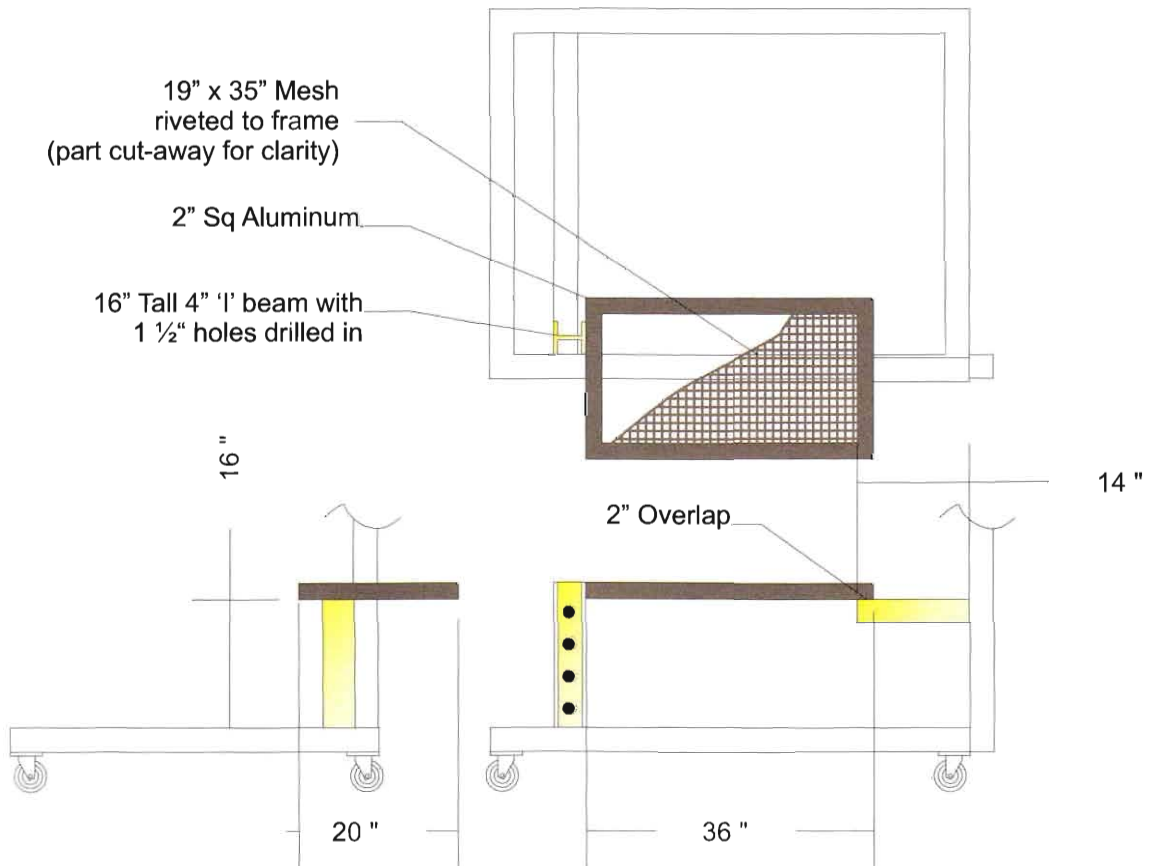
STEAM

BASE

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$

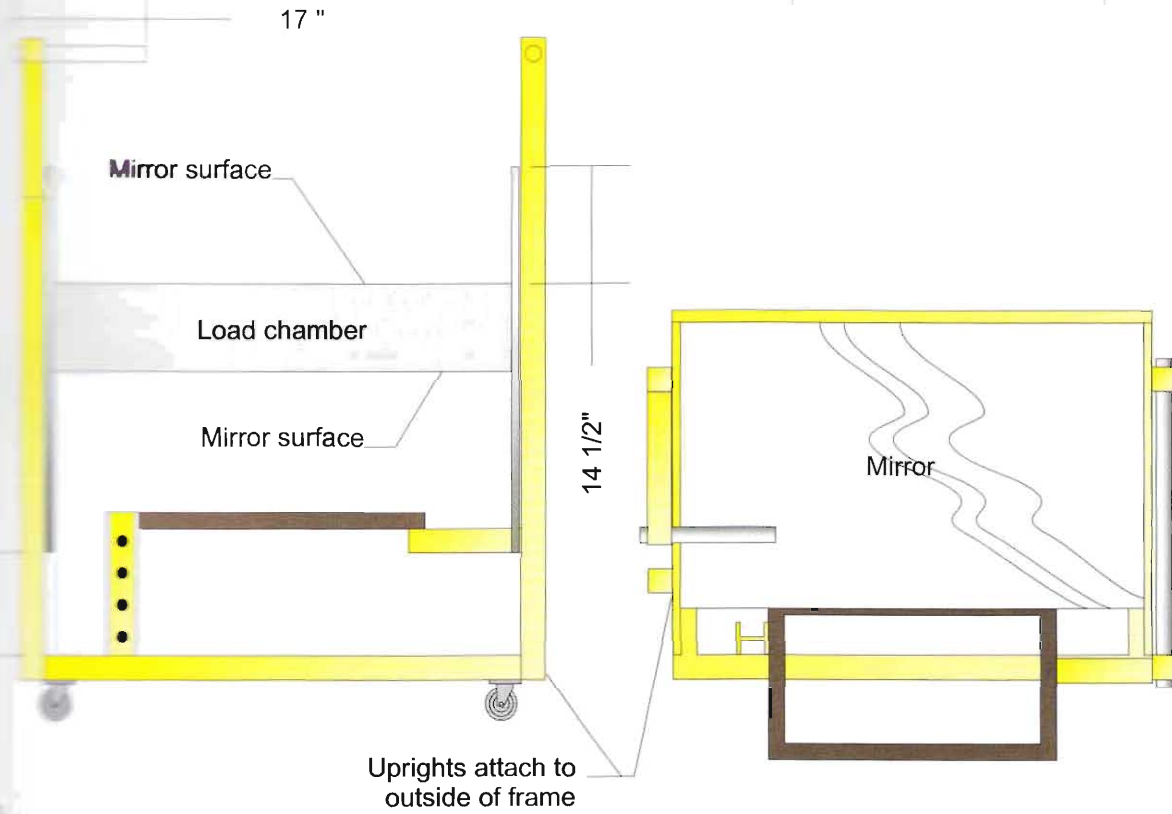
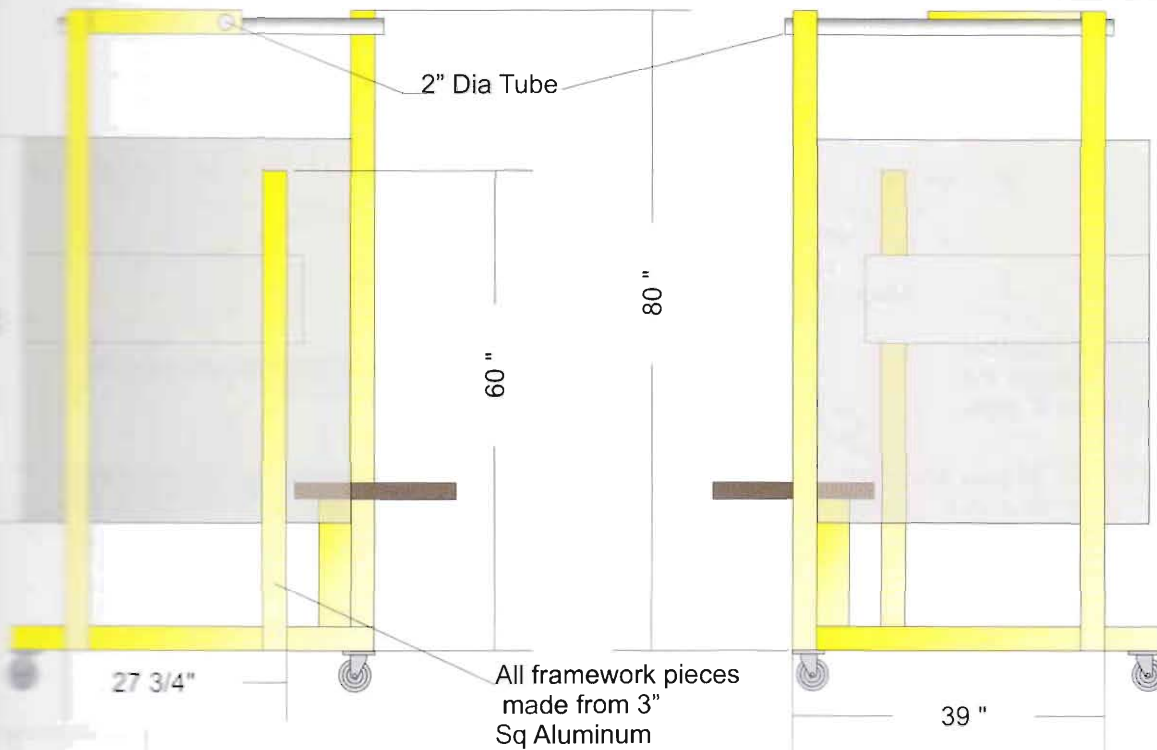


STEP



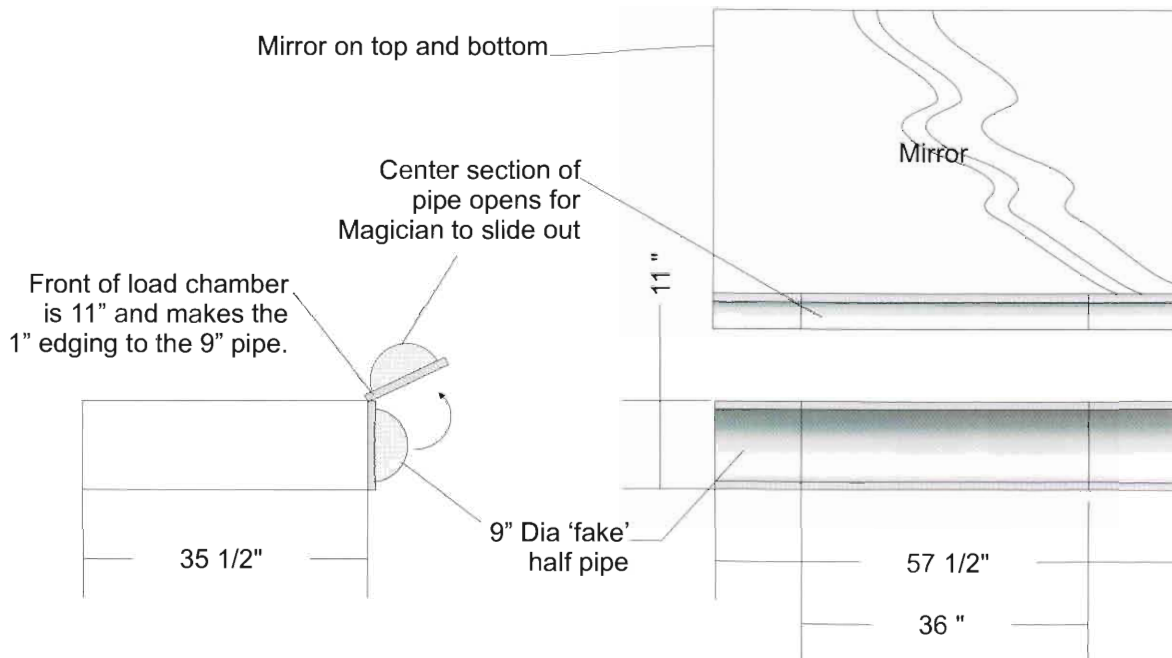
Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$

FRAMEWORK

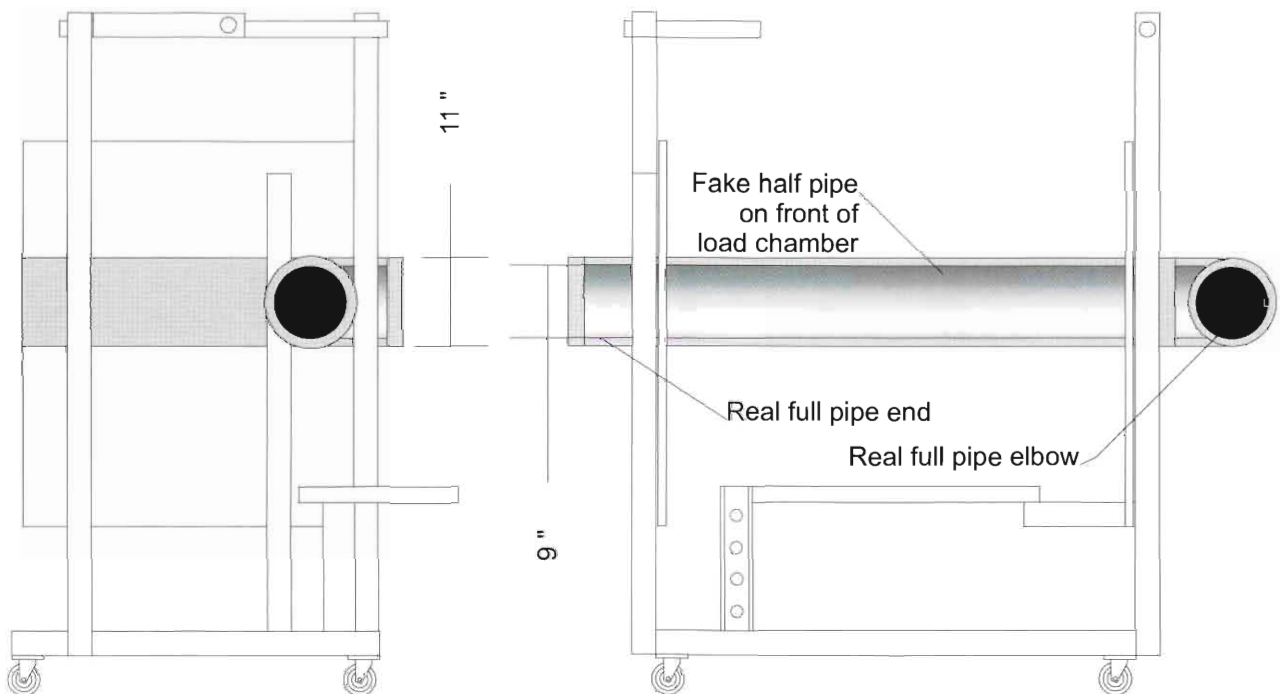


LOAD CHAMBER

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



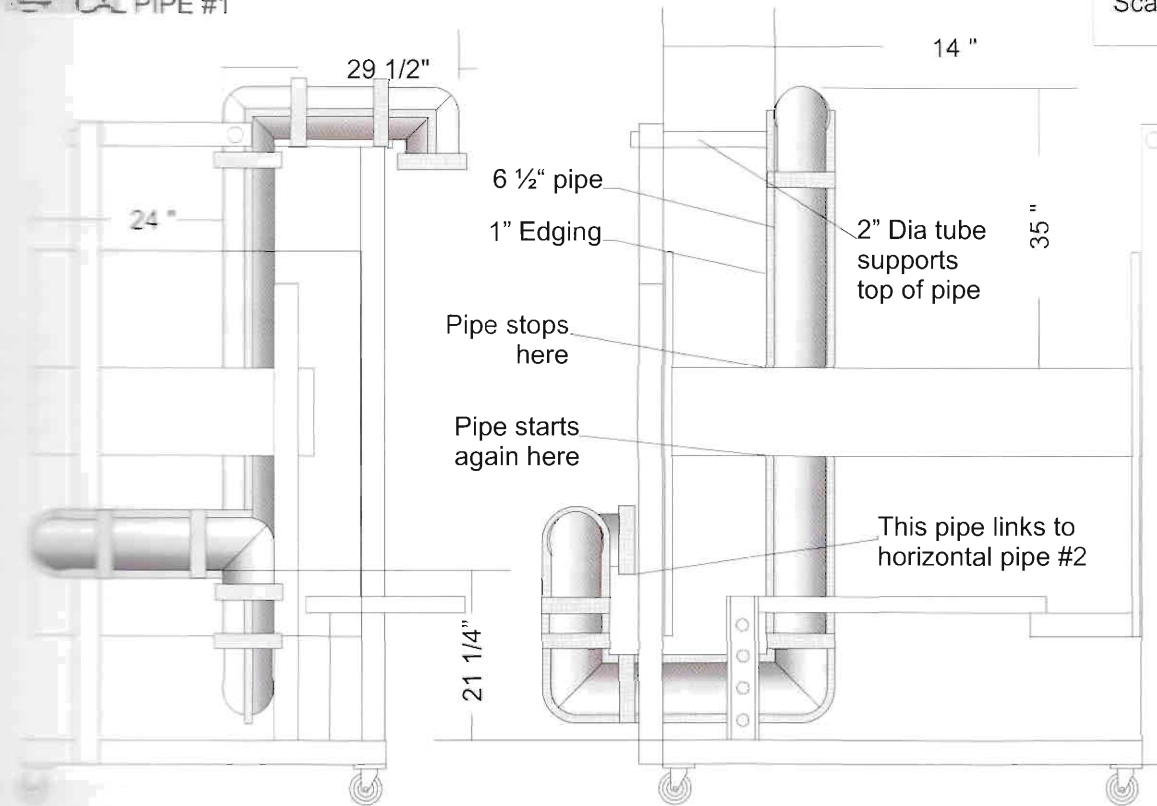
LOAD CHAMBER PIPE



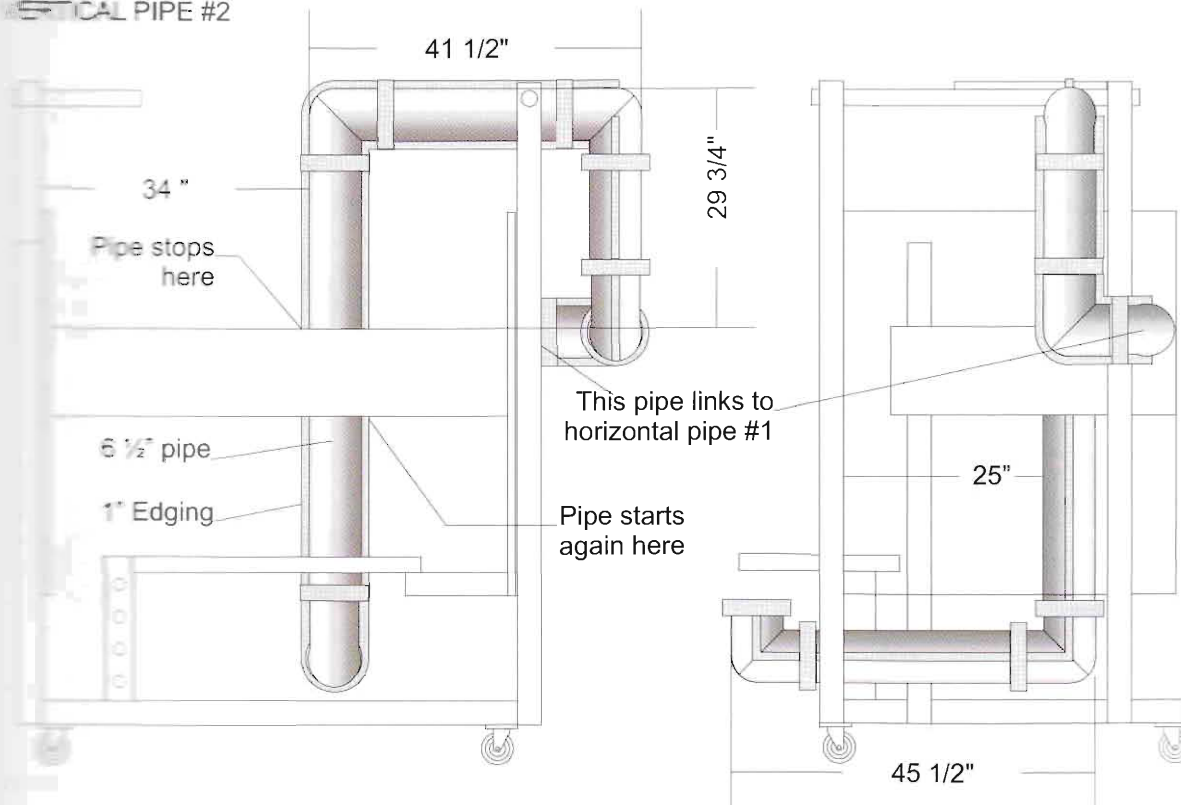
STEAM

VERTICAL PIPE #1

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



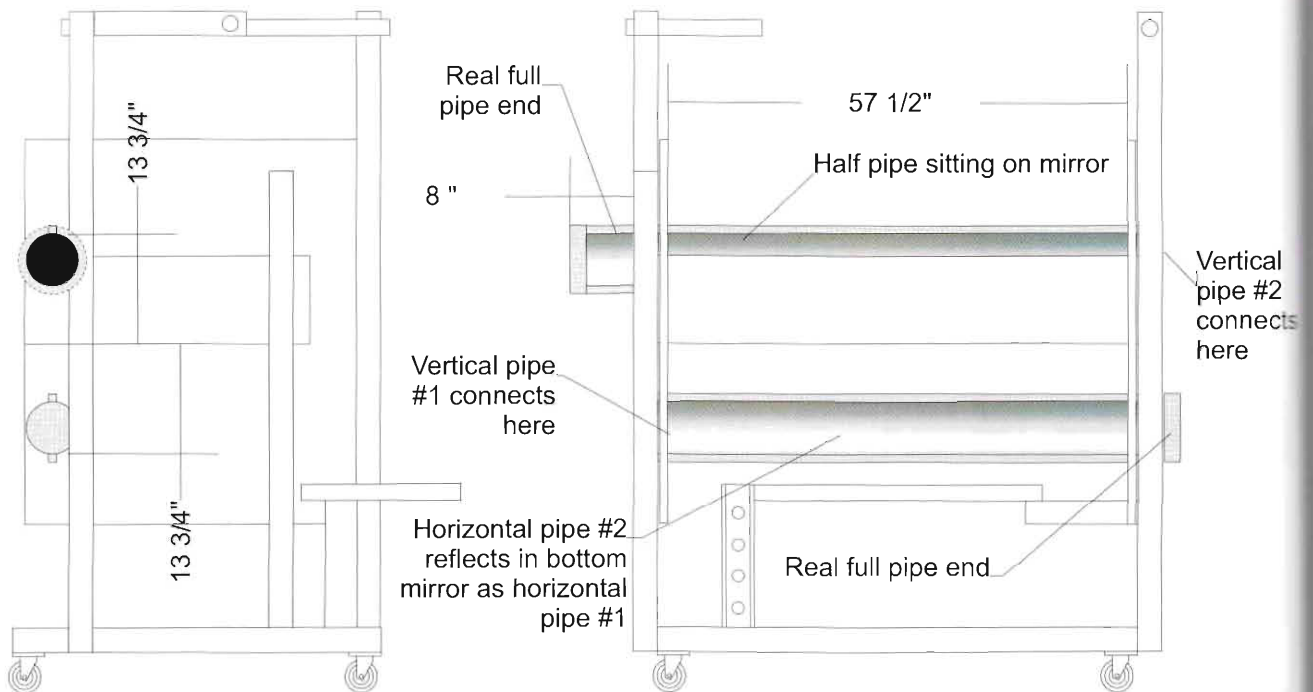
VERTICAL PIPE #2



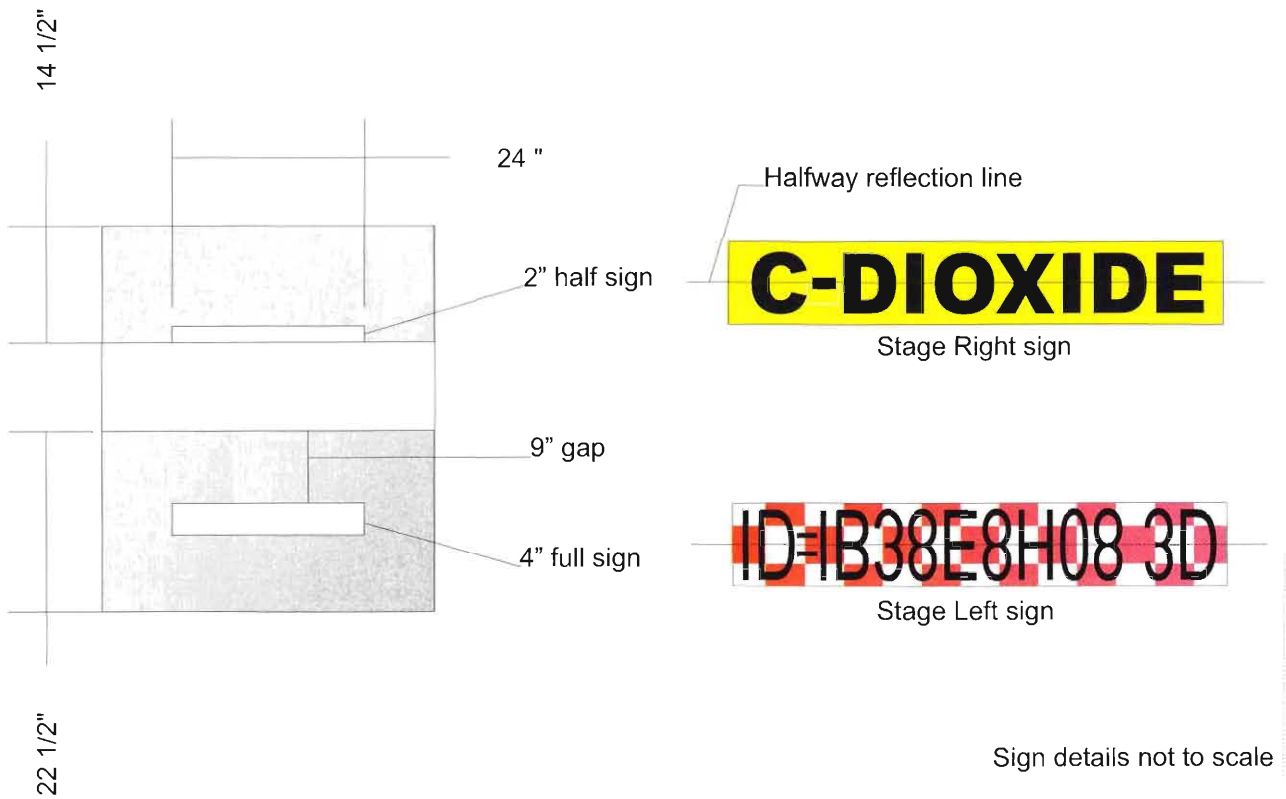
STEAM

HORIZONTAL PIPES #1 & #2

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



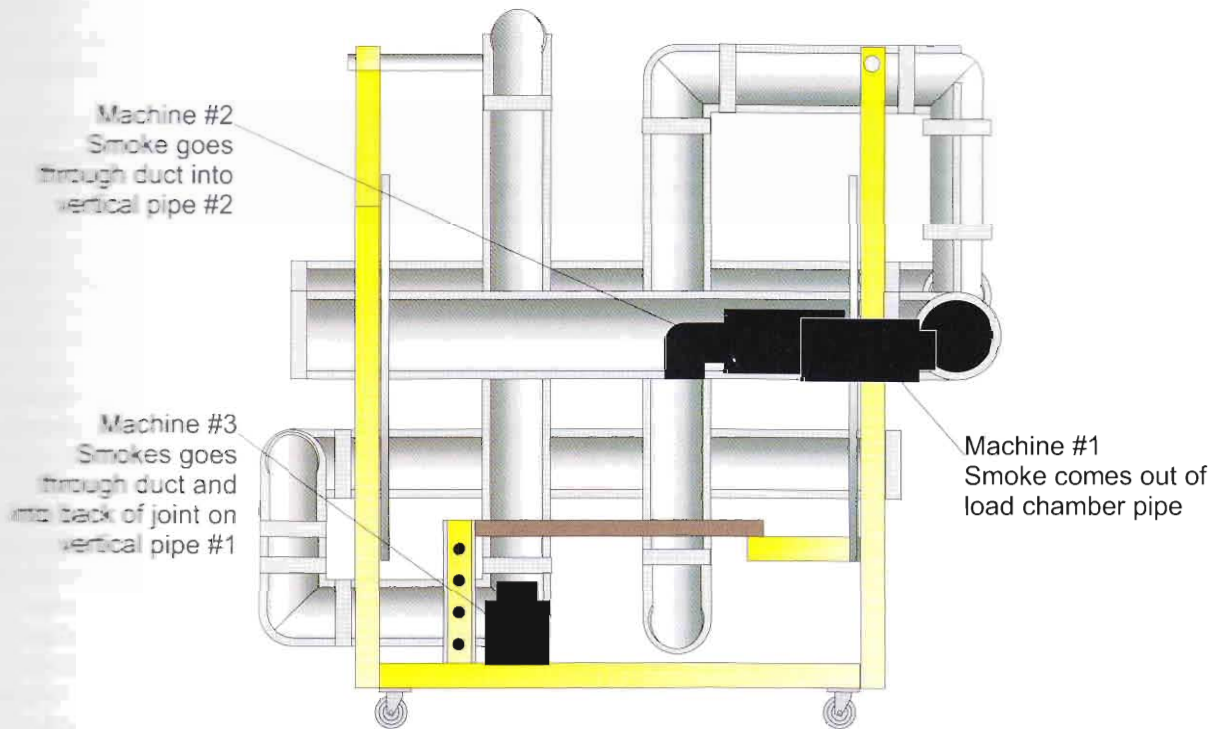
PANELS



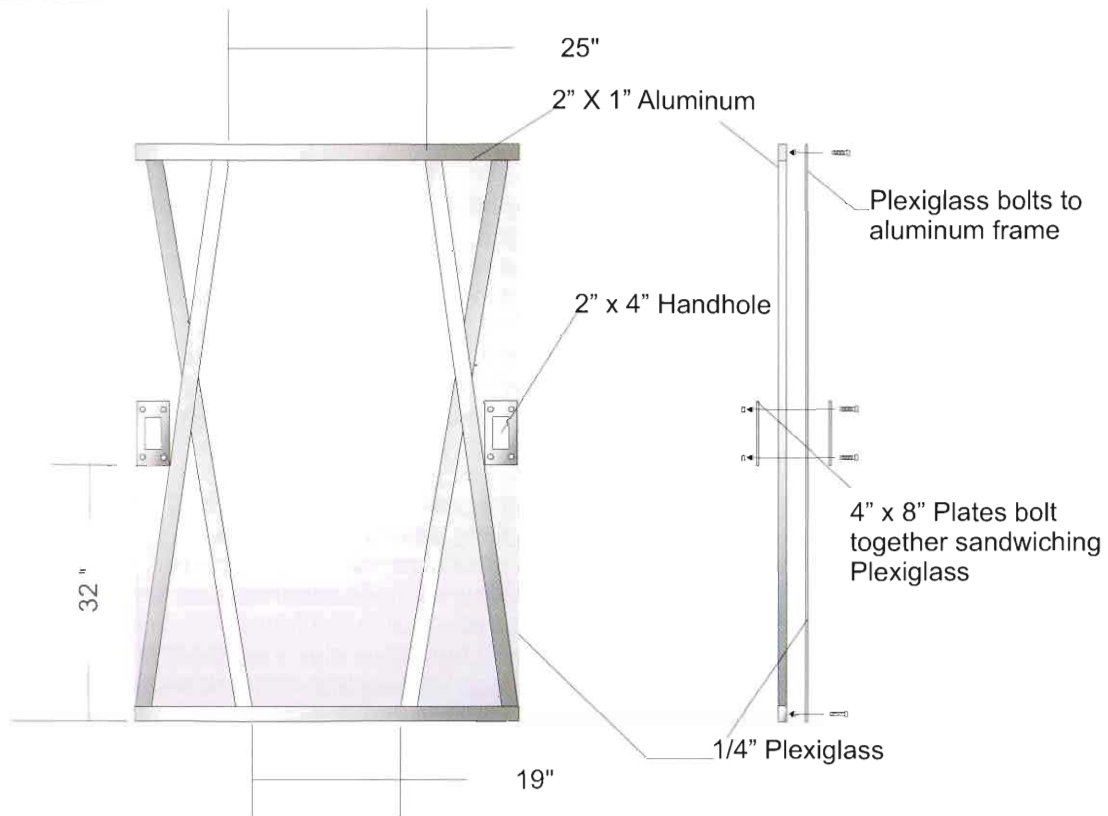
STEAM

SMOKE MACHINE PLACEMENT

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



CLEAR SCREEN



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

These views give basic dimensions of the overall size of the illusion. You can see the shape of the Magician in the load chamber. I have also detailed the names of the various pipes and parts of the illusion.

BASE

The base is just a framework with one internal brace and mesh covering the entire top of it. I have used mesh to give the illusion an open feel rather than using too many solid surfaces.

STEP

Similar to the base, the step is framework with mesh on top. The top view also shows the downstage left leg from which a support comes across to the underside of the step.

FRAMEWORK

In these views I have removed all the pipes to make structure of the prop easier to see. The load chamber sits 35½" up from the top surface of the base to the bottom of the load chamber. The top view also shows the mirror that is on top of the load chamber.

LOAD CHAMBER

The Magician hides in this load chamber, which is basically a box with mirrors on top and bottom of it and a fake 'half' pipe on the front of it. It is essentially a mirror tunnel without the sides. The middle section of pipe hinges upwards to allow the Magician to slide out to make the appearance. I would make this piece from 3/4" x 2" steel framework (with the 3/4" dimension as the height so as not to take up too much of the available space) with the top of the chamber constructed in a thinner material, 1/2" x 2". The top and bottom skinned on the outside in 1/8" aluminum sheet with the mirror glued to it. Assuming the mirror is 1/4" thick, this would leave a total inside space of 9" for the Magician. If you feel you need more than 9", then adjust the size of the middle pipe to allow this (you may want to make all the other pipes slightly larger as well, to keep good proportions).

LOAD CHAMBER PIPE

The pipe on the front of the actual load chamber is only a 'half' pipe (to create the illusion this is a full pipe there are two ends of the pipe that stick out of the framework that are made from full round pipe). The load chamber pipe does not have the upstage half of the pipe, as it is only a half and because of the mirror positions, that upstage half of the pipe is cancelled out.

If I had not added the 1" edging top and bottom, it would be apparent that the load chamber pipe is not a complete pipe. Imagine a shell billiard ball. If you hold it up and look at it, it is obviously only half not full round (unless you are dead straight on). Once placed between the fingers for a multiplying balls routine, the fingers obscure the vision of the back half of the ball so you can not tell it is only half.

All the pipes on this illusion have a 1" x 1" edging on them. I would simply use wood for this, drilled and attached with self tapping screws into the plastic pipe. The edging on the pipes does the same job as the fingers do in the billiard balls routine. I added the edging to all the other pipes to keep the look consistent.

VERTICAL PIPE #1

The pipes that pass around and 'through' the load chamber area are really what 'sell' the illusion of open space in the middle of the prop. This pipe is 6 1/2" diameter pipe (see more info on the pipes at the end of these notes) that runs right 'through' the load chamber. The pipe is built in two parts and actually butts up to the top and bottom mirrors. The top half of pipe is held up by the 2" tube from the framework. The lower part of this pipe is attached to the framework where it passes outside the frame. Once outside the frame, it bends around and heads upstage where it will joint up with horizontal pipe #2. The lower part may also need a support coming up from the base, although I have not shown this on the drawings. Because of the mirrors, the reflection of the straight piece of pipe gives the illusion of the pipe passing through the load chamber.

VERTICAL PIPE #2

This pipe is similar to vertical pipe #1 in that it passes 'through' the load chamber. The top part of the pipe is held up by the 2" tube cross bar on the framework and it 'sits' on the top mirror surface. The top part also heads back down and upstage where it joins to horizontal pipe #1. The lower part of the pipe is attached to the underside mirror surface and supported from the base, although I have not shown this in the drawings.

HORIZONTAL PIPES #1 & #2

I chose to draw these two pipes together as they are linked together in the reflection. horizontal pipe #1 has a full pipe end sticking out 8" on the stage right side. The pipe passes right over the back edge of the load chamber - it is actually a 'half' pipe (this time, cut in half with the upper half only remaining) sitting on the top mirror surface. The mirror reflects the top half of this pipe, completing the pipe (if you look at this pipe in the last picture on the story board you can see the reflected images on the pipe inverted across the mirror line). Horizontal pipe #2 has a full pipe stub sticking out of the stage left side of the framework. This pipe is actually a full pipe running across and under the load chamber, the same distance from the back of the prop as horizontal pipe #1. The underside mirror on the load chamber perfectly bisects the space between horizontal pipe #2 and #1 (I have shown this on the drawing as the 13 3/4" measurement from the outer edge of each pipe to the line of the underside mirror). When looking at the prop from a lower point of view horizontal pipe #2 will reflect in the underside mirror as horizontal pipe #1.

PANELS

The panels on the sides of the load chamber are 41 1/2" x 48". The diagram on the left shows the inside view of the panel with lines showing where the mirrors and load chamber are positioned. Two signs are included on the inside of each of these panels. The signs work just like horizontal pipes #1 and #2, in that the top sign is only half height and is reflected in the top mirror to complete it. The bottom sign is positioned an equal distance from the bottom mirror so its reflection appears as the top sign. The signs (in keeping with the industrial theme of this prop) are an 'ID' number and a Carbon Dioxide warning sign. You may think this is taking it too far, but I couldn't resist including these clever little signs.

Both signs share interesting common properties in their design - each sign is symmetrical across its horizontal axis and (because of the symmetry) each sign appears the same if you reflect it upside down in a mirror. I have drawn in a halfway reflection line. This is where the sign will sit against the top mirror - place a mirror along this line and the sign will still read exactly the same. Now, place a mirror above the sign (to simulate how the bottom sign will be seen in the mirror) and the reflection will also read exactly the same. The mirroring of the word 'Dioxide' is from an old trick my science teacher used to do with the words 'Carbon Dioxide' and a glass stirring rod. It seemed appropriate to use it here.

SMOKE MACHINE PLACEMENT

I am showing three smoke machines to cover the appearance of the Magician, however, two could be enough. The smoke comes out of three points on the prop, the two ends of the vertical pipes and from the stage left end of the load chamber pipe. Machine #1 is positioned inside the load chamber just downstage of the Magician's head. Machine #2 is in the load chamber with a pipe angling the smoke down out of the load chamber and into the pipe - it sits upstage of the Magician's head. Smoke machines get hot, so it is very important to have proper protection around the machines to ensure the Magician does not get burnt. The machines could be controlled by the Magician in the illusion or outside by the crew.

CLEAR SCREEN

Smoke needs something to hit to give adequate cover for the appearance. The screen is held in front of the area where the Magician will appear for the smoke to bellow against. The screen is a piece of 1/4" plexiglass bolted to a 2" x 1" aluminum frame. The hand holes are just holes cut in the plexiglass and then a plate, with a corresponding hand hole in it, is bolted to each side.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

The framework is all finished in a yellow powder coat finish on the aluminum. I would finish the mesh parts of the base and step in a grey or silver. Bob North at Splashes Creative Services suggested using plastic pipes for all the pipes. Metal pipes would add considerably to the weight of the prop. If you have ever tried to buy pipe before you'll know that pipe sizes are a bit different to tube sizes.

6" Sch. 40 pipe is actually just over 6 1/2" for the smaller pipes. For the load chamber pipe use a 9" air duct or an 8" Sch 40 pipe, which is around 8 5/8" (3/8" smaller than the ideal 9"). The 8" pipe fittings and elbows could be used on the ends of the pipe to keep the look the same as the other pipes.

For the story boards I had all the pipes finished in a chrome metal look. The pipes could be painted with a bright silver. Alternatively, there is a product I have had some success using from Alsa Corp (their info is in the RESOURCES section). Alsa sells a metal contact paper - its made of real metal (very thin) on a thin layer of Lexan with a peel off adhesive backing. It cuts with scissors or a knife blade, goes on like contact paper and looks like real metal. They have a polished aluminum, that would give a real chrome look to the pipes, also a brushed aluminum that would also look really good. This would probably be an excellent product to 'spice' up that old Zig-Zag in your garage.

The panels on the illusion would be finished in a grey or dull silver paint finish, possibly with a confusing texture look so as to hide the mirror line. I had the 'C-Dioxide' sign in black and yellow and the 'ID number' sign in red and white.

ETC...

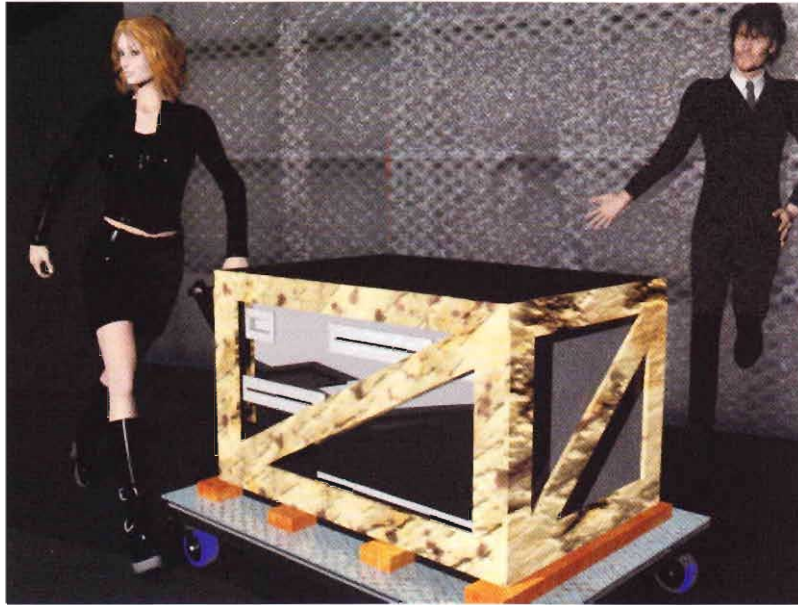
I know this prop looks fairly complicated and it is to a degree, although, I hope it seems easier to follow now I have broken it down one pipe at a time. I have always liked the idea of passing objects through a mirrored area to give the perception that the area is open. Both mirrors will, of course, reflect the backdrop behind the illusion - much like a mirror tunnel. It is important that the backdrop be consistent design or feature vertical lines only (the folds of the curtain, or a rain curtain etc.). I feel that slight discrepancies in the backdrop won't be noticed because the main focus is the pipes on the prop.

I'm sure you will have concluded that once past a certain upper or lower viewing angle reflected images of the pipes will start to conflict. For instance, from low down looking up the top of the pipe will vanish and you will see the reflection of the bottom of the pipe in the air. Careful positioning of the prop on stage will solve this - if the front row looking up sees the wrong thing the prop needs to move slightly further upstage. You also have the advantage that people in a theater are in seats and do not have the chance to look at the illusion from down low then up high. Their only perception of the pipes is that of the position they see it from when the curtains open. Slight discrepancies could still work with extreme viewing angles.

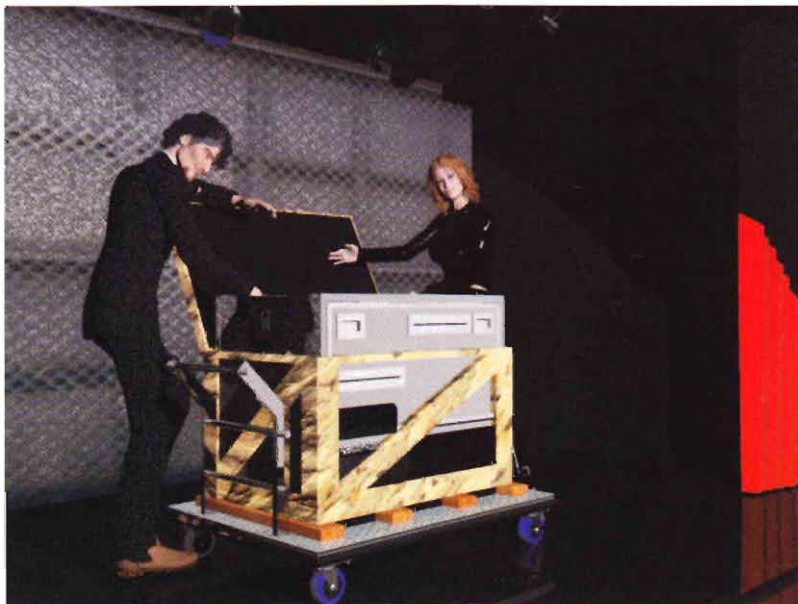
The beauty of 3d modeling on the computer is it enables me to put the mirrors on the prop (they behave like real mirrors reflecting in the 3d view) then view the illusion from all conceivable angles to see how it looks. Look again at the story board pictures. The mirrors are there and you can see the reflected parts of the prop in them.

I came up with the idea for this illusion basing the mirror setup on the mirror tunnel principal. After my initial designs I found the plans for a Robert Harbin illusion in which a girl passed through a small pipe. The mirror setup in Harbin's illusion along with the side panels is very similar to Steam.

HEADZ UP



The Magician's new illusion has just arrived. It is so new it is still in its packing crate. The assistant enters with the crate containing the illusion. The crate has an open front and the illusion box can be seen inside.



The Magician and assistant remove the illusion from the crate. Because there is nowhere else to put the illusion, the Magician sets the illusion on top of the crate. There is a clear view of the empty crate through its open front.



The assistant sits in the illusion box with her legs sticking out of the hole in the front door. The Magician takes a saw and pretends to cut the assistant at the waist (the audience is not convinced), so the Magician lifts the assistant's upper body and places it next to her legs (all inside the box). The Magician then saws again at the assistant's neck and apparently places her head in the bottom of the illusion box.



The audience doesn't seem convinced - so the Magician removes the front of the box and drops all the doors to show the assistant cut into three pieces. The box is closed up and the Magician tells the assistant to 'pull herself together!' - The box is opened and the assistant is restored to one piece.

METHOD

A mirror inside the crate placed at 45 degrees, reflects the bottom of the crate as the back. Once inside the illusion box, the assistant pushes down through the spandex top on the crate and sits into the space behind the mirror (this is when the Magician pretends to cut her head off and then pushes it out of sight). Once sat on the mirror, the assistant pulls the back wall of the illusion box down to become the floor. This back wall has the fake body parts of the assistant's thighs and hips; torso and arms - all in the 'cut into three' configuration. The assistant places her head through the head hole in the illusion box floor and her hand through a hole that corresponds with the end of the fake arm.

The diagram on the next page shows the assistant's position when cut into three.

In performance the assistant pushes out the prop with the illusion box inside the crate. The illusion box has no bottom to it and fits around the mirror triangle unit that is inside the crate. The Magician and assistant open the crate, lift out the illusion box and then close the crate and set the box on top - locating the pins on the illusion box with the holes on the lid of the crate.

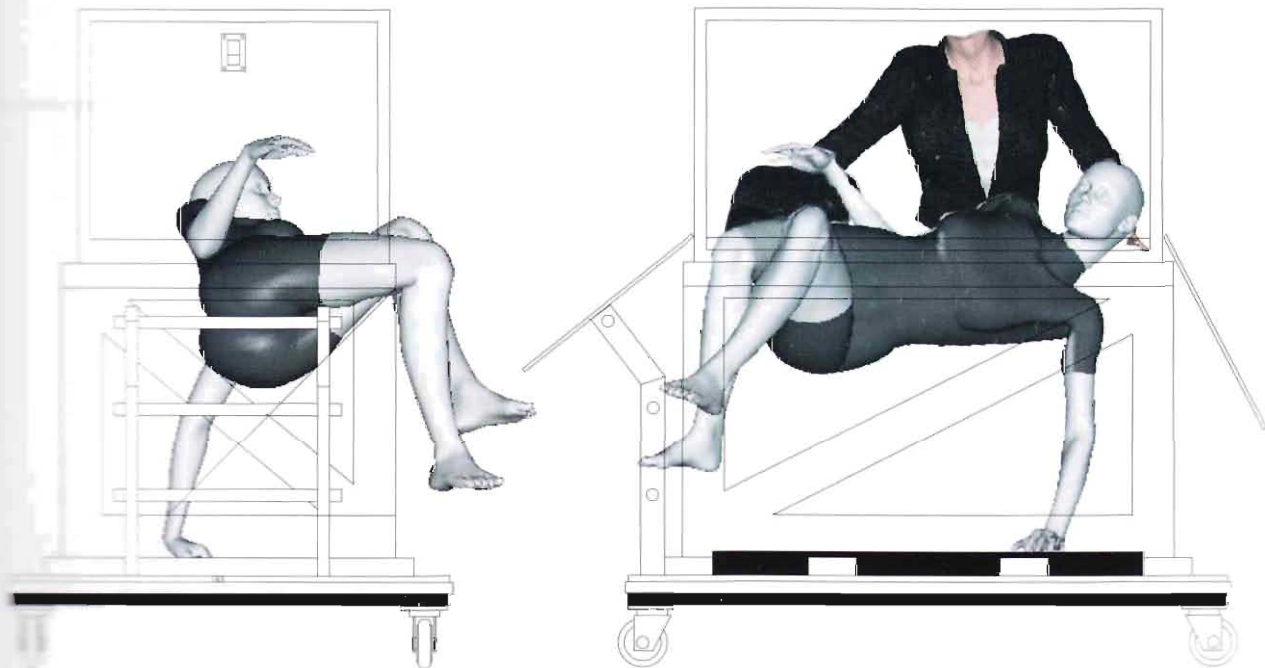
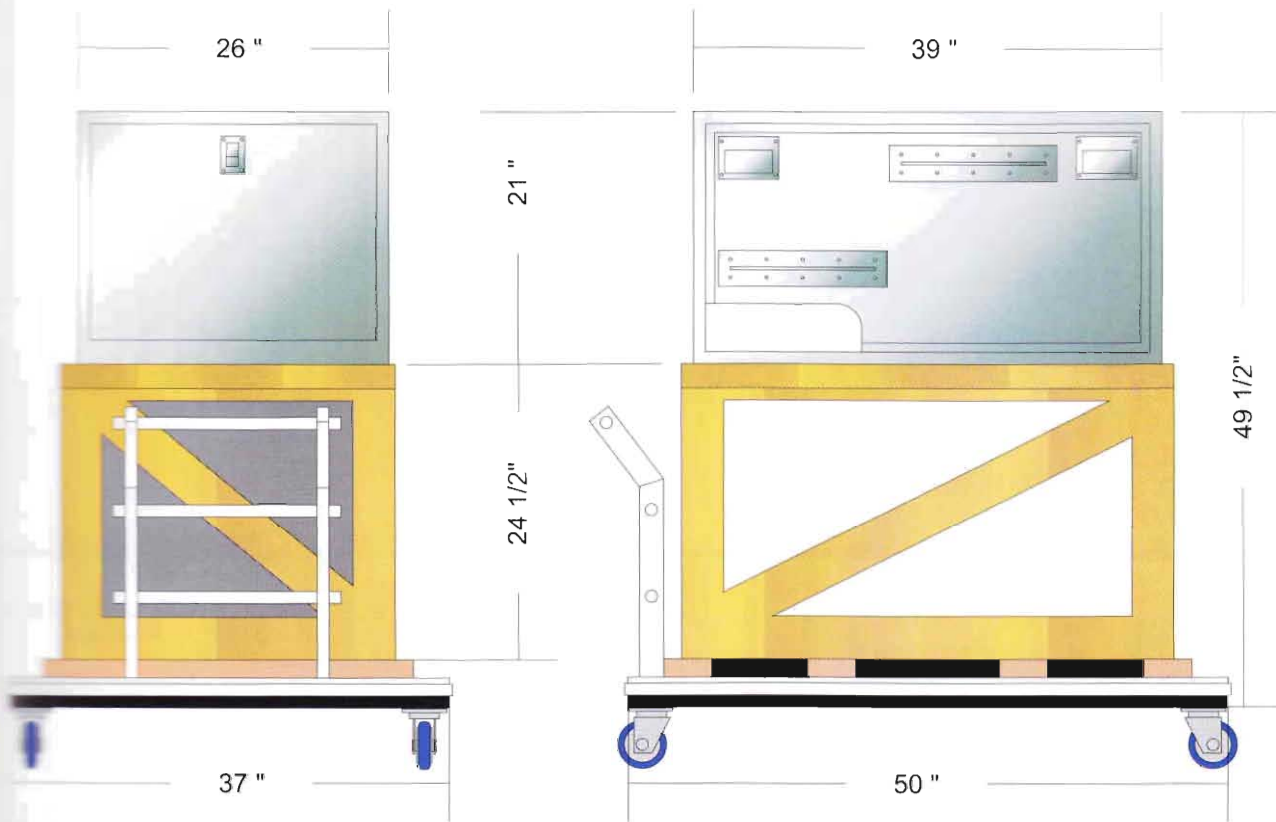
The assistant gets into the box by leaning over into it and then sitting up straight with her head and shoulders out the top. The assistant supports her weight by placing a hand on the framework of the box to keep herself in a position that looks like she is sitting on the floor of the illusion box. The Magician puts the front of the box on so the assistant's legs stick out of the front.

The Magician pretends to saw the assistant at the waist by inserting the saw through the lower slot and sawing along, without the saw ever going in far enough to touch the assistant. This is played for laughs more than realism. The Magician explains that the assistant is now in two pieces and lifts the assistant by the shoulders and moves her over to the middle of the box. The assistant slides her shoulders over with the Magician and then sits down a few inches through the spandex on the crate lid, still supporting herself by resting on the framework of the illusion box.

Now the Magician pretends to cut off the assistant's head. This is the same motion as before. The saw is swiftly pushed through and 'sawn' along the slot, not going in far enough to touch the assistant. The Magician then pretends to move the assistant's head to the far side of the box. The assistant ducks fully out of sight and the Magician's hands in the box (through the top) mime the action of putting the head onto the floor of the box.

The assistant now removes the velvet covering the false back and releases the barrel bolt that holds it up, lowering it onto herself. As it comes down, the assistant puts her head through the head hole. The assistant uses her left hand to support herself against the crate attachment pieces in the bottom of the crate. The assistant's free right hand pushes up through the hole in the floor, through the hips body fake and sticks out the hole to appear to be at the end of the sleeve.

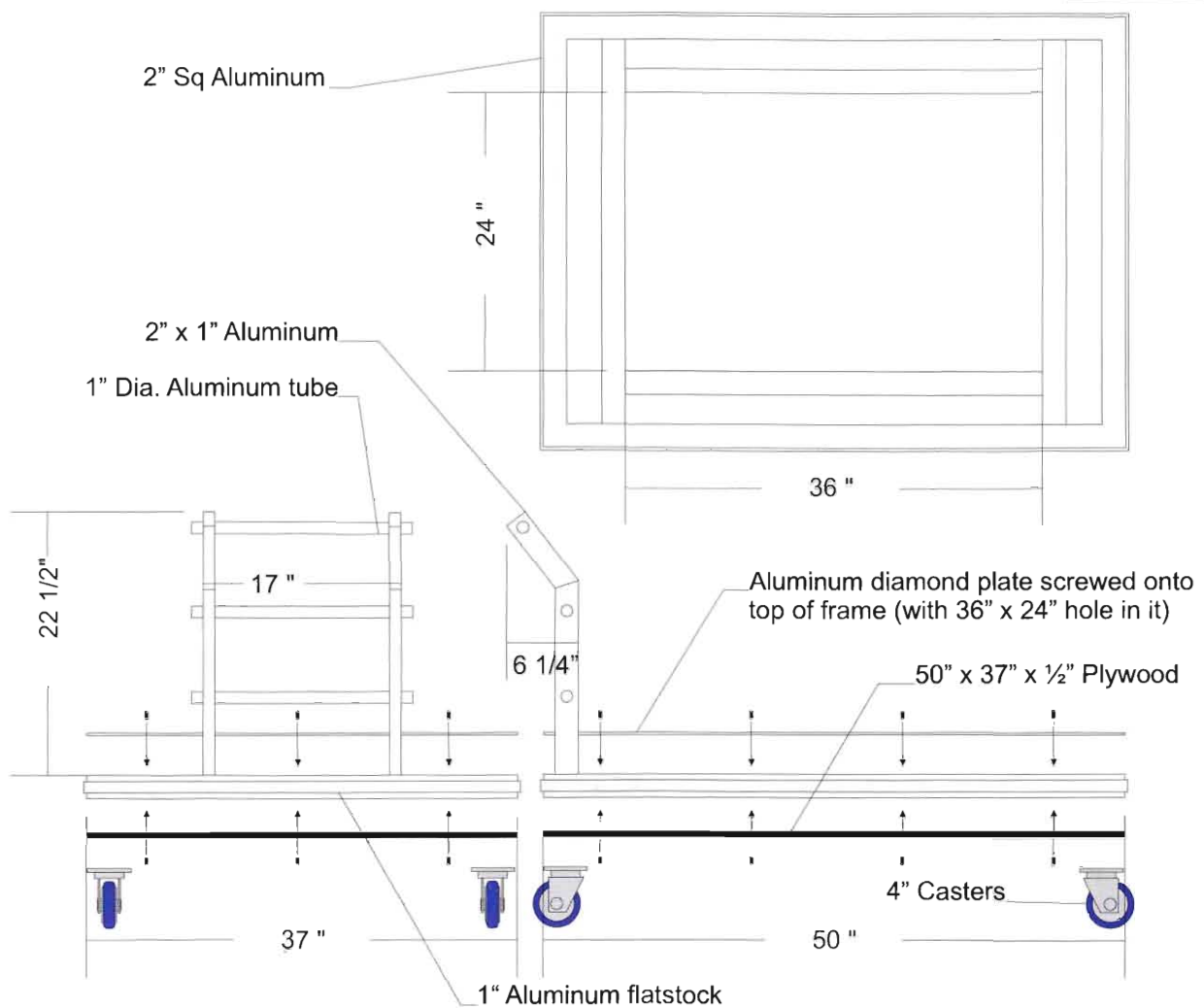
The Magician opens the box to show the assistant cut into three pieces. Once the box is closed again, the assistant lifts the floor up again to become the false back of the illusion box and re-attaches the velvet that covers it. The assistant now sits back up to a sitting position and is restored.



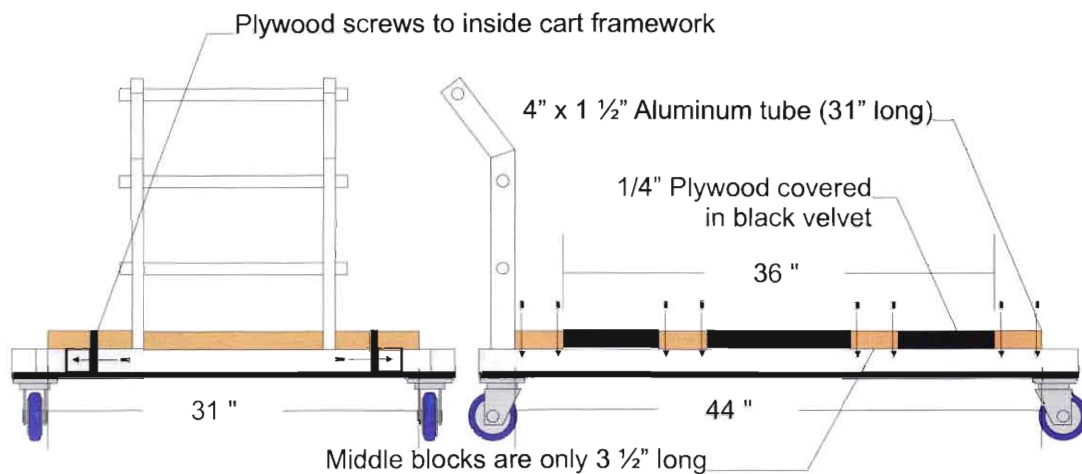
HEADZ UP

CART BASE

Scale $3/4" = 1'$

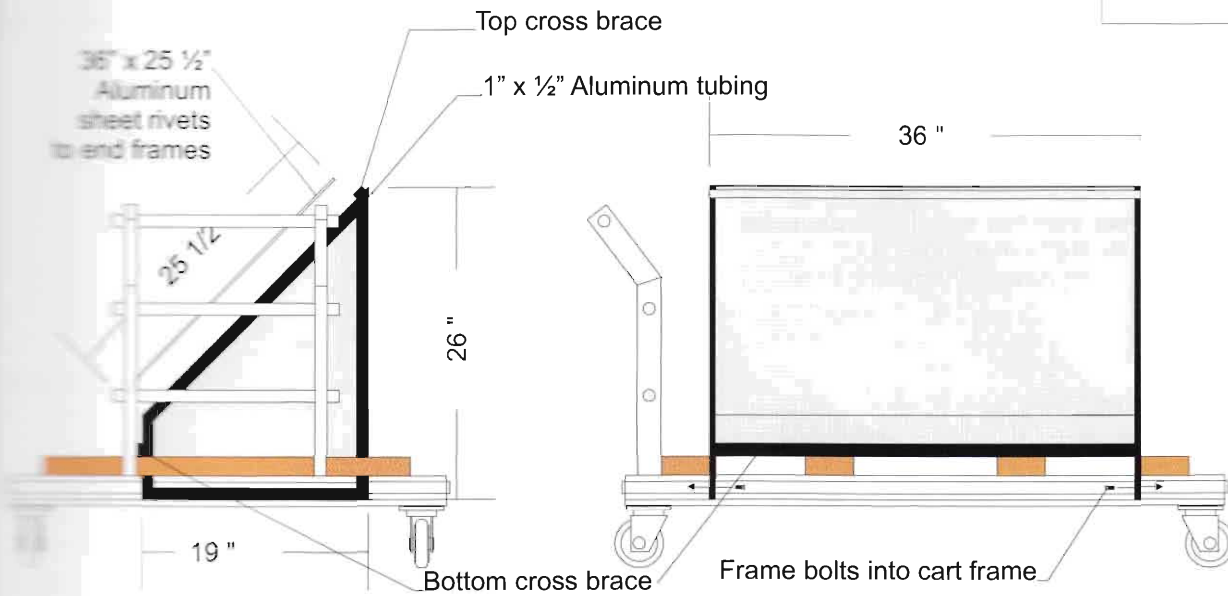


BLOCKS AND BLACK BACKING

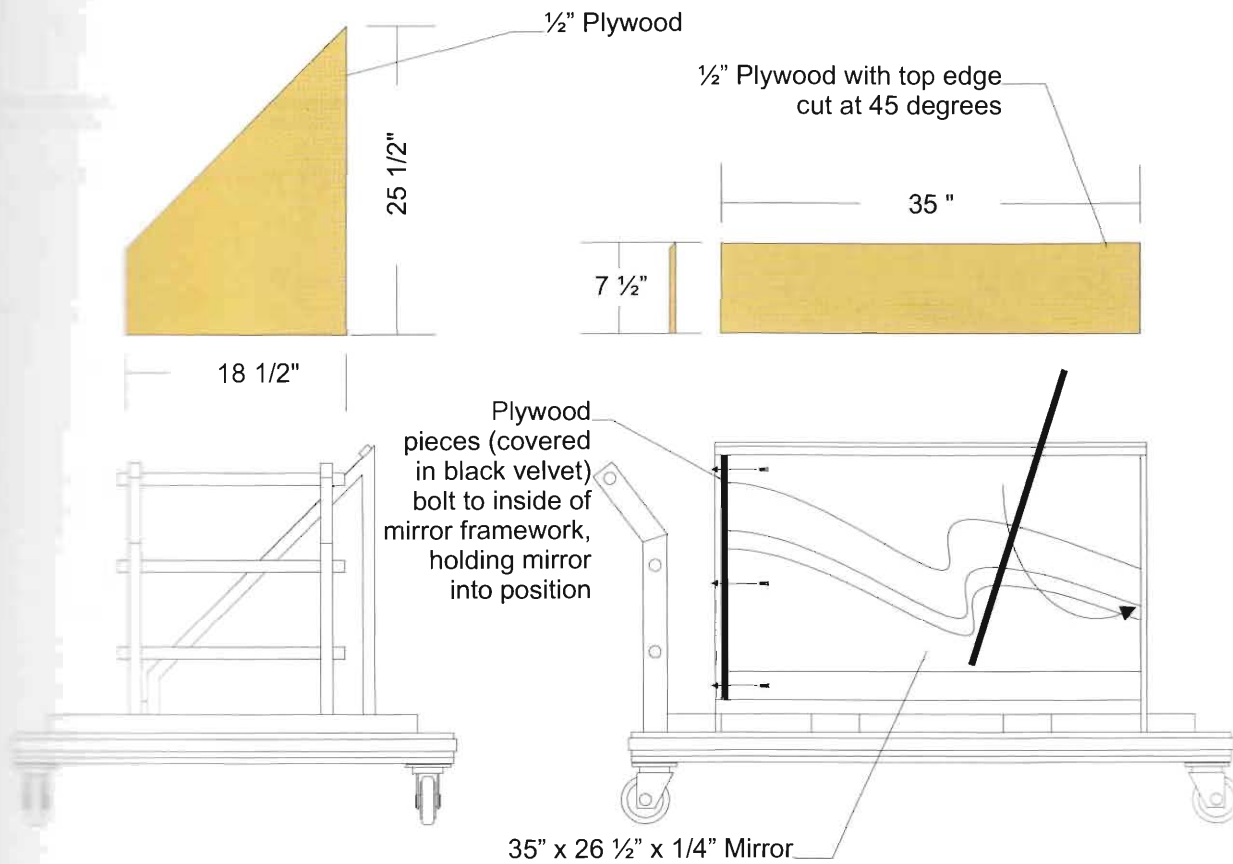


MIRROR FRAMEWORK

Scale 3/4" = 1'

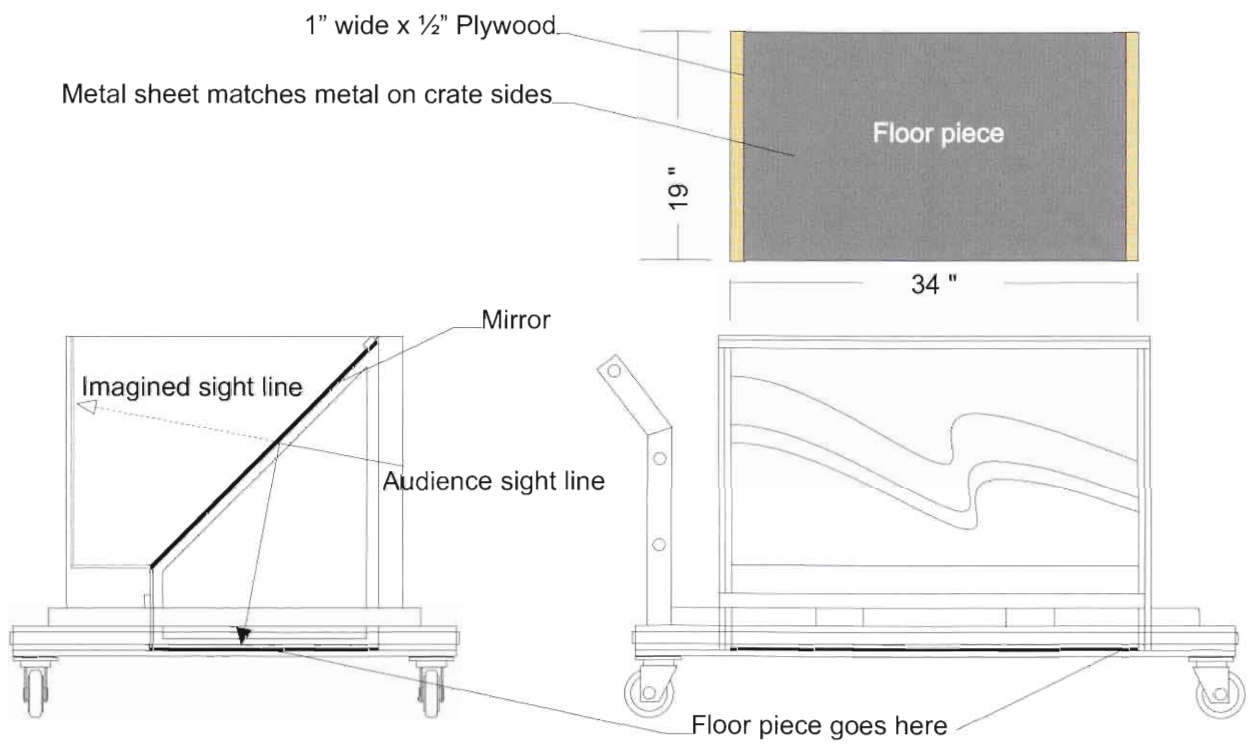


MIRROR AND WOOD PIECES

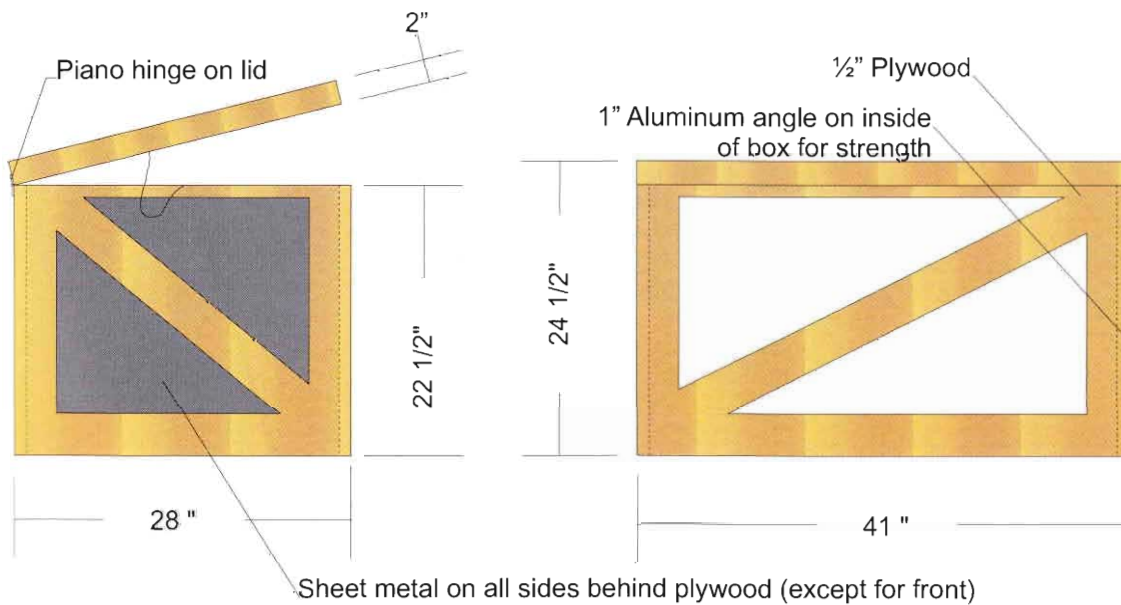


INSIDE FLOOR

Scale 3/4" = 1'



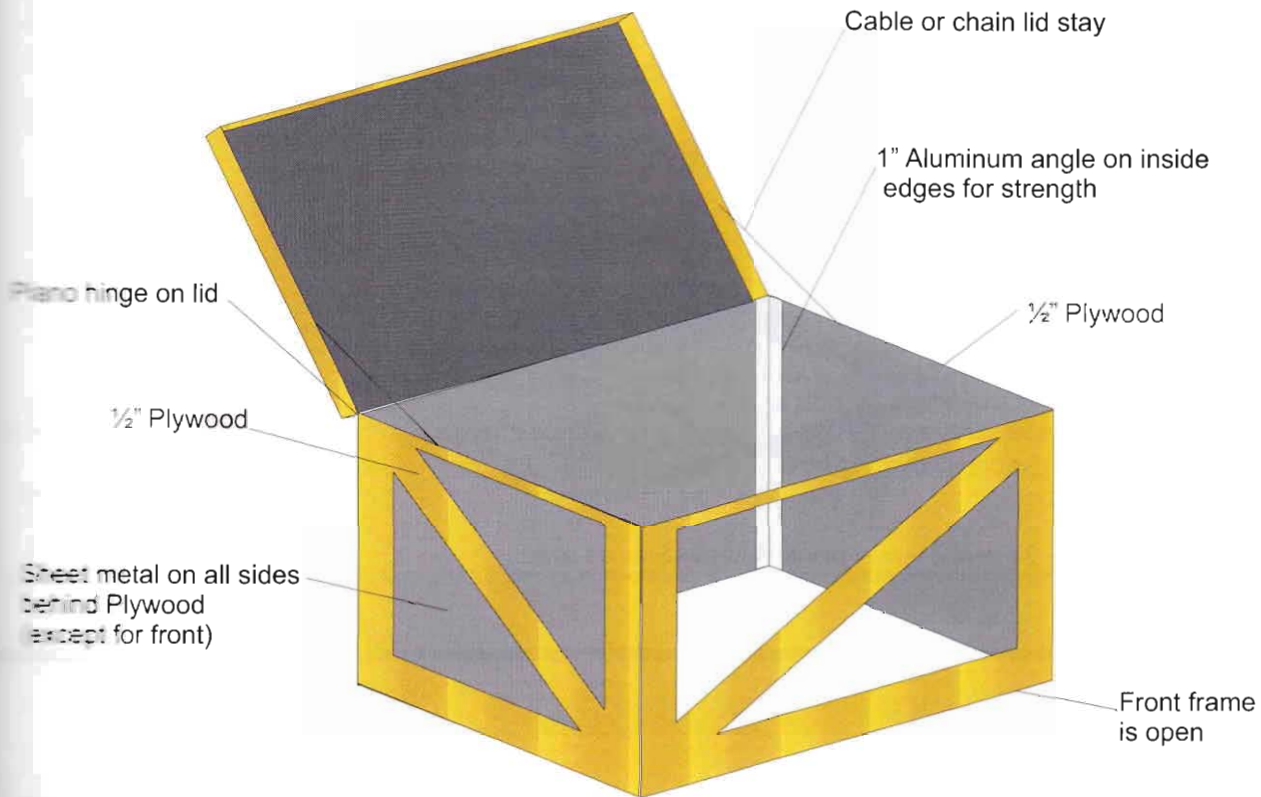
CRATE



HEADZ UP

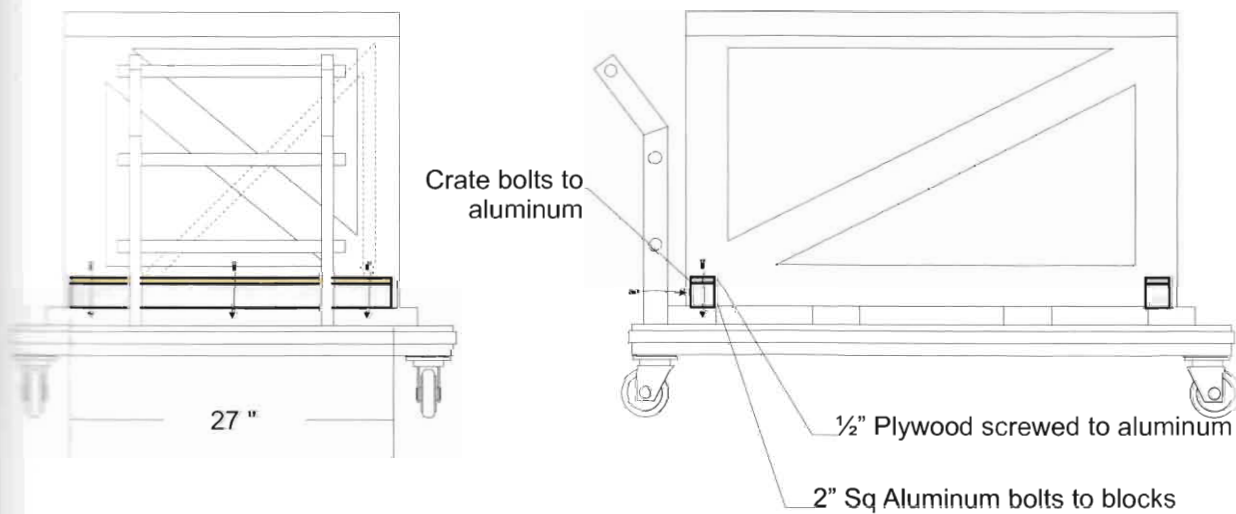
CRATE (3D VIEW)

Not to Scale



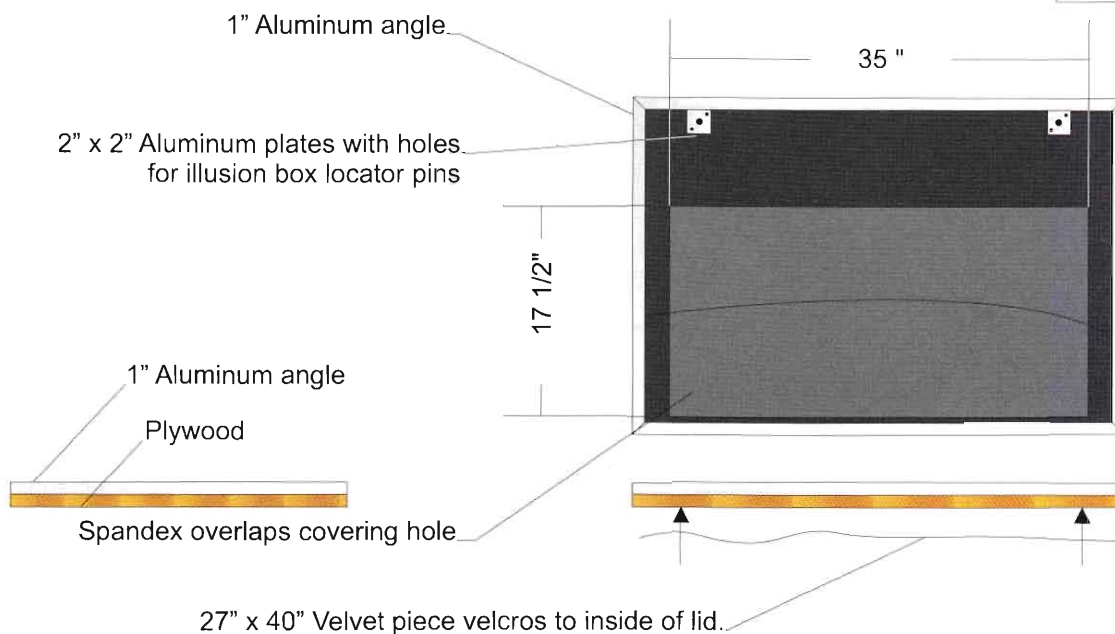
CRATE ATTACHMENT TO CART

Scale 3/4" = 1'

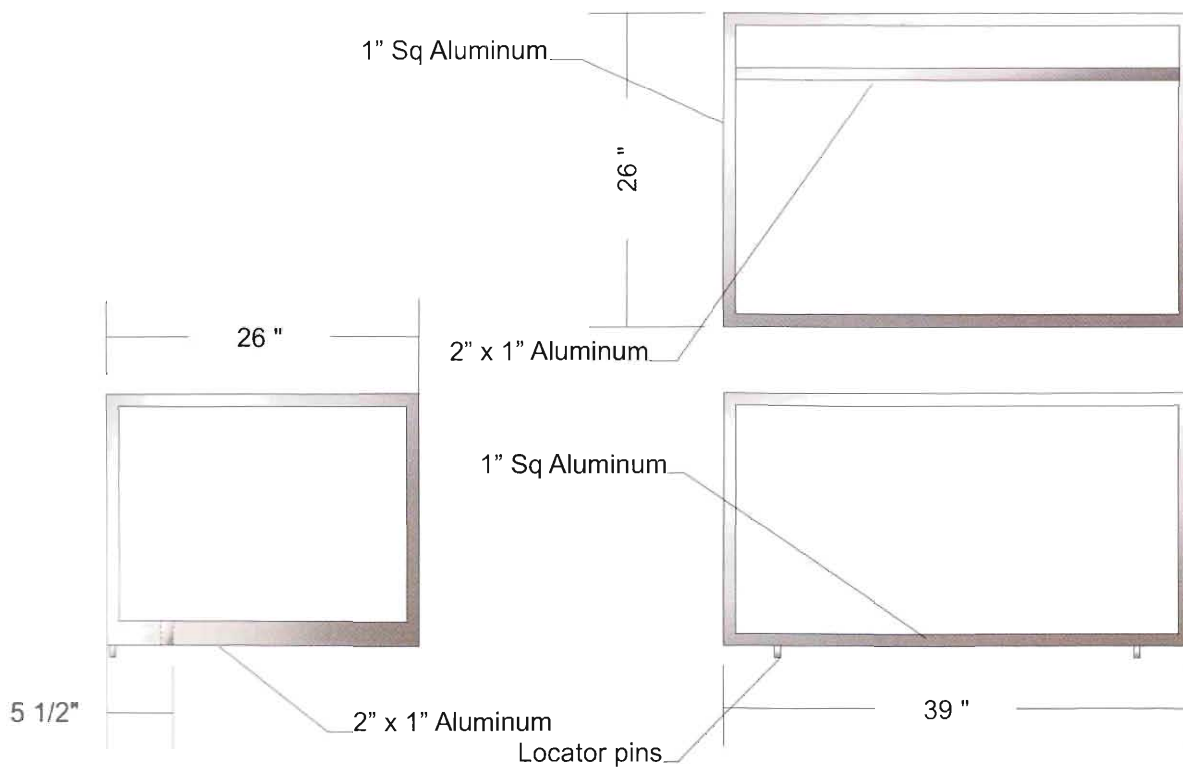


CRATE LID

Scale 3/4" = 1'

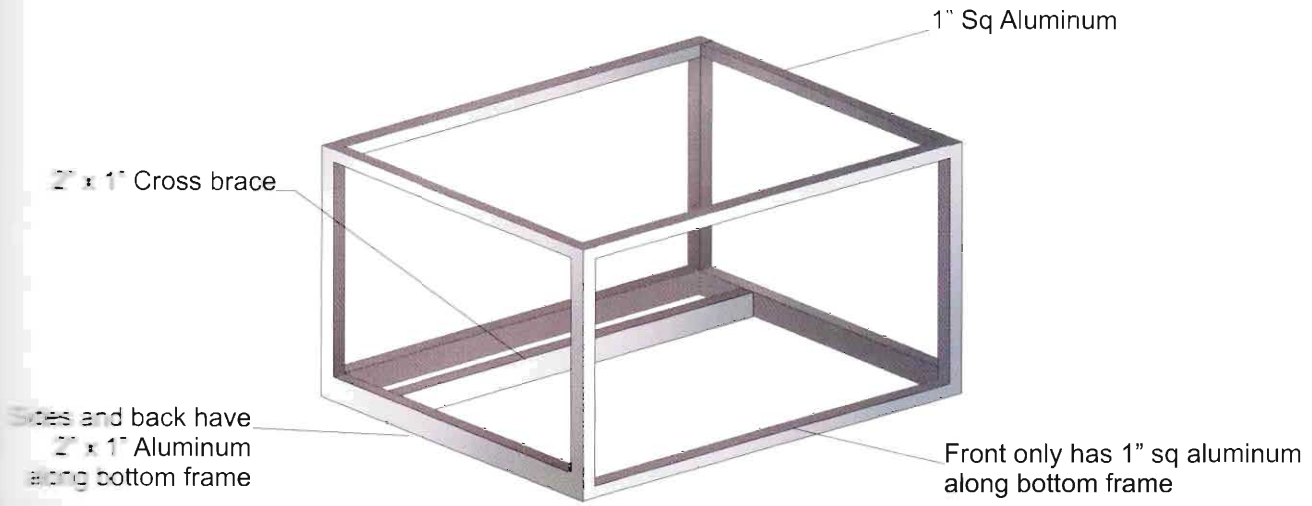


ILLUSION BOX FRAMEWORK



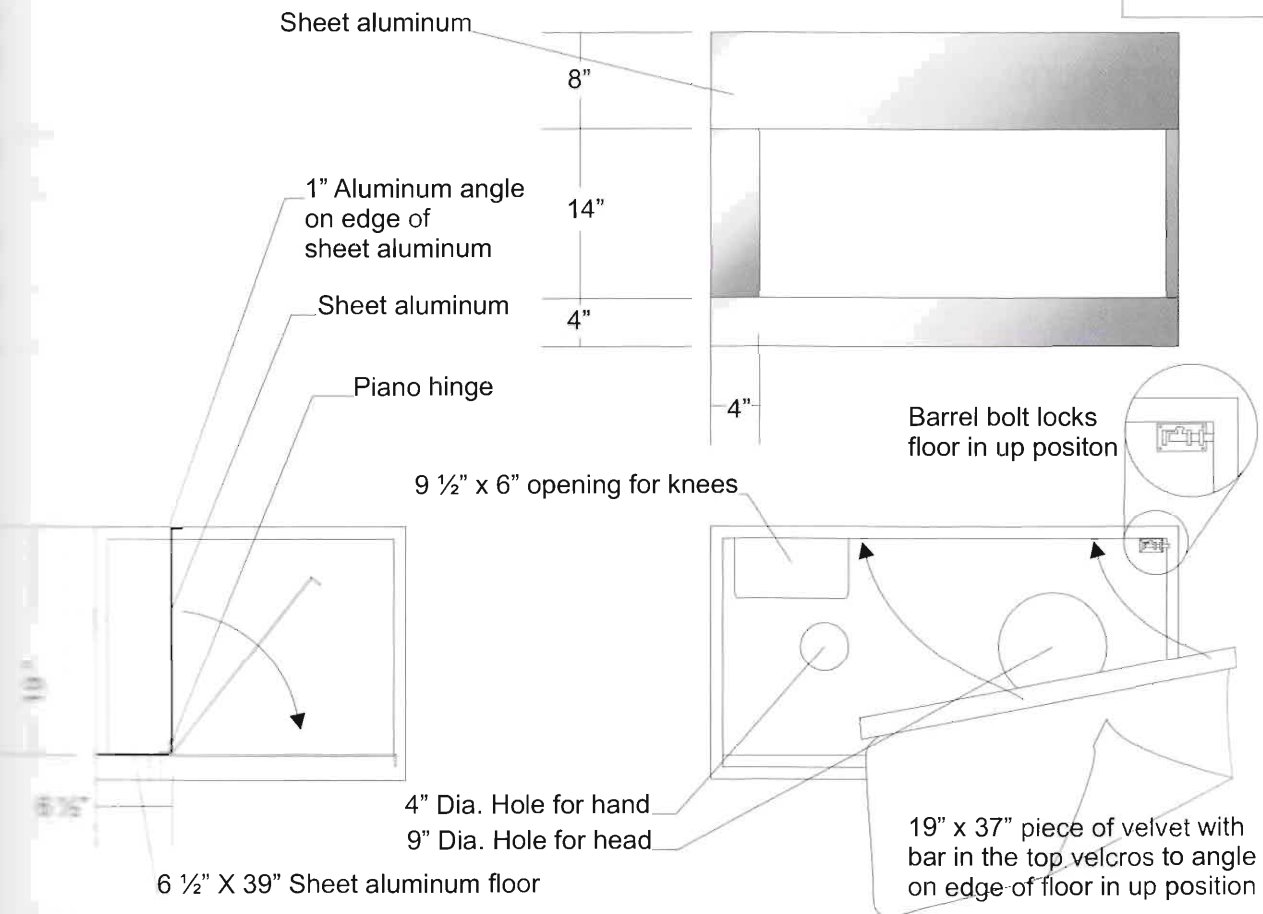
ILLUSION BOX FRAMEWORK (3D VIEW)

Not to Scale



ILLUSION BOX TOP AND INSIDE FLOOR

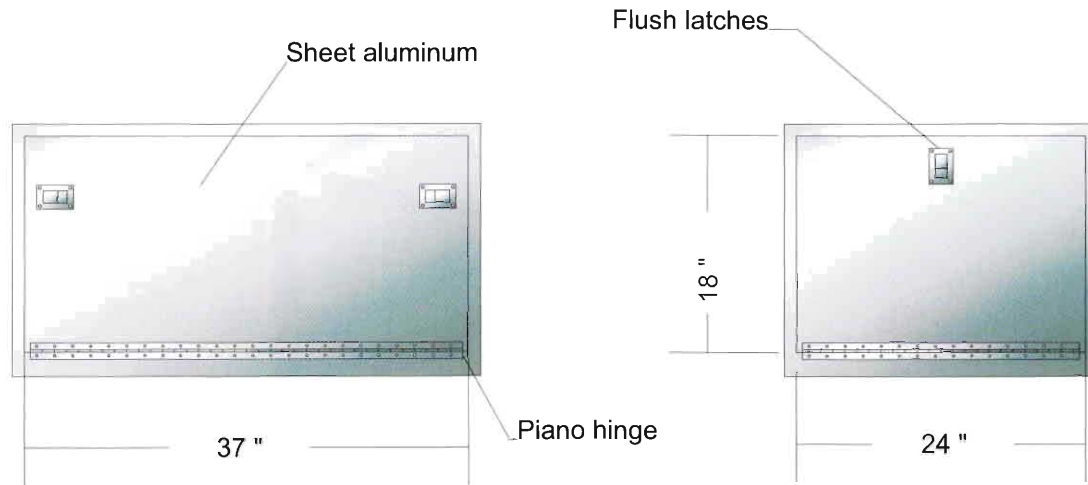
Scale 3/4" = 1'



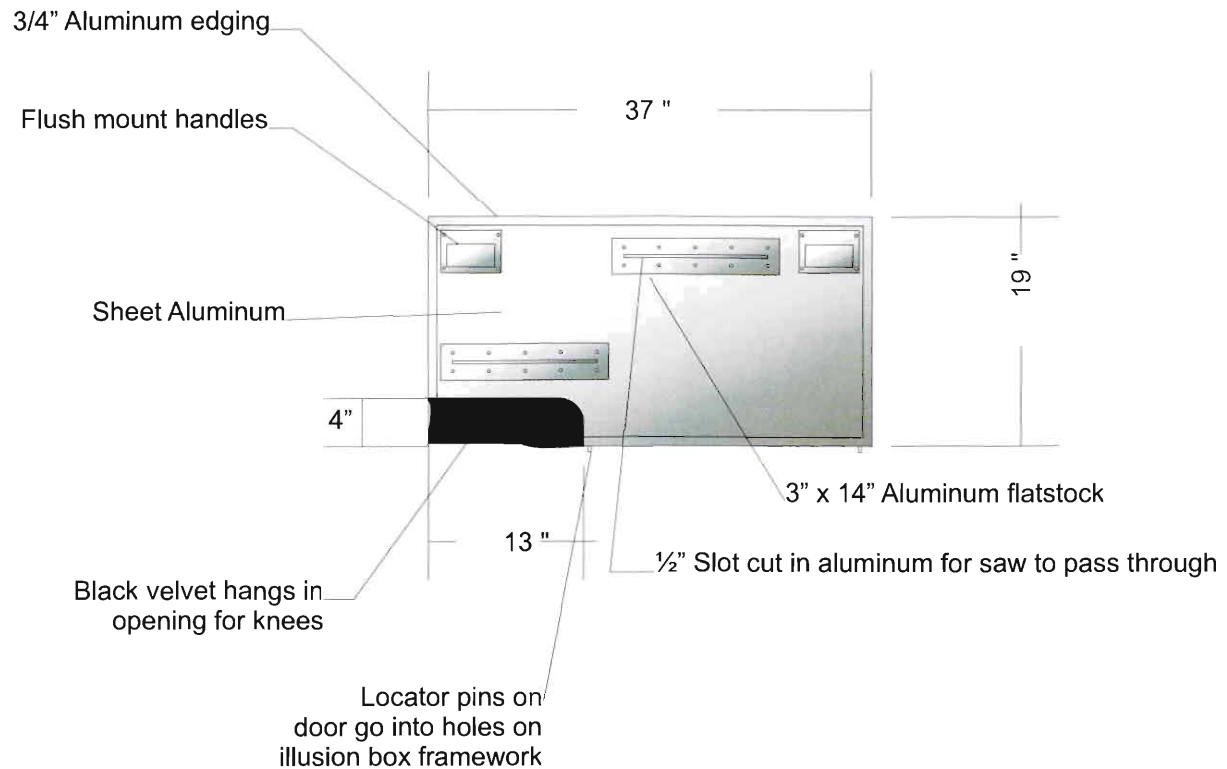
HEADZ UP

SIDE AND BACK DOORS

Scale $3/4" = 1'$

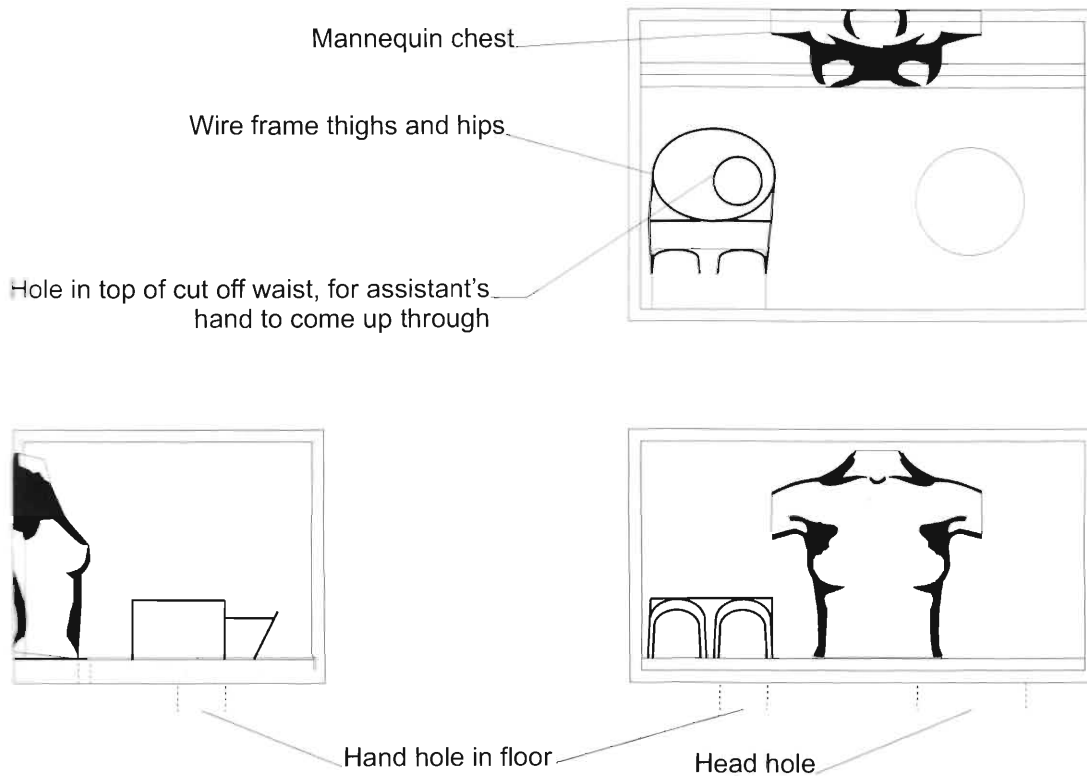


FRONT DOOR

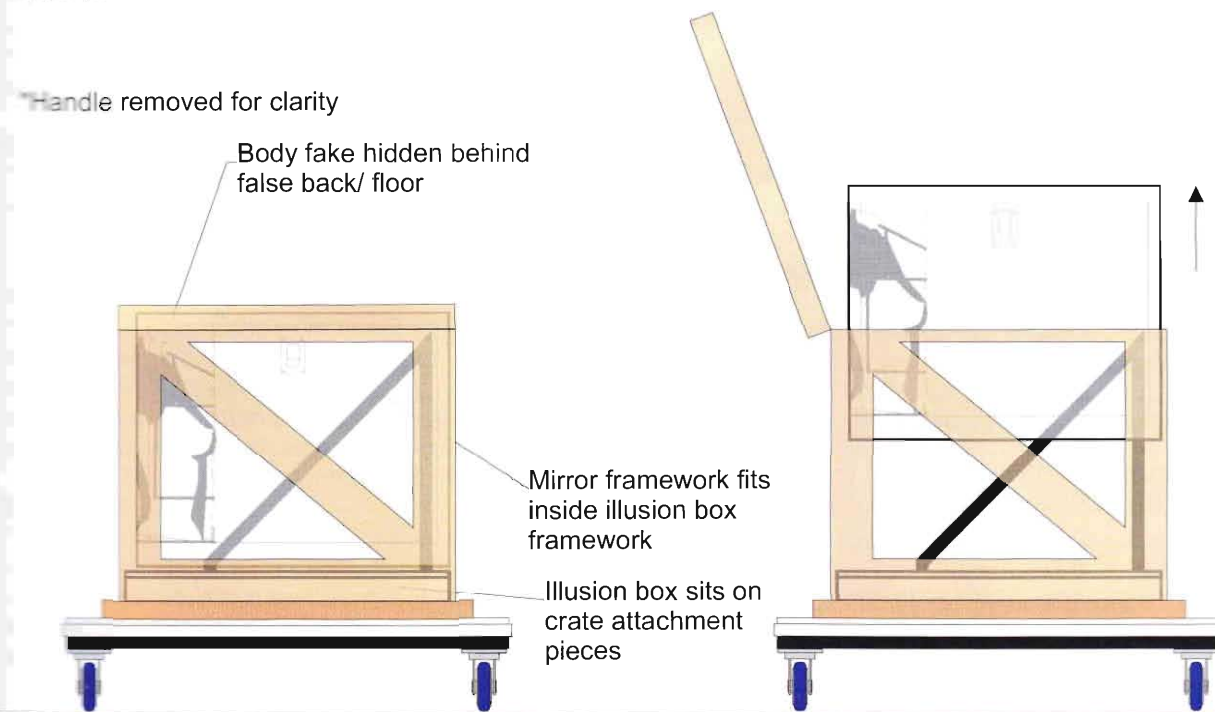


BODY FAKE

Scale 3/4" = 1'



ILLUSION BOX FITTING INSIDE CRATE



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

The top drawing shows the basic prop dimensions with the Illusion box sitting out on top of the crate. Although not shown in this drawing, the front of the crate is open to allow the audience to see into it. The assistant's body position is shown on the lower drawings. Trust me, this is not a comfortable position to get into, but it looks very effective in this illusion.

CART BASE

The base of the cart is made from a frame of 2" sq aluminum, with an inner frame - like a mini deceptive base. The plywood on the bottom adds another 1/2" making the total 2 1/2". I would round off bottom edge of the plywood with a router. The bottom of the cart base is covered in black velvet that wraps up the side of the aluminum and is glued or taped to the aluminum behind the 1" flat stock trim. The casters bolt into the 2" sq aluminum through the plywood. The top of the frame is covered with thin aluminum diamond plate. The center of the frame is left open with no diamond plate covering it.

BLOCKS AND BLACK BACKING

The idea here is the crate is sitting on four long blocks - like you would put under something if you were putting it down with a forklift and needed to get the forks out afterwards. The two outermost blocks are full length (31") but the center two are just stubs on the front and back. A black backing piece made from 1/4" plywood covered in black velvet goes, behind these stub pieces, again keeping the hole in the base open.

MIRROR FRAMEWORK

Most mirror boxes are built as a box with a mirror set in them. In this case, as the illusion box will appear to lift out of the crate, the mirror and inside edges of the box are built as a separate unit. The illusion box will slide over the mirror unit, then the crate sits on the outside. The frame needs to be strong enough to take some of the assistant's weight as she will be sitting back against the mirror and it must not flex. The top and bottom cross braces give most of the support, and the side frames sit inside the hole in the cart base, bolted to the cart framework. The sheet aluminum that attaches to the frame is to take the main weight of the assistant sitting against it.

MIRROR AND WOOD PIECES

The wood pieces hold the mirror in position. The pieces go outside the mirror and are covered in black velvet. With good stage lighting, you can almost make the mirror line invisible when it butts up to the velvet in this way.

INSIDE FLOOR

Because the mirror is set at 45 degrees, the audience perceive they are looking through the mirror and seeing the back of the box. They are, of course, looking at the floor of the box reflected to appear as the back. Because I have set the floor lower into the bottom of the cart, the reflected image appears further back. It lines up with the back of the box and gives greater unseen space inside the box for the assistant. The floor matches the metal used on the outside of the crate with wood strips that mimic the wood on the crate. I chose not to put a design on the inside sides. Instead, the velvet on the wood pieces is reflected and appears as full black velvet sides. The visual focus is entirely on the back of the crate to re-enforce to the audience the sense of depth and space inside.

CRATE

The crate is made from 1/2" plywood, with the design cut out with a jigsaw. The sides are backed by sheet metal (some sort of decorative aluminum - a perforated metal with a black backing; a brushed finish or a stucco aluminum). To add strength to the crate, the plywood is bolted to 1" aluminum angle on the inside corners. The crate has no bottom of course.

CRATE (3D VIEW)

This is a better view showing the open front, aluminum angle on the insides and sheet metal on the outside.

CRATE ATTACHMENT TO CART

Two lengths of 2" sq aluminum bolt to the block pieces. The crate drops over them and bolts from the outside into them. The ½" plywood strip on top of each piece is screwed on and serves as a place for the illusion box to sit when it drops into the crate.

CRATE LID

The lid is made of plywood and hinges to the crate. The plywood has a hole cut in it for the assistant to pass through. This hole is cut just 1½" back from the front of the crate. The entire top is then covered with overlapping spandex to cover the hole. The spandex is stapled to the plywood at the very edge of the lid. The aluminum angle around the lid helps to strengthen it and hides the staples and edge of the spandex. The two plates with holes in them are for locating and locking the illusion box in place on top of the crate. A piece of velvet with velcro sewn around the edge of it is used on the inside of the lid to cover the hole. When the lid is opened to take out the illusion box, the audience will see the velvet on the inside of the lid. Once the illusion is in progress and the assistant pushes through the lid into the crate, the velcro will come off and the velvet will just fall into the bottom of the crate behind the mirror.

ILLUSION BOX FRAMEWORK

This is the main framework of the illusion box. The box is constructed of 1" sq aluminum, except the bottom frame which is 2" x 1" aluminum on the back and sides. The front has 1" sq aluminum across the front to help keep it looking thin when the box is opened. The angle on the front edge of the inside floor (which is the false back that drops down to become the floor) will rest on the front 1" and make up the extra inch to equal the same 2" thickness this frame has on the sides and back. Notice the locator pins on the bottom of the box - these will locate onto the aluminum plates on the lid of the crate.

ILLUSION BOX FRAMEWORK (3D VIEW)

This view shows more clearly the 2" bottom frame (and cross brace) and the 1" sq aluminum on the front of that bottom frame.

ILLUSION BOX TOP AND INSIDE FLOOR

The top of the box has sheet aluminum riveted to it. This hides the back area of the box that contains the body fake parts when the inside floor is hinged up to become the false back. The lower diagrams show the floor in its 'up' position leaving a 6 ½" space at the back of the box for the body fake pieces. The arrow shows the movement of the floor as it drops over the assistant. The bottom right drawing shows the cut out holes on the floor. The barrel bolt holds the floor in the 'up' position. A simple piece of velvet with a rod across the top velcros to the angle across the top edge of the hinging floor. When the floor is up, this velvet hangs down and hides the holes and cut outs in the floor. It also blends with the black velvet on the inside of the side doors.

SIDE AND BACK DOORS

These doors are made from sheet aluminum with a piano hinge along the bottom. The latches need to be flush mount so that nothing sticks out of the box when it slides into the crate. The insides of the doors are covered with black velvet.

FRONT DOOR

The front door is made from sheet aluminum. The slot pieces for the saw are flat stock with a slot cut through them and bolted or riveted to the door (Cut a slot through the door too). The handles are flush mount (Like the latches on the sides and back). The locator pins on the bottom of the door go into holes in the 1" sq aluminum on the front of the Illusion box frame. The top of the front door has velcro along it and just pushes against velcro on the inside of the illusion box frame.

BODY FAKE

The chest section of the body fake is a plastic mannequin store display fixture. These mannequins are about 8 or 9" deep, so it needs to be trimmed with a jigsaw. Once clothed (and because this illusion is never turned around) the reduced depth is not really noticed. The thighs and hips section is made from a wire frame with a plastic disc covered in black velvet for the top of the waist where the assistant is cut. The plastic has a hole in it for the assistant's hand to come through.

To make the assistant's arms, I used foam rubber rolled into a tube with one tube for each section of arm (upper arm, lower arm). The right arm finishes resting on (attached to) the plastic disc on top of the wire frame - the assistant's hand now looks like it comes through this sleeve. The left arm finishes right behind the head and has a fake hand on it - the hand is obscured by the assistant's head. The foam rubber needs to be light enough that it can move when the floor folds up. Space is quite tight to hide all the body parts, and the right arm ends up folded tight at the elbow resting on top of the wire frame.

ILLUSION BOX FITTING INSIDE CRATE

This final drawing shows a transparent view of the crate and illusion box as the box is removed from the crate at the beginning of the illusion. Notice how the framework of the illusion box fits around the mirror frame unit and the crate fits around both. The inner floor is up in the false back position hiding all the body parts and this part of the box fits right into the space between the bottom of the angled mirror and the back of the crate.

THE SAW

Although I did not draw the saw in the plans - I thought I should mention it. The saw is basically a normal saw from a tool shop - I found that a medium length wood saw (about 14" long) was long enough to look good but short enough to easily avoid the assistant. The teeth of the saw are ground to almost flat, leaving just enough to show the ridges along the blade. Smooth it all off with a fine file or abrasive paper so the saw is safe and ready to use.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

I would try to treat the cart, blocks and crate as three separate items for decoration purposes. The cart should be left in aluminum, perhaps an even grinder finish or drum sanded with the diamond plate on top of it. It actually looks like a stock cart that can be purchased at hardware stores (this is a good thing). I finished the blocks in a smooth nutmeg color - could be powder coat or spray paint. I would have all the aluminum for the illusion box finished in an even look, probably sandblasted then clear coated. The inside of the illusion box is covered with black velvet to blend with the black velvet pieces that velcro on to hide the holes in the false back etc.

The assistant's costume is an important part of this illusion. I would suggest a jacket and skirt combo. The duplicate skirt is cut up and attached around the wire frame so when the inner floor is down, the skirt sits right on the assistant's knees. The duplicate jacket goes on the mannequin with the rolled foam rubber filling the sleeves. For the exposed piece of neck on the mannequin, use a flesh colored pair of ladies tights- cut off the foot and stretch it over the neck, taping it on so the tape is hidden by the duplicate top the mannequin is wearing.

ETC...

I have so many drawings in my files of this illusion I could probably do a book called 'Headz Up - the many designs that weren't quite right'. My original idea was to design an illusion that sliced off the assistant's head and set it down next to her so the audience could see the head, but using one assistant only. I actually prefer the cutting into three it has now become as it adds another beat to the routine and creates an effective visual when the audience see the severed assistant.

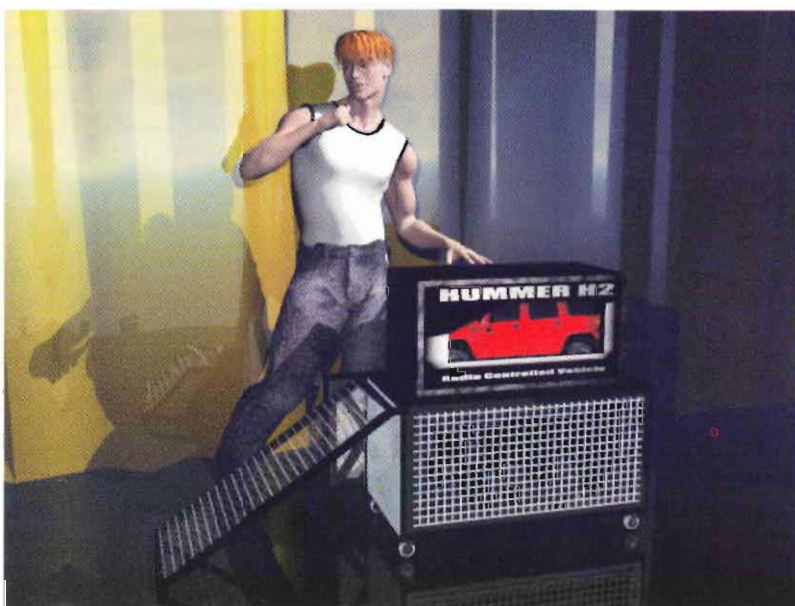
I always thought the Shadow Vision illusion was a good illusion visually - I had the opportunity to work with one for a few years, in Dirk Arthur's 'New Art of Magic' Las Vegas show. I have to say that it is one of the most complicated array of folding plywood flaps, foam rubber and odd shaped moving metal pieces I have ever seen. All credit to Ken Whittaker for working that one out! Headz Up creates a similar effect of showing the assistant cut into three pieces but without the necessity of a hidden second assistant.

R/C CAR VANISH

R/C CAR VANISH



The Magician shows the audience his Radio Controlled Car. The car is driven around the stage. A platform with a mesh front sits on stage. On the platform is a box and some flat pieces of a folded box stacked on top.



The Magician removes the folded box pieces, leaning them out of the way against the platform. The car is placed into the box. A window in the front allows the audience to see the car in the box.

R/C CAR VANISH



The box containing the car is placed onto a table away from the platform. The Magician then assembles a second box from the flat pieces. The final piece to go on is the lid of this second box.



The Magician turns the box containing the car around, then suddenly folds it flat on the table showing that the car has vanished. The Magician picks up the Radio Controller and operates it. Suddenly the car bursts through the paper side of the second box, having reappeared.

METHOD

I have always liked the old duck vanish box and bucket routine. This effect has its roots in that trick, but I really wanted to come up with something that didn't use ducks. Having had plenty of experience working with these feathered assistants, I always liked the idea of a trick that didn't involve having to clean poop and feathers out of the bottom of a wooden bucket.

There are really two props working together to achieve this illusion. The platform is basically a box with no back, a mesh front and a ramp on the side. This platform is responsible for most of the method. The top of the platform has a dropping floor built into it that lowers the car into the platform. As the car lowers, a black art roller blind comes down behind the mesh hiding the car. This trick does not need a black backdrop for the black art however. The point in the routine when the car drops into the platform is right after the pieces of the stacked reappearance box are leaning against the back of the platform. The lid of the folding reappearance box is covered in black velvet and is the first thing to lean against the back of the platform - now the platform has its own black back to it.

When the reappearance box is being assembled on the platform, first the sides of the box are set up - at this moment the car moves up inside these box sides and the black art roller blind goes away. When the lid of the box is picked up, the audience can again see through the platform. The car is already loaded into the reappearance box, ready to drive through the paper.

The vanish box is decorated to resemble the type of box that toy cars actually come in from the shops. The window in the front gives the view of the car. A thin slice of car (2" thick) is permanently mounted behind the window. The lid of the vanish box swings all the way open to cover this front window at the start of the trick. When the car is placed into the vanish box, it actually lowers straight into the platform. When the lid is closed, the audience see the car still in the box (the thin slice of car). Once on the table, the slice of car ends up lying flat in the 2" thick table top as the box is collapsed flat on top of it.

The story board on the next page shows the workings.

(Pic.1): (End view of platform and vanish box.) The car is placed into the vanish box and drops into the platform (notice the thin slice of car at the front of the box).

(Pic.2): The vanish box (not shown in this pic.) has been placed on the table and the sides of the reappearance box are assembled on the platform. The lid of the reappearance box is still leaning against the back of the platform to give the black art effect. The car lifts back up to the top of the platform (inside the reappearance box sides).

(Pic.3): The lid is placed onto the reappearance box - the platform can now be seen through again.

(Pic.4): The vanish box that was sitting on the table is now turned around so the audience can see the back of it only.

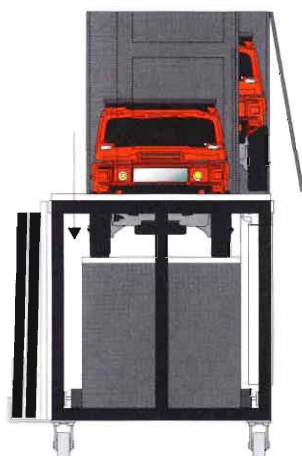
(Pic.5): The vanish box is laid down so that the front of the box (with the slice of car) lies in the 2" well of the table. The lid is lowered (it is at the back) and the bottom is opened to allow the audience to see through the empty box.

(Pic.6): The sides of the box collapse over to one side.

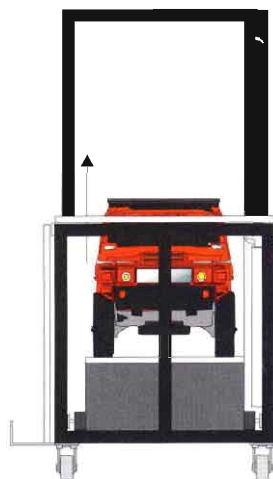
(Pic.7): The vanish box is flattened and the car has gone.

The car is already loaded into the reappearance box and facing the paper side and ramp. The Magician simply drives it forward through the paper (which has been scored with a knife to break easily) and down the ramp.

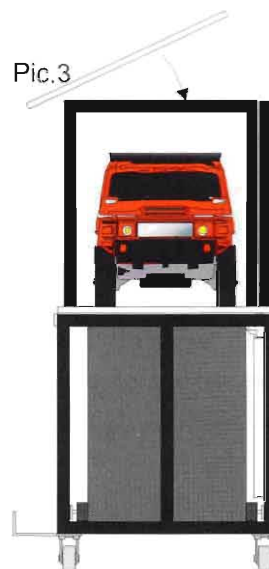
Pic.1



Pic.2



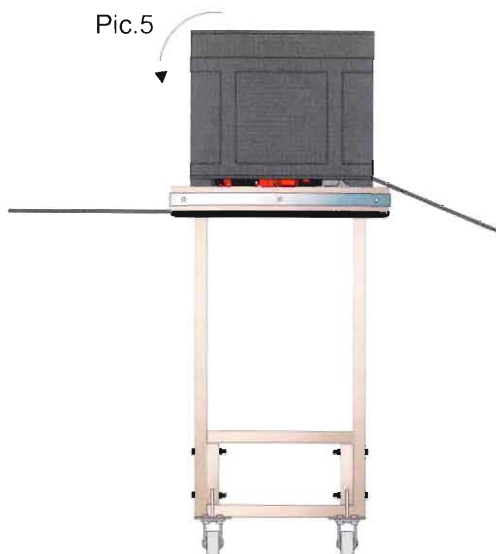
Pic.3



Pic.4



Pic.5



Pic.6



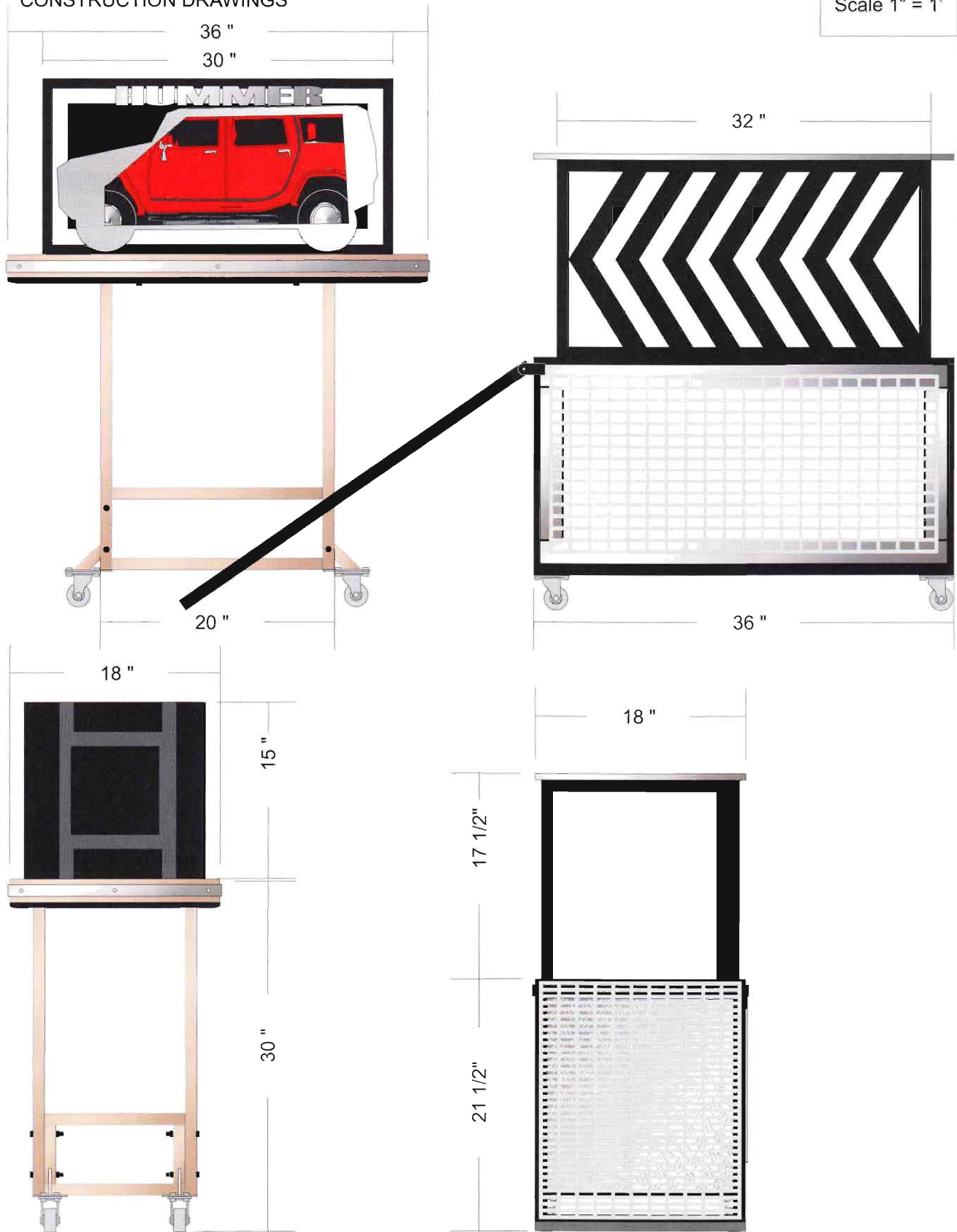
Pic.7



R/C CAR VANISH

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

Scale 1" = 1'



R/C CAR VANISH

TABLE LEG FRAMES

Scale 1" = 1'

Front and back frames

Side frames (2 of these)

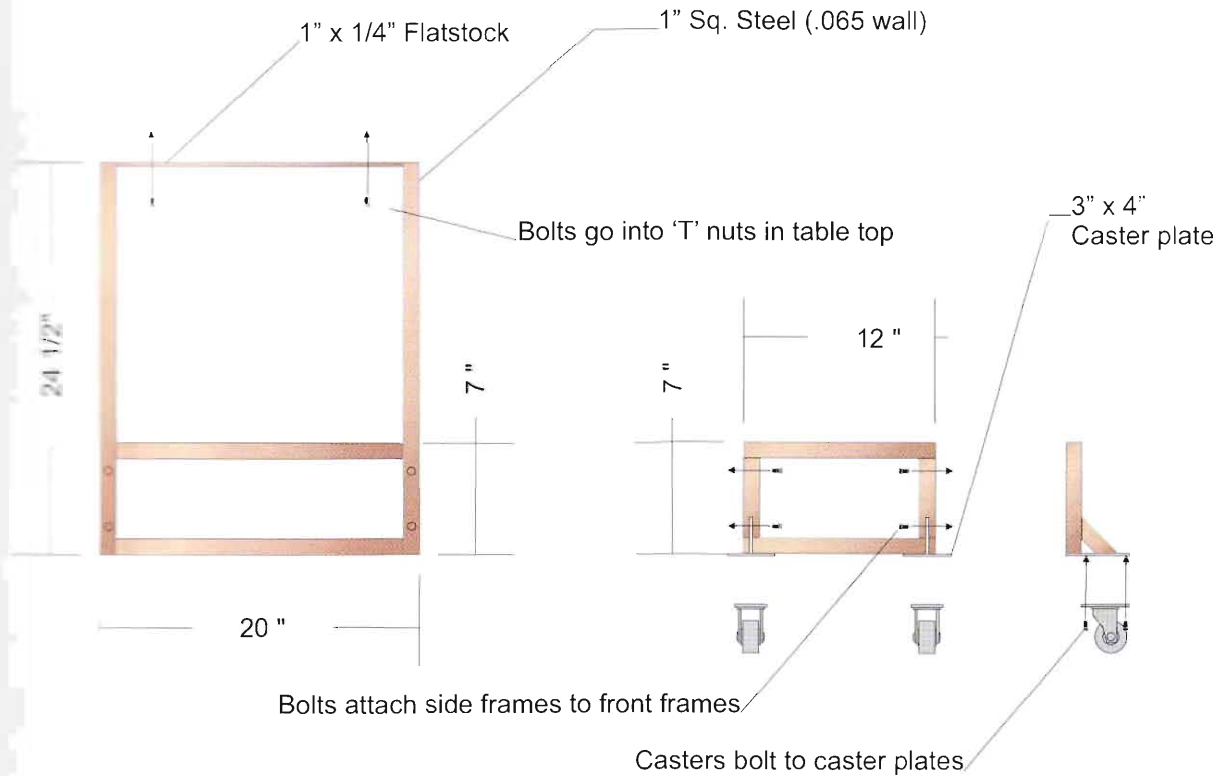
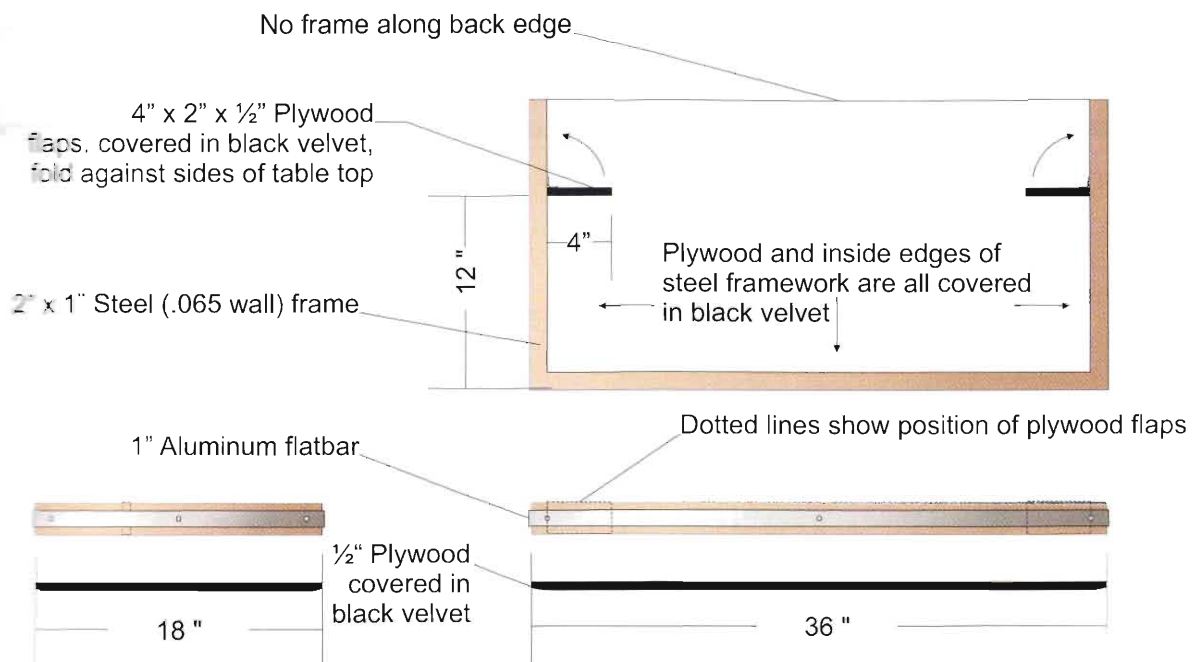


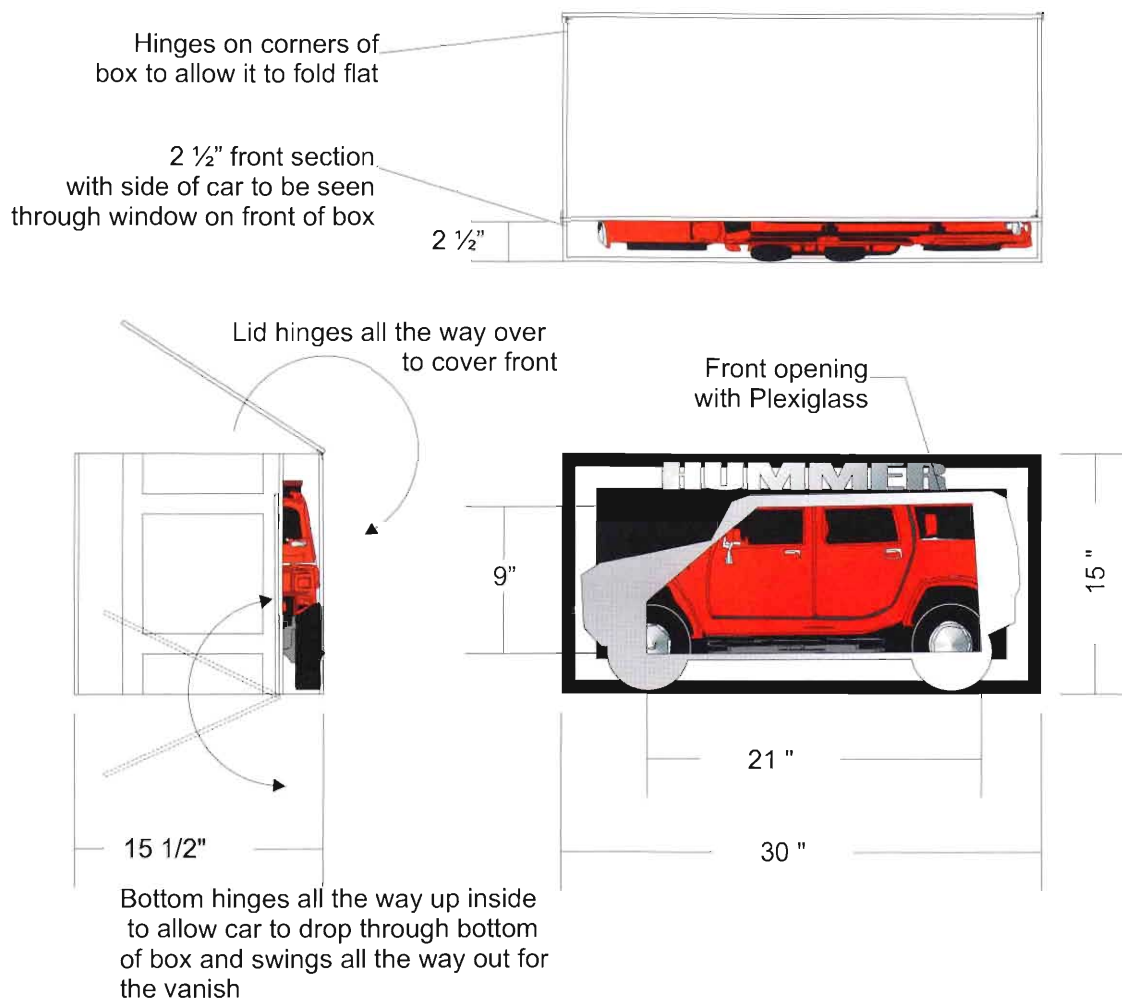
TABLE TOP



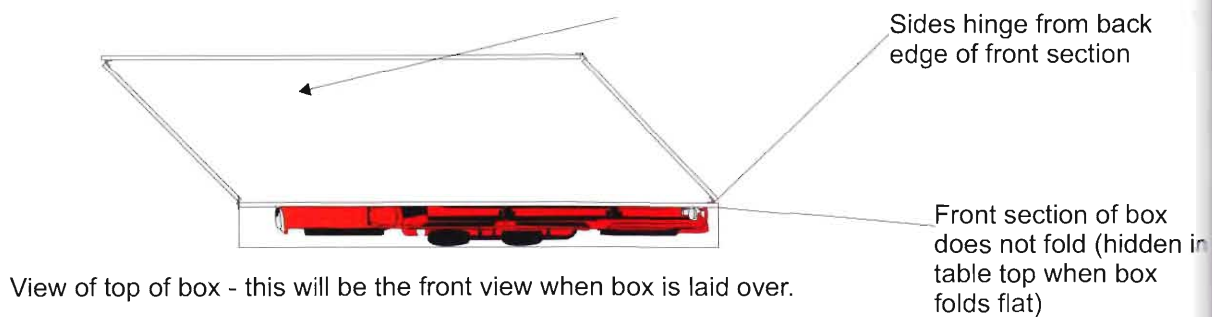
R/C CAR VANISH

CAR BOX

Scale 1" = 1'



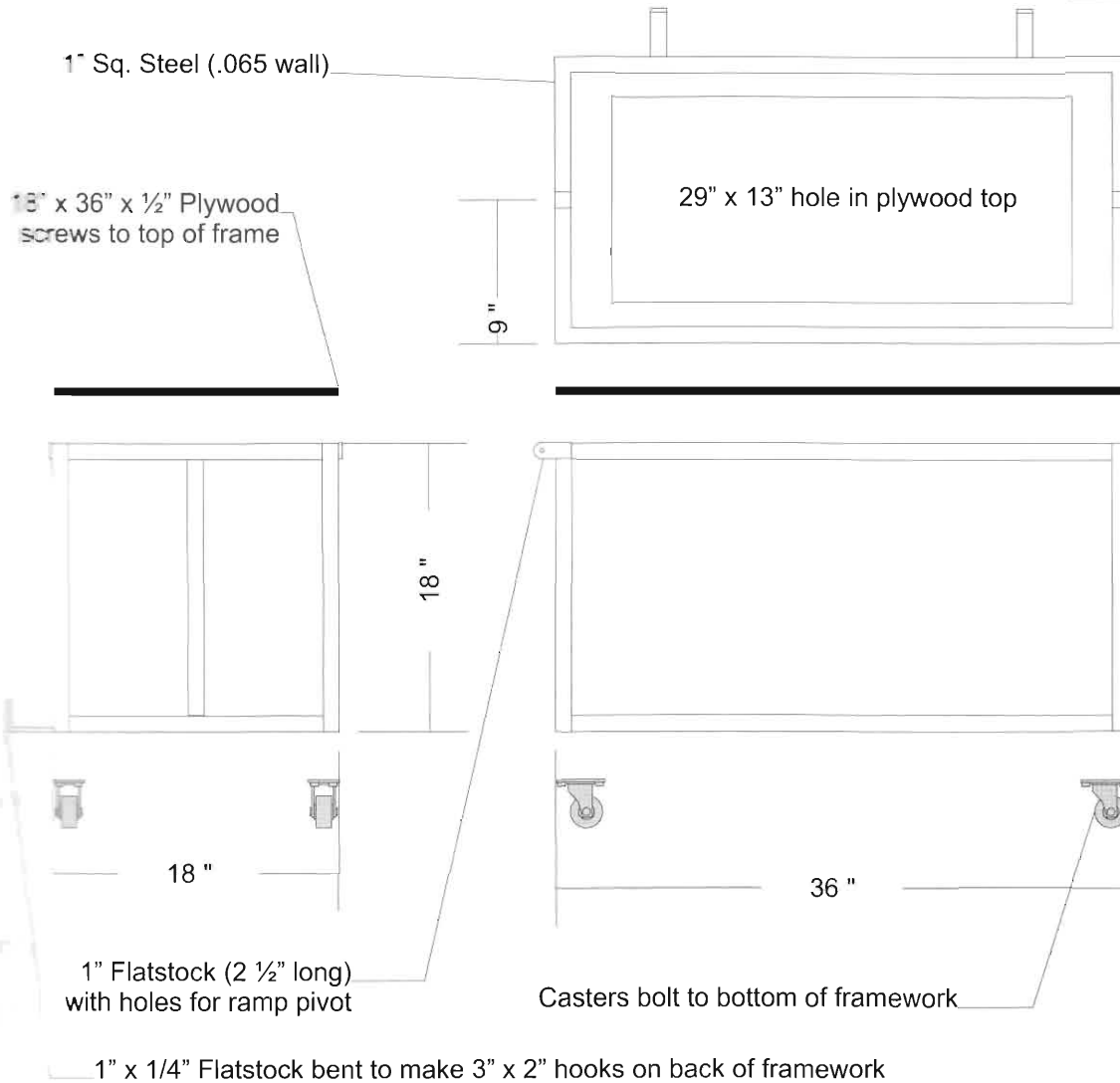
BOX FOLDING FLAT



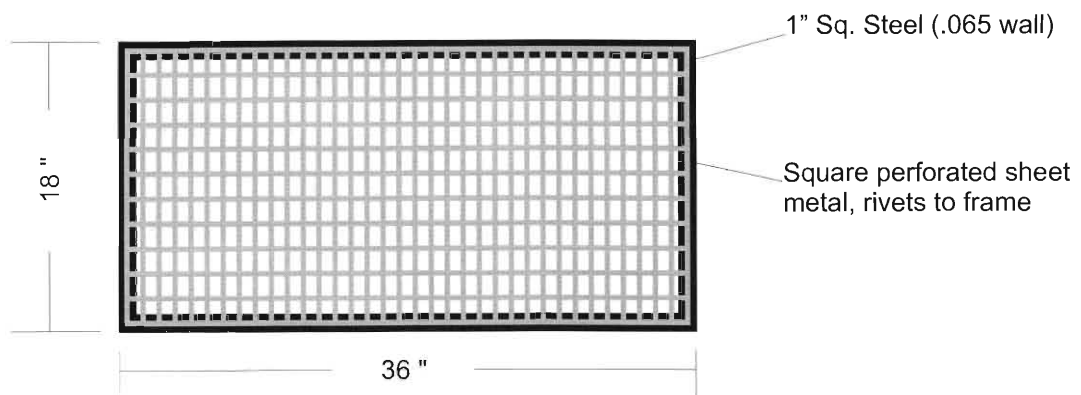
R/C CAR VANISH

RAMP PLATFORM FRAMEWORK

Scale 1" = 1'



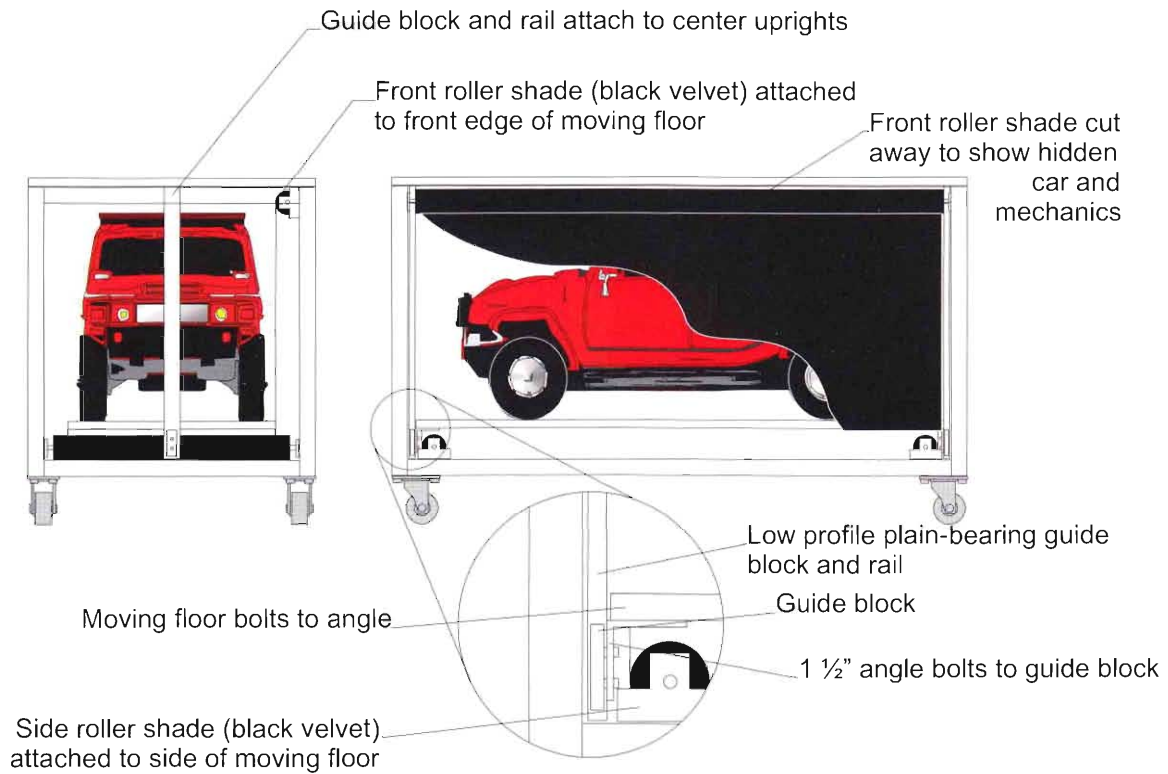
RAMP



R/C CAR VANISH

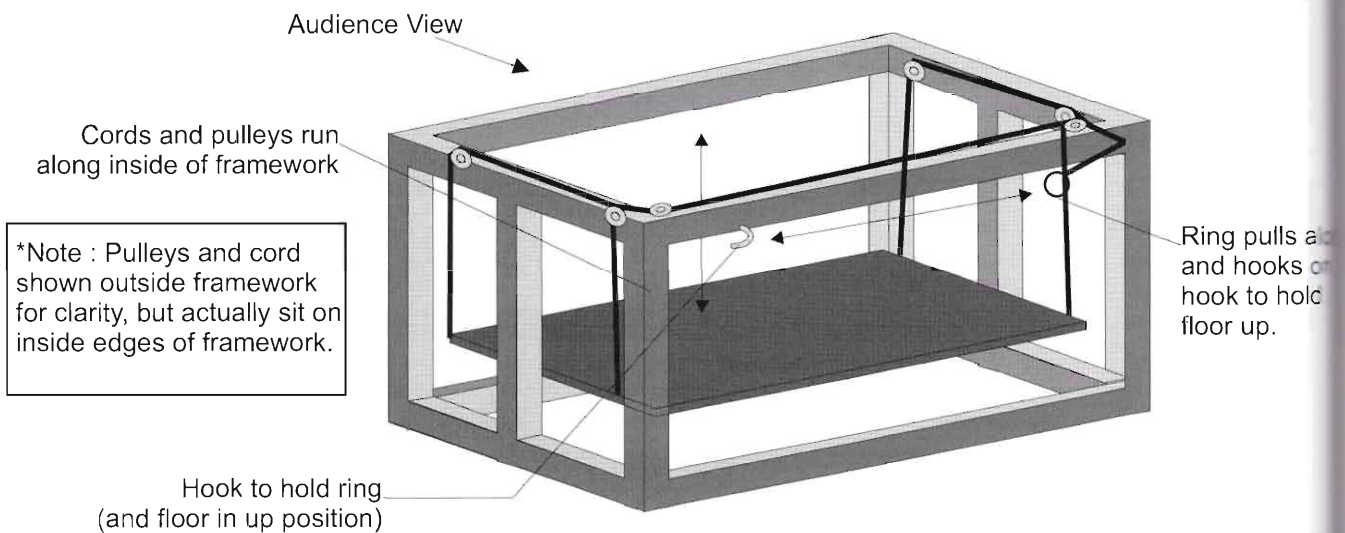
MOVING FLOOR

Scale 1" = 1'



PULLEY AND CORD SYSTEM

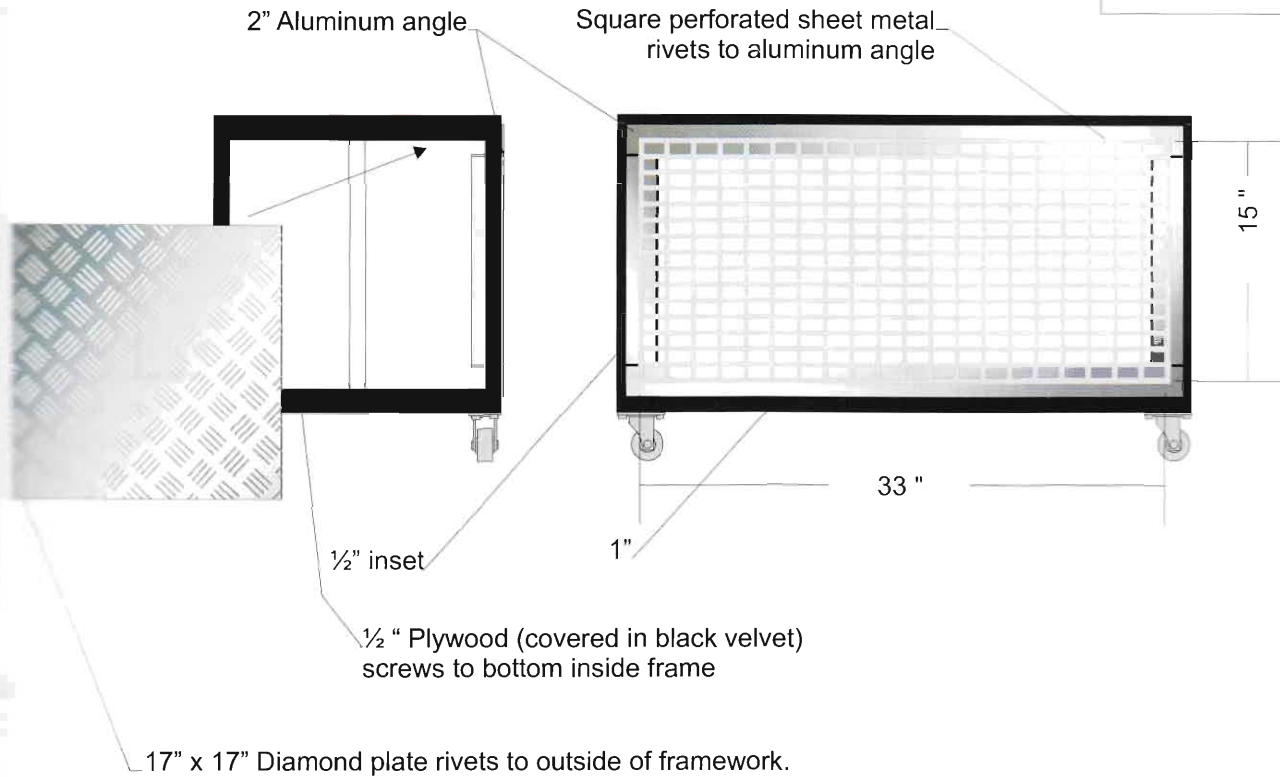
Not to Scale



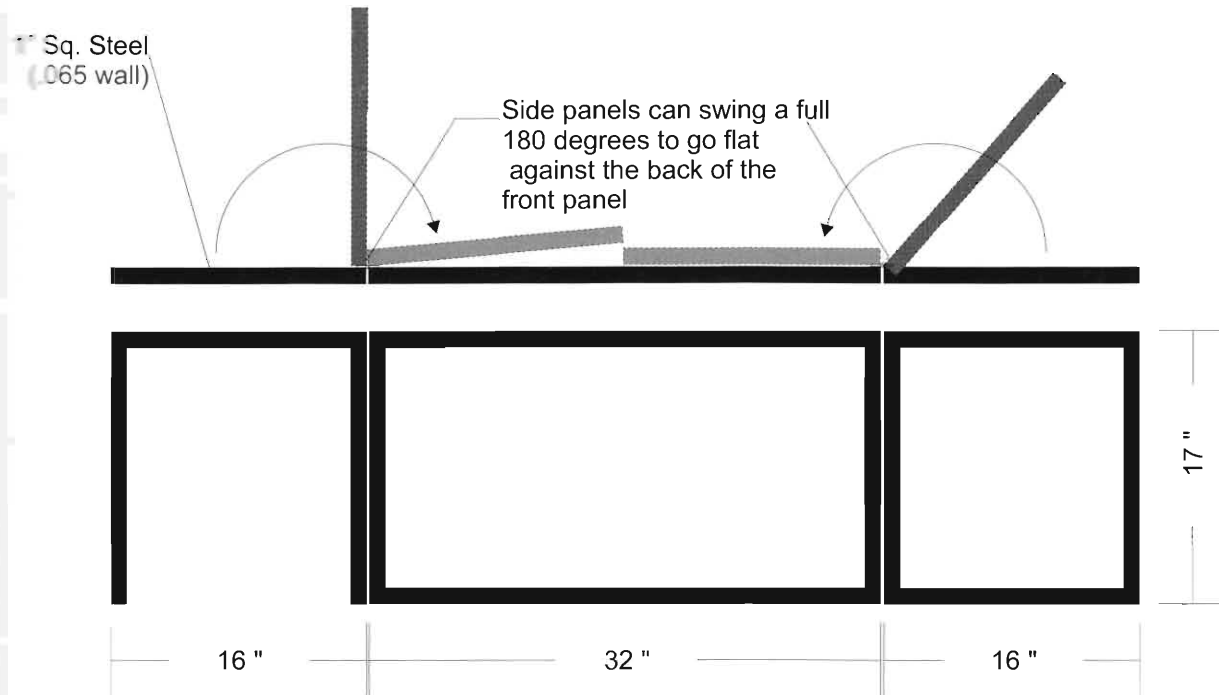
R/C CAR VANISH

EXTERIOR DECORATION

Scale 1" = 1'



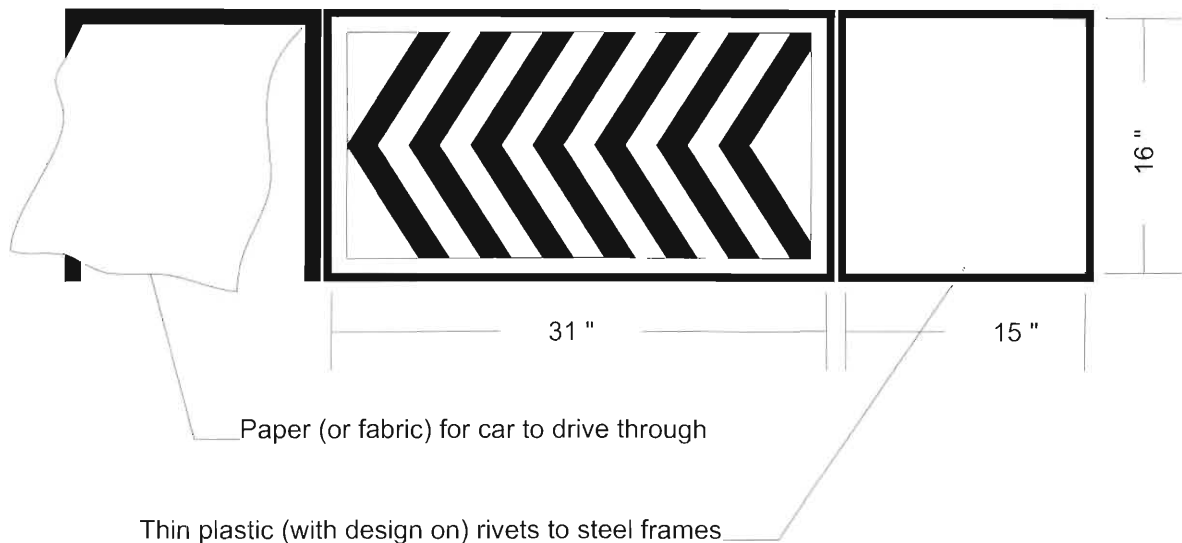
REAPPEARANCE BOX FRAMEWORK



R/C CAR VANISH

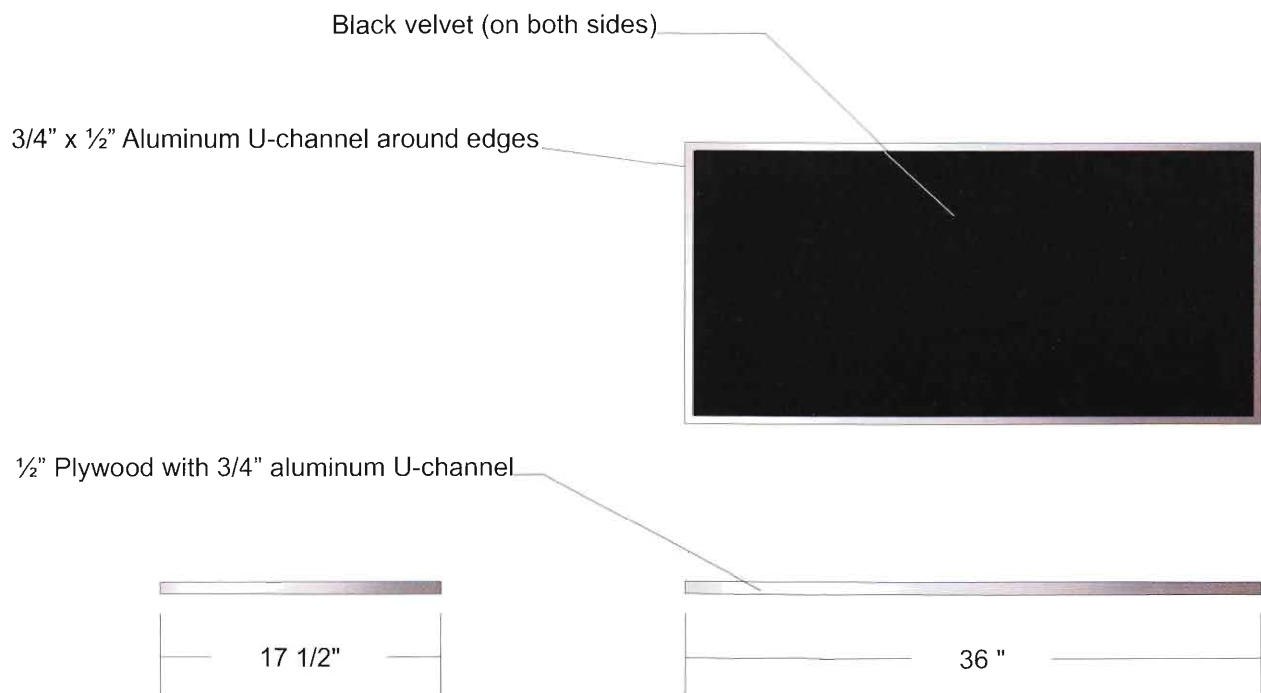
REAPPEARANCE BOX SIDES

Scale 1" = 1'



REAPPEARANCE BOX ROOF

Scale 1" = 1'



R/C CAR VANISH

NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

These are the basic dimensions of the props. I have used a Hummer H2 1:6 scale Radio Controlled car for the illusion, although it could work with any R/C car. The Hummer is 28" long, 12" wide and 13" high. For a smaller car, the dimensions of the entire illusion would all be scaled down of course.

TABLE LEG FRAMES

For the vanish table I would build the frames in 1" sq. steel. With thin wall steel, the legs will not be heavy. The front and back frames are identical and the two side frames bolt to these. The leg frames and the steel part of the table top are powder coated in a bronze/ copper finish.

TABLE TOP

The table top is made from a 2" x 1" steel frame that only covers three sides of the top. The back is left open. The 1/2" plywood floor is covered in black velvet. The staples for this velvet are covered by the steel frame when it is screwed to the plywood.

There are two 4" x 2" flaps made from plywood that hinge against the sides and are also covered in black velvet. When the vanish box is placed onto the table, the front if it rests on the frame and the back rests on these little flaps. When the box is turned around then laid over for the vanish, these flaps fold against the sides of the frame and allow the front of the vanish box to sit into the table top. Once the box is laid over, the bottom lid opens towards the audience. Because it is hinged from 2 1/2" back from the front (or up from the bottom because the box is laid over), it lies flat on the table frame edge. The back lid (originally the top lid) is the full depth of the box and because the table has no back edge to the frame, this lid also opens flat away from that audience. Inside edges of the frame are also covered in black velvet to create a 'well' type of table top. 1" aluminum flat bar edges the table top frame.

CAR BOX

I would build the car box from 1/4" black plastic. The front 2 1/2" section of the car box is made as a solid box that does not fold. The rest of the box sides are hinged from the front solid section to fold flat. The lid is hinged so that it swings all the way over (270 degrees) to cover the front window on the box.

The bottom of the box is smaller than the lid because it is hinged from the back edge of the solid 2 1/2" front section. This bottom lid can swing all the way up into the box and all the way out flat (180 degrees) for the vanish. The bottom lid is hinged all the way inside the box at the beginning of the illusion so the car can move through the box and into the platform. Once the car goes down, the Magician drops the bottom lid closed. When carrying the box to the table, the Magician simply holds the bottom lid from falling open.

The front of the box could be made from a piece of clear plexiglass. A printed adhesive-vinyl graphic is applied to the plexiglass. The 2 1/2" section contains a 2" thick slice of the car. On the slice, and the whole car used in the illusion, the windows are spray painted black from the inside so they look heavily tinted. This way the windows on the slice of car do not allow the audience to see into the car and see that it has no depth.

BOX FOLDING FLAT

I wanted to show how the sides of the box fold flat. The lid and bottom lid are not shown in this diagram. The front section of the box has been laid into the table top and the lids are both opened allowing the audience to see through the box. Then the sides hinge flat as in the drawing.

RAMP PLATFORM FRAMEWORK

I have made this ramp platform from the same 1" sq. steel used for the table legs. The uprights, half way back, are for the guide block and rails on the moving floor. This frame is powder coated black. The plywood on top is covered in black velvet or vinyl. The 29" x 13" hole in the plywood is for the car to drop down through. 2" casters, the same as the ones on the table legs, bolt to the bottom of the framework.

RAMP

The ramp is a basic frame, with perforated sheet metal riveted to it. The frame is powder coated black to match the ramp platform framework. The perforated sheet metal should be finished in a bright silver color.

MOVING FLOOR

The moving floor is made from 1/2" plywood and slides up and down on a guide block and rail system. There are three roller blinds with black velvet. One is attached to the front top edge of the ramp platform framework and its fabric is attached to the front edge of the moving platform (this is cut away to show the car in the front view drawing). The two side roller blinds are mounted to the bottom sides of the ramp platform framework and their fabric is attached to the bottom of the moving floor. The moving floor is also covered in black velvet. As the floor moves down, the two side roller blinds roll up, and the front roller blind unrolls, covering the car from view.

PULLEY AND CORD SYSTEM

To raise and lower the moving floor, the Magician has a cord with a ring attached that is moved along the back top edge of the ramp platform framework. Four cords run from the corners of the moving floor up to some small sheaves mounted on the inside edge of the framework. The cords run through the framework and out the back corner where they are attached to a small ring. As the Magician pulls the ring along it lifts the floor up. The ring goes over a hook to hold the floor in the up position.

EXTERIOR DECORATION

On the sides of the ramp platform framework, diamond plate aluminum is attached. On the front, 2" aluminum angle is attached around the edge. The side roller blinds run just behind the inside edge of this angle. The angle hides the roller blinds and mechanics. The square perforated sheet metal attaches to this. Plywood covered in black velvet makes the floor.

REAPPEARANCE BOX FRAMEWORK

The reappearance box is a simple three sided framework that sits on the platform. The framework is made from the same 1" sq. steel that the table legs and ramp platform framework are made from. It is important that the sides swing fully in to allow the box to fold flat for the beginning of the illusion when it is stacked on top of the vanish box. Notice that one end does not have a bottom piece. This is the end that is covered with paper for the car to drive through.

REAPPEARANCE BOX SIDES

The front and one side piece are made from 1/4" white plastic with the design either painted on or decorated in black adhesive-vinyl. The end for the car to drive through is either fabric or paper. For fabric, a piece of fabric attached along the top, perhaps with a couple of very small tabs of velcro on the bottom corners. For paper, it is attached to the frame with double sided sticky tape and then scored with a knife for easy breaking through by the car.

REAPPEARANCE BOX ROOF

The roof is a simple piece of plywood covered in black velvet. 3/4" Aluminum U-channel is screwed around the edges.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

Most of the finish is in the construction - with powder coating finishes and colored plastic with vinyl attached. You could scenic the reappearance box or add more shiny hardware to the table etc. I like the look of this illusion as it is, not too fussy with a box that looks like a real world item (the vanish box).

ETC...

When I've been involved in putting together the running order of an illusion show - be it my own or a big Las Vegas show - one of the hardest bits has always been those smaller effects that take place in front of the curtain while the hard working stage crew strike one big piece and set another. In a big show, really small props are difficult for all to see (unless you use video projection) and mid size illusions require one or more assistants who need to be changing costume or climbing into the next big prop backstage.

The size of this illusion was devised with that scenario in mind. It offers good sized props and action with the car, but only needs the Magician to operate it. Plus, even if you carry your show around in a medium sized truck or trailer, you can now advertise an illusion with a car !

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

It's that classic 'small print' at the beginning of every illusion book - build a mock up before wasting thousands of dollars on a prop your assistant can't fit into. This book is no different and it is good advice to listen to.

So, I decided to dedicate a chapter entirely to this process. In the following pages you will see plans and wood cutting lists to make cheap plywood mock-ups of the load spaces for each illusion in this book. I feel that before building a new illusion you should at least build a mock-up of the load space to be sure that you or your assistant can fit into it. You could build complete mock-ups of the entire prop, perhaps using cardboard stuck to these wooden 'load space mock-ups' then painted.

During my time as a designer working with other illusion builders; and building illusions myself; I've seen everything from extremely crude mock-ups made from cereal boxes, drain pipes, gaffa tape and an old sock - to fully built, working, full size, painted, plywood props (unfortunately, some builders call this the finished article!).

The idea of a mock-up, as I see it, is to test sizing, any odd trap positions and movements of the person inside the prop. I believe the mock-up should be made as cheaply as possible, but be sturdy enough to do a fair test. The aesthetics and scenic design can all be generated on a computer or drawn by an artist to get an idea of the 'look' of the finished piece.

All the mock-ups detailed in this chapter are made from 1/2" plywood. Its easily available at Home Depot, for reasonable cost and they can cut it to size for you if you want (I believe there is a small fee for the cutting service). I have included a cutting list for each mock-up to help with this. I would use a wood glue to hold the wood together (Elmers wood glue) and nails or small screws. If you are into investing in good tools, then a nail gun or wood staple gun would speed up the process of building the mock-up. Glue each joint, then nail or screw it together.

For Compact Deception I made the CD player from 1/4" plywood held together with gaffa tape for the hinges.

Once you have built the mock-up, try your assistant (or yourself depending on the illusion) inside it. Take a piece of 2x2 stud wood and run it along the top edges of the plywood to make sure none of the person is sticking out or above the edge of the wood.

TRAPDOOR : Lay your assistant inside and run the 2x2 across the base, up the thighs and across the top shin load areas.

STEAM : Put the box on the floor and climb in. Practice sliding out through the 36" gap in the front.

HEADZ UP : Have your assistant sit into the box, legs hanging over the edge. Run the wood across to be sure the shoulders can fit below the box edges.

COMPACT DECEPTION : Sit your assistant into the table, put the CD player over them and use a bed sheet to simulate the cloth bunched up on the back of the table.

THE FURNACE : Step inside and have someone run the 2x2 down the open side to be sure you are in.

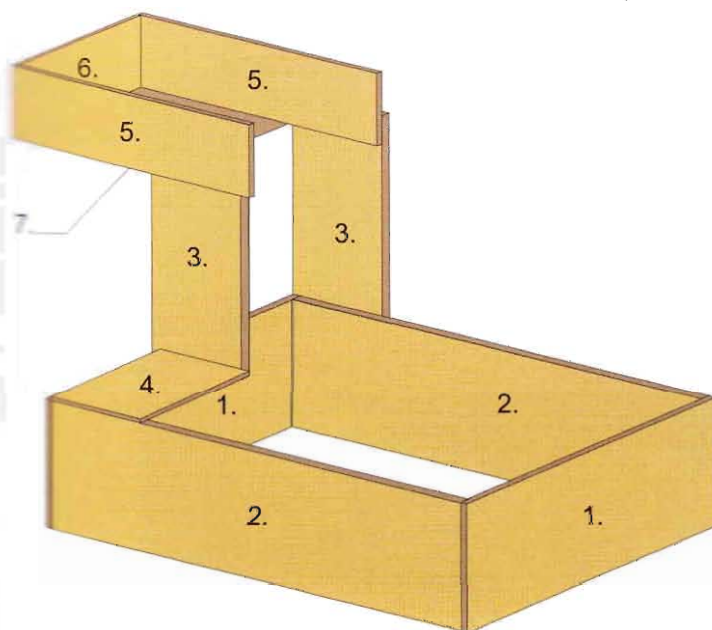
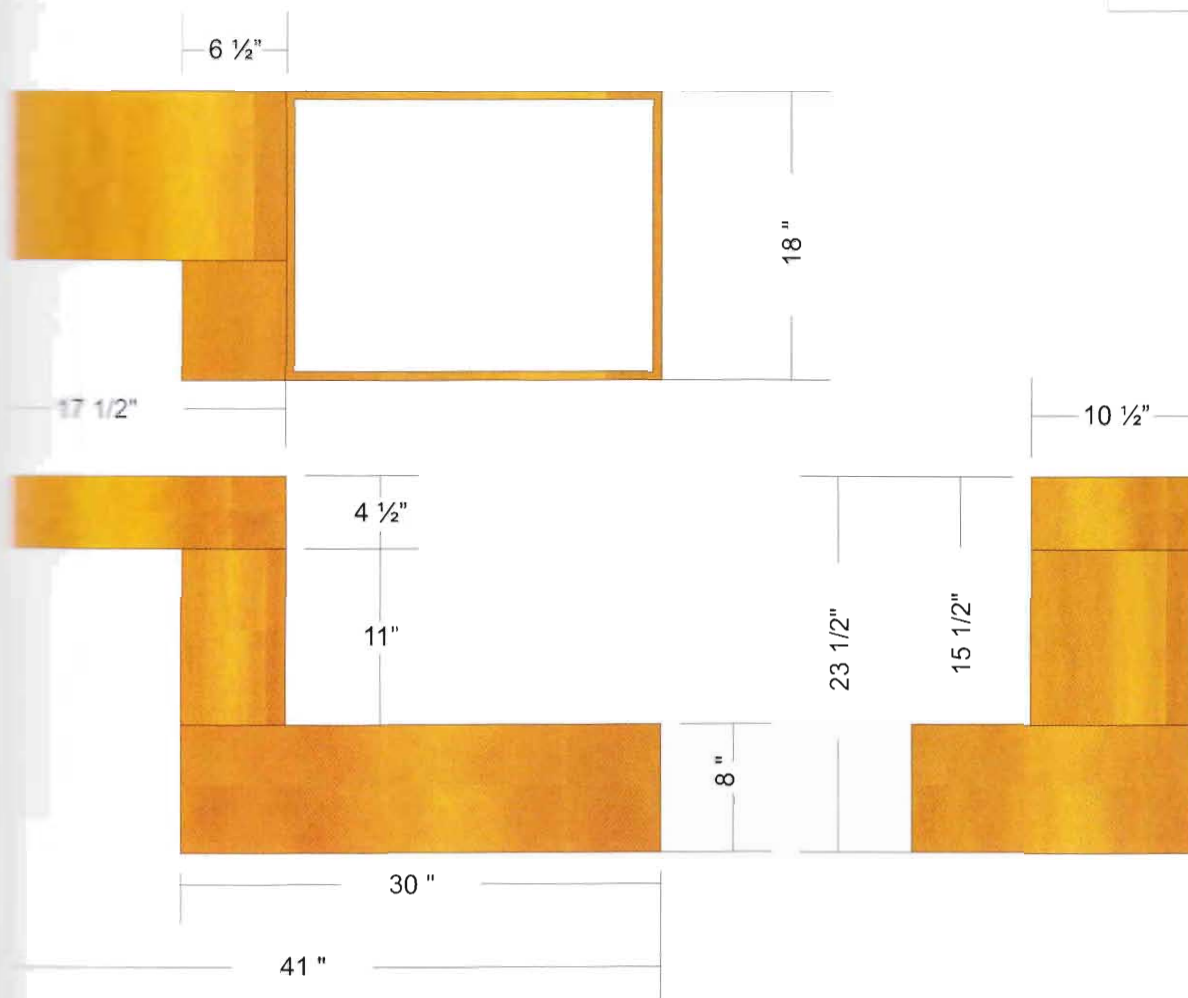
IRON : Assistant gets inside for sizing and practices climbing out the front.

ALIEN ABDUCTION : Lie the assistant inside the base. Run the 2x2 along the top edges.

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

TRAPDOOR

Scale 1" = 1'



Cutting list 1/2" plywood

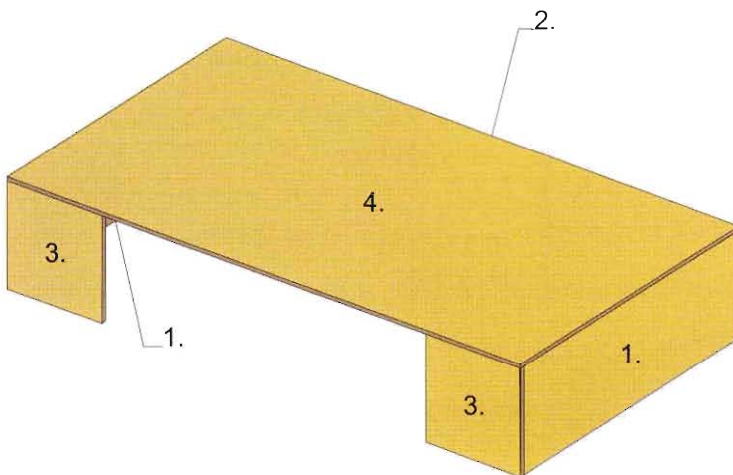
1. 19" x 8" (x2)
2. 30" x 8" (x2)
3. 6 1/2" x 13" (x2)
4. 7" x 8"
5. 18" x 4 1/2" (x2)
6. 10 1/2" x 4 1/2"
7. 11 1/2" x 11"

Not to Scale

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

STEAM

Scale 1" = 1'



Cutting list 1/2" plywood

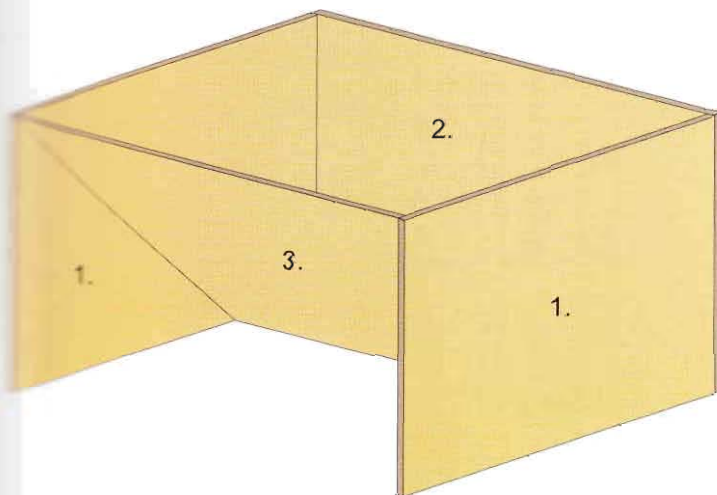
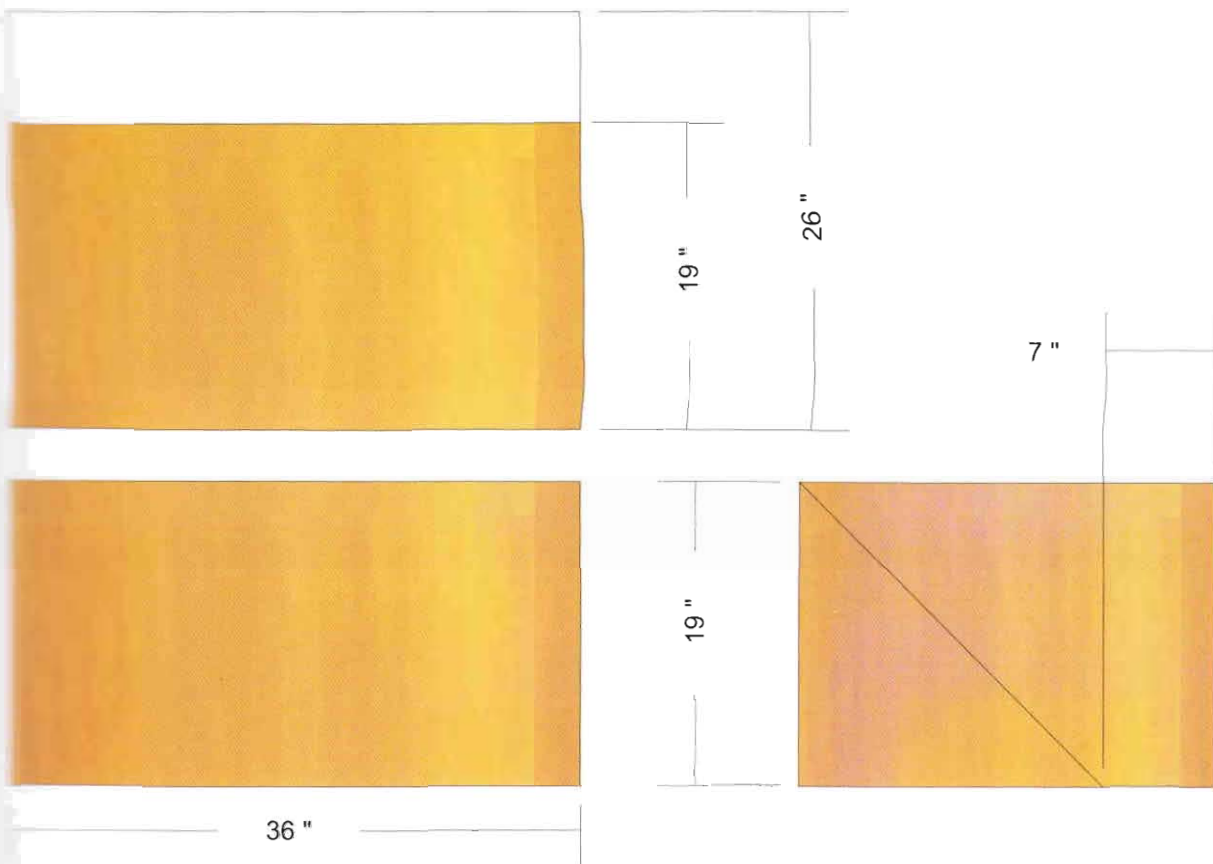
- 1. 35 1/2" X 9" (X2)
- 2. 58" X 9"
- 3. 11" X 9" (X2)
- 4. 58" X 36 1/2"

Not to Scale

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

HEADZ UP

Scale 1" = 1'



Cutting list 1/2" plywood

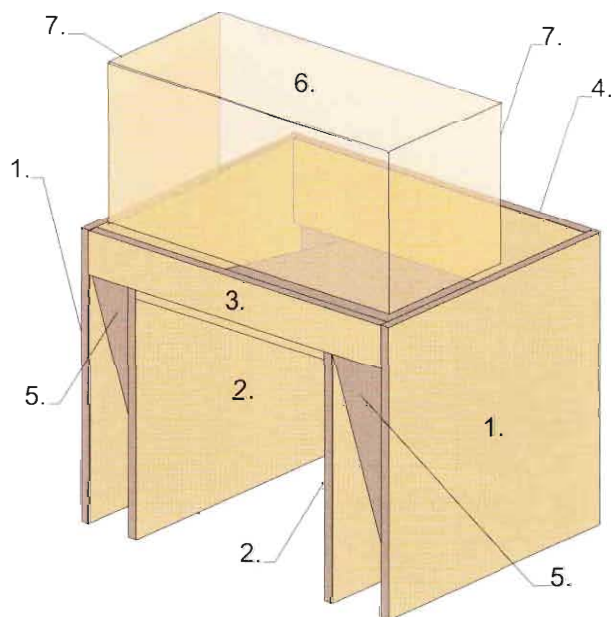
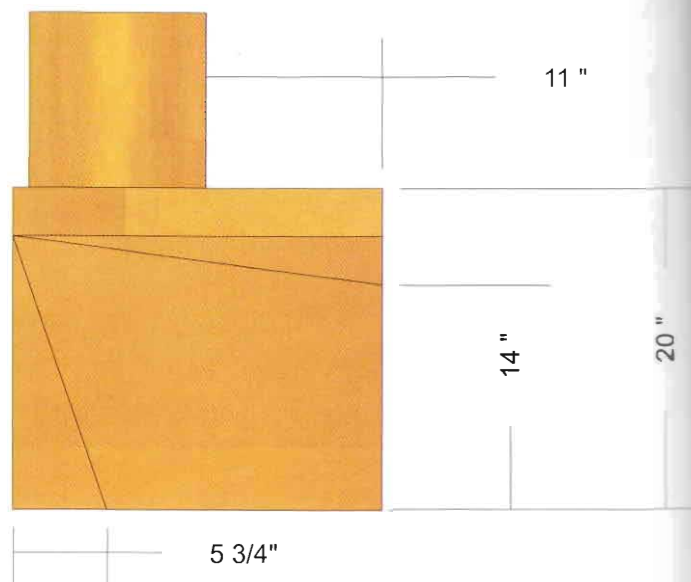
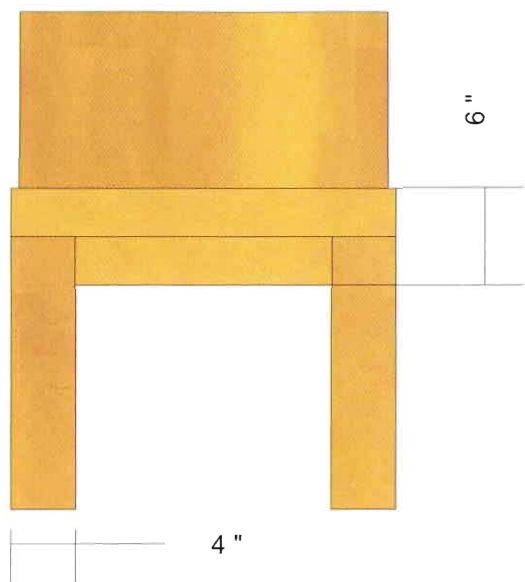
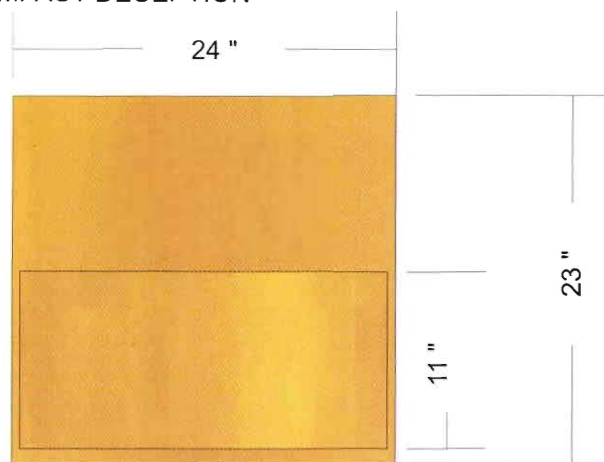
1. 26" x 19" (x2)
2. 37" x 19"
3. 36" x 26"

Not to Scale

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

COMPACT DECEPTION

Scale 1" = 1"



Cutting list 1/2" plywood

1. 24" x 20" (x2)
2. 17" (Sloping to 14") x 24" (x2)
3. 24" x 3"
4. 24" x 6"
5. 4" x 17 1/2" (x2)

1/4" Plywood

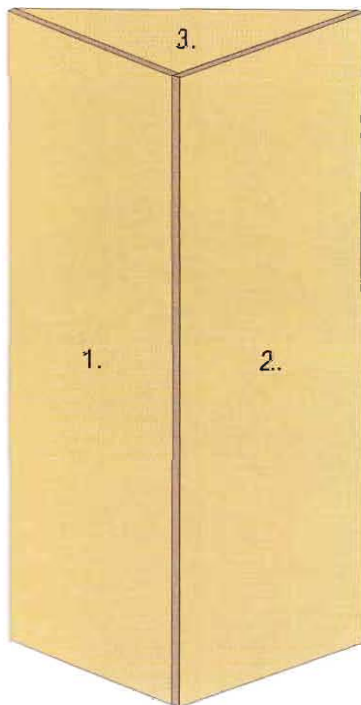
6. 23" x 11" (x2)
7. 11" x 11" (x2)

Not to Scale

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

THE FURNACE

Scale 1" = 1'



Cutting list 1/2" plywood

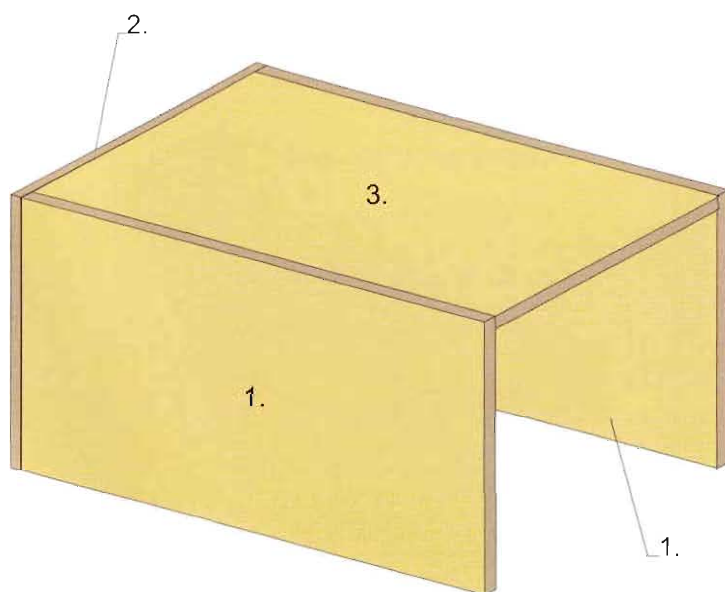
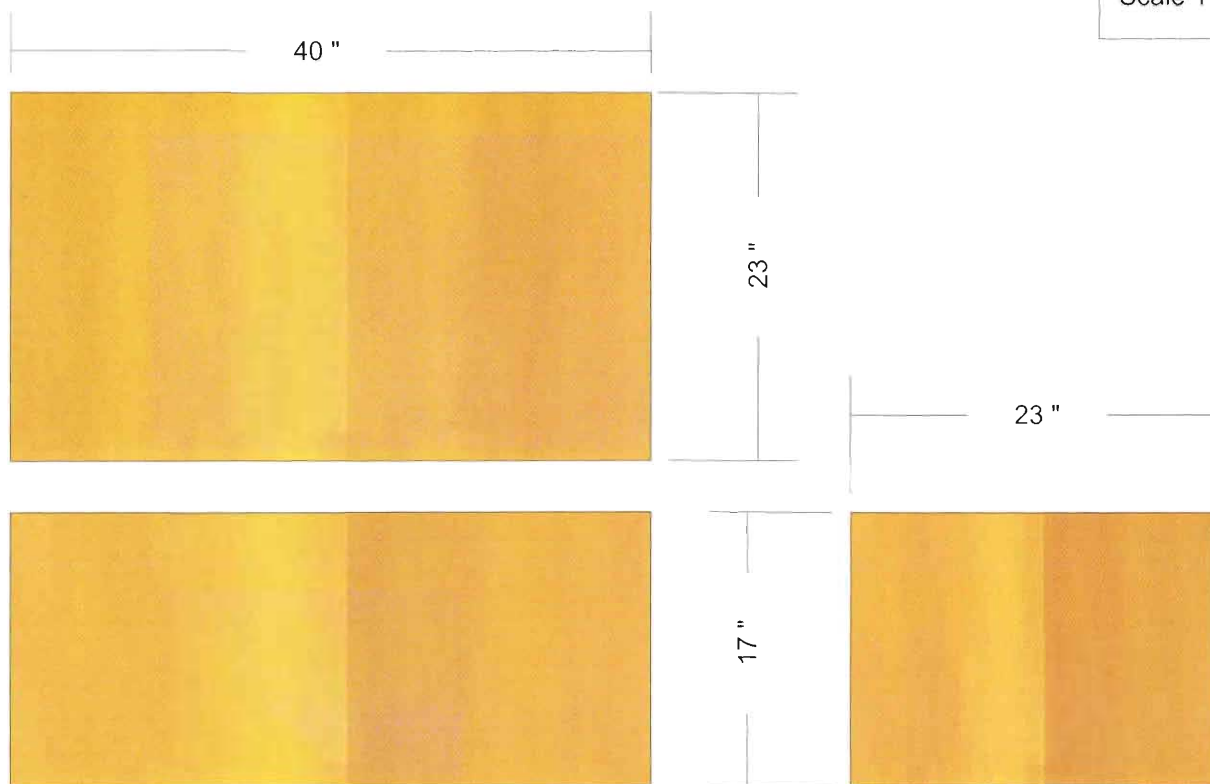
1. 19 1/2" x 70 1/2"
2. 20" x 70 1/2"
3. 19 1/2" x 19 1/2" Triangle

Not to Scale

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

IRON

Scale 1" = 1'



Cutting list $\frac{1}{2}$ " plywood

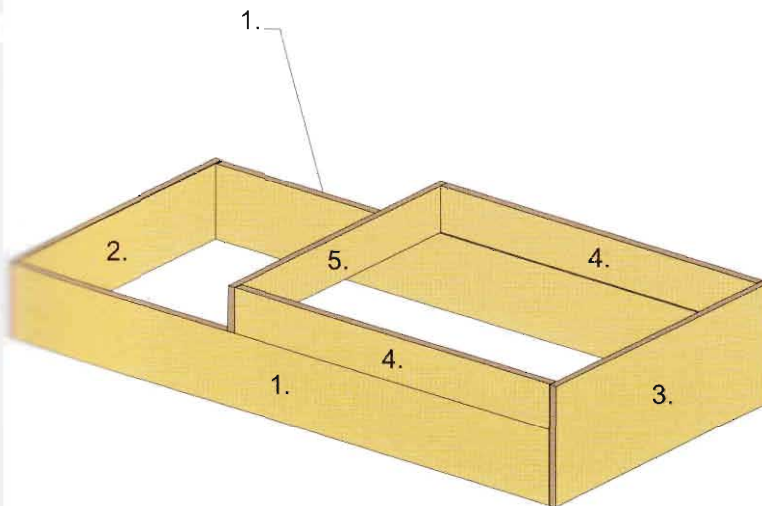
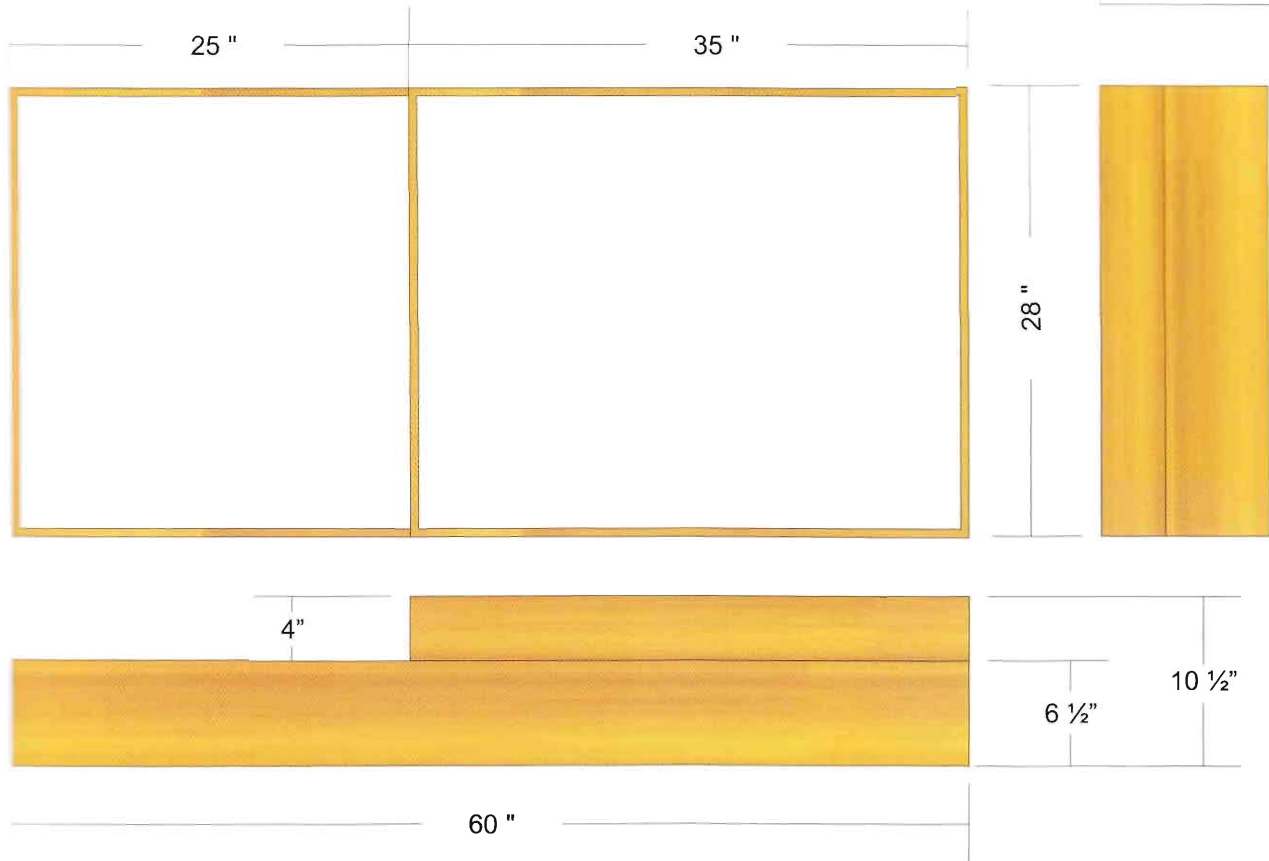
1. 40" x 17 $\frac{1}{2}$ " (x2)
2. 24" x 17 $\frac{1}{2}$ "
3. 40" x 23"

Not to Scale

BUILDING A MOCK-UP

ALIEN ABDUCTION

Scale 1" = 1'



Cutting list 1/2" plywood

1. 60" x 6 1/2" (x2)
2. 29" x 6 1/2"
3. 29" x 10 1/2"
4. 35" x 4" (x2)
5. 29" x 4"

Not to Scale

86. Tim Clothier - Advance Illusion Projects

COMPACT DECEPTION



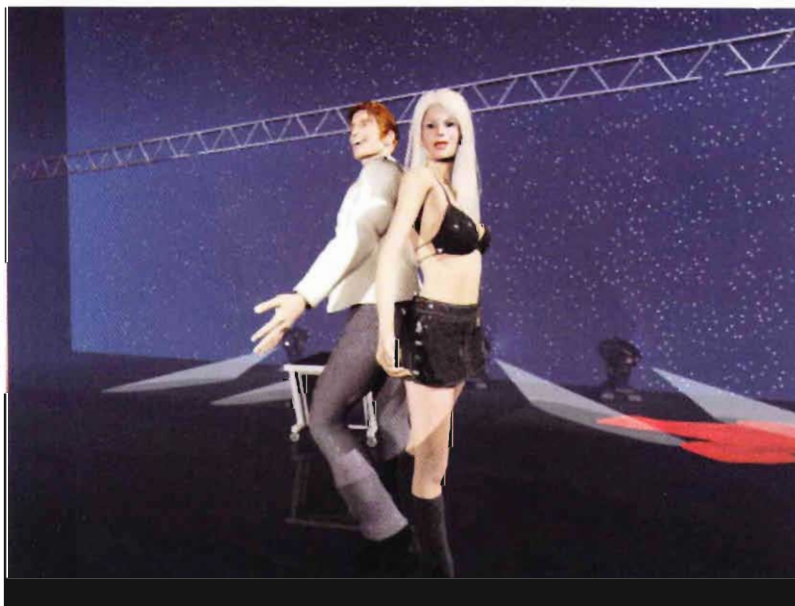
The Magician enters. On stage is a household CD player on a very small table, a cloth is also folded on the table behind the CD player. The Magician starts the player and the music begins.



The Magician unfolds the cloth and pulls it over, covering the CD player and table. The Magician lifts the cloth and shakes it for a moment above the player.



The cloth is pulled away to reveal that the Magician's assistant has appeared and the CD player has vanished.



The Magician and assistant take their applause and are ready to begin the rest of the show.

METHOD

The assistant is hidden inside the table, CD player and the bunched up cloth. I have 'split the load' between these three areas to keep the whole prop as small as possible.

The table conceals the assistant's legs in the legs of the table. A tapered design on the table legs disguises the thickness (more on this later). The CD player conceals some of the assistant's upper body and head, with the arms of the assistant hiding in the table top. The bunched up cloth on the table is used to hide the assistant's bottom and lower back. The pictures on the following page show the prop with the assistant hidden inside.

In performance, the assistant is hidden in the prop.

The Magician un-bunches the cloth from the back and pulls it down over the CD player and table. The Magician is careful not to actually remove the cloth from the table as this will expose the assistant.

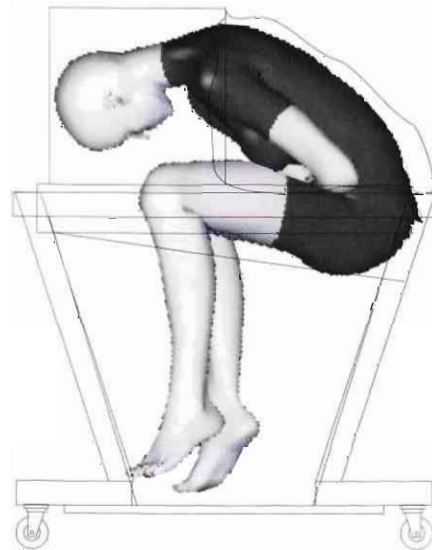
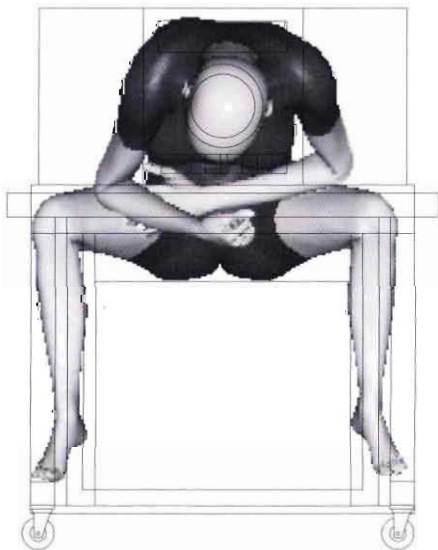
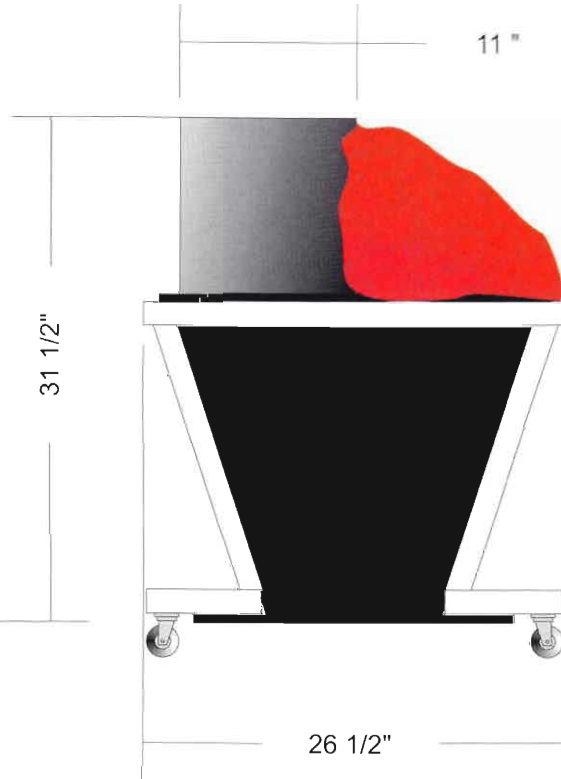
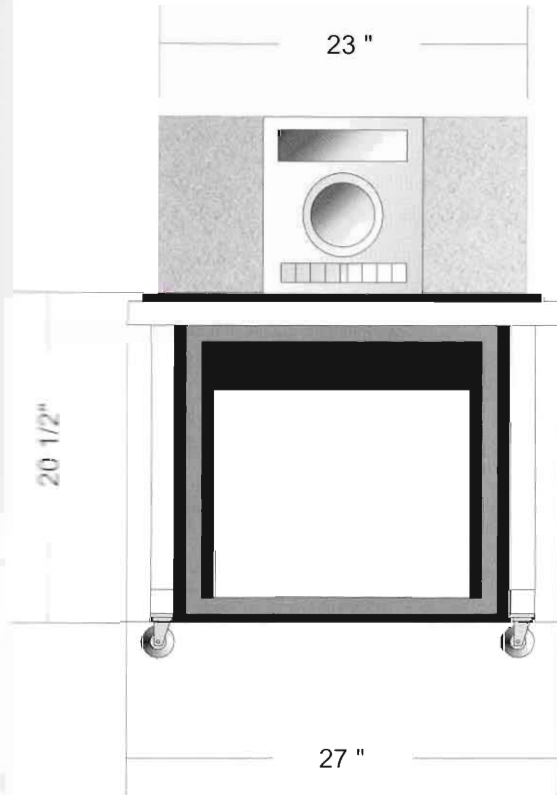
The Magician lifts the cloth up above the CD player and shakes it slightly - at this moment, the assistant sits up and quickly folds the CD player flat, lies it down and fits it into the table top.

The assistant sits on the back edge of the table frame and lifts their legs up and out onto the table top, The Magician pulls the cloth away and the assistant has appeared and the CD player is gone.

COMPACT DECEPTION

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

Scale 1" = 1'



COMPACT DECEPTION

TABLE FRAMEWORK

Scale 1" = 1'

Frame made in 1 1/2" Sq Aluminum

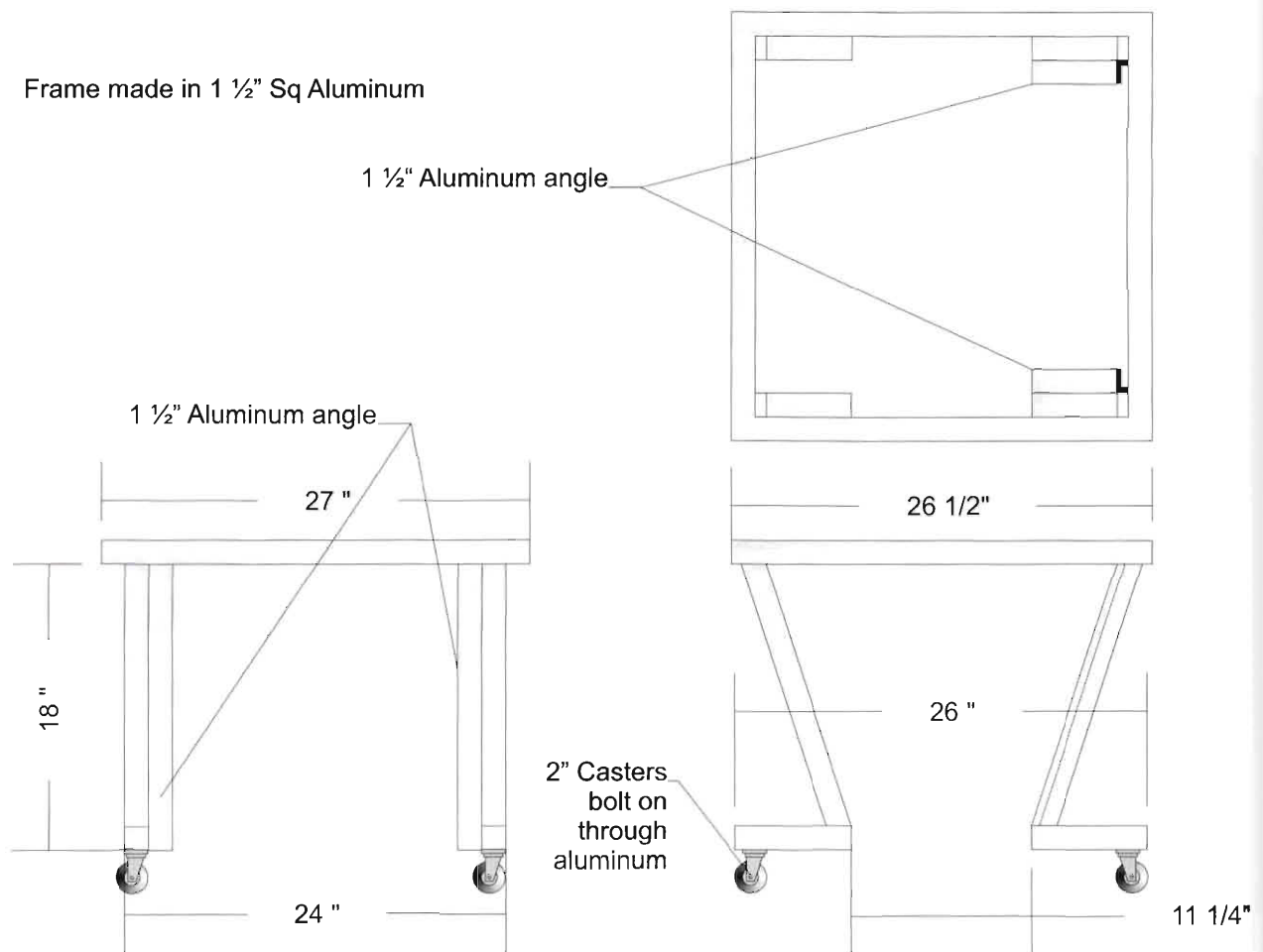
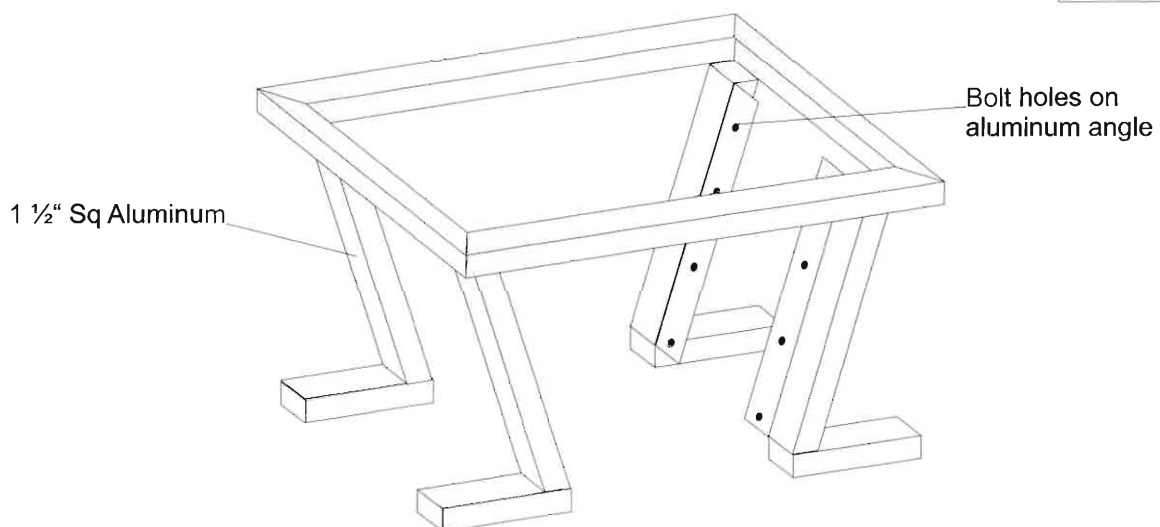


TABLE FRAMEWORK (3D VIEW)

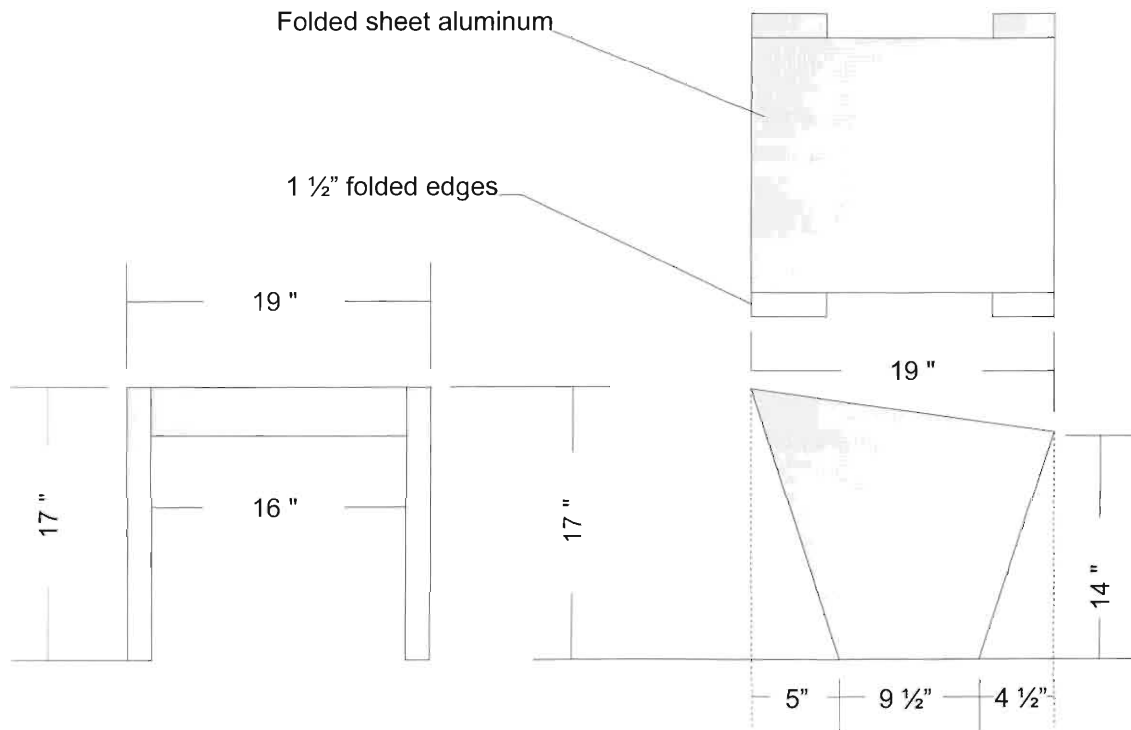
Not to Scale



COMPACT DECEPTION

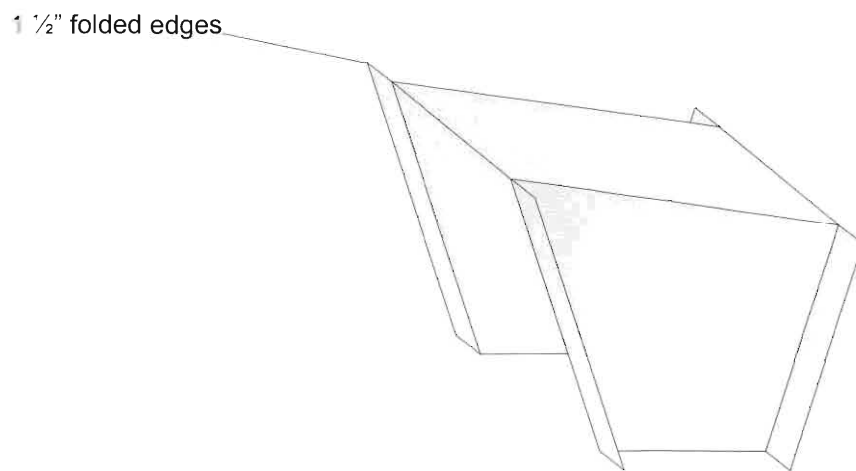
INSIDE EDGES

Scale 1" = 1'



INSIDE EDGES (3D VIEW)

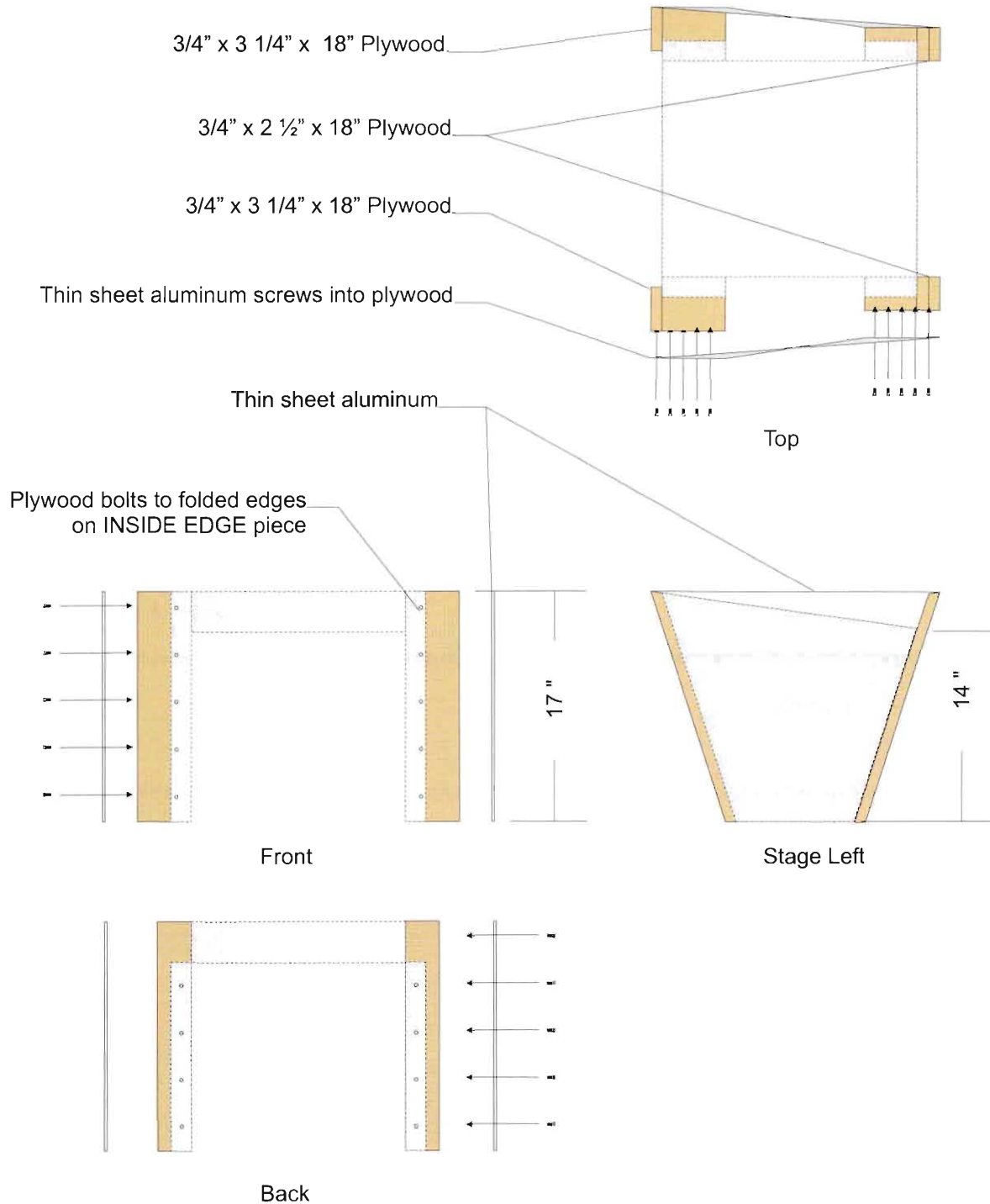
Not to Scale



COMPACT DECEPTION

LEG LOAD CHAMBERS

Scale 1" = 1'

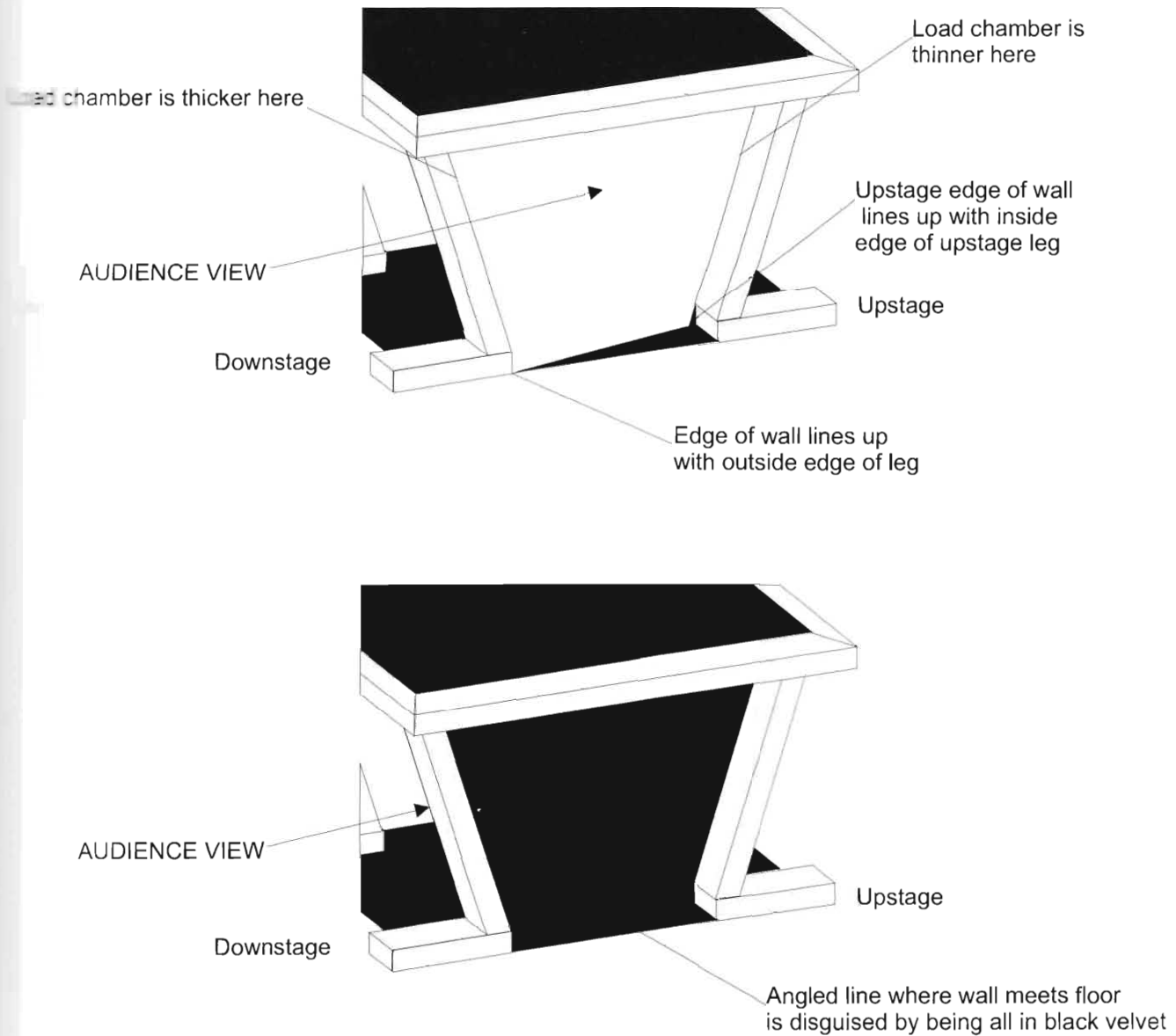


COMPACT DECEPTION

ANGLED LOAD CHAMBER WALL

Not to Scale

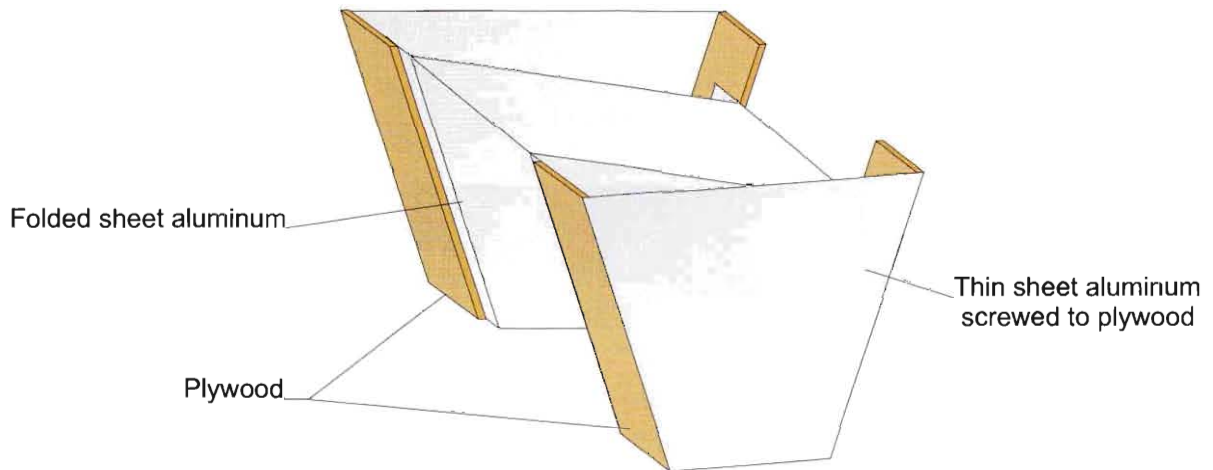
*Angled wall shown in white (actually covered in black velvet)



COMPACT DECEPTION

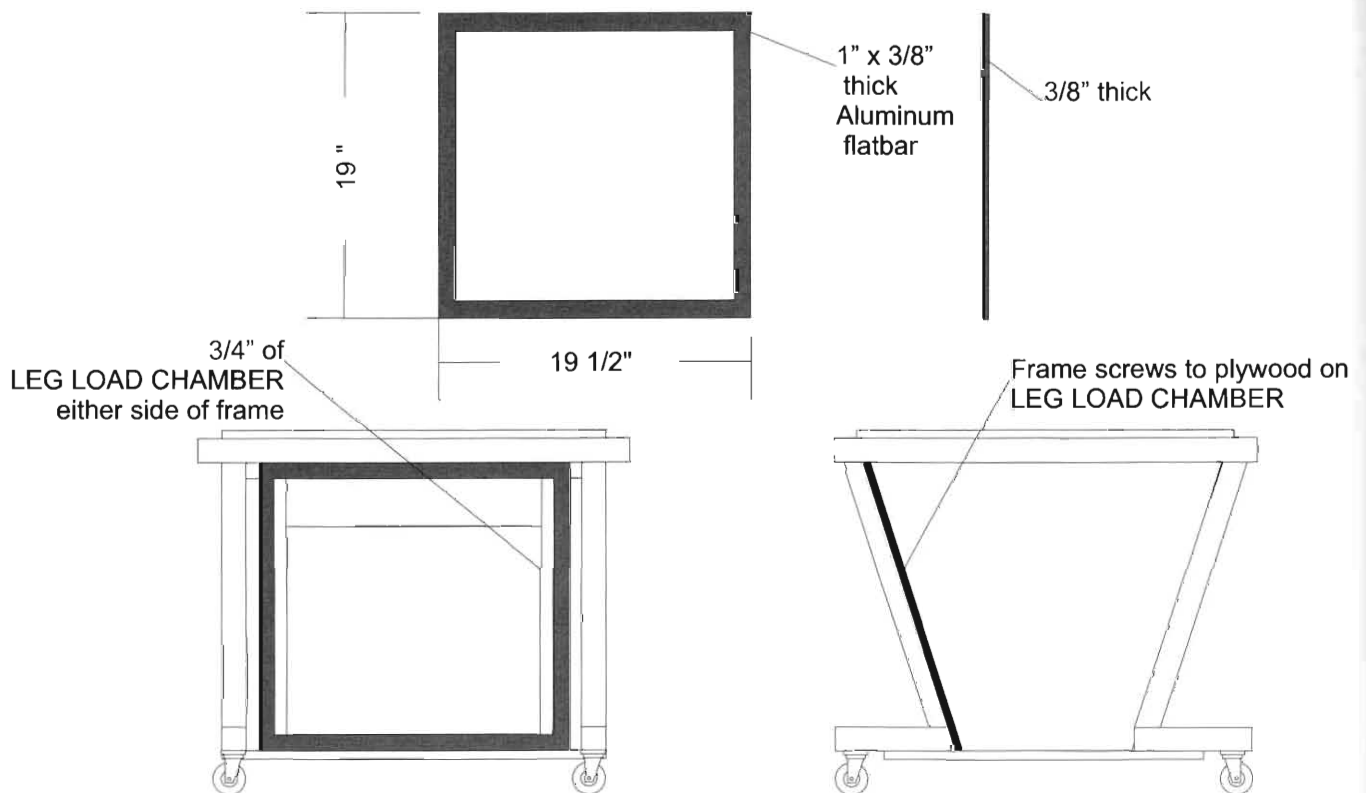
LEG LOAD CHAMBERS (3D VIEW)

Not to Scale



FRONT FRAME

Scale 1" = 1'



COMPACT DECEPTION

LEGS LOAD CHAMBER AND TABLE FRAMEWORK ASSEMBLED

Scale 1" = 1'

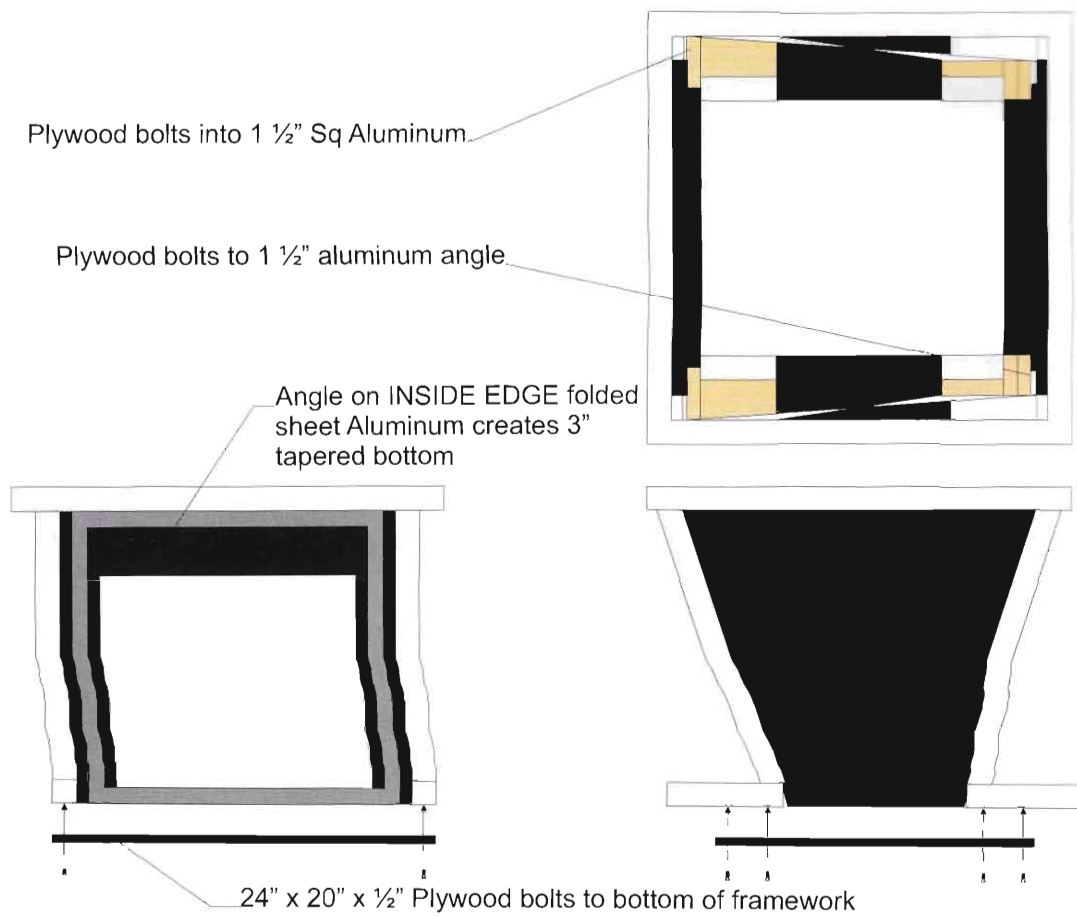
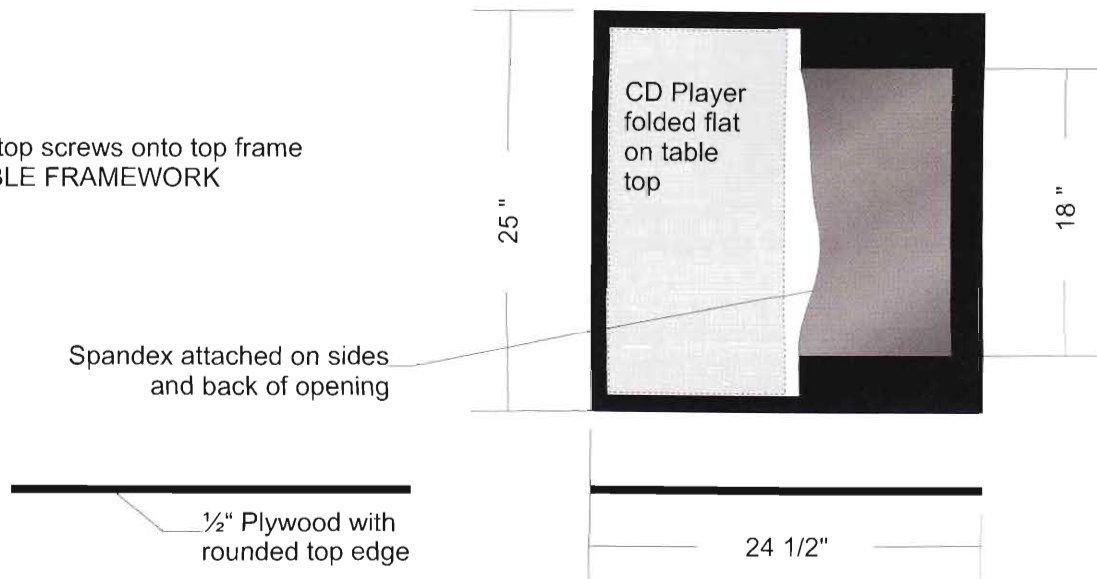


TABLE TOP

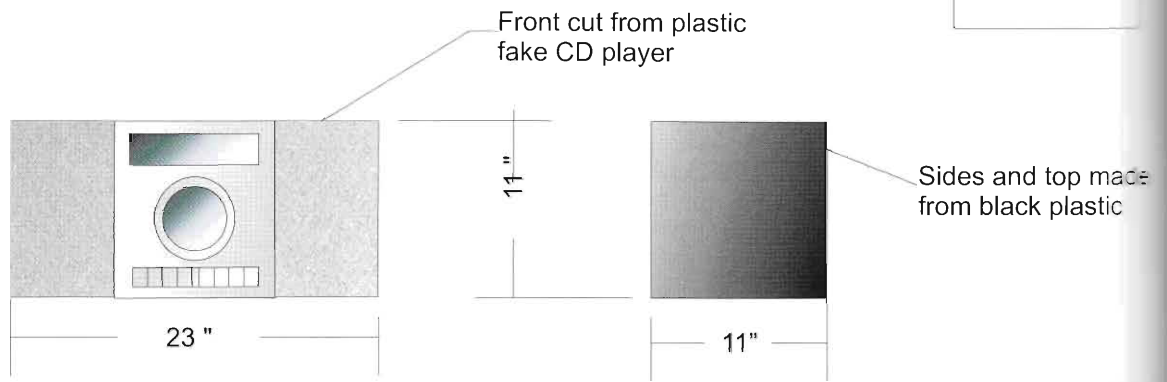
Table top screws onto top frame of TABLE FRAMEWORK



COMPACT DECEPTION

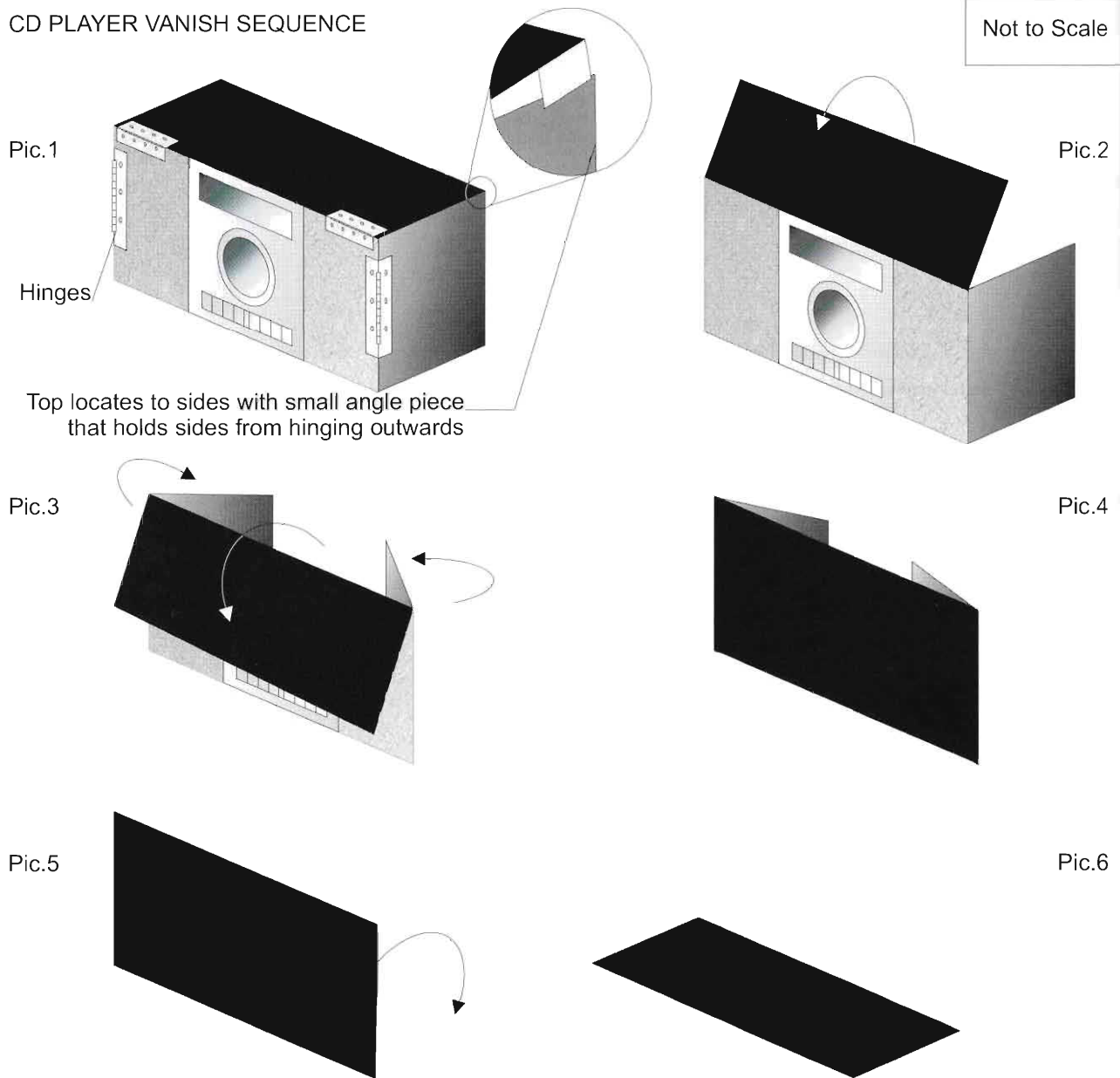
CD PLAYER

Scale 1" = 1"



CD PLAYER VANISH SEQUENCE

Not to Scale



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

Basic dimensions of the table and CD player. The lower diagram shows the hiding position of the assistant. The assistant has to lean as far forward as they can and then tuck their head to one side.

TABLE FRAMEWORK

The framework is made from 1 ½" sq aluminum and welded together. The back two angled legs also have two pieces of 1½" angle on their inside edges, this is used to mount the backs of the legs load chamber to. Either rivet, bolt or plug weld the angle to the back legs. This framework is the main support structure for the prop. The 2" diameter casters are the bolt-on type (not plate attachment) and the bolt passes through the sq aluminum to bolt the casters on.

TABLE FRAMEWORK (3D VIEW)

I thought it would be useful to show a 3d view of the framework. This view further illustrates the position of the angle on the back legs and shape of the table framework.

INSIDE EDGES

This is the inside edge of the legs load chambers and table top. The piece is made from folded sheet aluminum. Ideally it is bent from one piece, although it could also be made in three pieces (two sides and a flat piece for the center) welded together. The 1½" folded edges will be used for attachment to other parts of the prop. The table top has a 3" taper towards the back - it's thin at the front and the extra 3" lower at the back allows more room for the assistant's bottom (see the side view of the assistant in construction drawings).

INSIDE EDGES (3D VIEW)

Again, I thought that a 3d view of this folded aluminum piece would be helpful.

LEG LOAD CHAMBERS

Plywood strips make the front and back of the leg load chambers. The inside edges bolt to the plywood (round or countersunk heads on the inside, to a 'T' nut in the plywood). A thin piece of sheet aluminum screws into the edge of the plywood to form the outside edge of the load chamber. This thin sheet will have to twist slightly to conform to the shape of the load chamber side.

ANGLED LOAD CHAMBER WALL

Notice that the legs load chamber is thinner towards the back and wider at the front. I know this goes against normal illusion design (stuff normally tapers wider to the back) - but this is an idea of mine to create the impression that the side of the load chamber is flat and is the thinner thickness (2 ½").

I have not seen this design idea used before, so let me try to explain. The load chamber is wider at the front, and the extra width is behind the legs framework (1½"). The load chamber does not go beyond the outside edge of that framework. The load chamber tapers inwards 1½" towards the back. So when the audience get a side or angled view of the load chamber they can see the upstage leg and the black side.

The perception is that the flat side of the load chamber is within the legs framework, therefore the only thickness perceived is the remaining 2 ½" of the 4" load chamber (which we will also disguise to look thinner).

Look at the story board pictures and you can see how this works visually with the upstage leg being seen. This design works particularly well here, as the thickest part of the assistant's legs being hidden is their knees, which are towards the front of the prop (therefore more space for them).

LEG LOAD CHAMBERS (3D VIEW)

This view shows all the pieces together. Notice that the front plywood does not come flush to the inside edge piece but is set outward ¾" (plus the 3 ¼" of the plywood makes a total 4" load space) - this adds more depth to this inside black edge. The entire Legs Load Chamber is covered in black velvet.

FRONT FRAME

The front frame adds a bit of extra design to help break up the remaining thickness of the load chamber. 1" x 3/8" thick flat stock is welded into a rectangle frame then bolted onto the outside of the legs load chamber. The frame is painted (or powder coated) in a dark grey color.

LEGS LOAD CHAMBER AND TABLE FRAMEWORK ASSEMBLED

This diagram shows all the pieces together. Notice the front plywood pieces bolt to the inside of the front legs, flush with the outside edge. The back plywood bolts to the 1 1/2" aluminum angle that is attached to the inside edges of the back legs (to allow the audience to see the back legs).

A piece of 1/2" plywood (covered in black velvet) bolts to the underside of the legs framework. The black bottom hides the angle line of the outside edge of the legs load chamber.

TABLE TOP

The table top is made from a piece of 1/2" plywood with the top edge rounded with a router. The plywood is covered in black velvet and screwed to the top frame of the table framework. The front of the table top has a cut out for the CD player to lie flat into (23" x 11"). The folding CD player will hinge to the front edge of this plywood. The back of the table top has an 18" wide hole for the assistant's bottom and lower back. This hole is covered with black spandex stapled to the plywood on the sides and back of the opening. The spandex pushes down into the table top when the assistant sits on it.

CD PLAYER

The CD player is a fake molded plastic CD player face with the sides and top made from black plastic and hinge to the face. This CD player is available from a company called PROPS by IDM- they make fake plastic electronic goods for furniture store displays. This CD player is actually a wall mount style CD player about 4" thick, I have altered it to look like a boom box style. A real CD player could also be used by gutting it and using the plastic front.

CD PLAYER VANISH SEQUENCE

The first picture shows the position of the hinges in the CD player. The top locates on the side with a small angle piece.

Pic.1 The CD player at the beginning of the illusion. It has no back as the assistant is hidden inside it.

Pic.2 The top of the player flips over and covers the front of the player. The inside of the top has velvet on it to match the table top.

Pic.3 The sides of the player fold in. At this point the assistant is sitting up and the sides fold in over the top of their thighs.

Pic.4 Top completely folded over and sides closing in.

Pic.5 The CD player is folded flat with the velvet inside of the top now on the outside.

Pic.6 The CD player lies flat onto the table top.

CLOTH

The cloth needs to be big enough to cover the prop with the CD player in position and reach the floor, plus a bit. In preset the assistant is in place and the cloth is gathered up and draped across the exposed part of the assistant. The ends of the cloth hanging over the sides of the table are then folded up onto the assistant's back. The whole package looks like a bundle of cloth on the table behind the CD player.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

The table framework is finished in a silver powder coat. The front frame in a dark grey. All the plywood and legs load chamber is covered in black velvet.

ETC...

I've been working on this illusion, on and off, for many years. I've taken this idea through many different designs and methods to get to this version.

One of the first 'big' stage tricks I purchased when I was about 14 years old was a Vanishing Radio from Vienna Magic. I purchased it second hand from British illusionist Richard Cadell. I thought that radio was pretty cool at the time and always liked the idea of having it change into an assistant. I never built that effect with my Vanishing Radio, but did alter it so you could carry it in on your shoulder like an 80's radio, then place it on the table for the vanish (I notice Vienna Magic now advertises a version of that for sale - coincidence?). So this illusion came from those early ideas and developed from there.

On a side note - the Vienna Magic vanishing radio was a great trick in the eighties (and maybe early nineties) but definitely looks very out of date now. However, it still amazes me how many Magicians are desperate to get their hands on one. Please wake up and look at the radios being sold in Circuit City - live in the now! Are you really going to use an old 80's radio for your modern act? Not unless you plan to dress like Billy Idol with an 80's revival magic show. Well, that's my personal opinion.

The table design features my idea of tapering an upright load chamber thinner at the back so the audience see the back upright of the table leg and the front table leg blocks view of the wider part of the taper. I have not seen this design idea used anywhere before. I used a version of this idea on the design for a load chamber on an illusion for Dirk Arthur, which is currently in his Las Vegas show at the Tropicana hotel.

The idea of hiding an assistant under a bunched up cloth is not new. If you have not played with this before, it's actually very effective. It is often hard to judge how much space a bunched up cloth would take, and the extra bulk of the assistant goes virtually unnoticed.

I've often thought it would be cool to put a CD in the player (it pushes in through a slot in the front and the assistant drops it into the load chamber) then start the music - which would be a vocal track of a female singer. While the music plays, the Magician covers the player etc. When the assistant appears she has a Mic. in her hand and is actually singing the last line of the song.

THE FURNACE

THE FURNACE



The Magician invites a volunteer on stage to assist. The volunteer is shown the 'Magic Cabinet of Secrecy!' - a box with a cloth wrapped around it.



The Magician opens the door slightly and pushes the volunteer inside. Once the cabinet is closed, the mood changes to a more sinister feel and the Magician announces that it is in fact the 'Magic Cabinet of Doom!'.

THE FURNACE



The cloth is pulled off revealing a metal box with a few vent holes in the sides. The Magician climbs a step ladder and places a funnel into a hole on the top of the box. An assistant hands the Magician a can of 'Flammable Liquid' which the Magician pours into the funnel. The Magician removes the funnel, lights a lighter from his pocket and throws it in through the hole.



Smoke pours from the box through the vent holes in the sides. The Magician throws open the door to reveal only the burnt remains of the volunteer and flames still burning in the bottom of the box.

METHOD

This is a good illusion for corporate events - everyone loves to set the CEO on fire! Not so good for children's birthday party shows though.

This is really a version of the Cremation illusion to be used on an audience member. The volunteer is set up before hand. They don't need to know the method or what is really going to happen. All they need to do is practice getting into the box once or twice and know that they will be in there for a couple of minutes then let out by an assistant off stage.

The box is essentially the old Protean cabinet. Two mirrors set at 45 degree angles to the side walls reflect the sides as the back of the box and the upright central post hides the point at which the mirrors join. The box has two doors. One door is on the back of the box and directly accesses the hiding space (triangle area behind the mirrors). This door has hidden hinges on the inside, so when the door is closed it looks like the back of the box, not a door. The front door has big hinges and is the door that opens to show the empty box with the skeleton hanging on the post.

The cloth wrapped around the box stops the audience from seeing where the hinges are on the box, plus, it gives a reason to convince the volunteer to step inside, as they have no idea what type of box it is. The following page has a basic story board showing the cloth coming off the box.

(Pic. 1) The box begins with the back facing the audience. The volunteers gets in through the back door with the box at an angle so the audience does not see inside.

(Pic. 2) Once closed the Magician begins to turn the box away from the audience.

(Pic. 3) The assistant begins to pull the cloth off.

(Pic. 4 & 5) The Magician quickly changes direction and turns the box back towards the audience as the assistant goes in the opposite direction pulling off the cloth.

(Pic. 6) The Magician brings the front door around to the front and stops as the assistant pulls the remaining cloth off and exits.

The whole sequence happens quickly with the Magician and assistant moving in opposite directions.

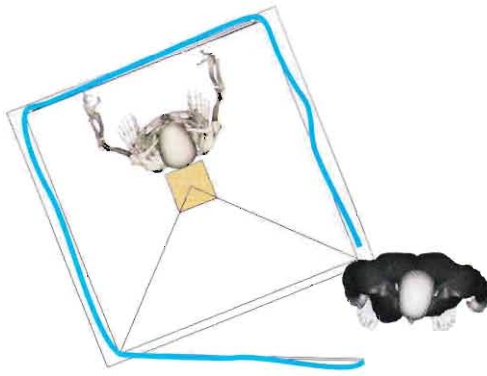
The volunteer is now safely in the back section of the box. The Magician climbs the step ladder and does all the gags with the 'Flammable Liquid' and the lighter etc. The funnel and the lighter (which of course goes out as soon as the Magician drops it in the box) go into a small door on the roof of the box.

A small smoke machine in the back of the box between the volunteer's feet is activated, it fills the front section of the box with smoke. When the Magician opens the door the smoke floods out and the skeleton is on view. An artificial flame effect unit gives the fire element without actually using fire (basically a fan, lights and a piece of silk).

I can not stress enough that it is NOT SAFE to use any sort of real pyrotechnics in a prop like this so close to a member of the public - so don't try it.

THE FURNACE

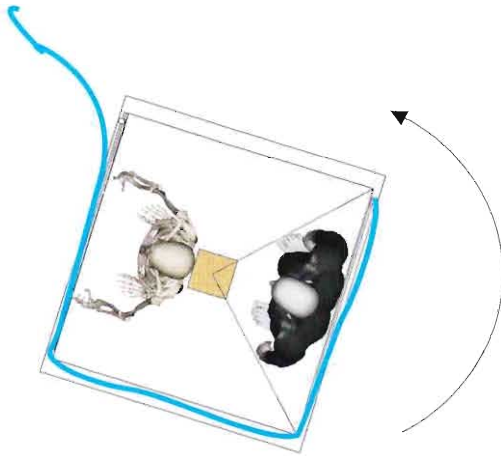
Pic. 1



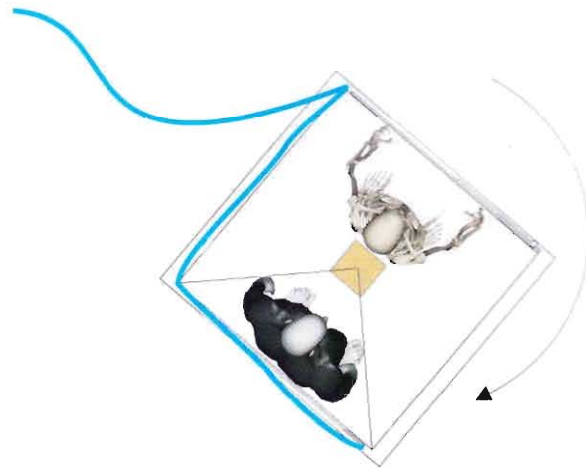
Pic. 2



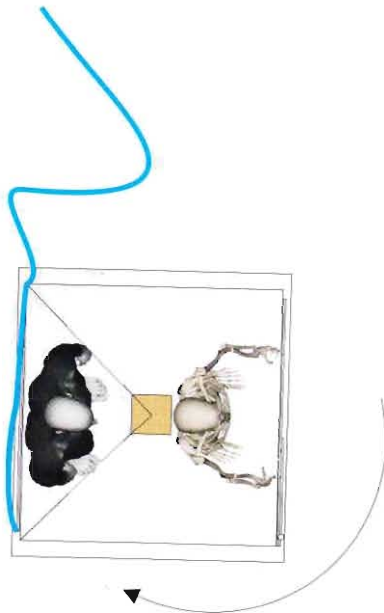
Pic. 3



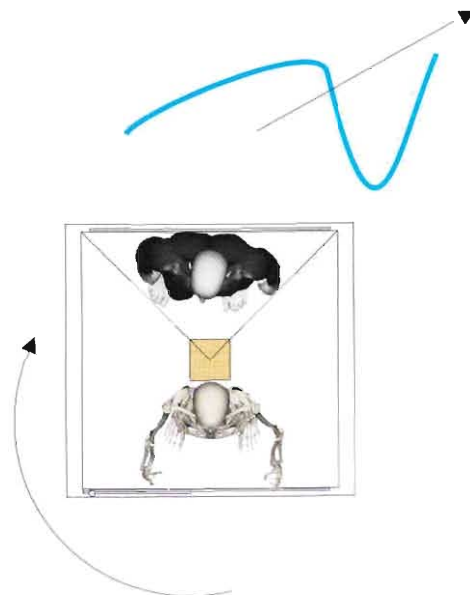
Pic. 4



Pic. 5



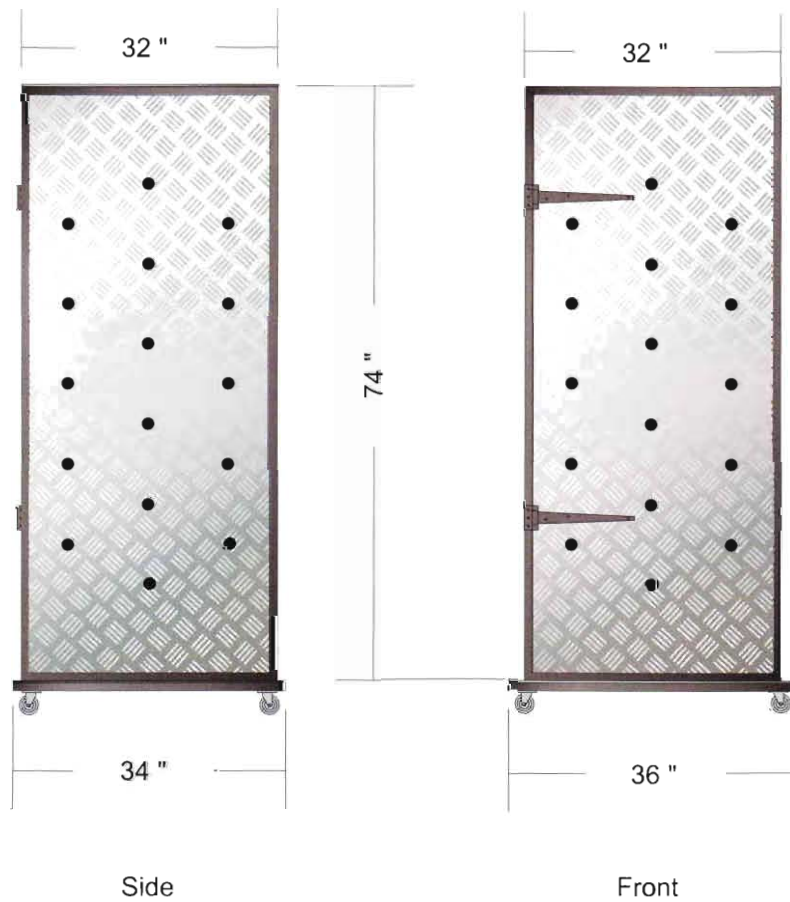
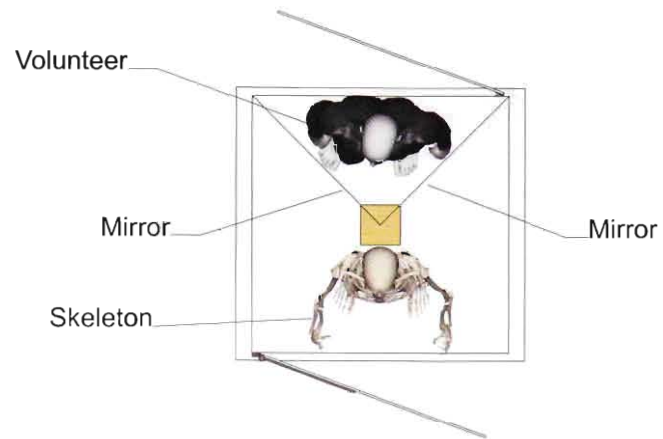
Pic. 6



THE FURNACE

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

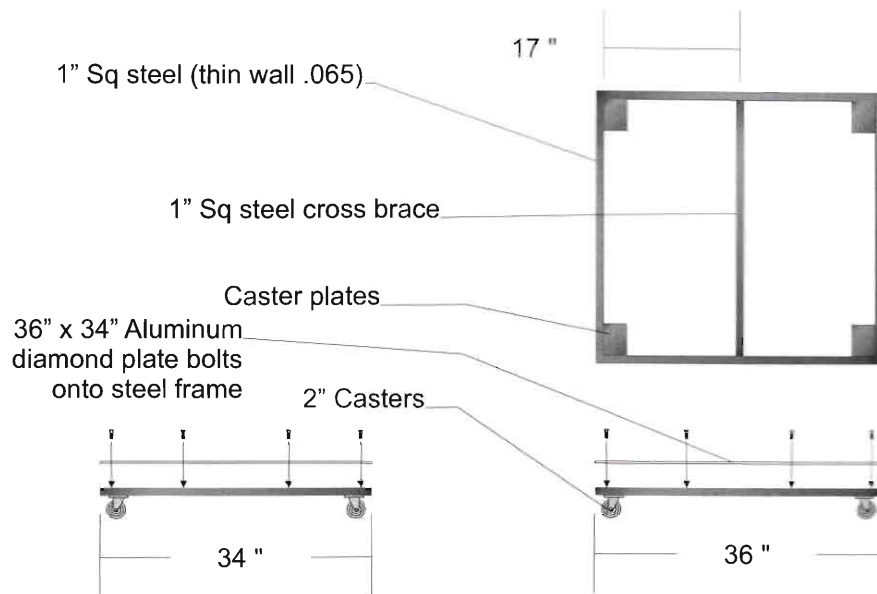
Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



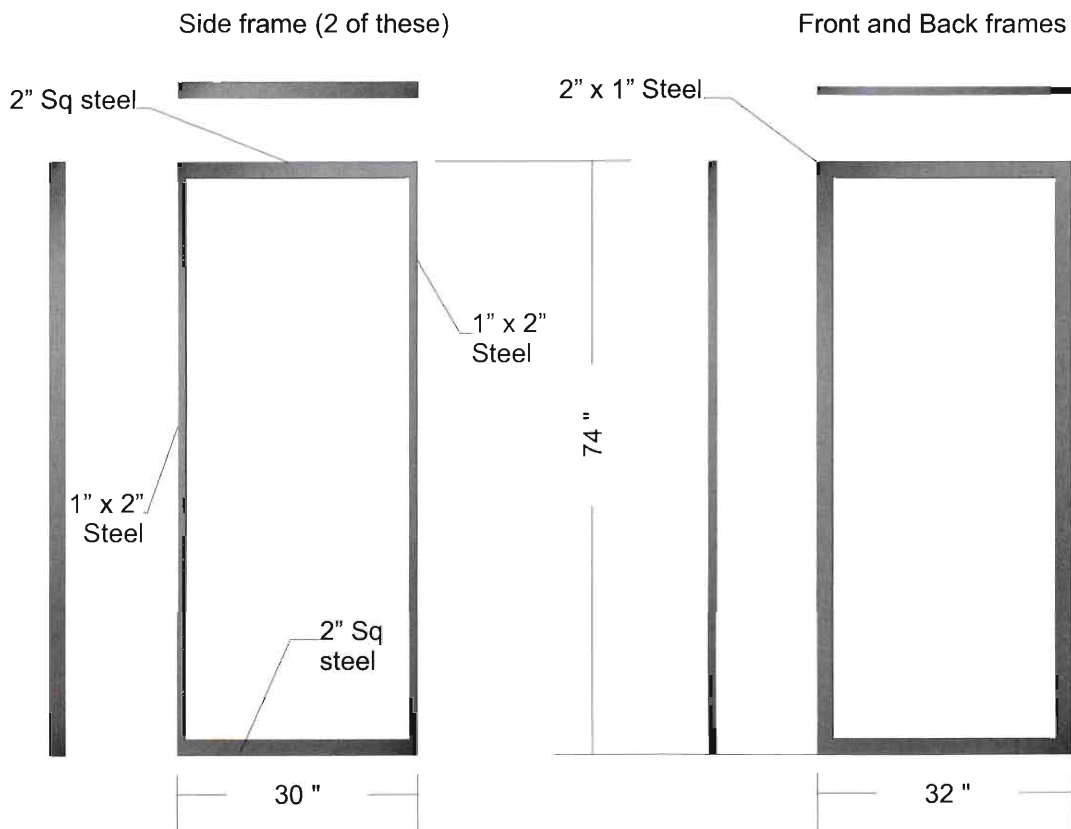
THE FURNACE

BASE

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



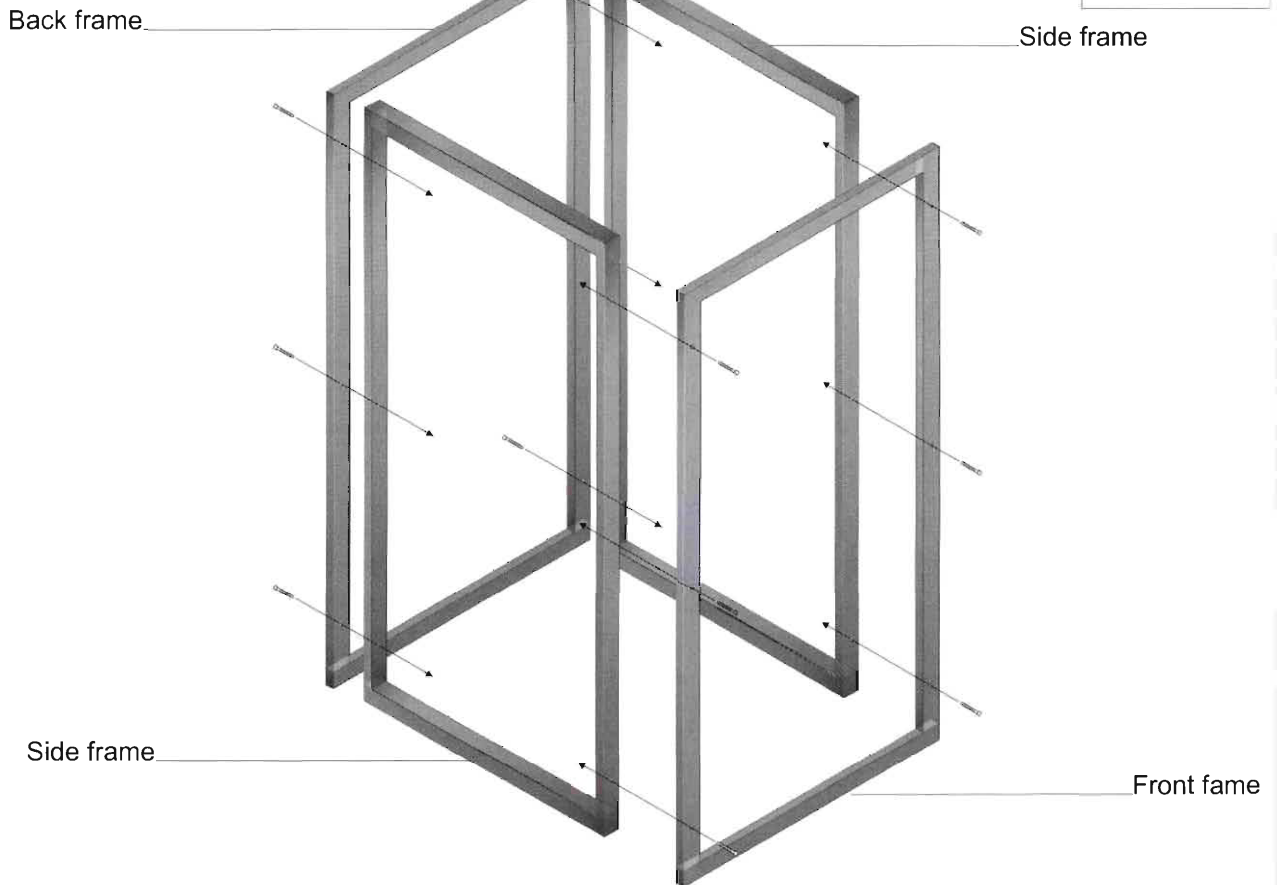
FRAMES



THE FURNACE

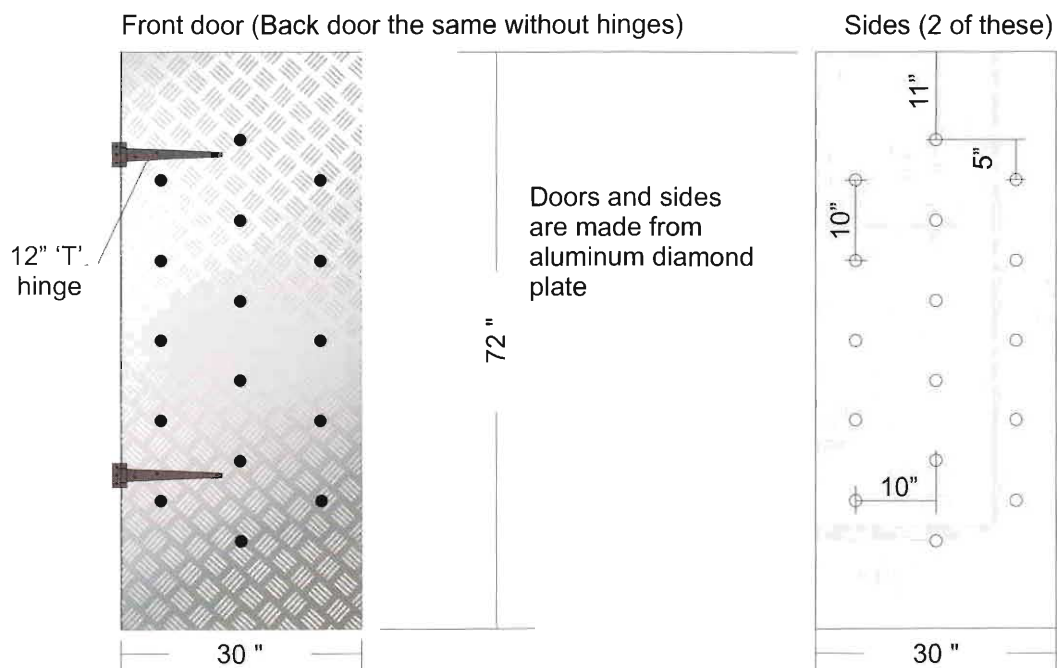
FRAMES ASSEMBLY (3D VIEW)

Not to Scale



DOORS AND SIDES

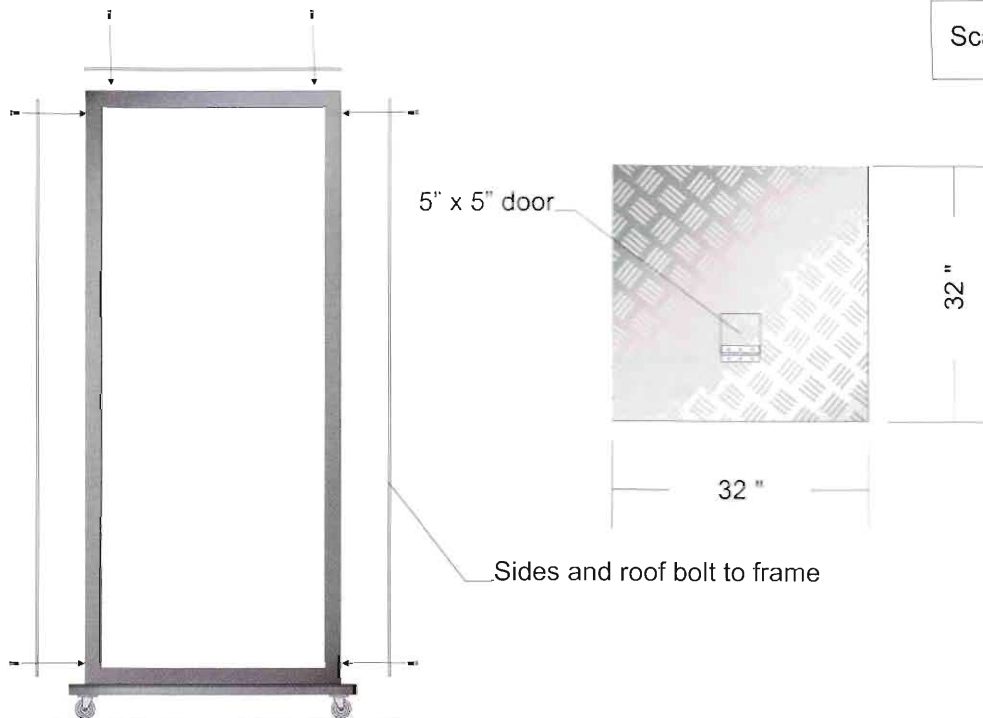
Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



THE FURNACE

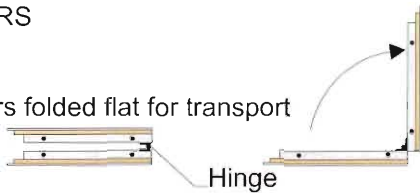
ROOF

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



MIRRORS

Mirrors folded flat for transport

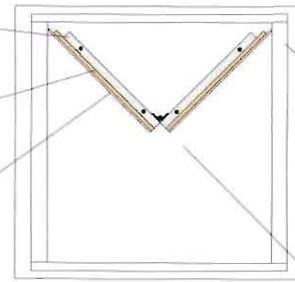


1" Sq steel bolts through floor and roof

$\frac{1}{2}"$ Plywood

$\frac{1}{4}"$ Mirror

18" Mirror



1" Sq steel

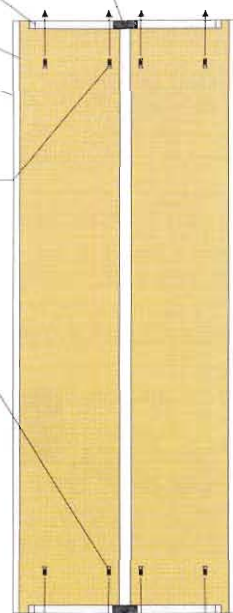
Hinge

$\frac{1}{2}"$ Plywood

$\frac{1}{4}"$ Mirror

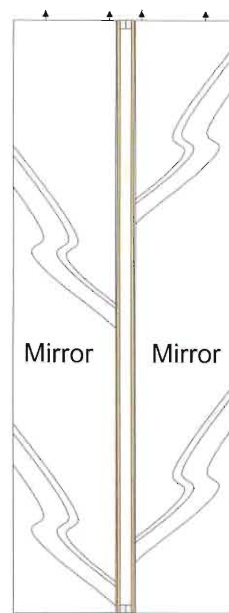
Bolts go through steel and roof to secure mirrors

Bolts go through steel and floor to secure mirrors



Back of Mirrors

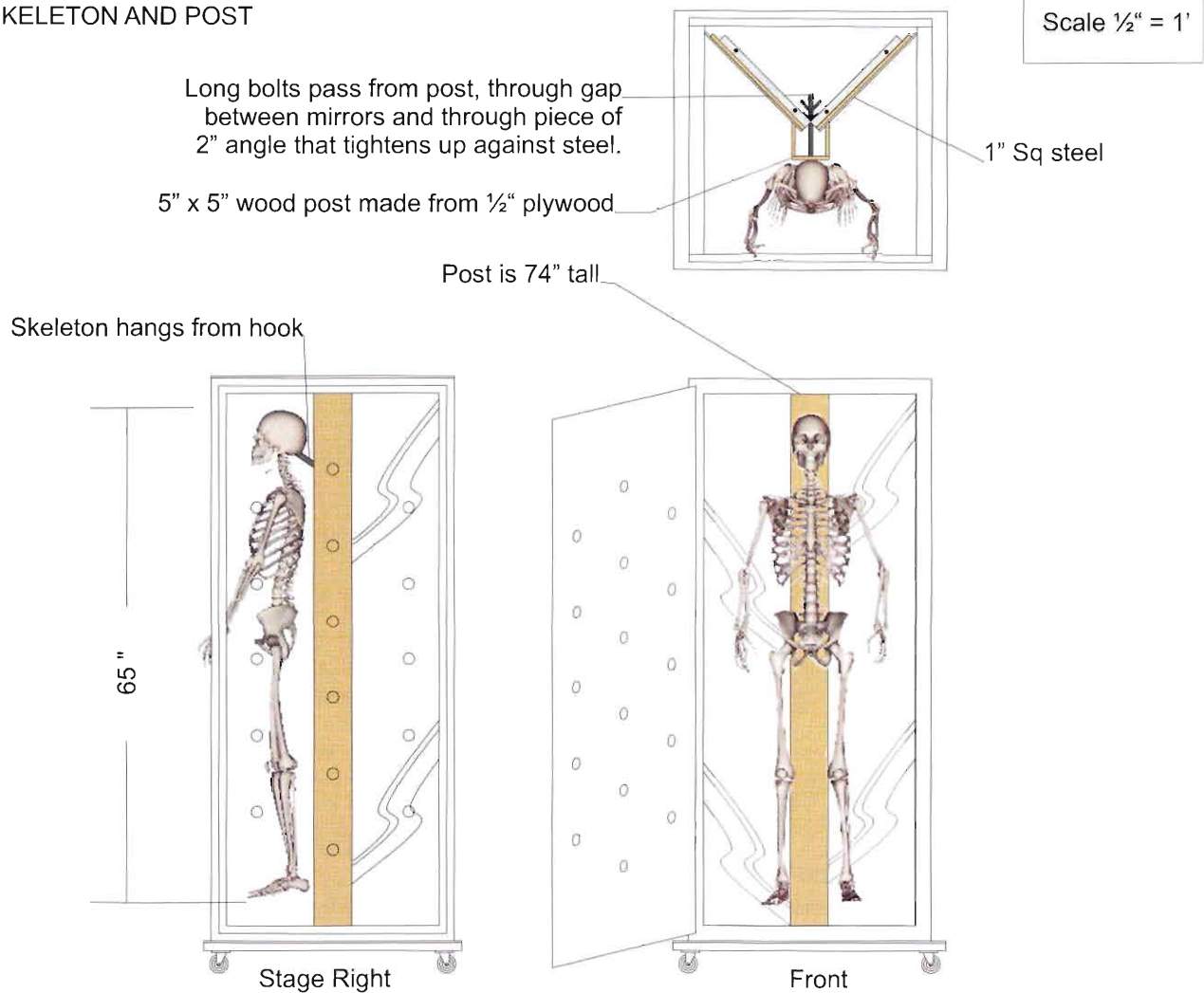
74"



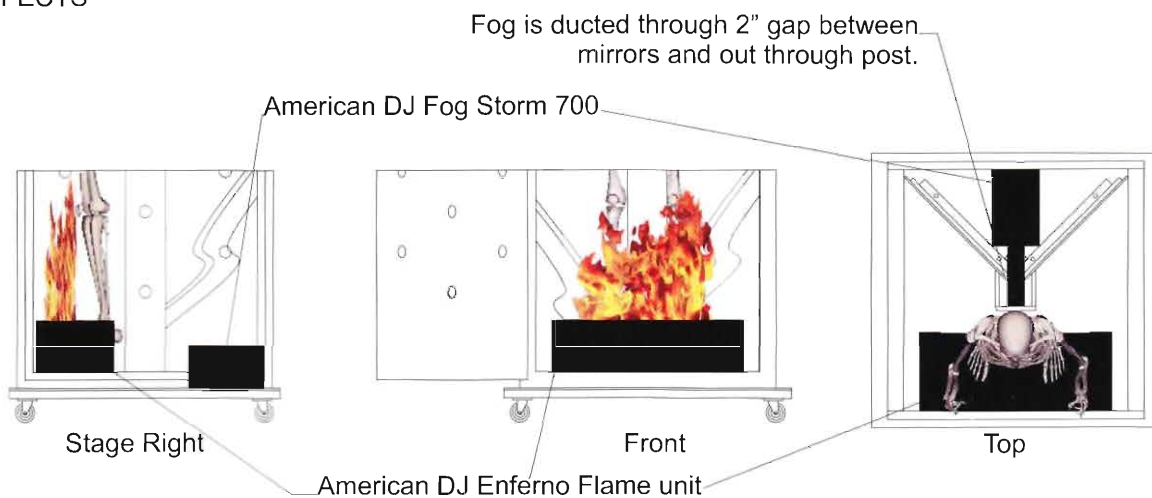
Front of Mirrors

THE FURNACE

SKELETON AND POST



EFFECTS



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

Here are the basic sizes of the illusion. The plan view shows the doors on the prop (front and back) plus, the position of the volunteer, skeleton and mirrors.

BASE

The base is simple in design. The frame is in steel with the aluminum bolted or riveted to it. I've set the casters in slightly to allow a caster plate to be welded to the inside of the frame.

FRAMES

The frames are made so that the framework of the box when bolted together will add up to be 2" square all around except the top and bottom cross bars on the front and back door frames.

FRAMES ASSEMBLY

I felt it would be useful to show this 3D view of the frames bolting together. Once the doors and sides are attached to the frames, they can still bolt together like this and come apart for transporting the illusion in flat pieces. Once together, the framework will bolt to the base.

DOORS AND SIDES

All these aluminum panels are made the same. The only difference is the hinges that get added to the doors. I have shown the hole spacing, the center row of holes centered to the panel. The back door is the same as a side panel except it hinges away from the frame with the hinge hidden behind the door when it is closed.

ROOF

The roof, as with the sides, bolts to the frame. The sides could be riveted on as they do not need to come off again, but the roof does if the illusion is to be broken down and transported.

MIRRORS

The mirrors are built as a separate unit that bolts inside the box. The mirror is mounted to a plywood backing and steel bracing runs horizontally across the top and bottom of the back side of the plywood. Bolts pass through the steel and the roof or base of the illusion to hold the mirrors in place. The steel is hinged so that the mirrors can fold flat when the illusion breaks down for transporting.

SKELETON AND POST

The post is simply a three sided tall box in plywood. Bolts run from the front of the post back through the gap between the mirrors. A piece of angle drilled on the angle has a bolt behind it and is used to 'suck' the post into place on the mirrors (not too tight though). I would also run velcro down the back edges of the post and on the mirror surface to stick the post on. A hook on the post holds the skeleton. Halloween suppliers will carry a few different skeletons - I've shown a 5' 5" skeleton here and imagine it being fairly comical looking.

EFFECTS

As I said in the Method section, I can not stress enough that it is NOT SAFE to use any sort of real pyrotechnics in a prop like this so close to a member of the public - so don't try it. To give a fire effect I have used a smoke machine and an artificial flame unit.

The smoke machine sits in the bottom of the volunteer's area and the volunteer must be instructed to step over it as he gets in. There is a 2" pipe that runs from the end of the machine just through the gap between the mirrors (the ply needs to be shaved away to allow this) and to the front of the post. The remote for this smoke machine is operated by an assistant off stage. Because of the small space, only certain machines will fit. I have shown an American DJ Fog Storm 700, it's inexpensive and it is the right size. I have not personally used this unit but it should have sufficient output for this illusion.

The flame unit sits right at the front - in front of the skeleton. I have shown an American DJ Enferno. Also two or three LeMatre 'LeFlame' units would also work well (I can recommend these, they look pretty good from a few feet away). Using an Enferno is a cheaper option than several 'Le Flame' units. The flames are turned on by the assistant off stage.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

The sides of the box are made from aluminum diamond plate. I would finish the insides of these with a light grinder look or a drum sander finish. The hinges should be big and old looking, perhaps rusty. The framework and base frame is all finished with a black powder coat. The wooden post is unpainted plywood with a stain to bring out the grain. If the lines of the mirror on the floor and roof are too apparent, then black lines in an 'X' shape will blend the mirror edges with a design.

ETC...

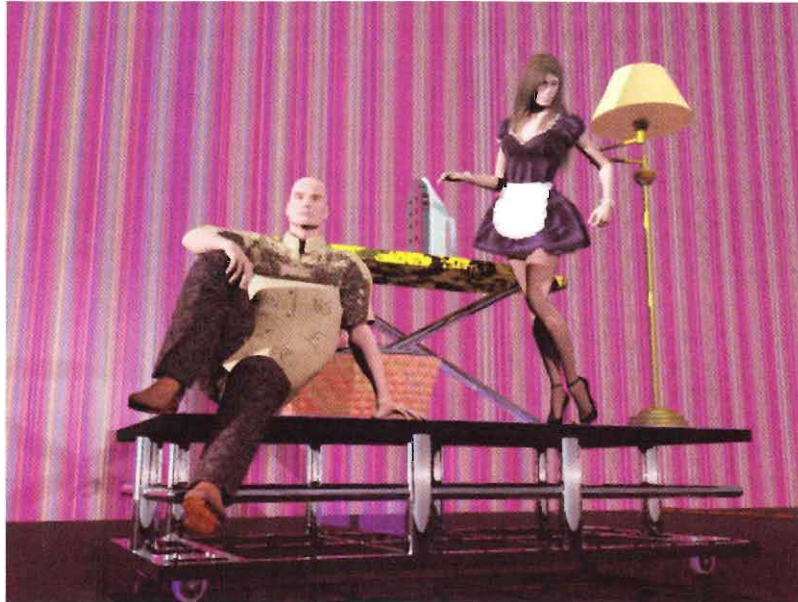
At a corporate show I performed in Reading in the UK; they wanted me to vanish the host of the show. There was no time to rehearse, so I needed to come up with a simple illusion that I could teach him to do in less than a minute. I built this illusion in a few days and proceeded to use it for many events after that. I have made a few improvements from the original for this book. My original version was a bit shorter and the guy had to stoop to get in. Constructed from all steel, including the side panels, it was pretty heavy - aluminum should be a little better.

I always used it as a comedy piece rather than dark or sinister, but I suppose either way would work. I would recommend building a wooden case or have a road case built to protect the mirrors in transport. When I performed this illusion I would run a line of gaffer tape around the inside edge of the volunteer's space to seal where the mirrors touch the sides, roof and floor. This keeps most of the smoke out of the space, only a bit leaks in from around the pipe fitting on the machine.

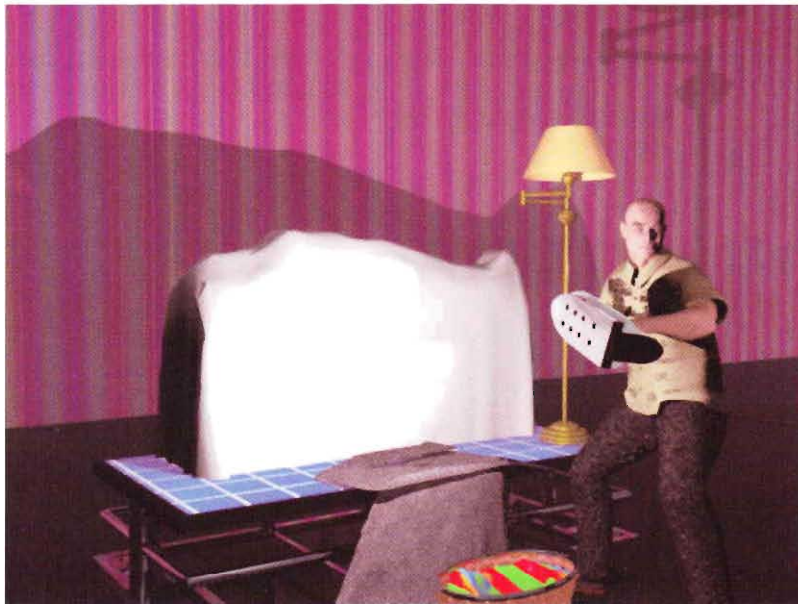
I found the effect of the empty box to be very convincing. With smoke disbursing from the box, stage lights would shine through the holes making 'spikes' of light through the smoke. These 'spikes' get reflected in the mirror and appear to be also coming through from the back - add to that the shiny random finish on the interior of the box and it looks great.

Oh, and make sure the latch to hold the back door closed can also be opened from inside - so the volunteer can let themselves out if your assistant forgets to!

IRON



The Magician introduces his new 'hired help'! The Magician's assistant is seen standing on a thin platform with an ironing board, some sheets and a basket of clothes.

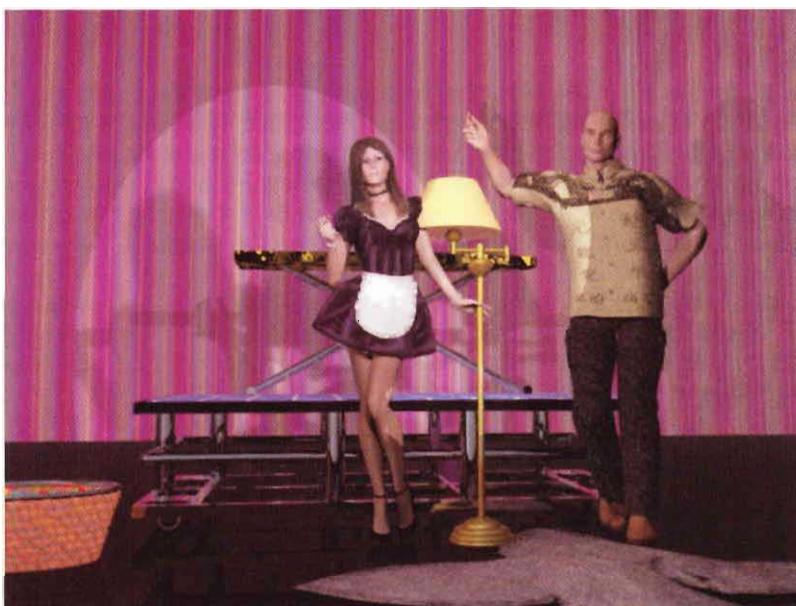


The Magician moves the basket and pulls the sheet out the way. The assistant is persuaded to lie on the ironing board and the Magician covers her with a sheet.

IRON



Using the Iron, the Magician irons the assistant completely flat. Pulling the sheet off the ironing board, the assistant has vanished.



The Magician takes the lamp from the platform and places it downstage. The lamp is covered with a sheet. The Magician snatches away the sheet and the assistant has reappeared holding the lamp.

METHOD

The platform that the illusion is presented on contains two double-sided mirrors within its framework. The mirrors run from front to back, much like the sides of a mirror tunnel. When the audience sees the illusion at the beginning of the routine, the inside mirrors reflect the backdrop and surrounding framework of the table, as do the outside mirrors. In this situation, the mirrors are virtually invisible. The first sheet the Magician casually throws off the platform falls onto the front of the table, covering the area between the mirrors. At this point the assistant can move into the secret compartment between the mirrors and the outside mirrors will not allow the audience to see she is there.

Once the Magician has covered the front of the load compartment with the sheet dropped across the front of the platform, the assistant takes her place on the ironing board.

The upstage half of the board has a trap that swings downward. The assistant keeps her weight on the front 11" of the board. The Magician throws a sheet covering the assistant. The sheet reaches all the way to the platform. The Magician begins to press on the assistant with the iron (which is, of course, a fake prop - not a real working hot one!).

(Pictures 1 to 4 on the following page.) The assistant drops the trap and begins dropping through the ironing board into the space under the cloth.

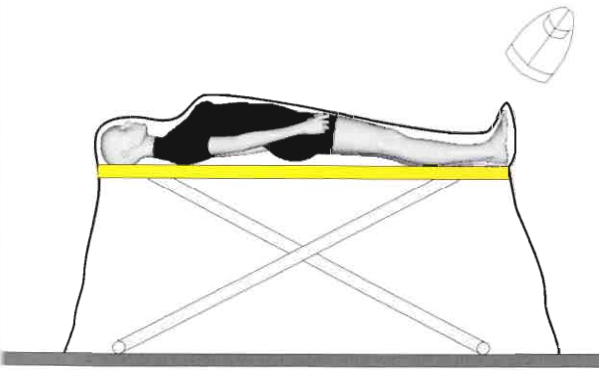
(Pic. 5) Once the Magician has completely 'ironed' the assistant flat, she is hidden under the cloth the covers that board.

(Pic. 6) The assistant opens a trap in the top of the platform. She steps down onto a dropping floor located on the underside of the platform top, that moves down for the assistant to kneel on. Once completely between the mirrors and the trap closed, the Magician pulls away the sheet to show the empty ironing board.

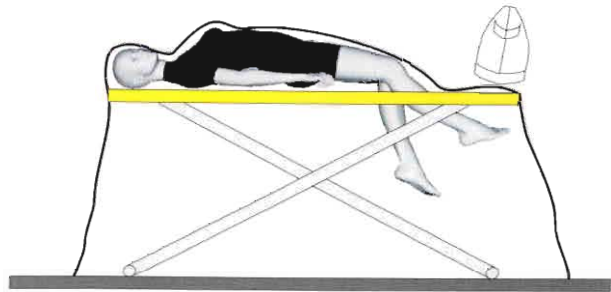
For the reappearance of the assistant the Magician takes the lamp from the platform. The lamp is placed just downstage of the platform. The Magician takes the sheet that is lying over the front of the load compartment and picks it up, walking it downstage and hanging it on the lamp. As this happens, the assistant climbs out of the load chamber (swinging the bar framework aside) and crawls along the floor between the Magician's legs. As the Magician hangs the sheet over the lamp the assistant stays crouched under it. On the Magician's command the assistant stands up as the Magician pulls away the sheet.

I'd love to take credit for this mirror table design, but I can not. This mirror table was inspired by the mirror table designed by P. T. Selbit (of Sawing in Half fame) for an illusion called 'Broadcasting a Girl' which I believe was performed by Dante. Details of that illusion can be found in 'P. T. Selbit, Magical Innovator'. It was published by Mike Caveney's Magical Publications.

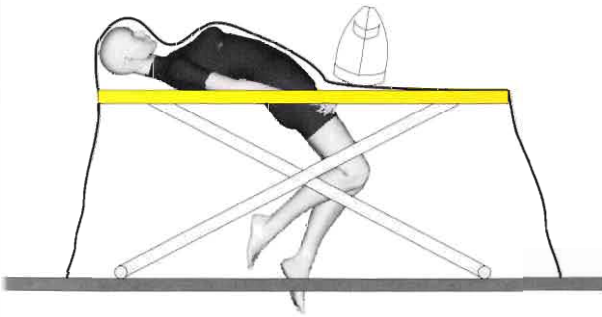
Pic.1



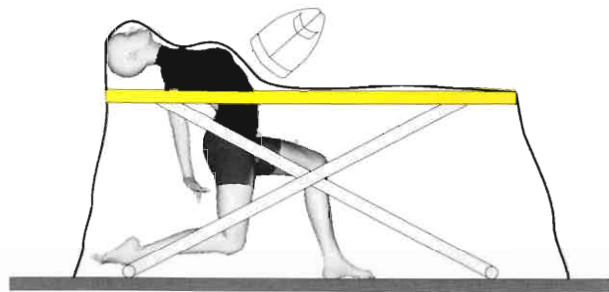
Pic.2



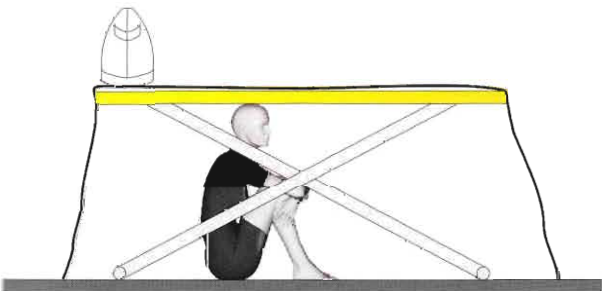
Pic.3



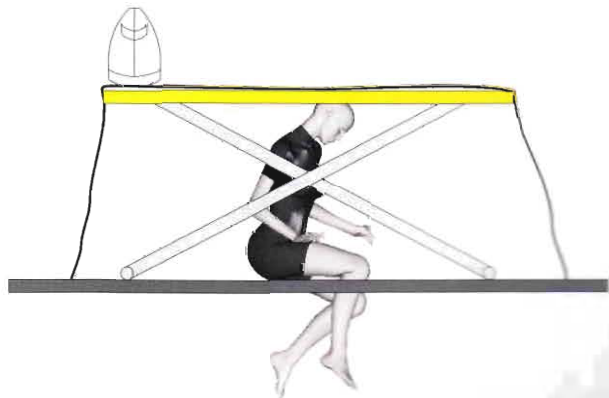
Pic.4



Pic.5



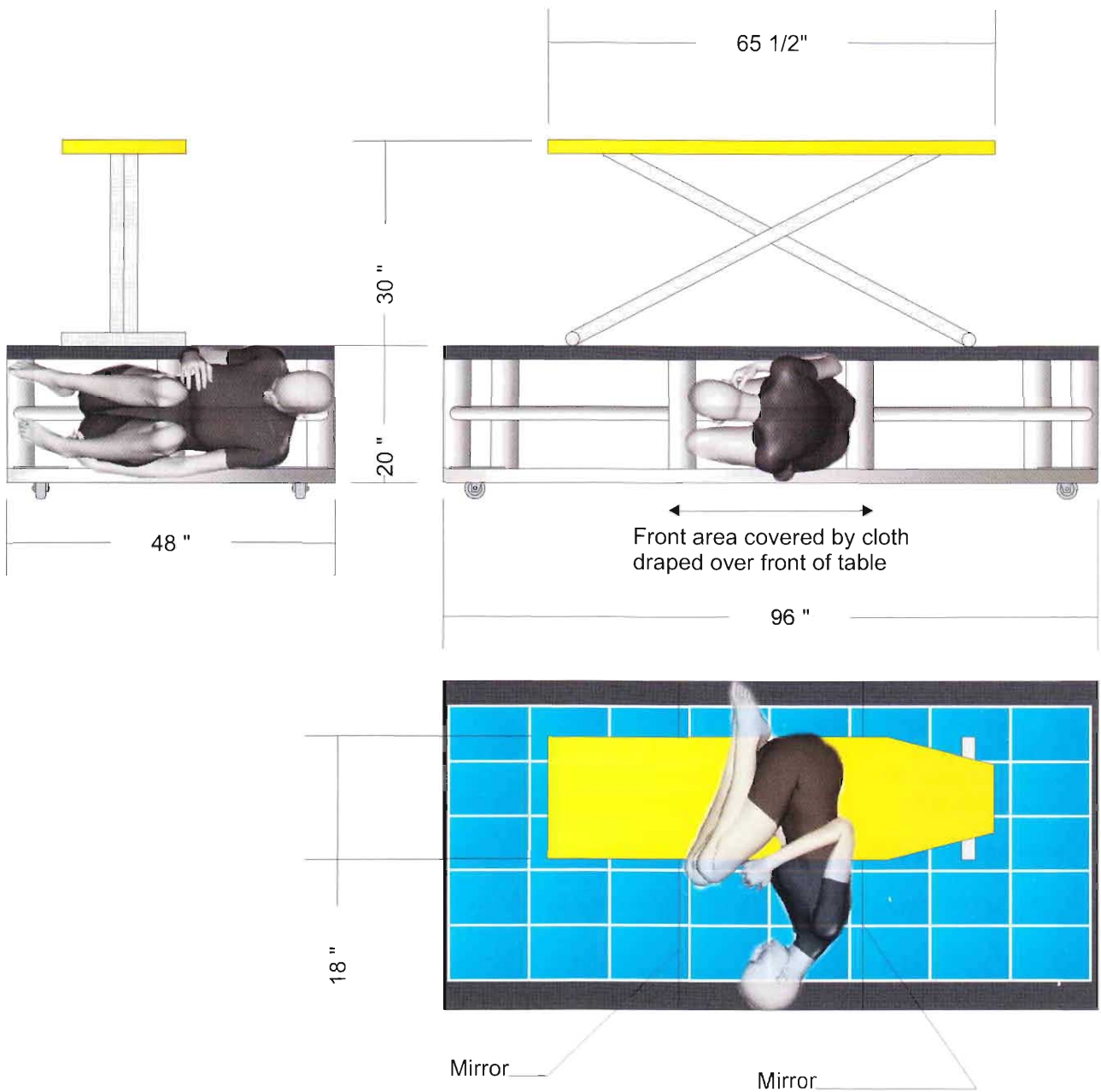
Pic.6



IRON

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

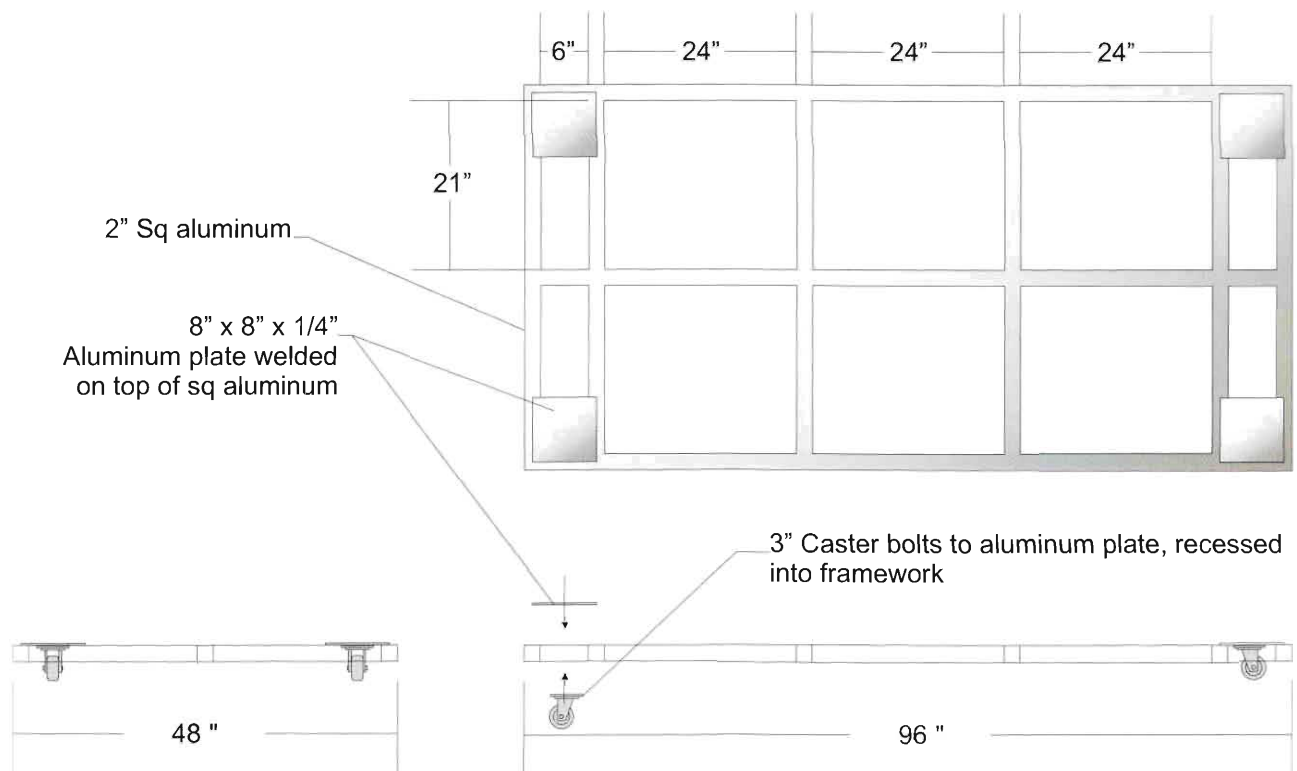
Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



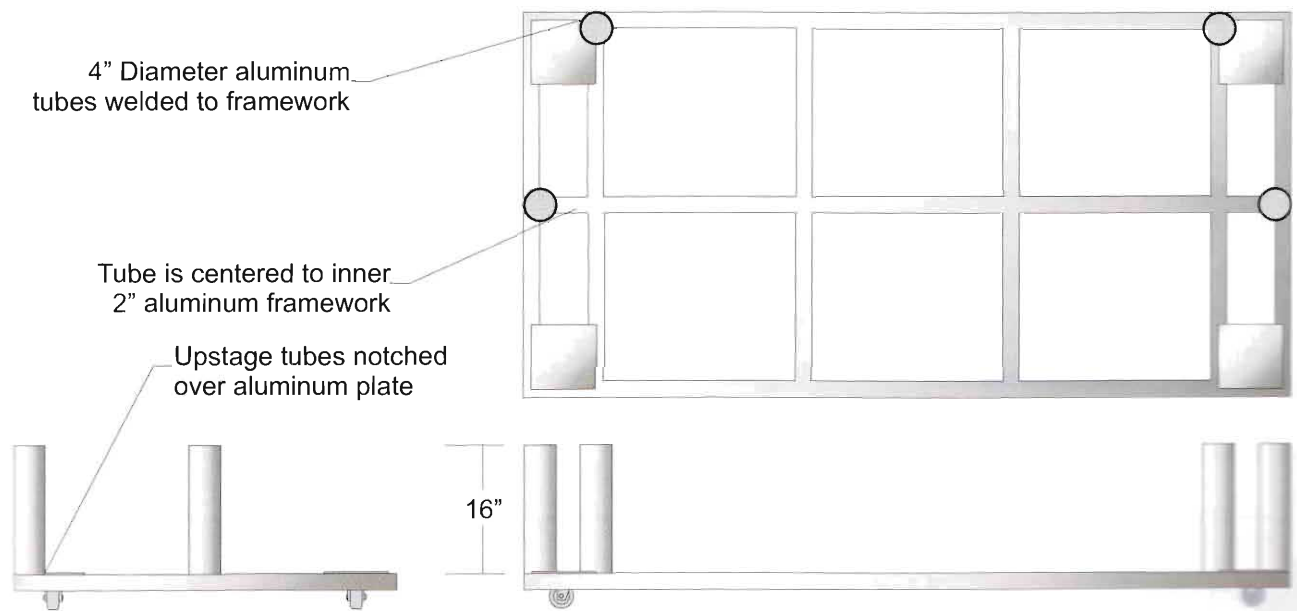
IRON

CASTER FRAMEWORK

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



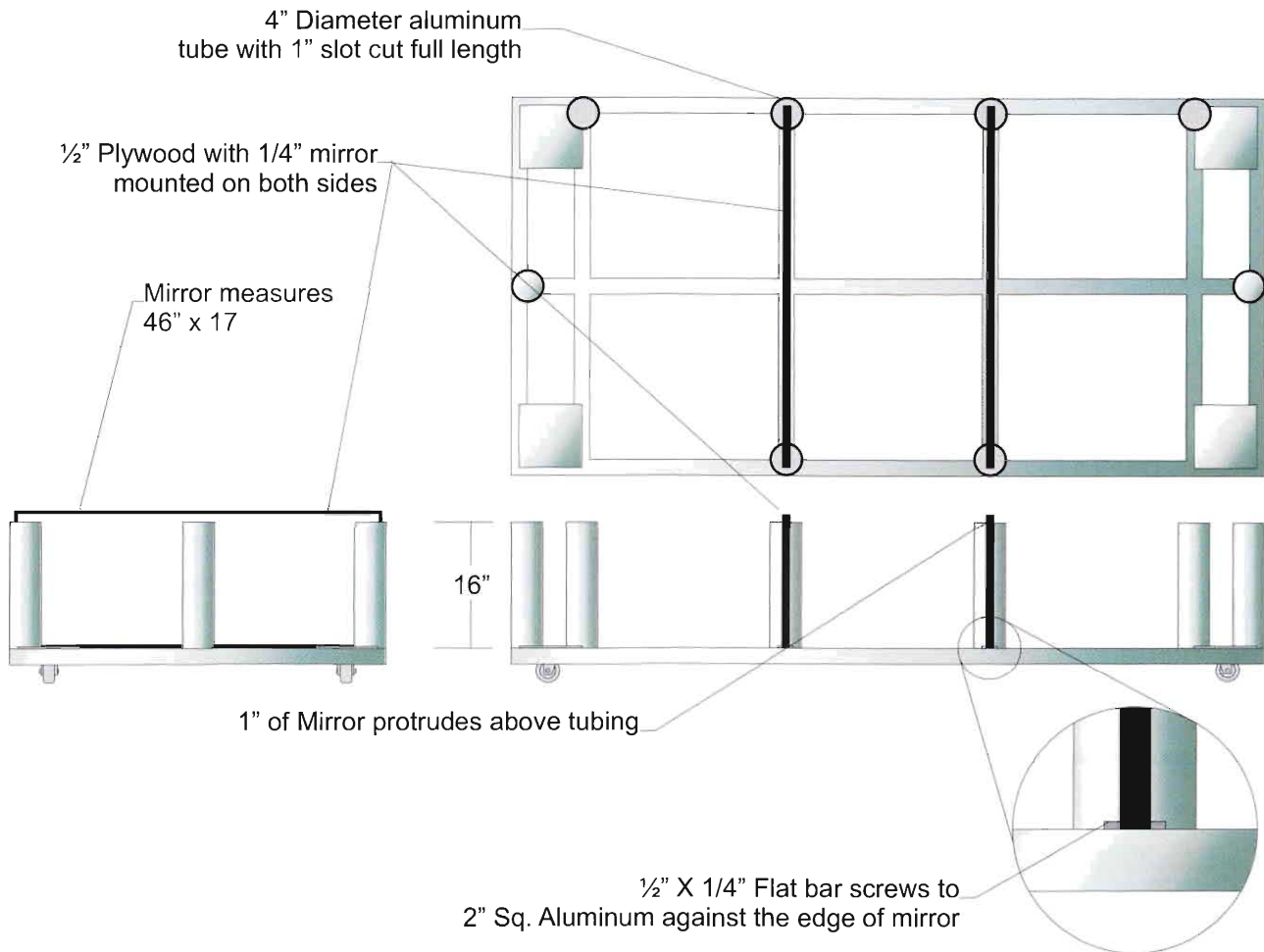
OUTER LEGS



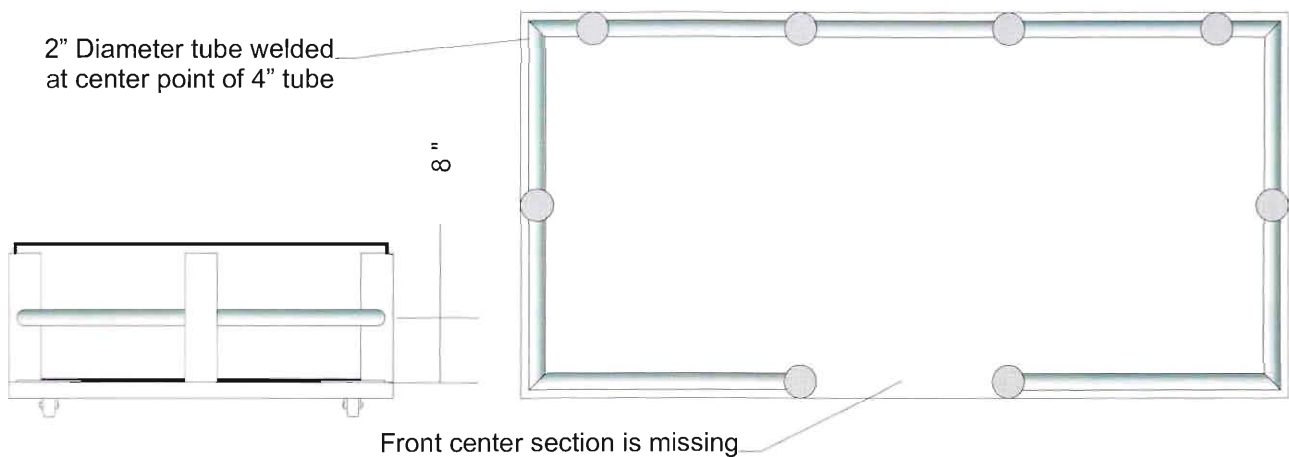
IRON

MIRRORS AND MOUNTING TUBES

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



RAIL



MIRRORS

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$

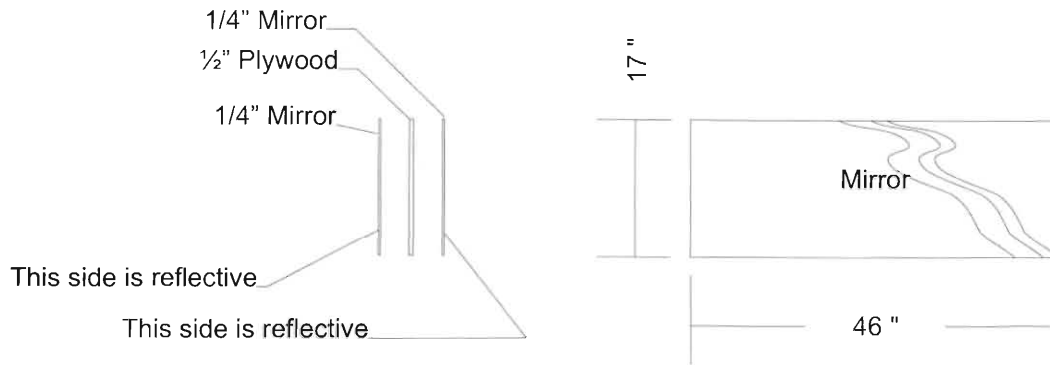
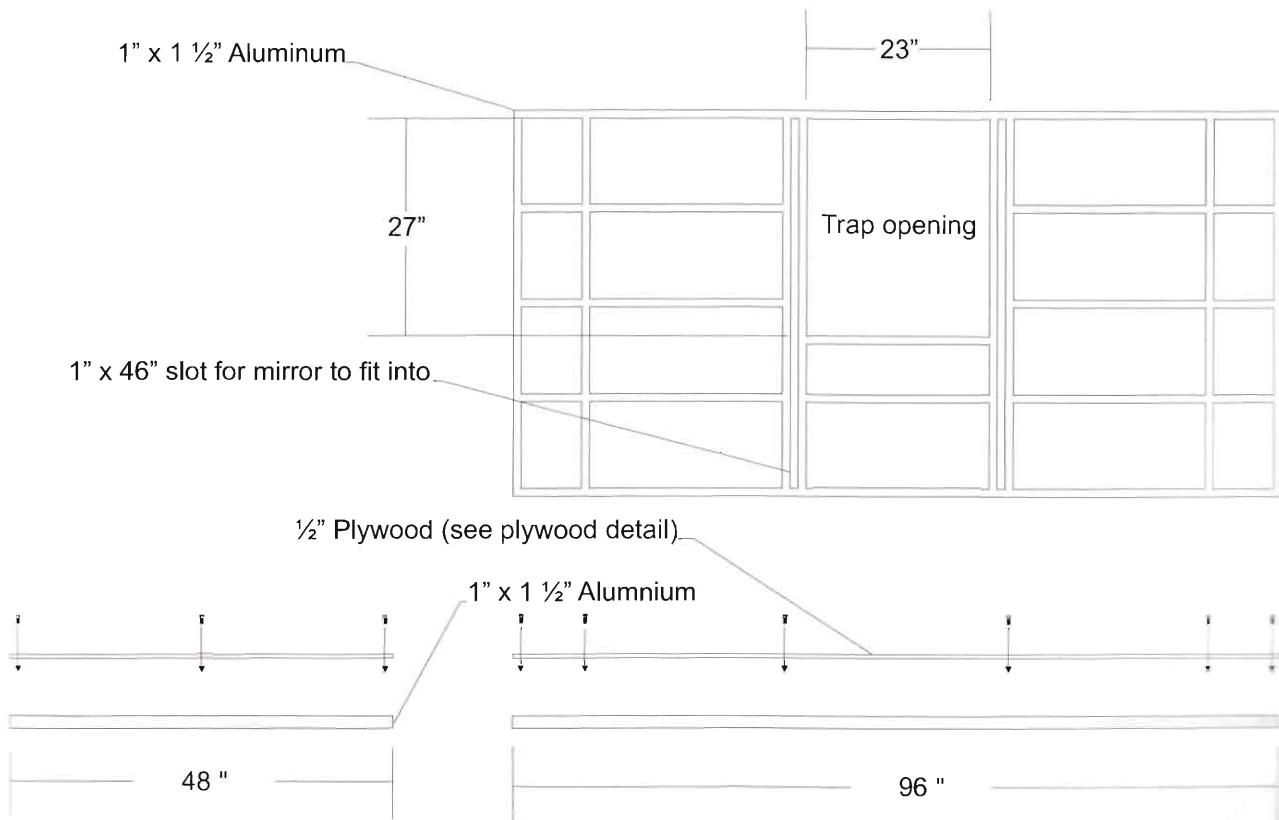
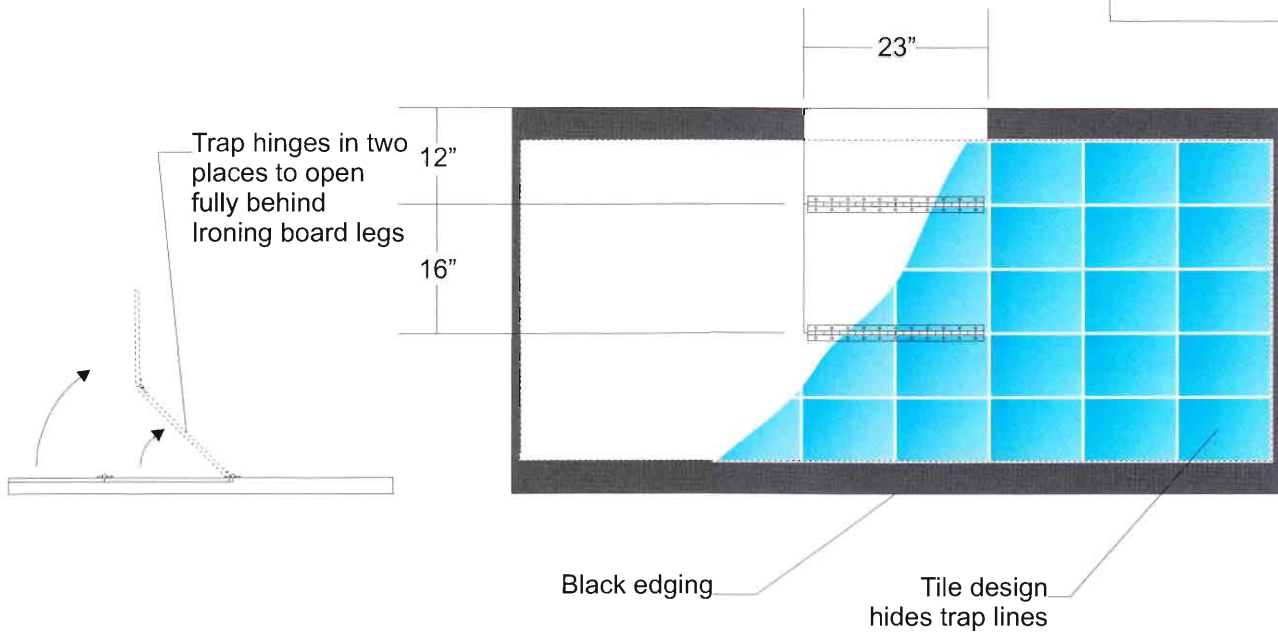


TABLE TOP FRAMEWORK



PLYWOOD DETAIL

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$ 

DROPPING FLOOR

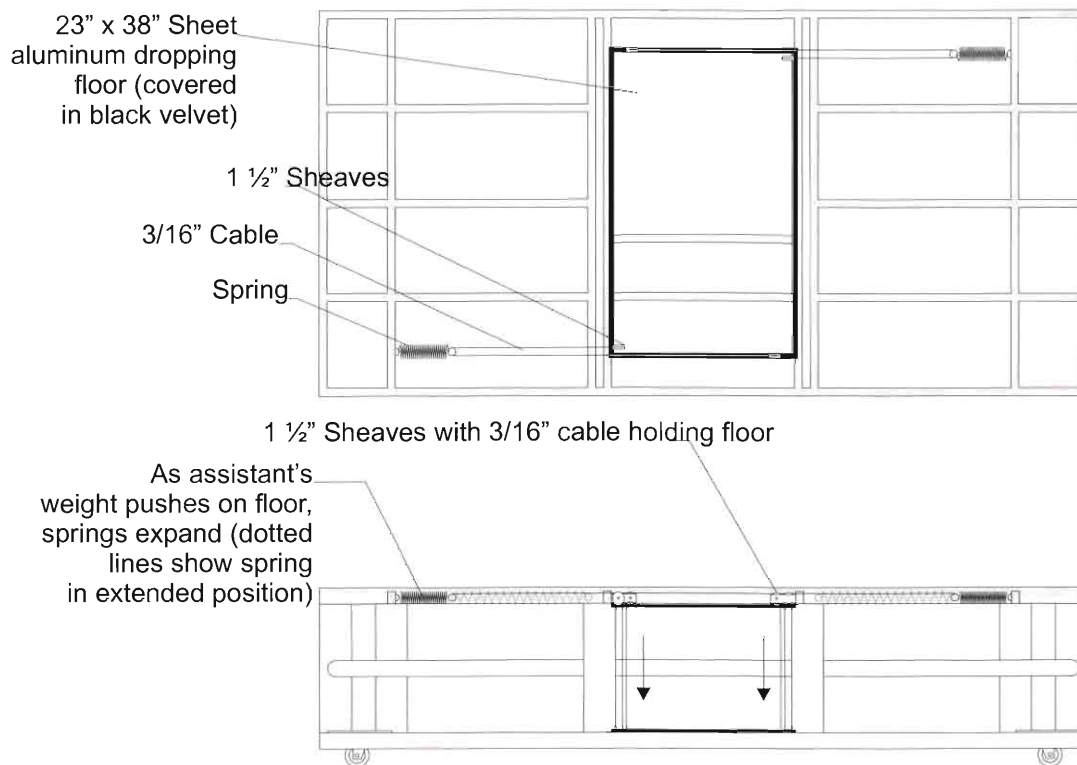
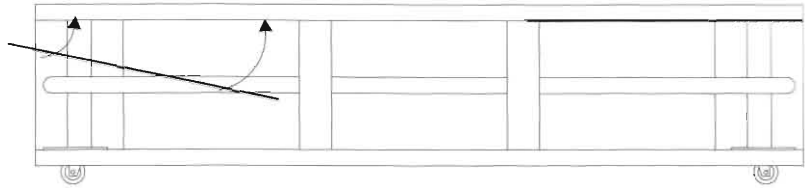


TABLE TOP UNDERSIDE

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$

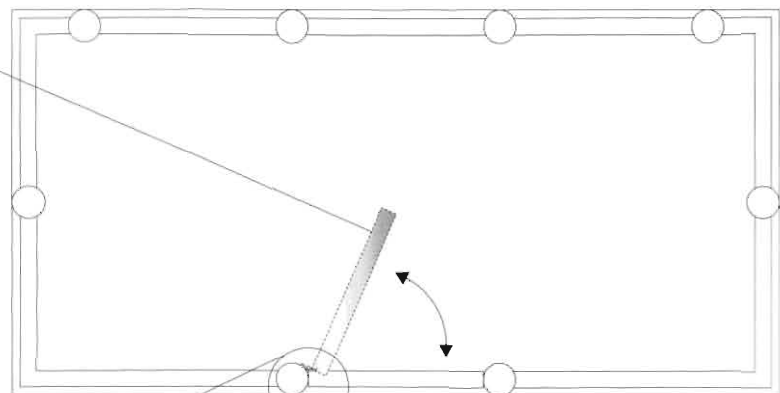
34 $\frac{1}{2}"$ X 48" Thin plastic (cut around tube legs) covered in black velvet, screws to the underside of the table top either side of the mirror section



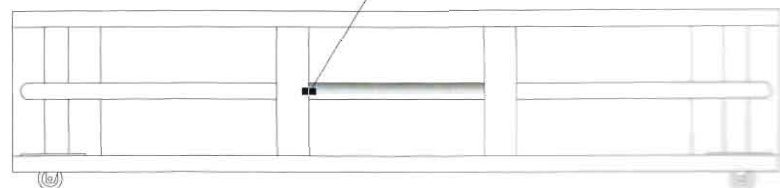
SWINGING FRONT BAR

Bar swings back into load chamber to allow assistant to exit

Spring hinge holds bar closed



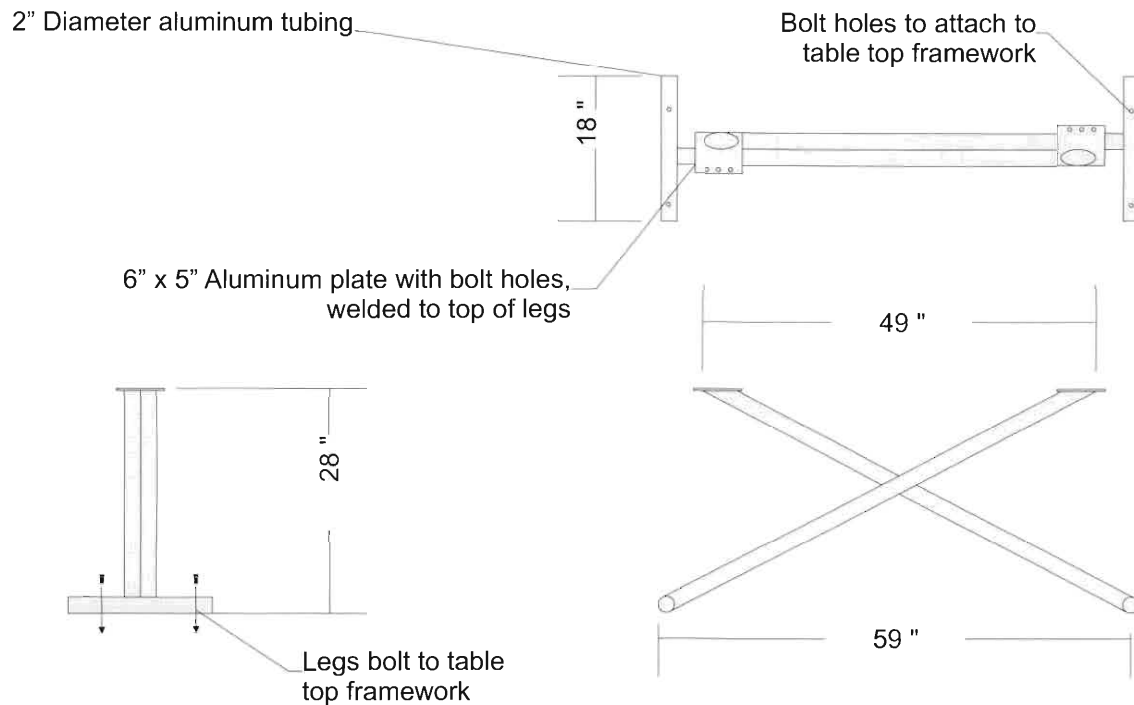
Position of spring hinge
(on back of bar)



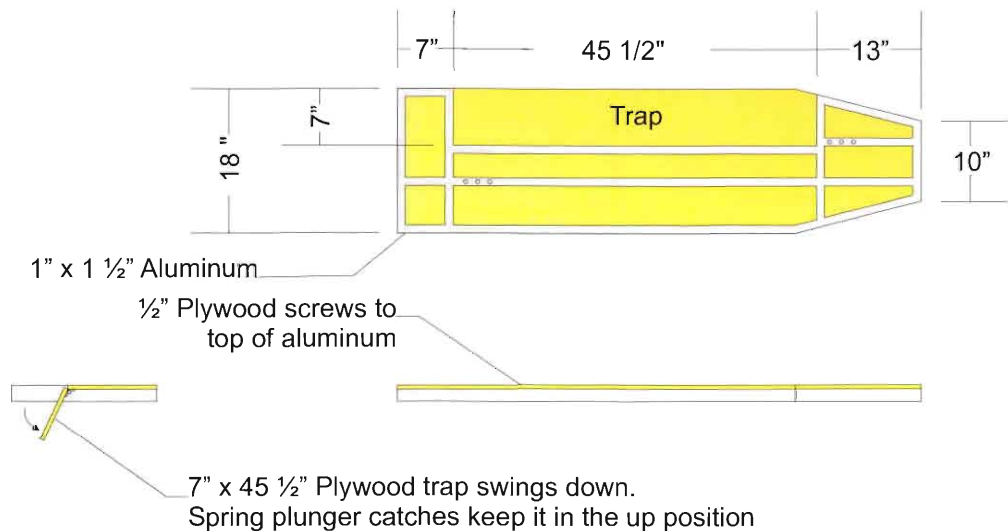
IRON

IRONING BOARD LEGS

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



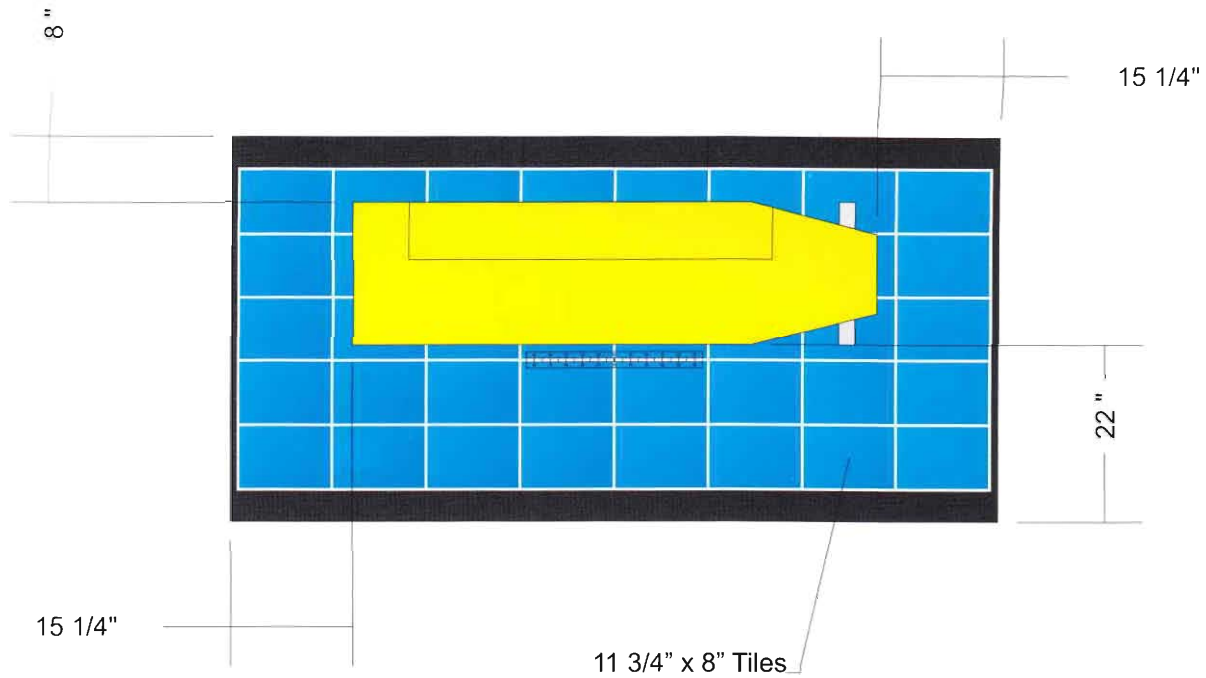
IRONING BOARD TOP



IRON

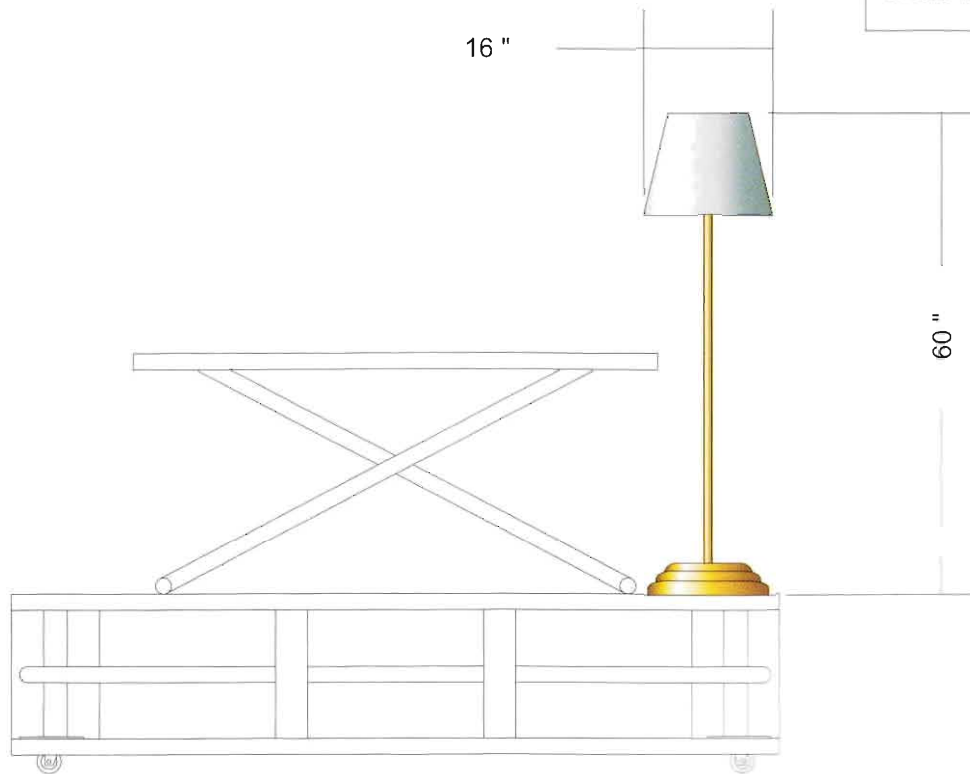
IRONING BOARD POSITION

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



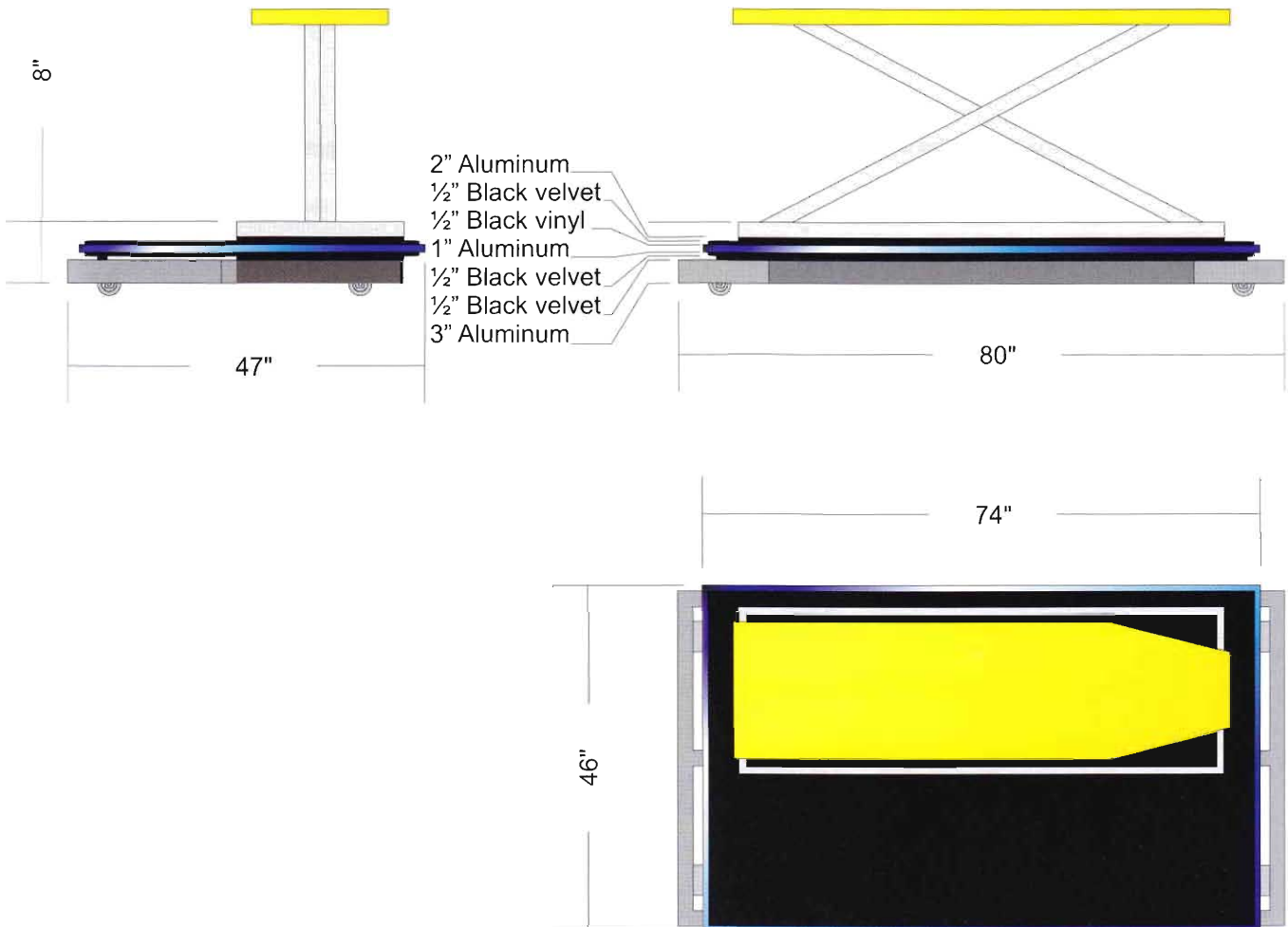
LAMP

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$

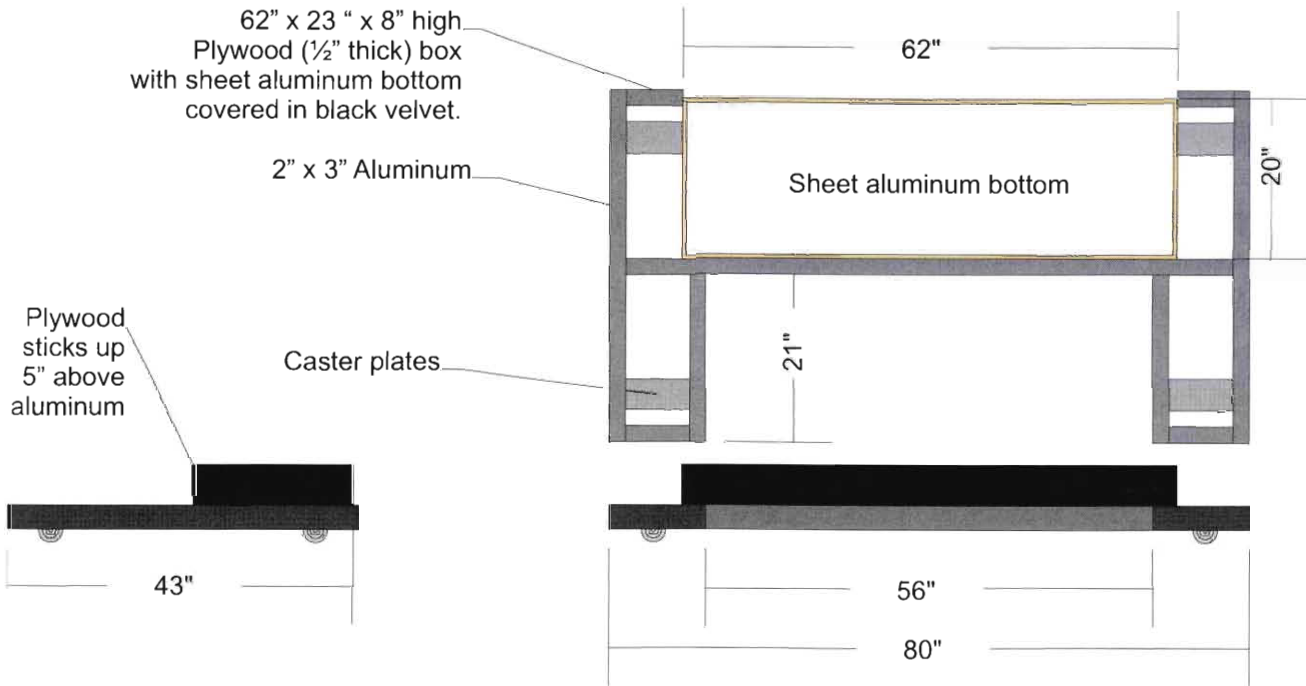


IRON

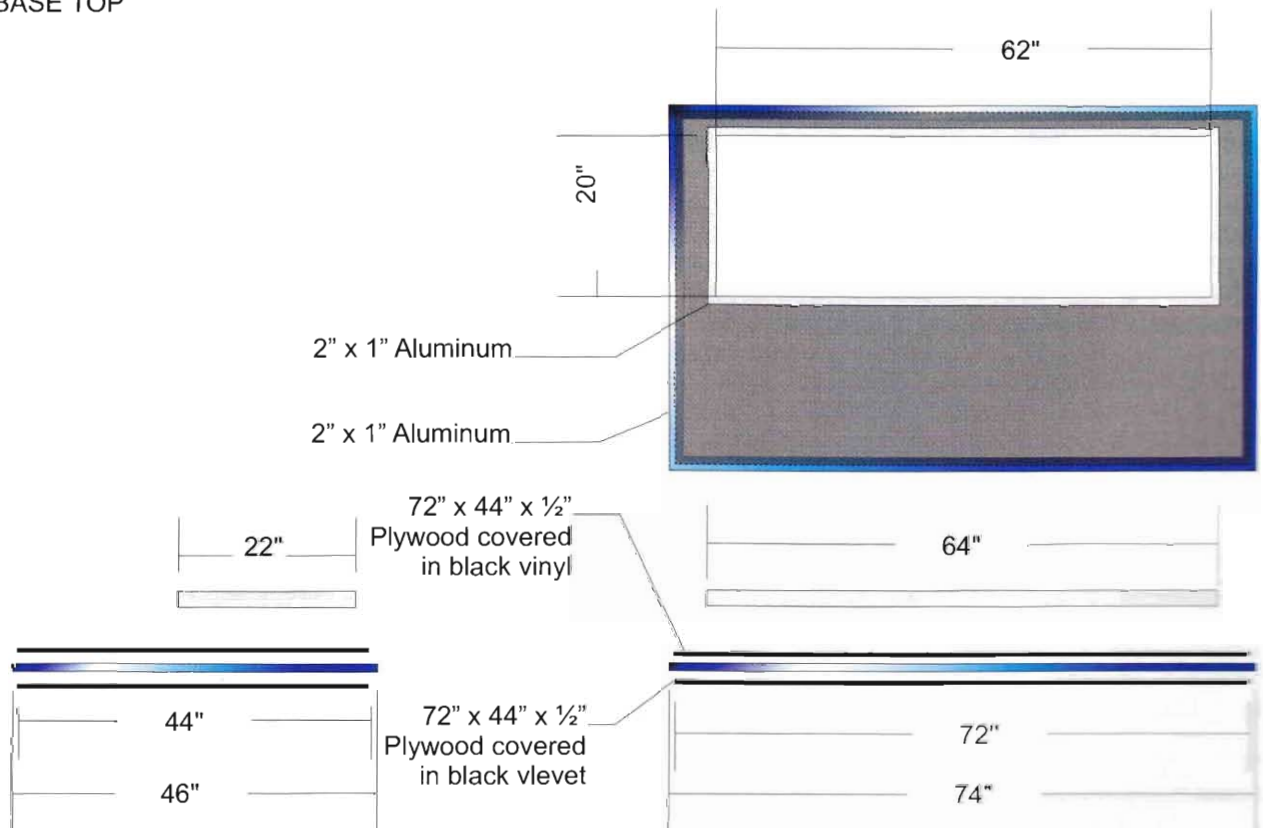
BASE VERSION



CASTER FRAME



BASE TOP



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

These three views show the basic sizes of the illusion, plus the position of the assistant inside the load compartment. The cloth that covers the front area (shown with the arrow) still allows audience members sitting slightly to the sides of the illusion to see the entire open table framework behind it (the mirror reflection).

CASTER FRAMEWORK

This simple framework with casters is designed to follow the lines and reflections of the mirrors. The mirrors run along the two middle braces. Of course, the reflection will make these braces appear as 1" not 2" because of the thickness of the mirrors. This slight difference is hardly noticeable from a distance.

OUTER LEGS

These four outer legs are un-gimicked. Made from 4" diameter aluminum tube, they weld to the caster frame and will weld to the table top framework. The two upstage legs will need to be notched over the aluminum caster plates, as they sit partially on top of them.

MIRRORS AND MOUNTING TUBES

The four leg tubes that hold the mirror are welded to the caster frame and table top framework in the same way as the outer legs. The slots cut in these tubes are 1" wide to accept the mirror. The mirror drops in place and sits on the 2" sq. aluminum of the caster framework. Lengths of 1/2" x 1/4" thick flat bar are screwed into the caster frame to hold the mirrors in position.

RAIL

The rail is really for decorative purposes but also reflects in the mirrors to give an added feeling of visible framework under the table. The rail is made from 2" diameter tubing with miter corners and welded to the 4" tubing.

MIRRORS

1/4" glass mirrors are glued (with Mirror Mastic) to pieces of 1/2" plywood. The mirrors are on both sides with reflective sides outermost. The resulting piece is 1" thick.

TABLE TOP FRAMEWORK

The table top framework welds to the 4" tubing legs. The framework is 1 1/2" tall (1" x 1 1/2" Aluminum), plus the 1/2" plywood top makes the whole top 2" thick. The frame is built with the two 1" wide, 46" long slots for the mirror. Once the table is assembled (without the plywood top on) the mirrors can slide down into place. A slot and cover could be built into the plywood so the mirrors could be removed for maintenance or packing.

PLYWOOD DETAIL

The trap is made in plywood and hinged to the plywood top. When flat, the upstage edge of the trap rests on the upstage edge of the table top framework. The trap is hinged in two places to allow it to open fully behind the legs of the ironing board (notice the drawing showing the first section of trap at an angle and the second part fully vertical).

DROPPING FLOOR

As the assistant puts her weight on this dropping floor, it moves down to rest on the caster framework. 3/16" cable is attached to the four corners of the floor. The cable passes through 1 1/2" diameter sheaves and through small holes in the table top framework where it attaches to a spring. The downstage cables attach to one spring and the upstage to another. The spring tension needs to be enough to lift the floor only. This system could also be accomplished with air shocks in place of the springs.

TABLE TOP UNDERSIDE

When the dropping floor is up, it is covered in black velvet. To match this on the outsides of the table underside, thin plastic covered in black velvet is screwed in place.

SWINGING FRONT BAR

To allow the assistant to exit the hidden compartment, the front bar must swing aside. The bar is held in place with a spring hinge. The assistant pulls the bar inwards, passing it under her head and over her knees, then crawls past it. As the assistant exits, the bar swings back into place. Then as the assistant takes their feet off the dropping floor, it moves back up to the table top.

IRONING BOARD LEGS

The legs are simple in construction, made from 2" diameter aluminum tubing. I would weld the whole thing up as one piece for strength. If aluminum seems too weak, steel may be better here. These legs bolt straight through the plywood on the table top framework and through the aluminum framework itself. The plates on the top of the legs have bolt holes to attach them securely to the ironing board top.

IRONING BOARD TOP

I have designed the aluminum framework to bolt directly to the legs and allow the space for the trap. The top is made from plywood and screws to the aluminum, making the board 2" thick total. The plywood is given a rounded edge with a router. The trap is made from plywood and hinged to drop down. It is held up with a spring plunger catch - a small steel ball with a spring behind it in a casing. As the trap comes up, the ball pushes in then springs out into a metal receiver on the side of the trap.

IRONING BOARD POSITION

This shows a plan view of the assembled illusion with the Ironing board bolted to the table top. The tiles are a painted design on the plywood.

LAMP

The lamp may be purchased. It needs to be sturdy enough to hold the cloth up when it is covered.

CLOTH AND SHEETS

The cloth that is 'dropped' over the front of the load compartment must be of a very heavy material, possibly with a pattern on it. This cloth is attached with velcro along the front of the table to cover between the mirrors - then it's folded up onto the table top. The Magician just flips it down as he clears the various items (basket of laundry etc.) off the platform.

The sheet that covers the assistant for the ironing vanish could be thinner and plain color to show the assistant's shape.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

The caster framework and tube legs are all in aluminum finished with a bit of Scotch Brite or fine grinder finish. The underside of the table top and dropping floor are covered in black velvet. The table top framework is powder coat black. The table top plywood is scenic painted with blue tiles and white or grey grout lines (that hide the trap opening). The ironing board legs are powder coat silver. The ironing board top could be covered in a pattern fabric (like a real ironing board) or scenic painted with a pattern effect (sponge effect?).

BASE VERSION

I decided to include this version of the prop after showing this book to other Magicians before it went to print. They liked the Iron, but several performers said they would find a base version more practical for their working situations (cruise ships, conventions etc.).

There are far too many Magicians today who seem to think that 'put a base on it' is the solution to everything. I have never been totally convinced with vanishing someone into a base, with the base on plain view. It seems not to be as deceptive to me, because the greatest mass of the prop is exactly where the girl is hidden. I feel that like any other deceptive illusion principal, bases should be used sparingly and only when appropriate.

Saying that, it is possible to work Iron with a base. I believe the use of the basket, lamp and ironing board props will give added interest and mass to the entire illusion. This will visually detract from the base.

CASTER FRAME

The frame is built in 2" x 3" aluminum using the 3" as the height. The plywood box is the load chamber for the assistant and is covered in black velvet. Black spandex is stapled to the top of this.

BASE TOP

The main step of the base is made from a frame of 2" x 1" aluminum with the 1" as the height. Plywood (with a hole cut out to fit over the plywood box) is covered in black vinyl and screwed to the top of the frame. Plywood covered in black velvet screws to the bottom of the frame. The 2" tall aluminum frame bolts to the plywood box and becomes the bottom framework of the ironing board legs. The ironing board legs are welded (or bolted to) this frame.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

The bottom aluminum caster frame is finished in a dark/mid grey powder coat. The aluminum edging to the main step is finished in a metallic blue powder coat. The top frame matches the ironing board legs finish.

ETC...

I've always like illusions with real looking objects that an audience can recognize - just wait for my 'Coffee Grinder of Death' illusion (that's for another book though!). The iron could be incorporated into a little scene or vignette type of presentation (Magician finds lost girlfriend, does Ironing, then it Snows ?). The 'set dressing' parts of the illusion are important too - the lamp, basket, laundry and sheets etc. They all add to the routine so the Magician doesn't just do a suspicious move of draping a sheet across the front of the platform, but does it as part of moving a lot of different items.

The design of this illusion began with a mirror right under the ironing board, then black art and now to this version, which I think solves the various problems of the illusion most effectively. The mirror platform or base version have their strengths and weaknesses. Consider each version carefully and choose which is right for you.

I also considered having a flat girl on the ironing board once the sheet is pulled off; or a flat girl on the inside of the sheet that is shown once it is pulled off the board.

I have never seen an ironing board flattening illusion before. The plot seemed so obvious to me I was surprised no one else had thought of it. The illusion lends itself a great comedy routine, plus any excuse to dress your assistant as a French Maid is a good one!

ALIEN ABDUCTION

ALIEN ABDUCTION



The Magician has an Alien in an AREA 51 style research tank. Lights on the prop illuminate the Alien. There is a high tech smoke unit beside the prop with a large hose connecting it to the tank.



The Magician pushes switches on the smoke unit and the tank with the Alien inside fills with thick smoke. The Magician lifts the panel and disconnects the smoke unit from the hose.



Smoke ejects through the top of the tank and the Alien has vanished. Suddenly, the Magician turns around pulling off his 'skin and hair' to reveal that he is actually the Alien.



The attention moves to the middle of the audience where the real Magician has reappeared.

METHOD

The illusion consists of two parts.

The containment tank with the Alien inside is the main prop. This Alien is an assistant in a costume. The base of the prop provides the hiding space for this assistant to vanish.

The smoke unit next to the prop is used to switch the real Magician for a double dressed as the Magician (this double will eventually reveal himself as the Alien) and to get the Magician secretly off stage.

(Pic. 1): The Alien begins in the tank. Smoke from the smoke unit goes through the duct and fills the tank. Once covered with smoke, the assistant in the tank slips down into the base.

(Pic. 2): Once the tank is full the Magician steps into the frame of the smoke unit. The double (dressed as an Alien, with Magician costume and face mask on top) is crouched behind the panel on the smoke unit. The Magician places his legs into the load space on the side of the frame with his body half twisted at the waist (like a Zig-Zag). He appears to be standing upright behind the panel.

The Magician pulls the panel up, covering the top half of his body (this disconnects the smoke duct). As this happens, the Double stands up so the audience gets the impression they see the standing Magician's legs. The Double exits the prop, turning to face upstage of the audience.

The Magician is now hiding with legs in the load space and upper body behind the panel. A cable attached to the smoke unit allows the stage crew to pull the unit off stage. Once off stage, the Magician exits the unit and runs for the back of the audience.

(Pic. 3): Meanwhile, the original Alien assistant, hiding in the base, pulls a release cable that opens the roof of the tank to eject the smoke. The audience can now see that the tank is empty and the Alien has vanished.

The double on stage now turns around pulling off a wig and face mask, and removing his jacket to show he is in fact the Alien and not the Magician.

The Magician makes his appearance in the audience.

The sliding panel to switch the Magician is similar to an illusion by Rand Woodbury called 'Body Transformer' in Illusionworks 1 - although it is used here in a different way.

Pic.1

The diagram shows a human figure standing on a platform. To the left of the figure is a vertical structure with four sensors or cameras. The entire setup is mounted on a base with wheels.

Pic.2

Diagram illustrating the 'Double' effect in a magic trick. The sequence shows:

- A **Magician** figure standing behind a **Double** figure who is crouching inside a box. An arrow indicates the box moves up.
- The **Double** figure stands alone, labeled **Double**.
- The **Magician** figure steps out from behind the box, labeled **Double steps out**.

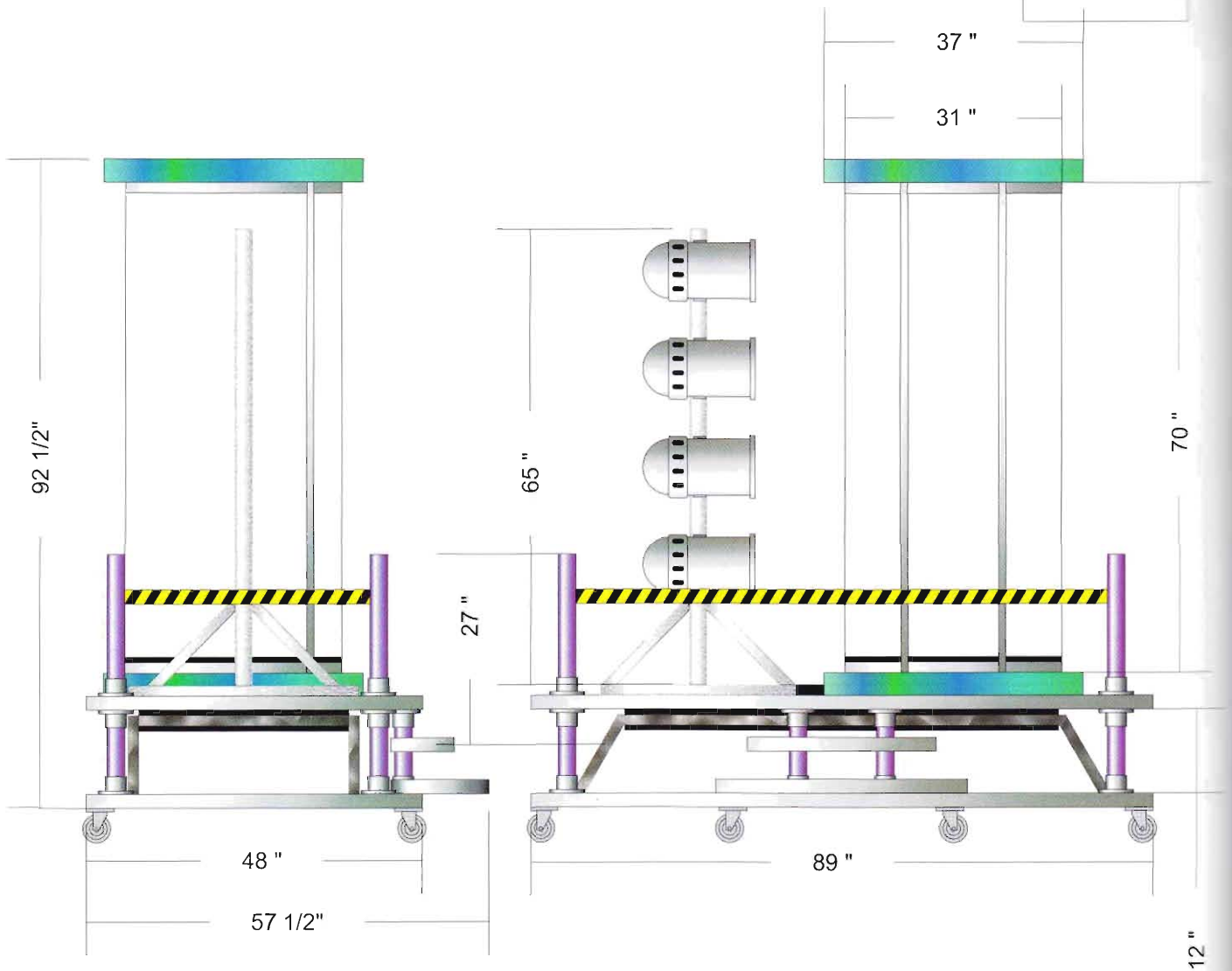
Pic.3

A technical diagram showing a human figure lying prone on a horizontal platform. The platform is supported by a frame with four vertical actuators or sensors positioned above the figure's head, torso, and legs. The entire setup is mounted on a wheeled base. To the right of the diagram is a 3D rendering of a human figure in a standing, slightly flexed pose, wearing a dark, form-fitting suit.

ALIEN ABDUCTION

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

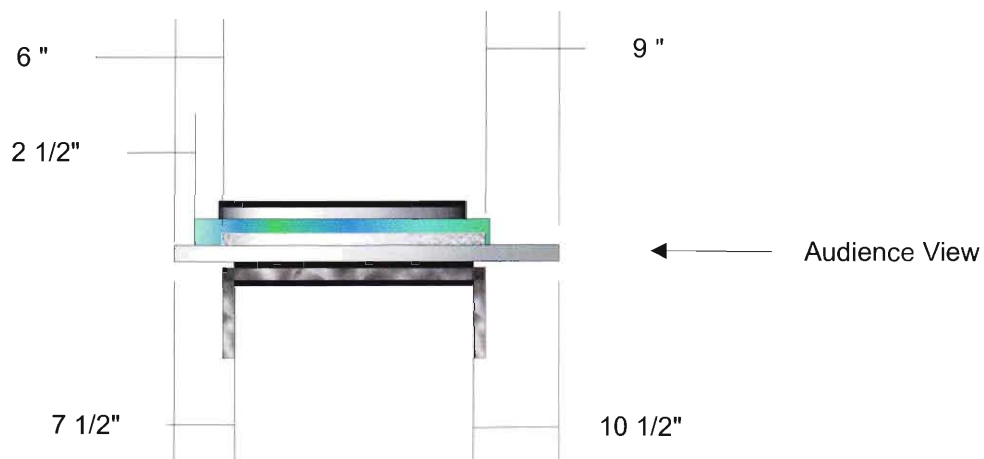
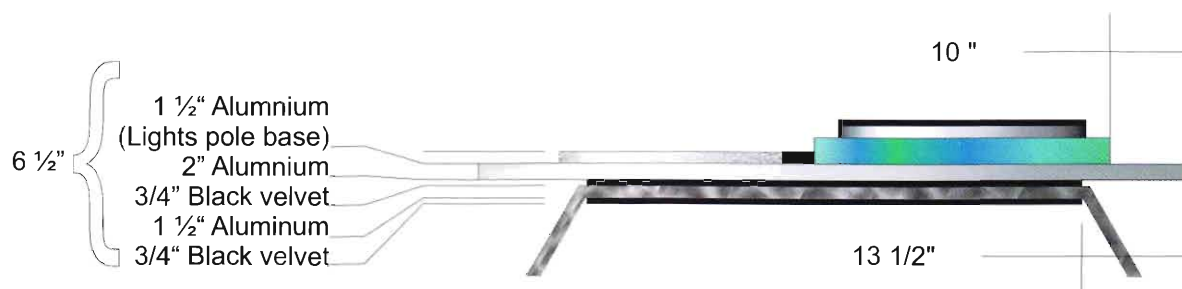
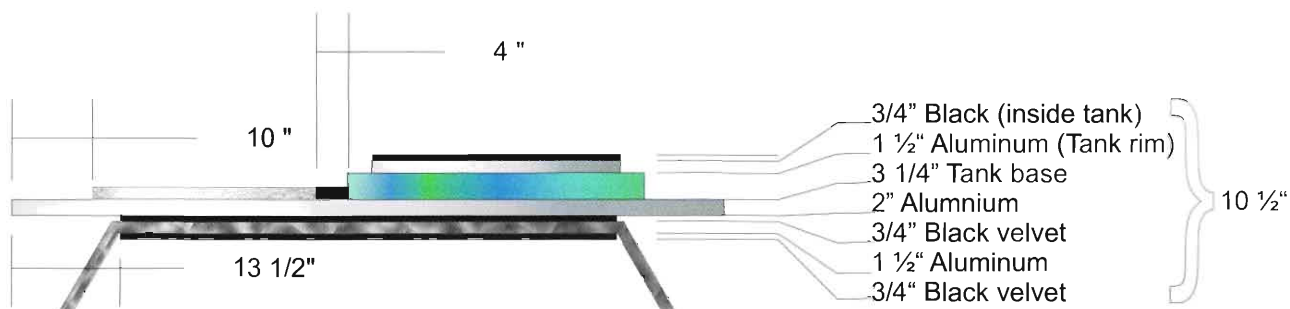
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ALIEN ABDUCTION

BASE DETAILS

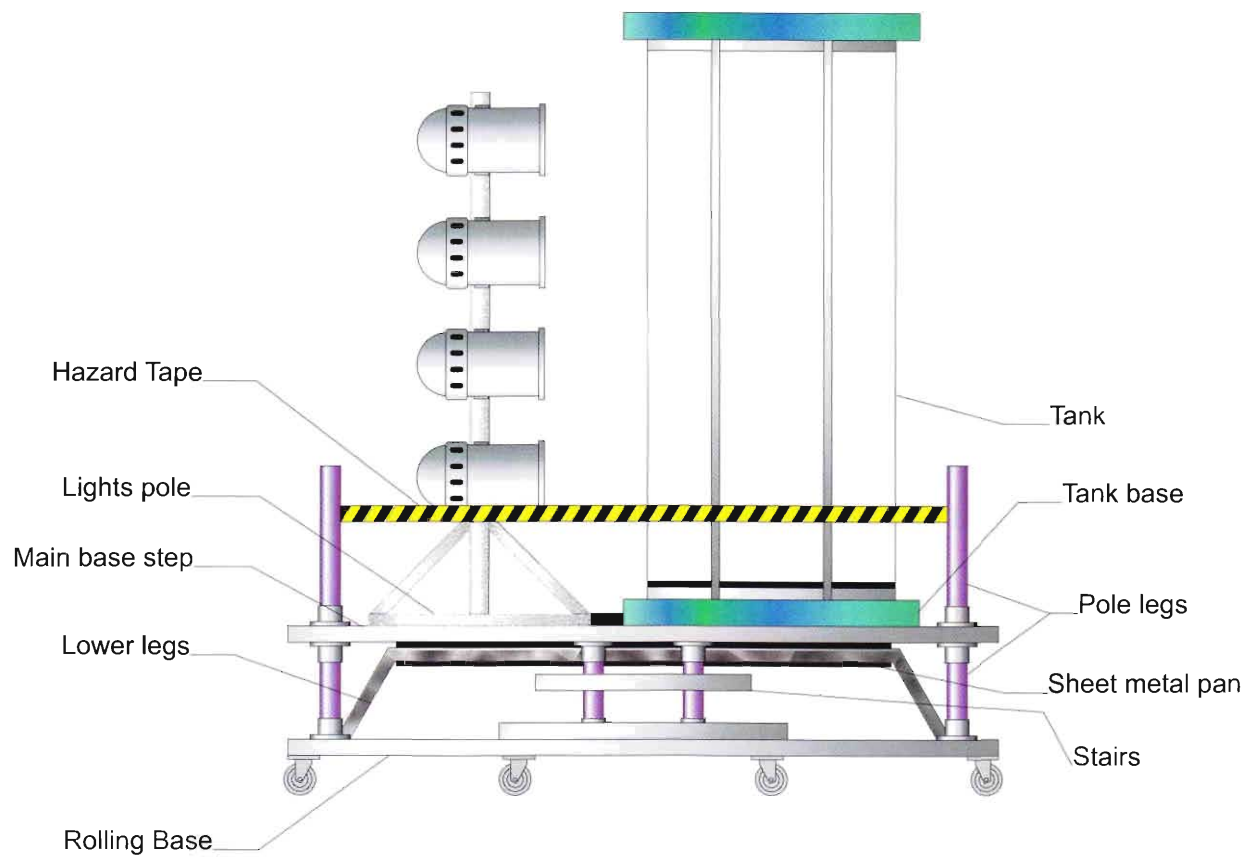
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ALIEN ABDUCTION

PARTS DESCRIPTION

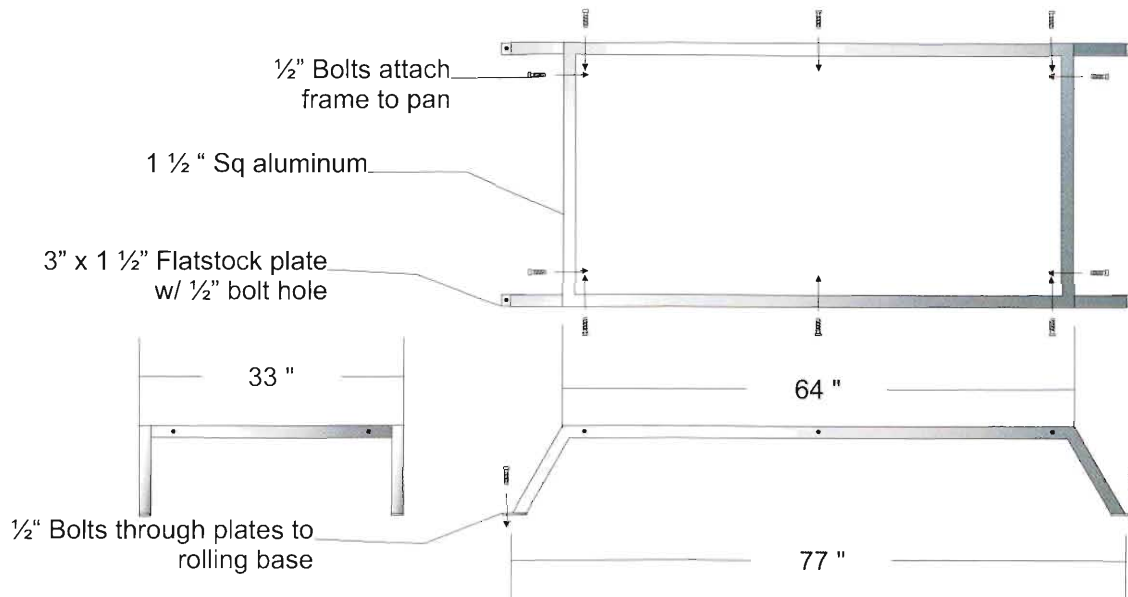
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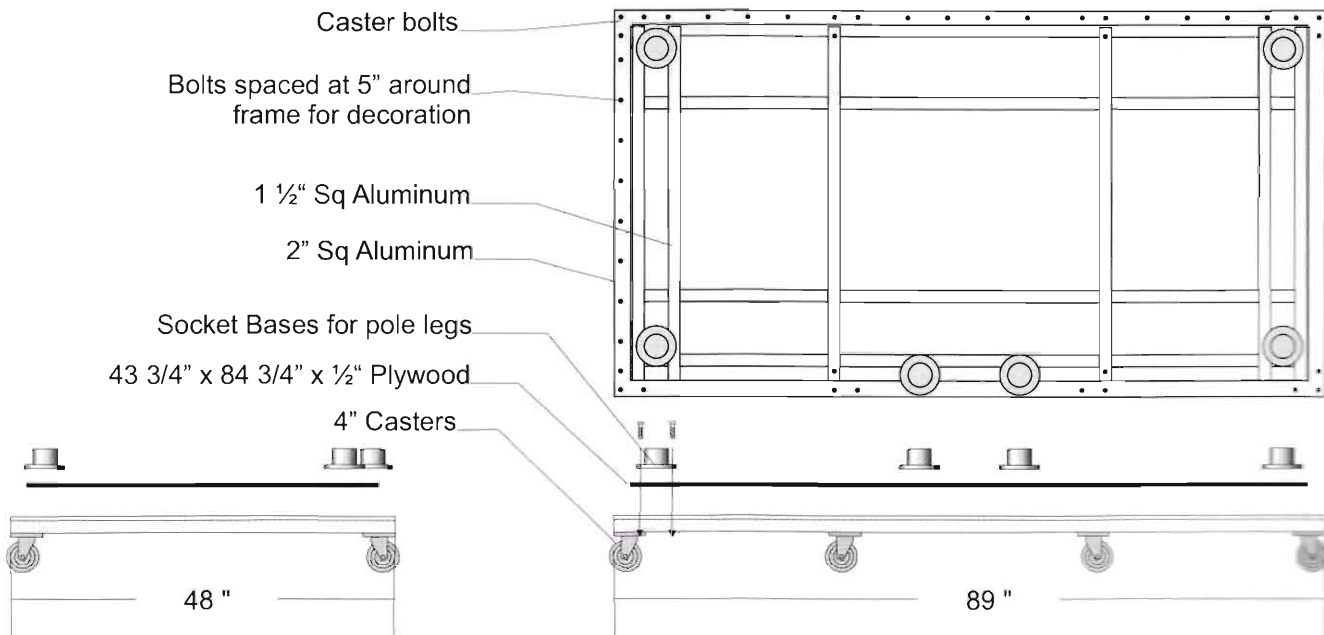
ALIEN ABDUCTION

LOWER LEGS

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



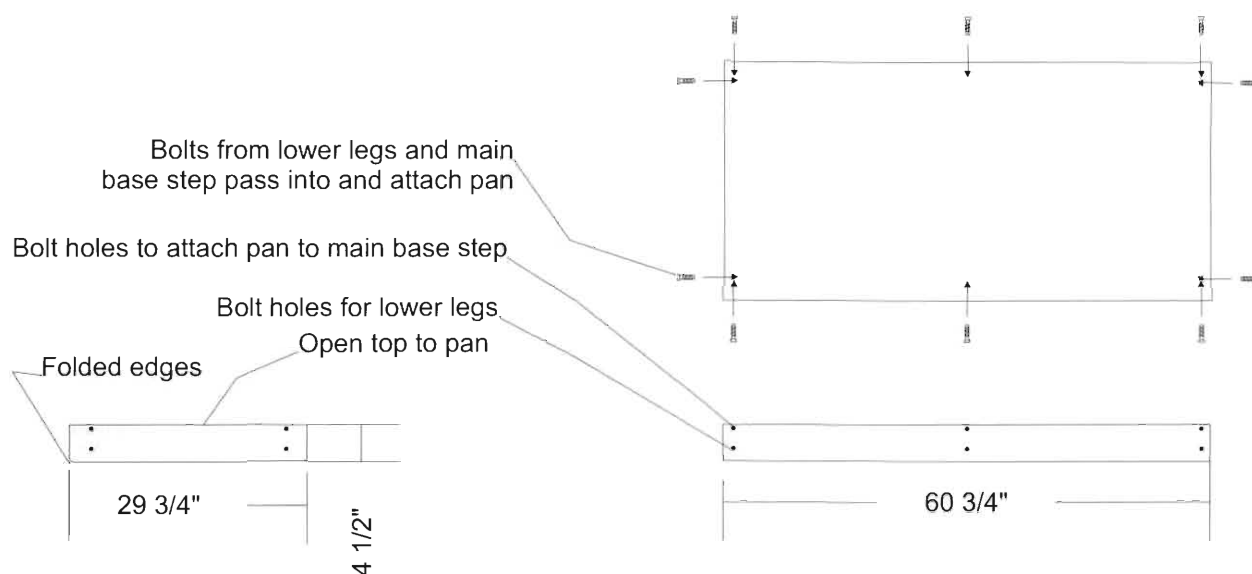
ROLLING BASE



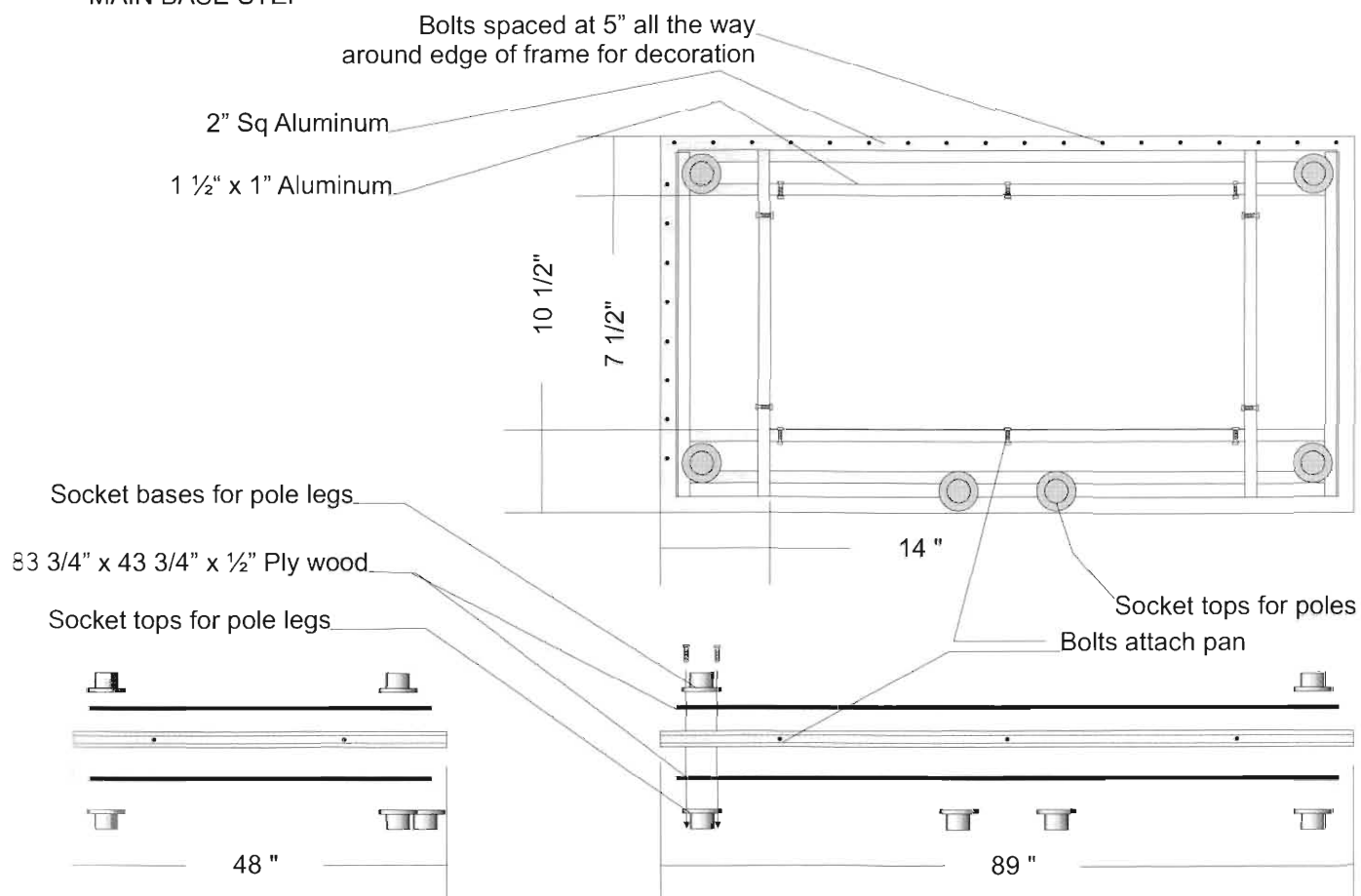
ALIEN ABDUCTION

SHEET METAL PAN

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



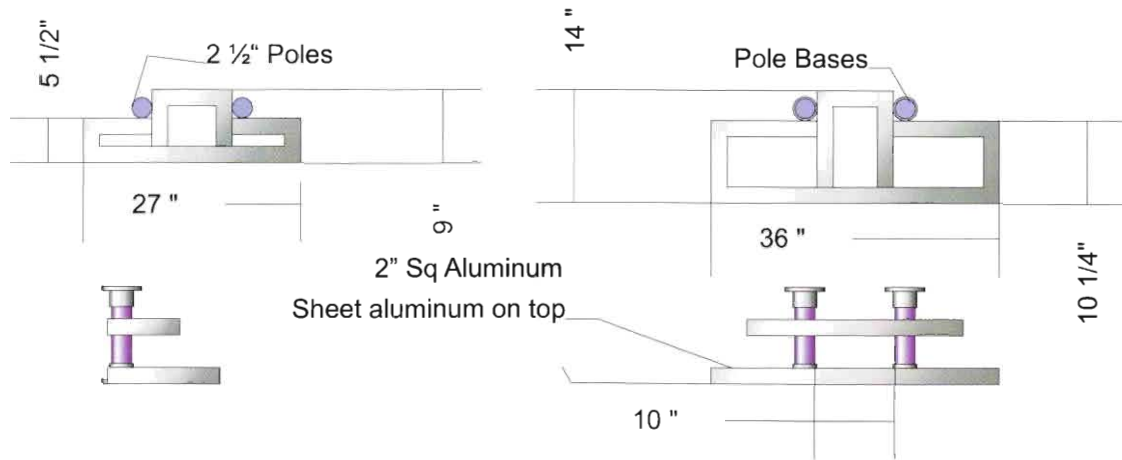
MAIN BASE STEP



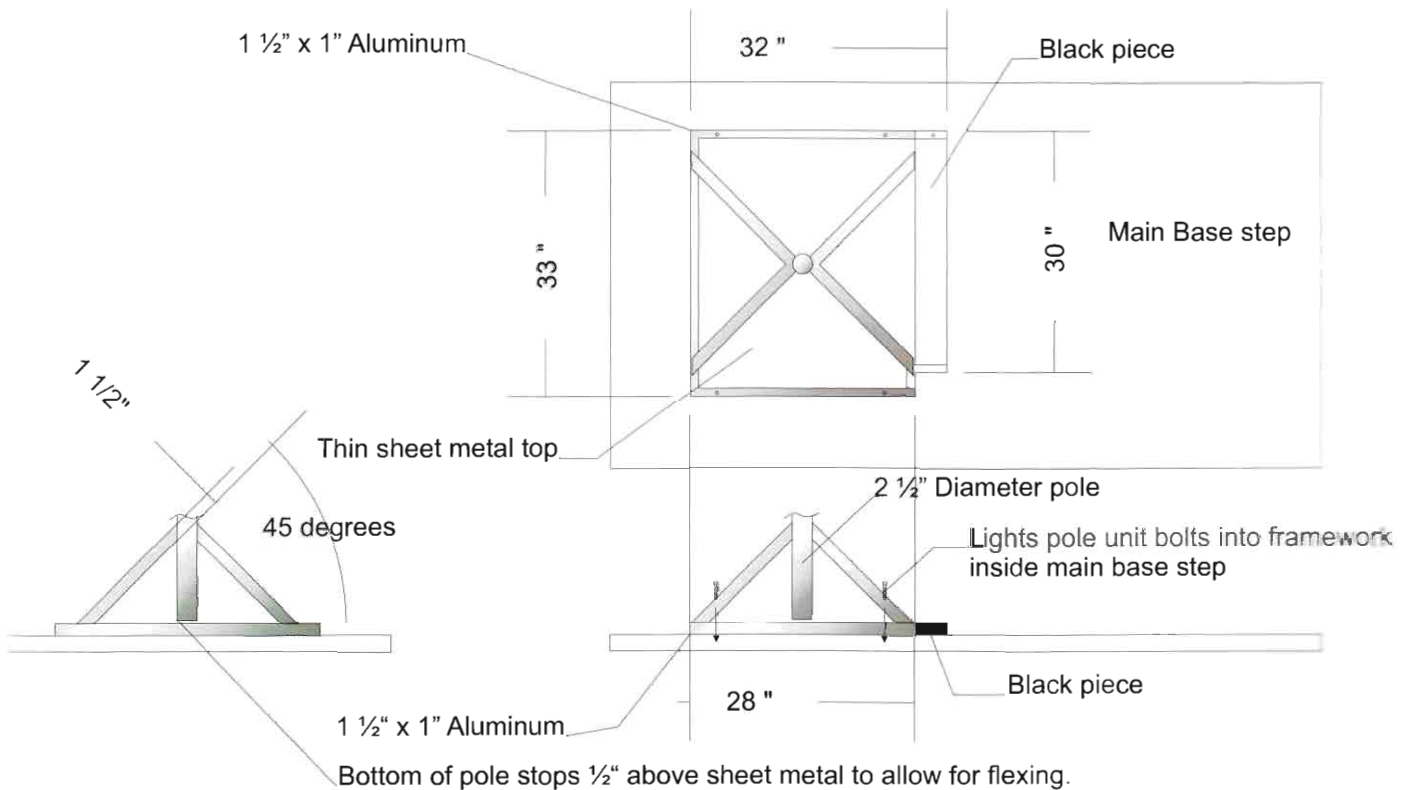
ALIEN ABDUCTION

STAIRS

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



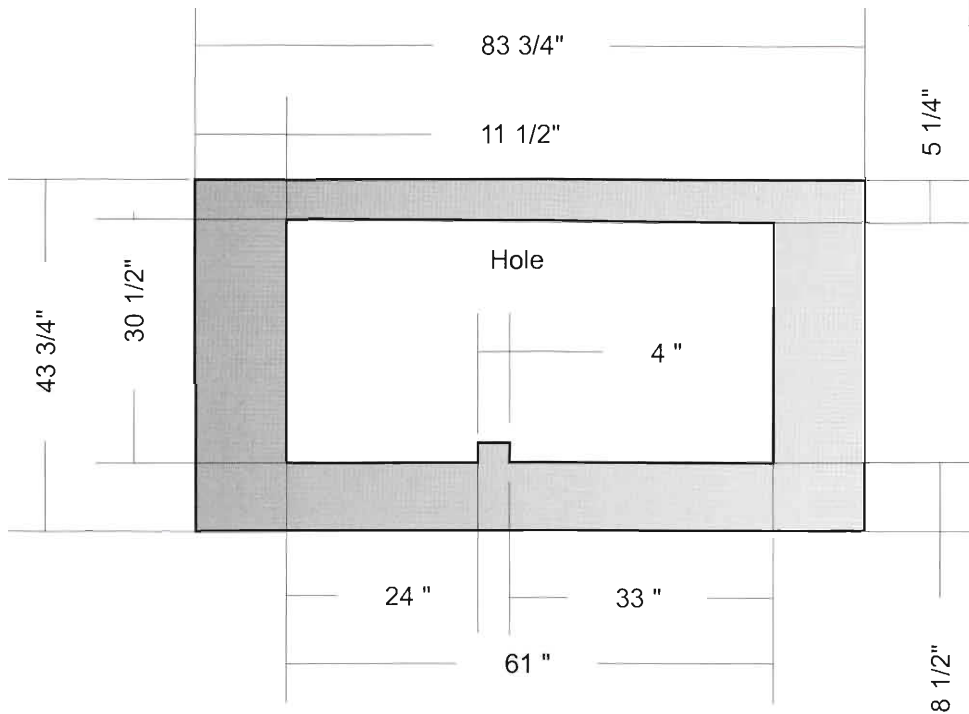
LIGHTS POLE



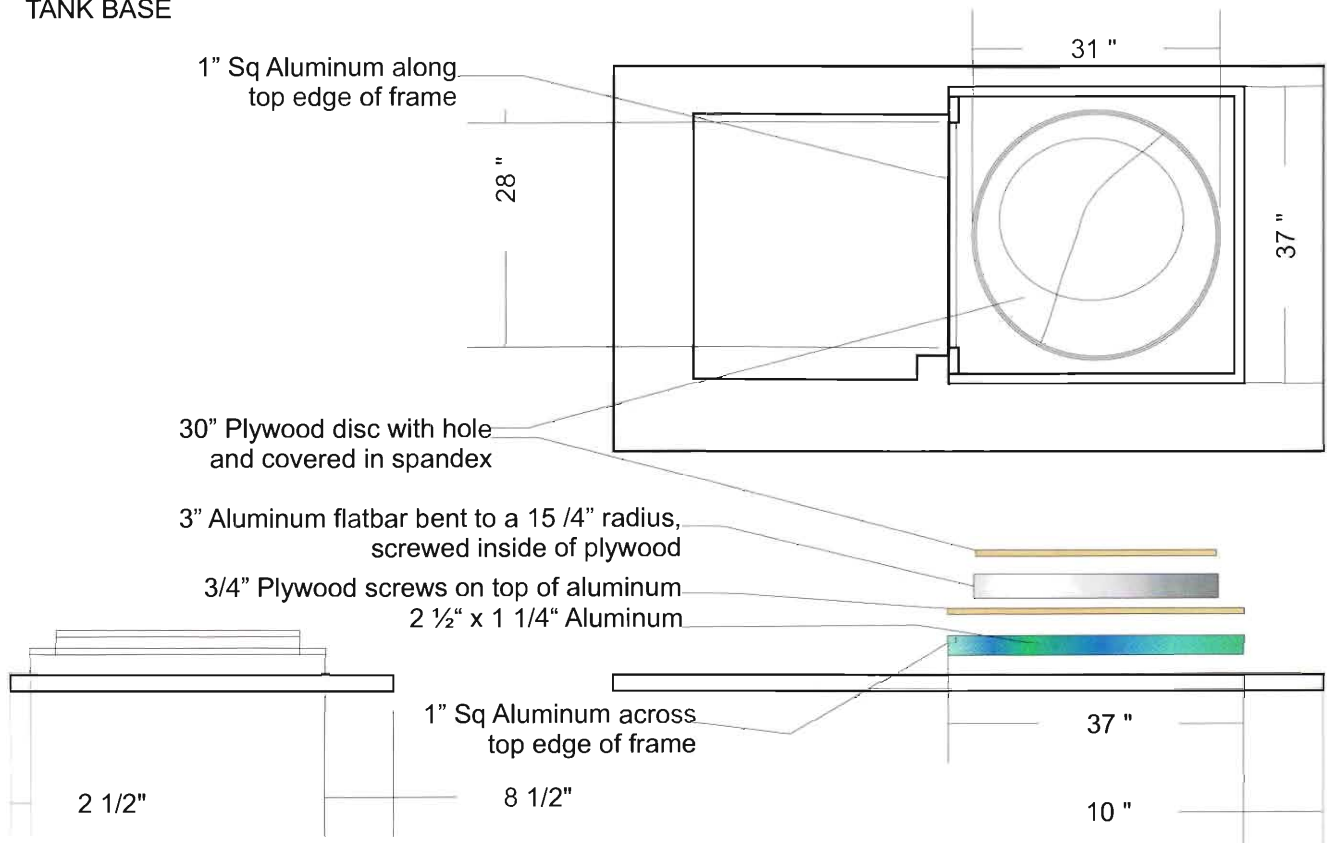
ALIEN ABDUCTION

MAIN BASE STEP PLYWOOD TOP

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



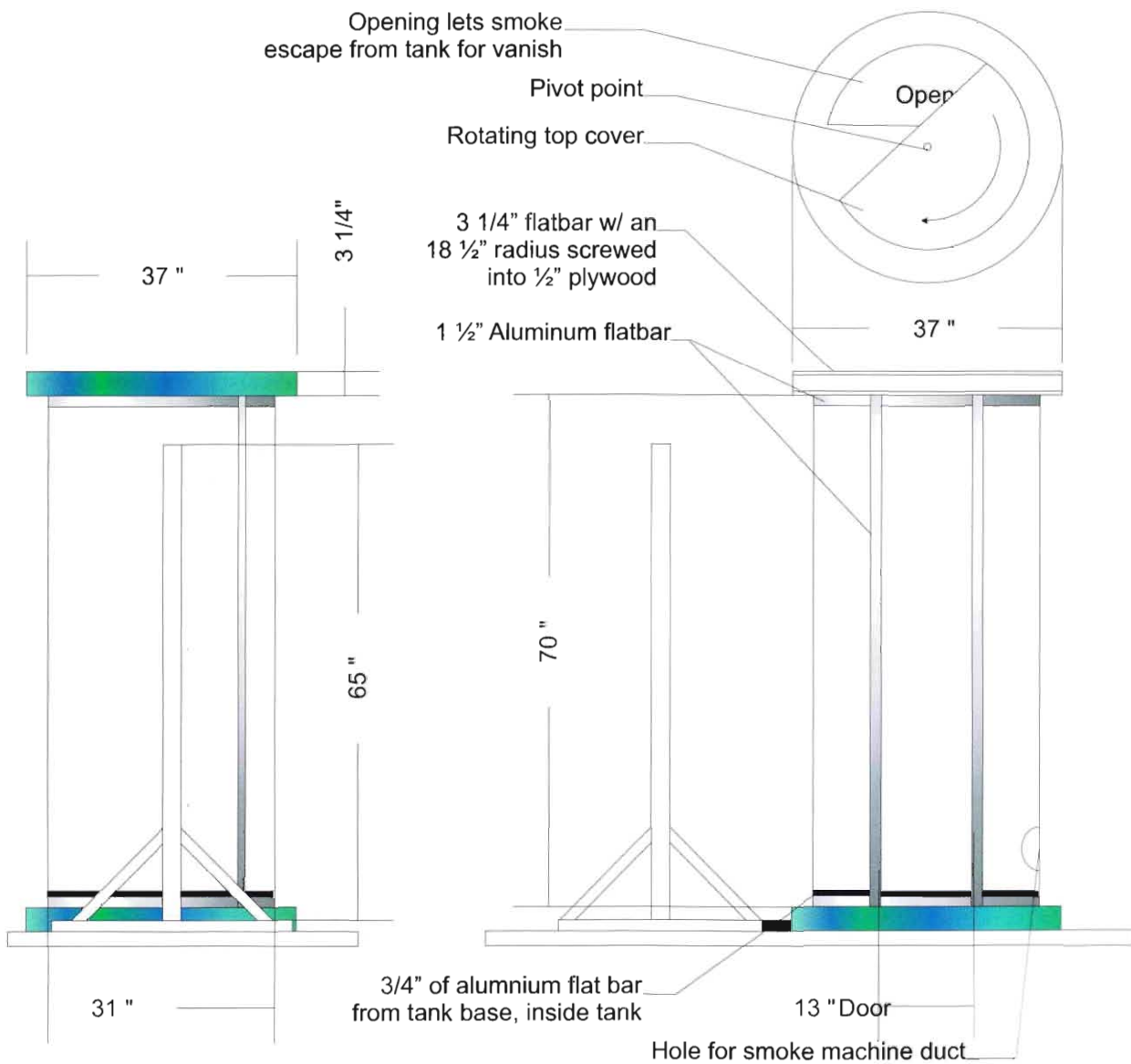
TANK BASE



ALIEN ABDUCTION

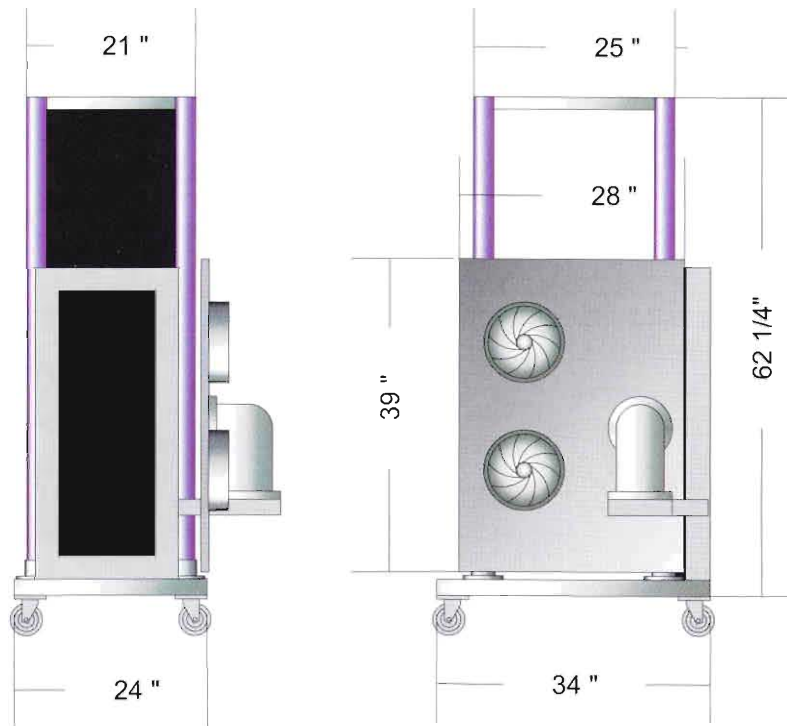
TANK

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$

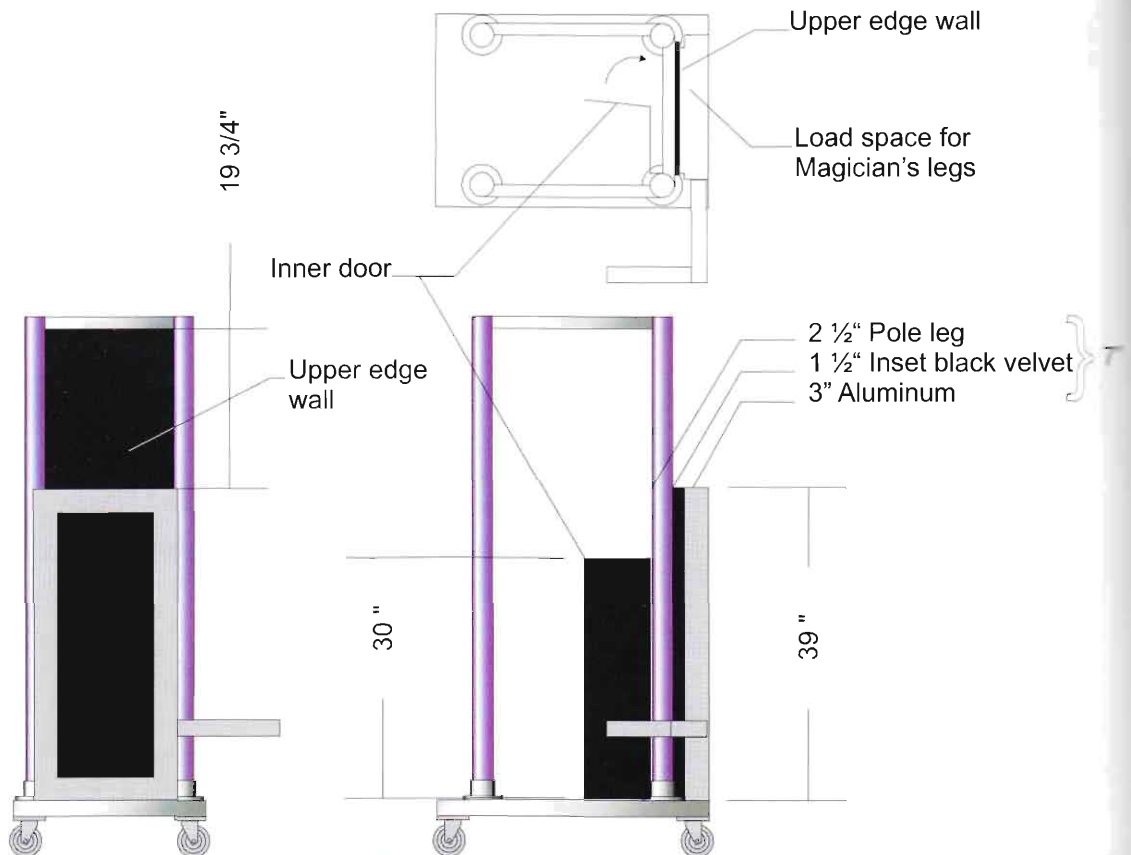


ALIEN ABDUCTION

SMOKE UNIT

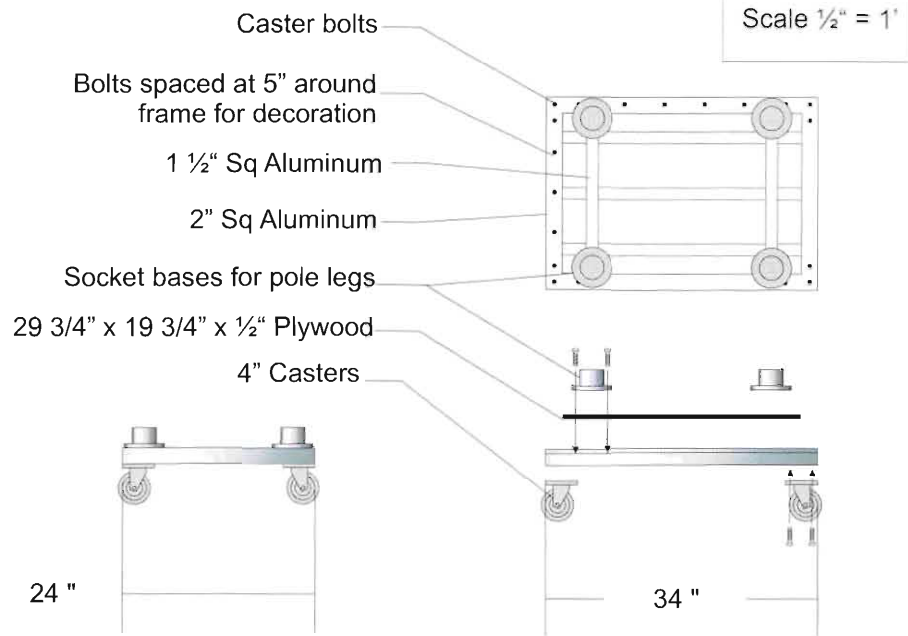


LEGS LOAD SPACE

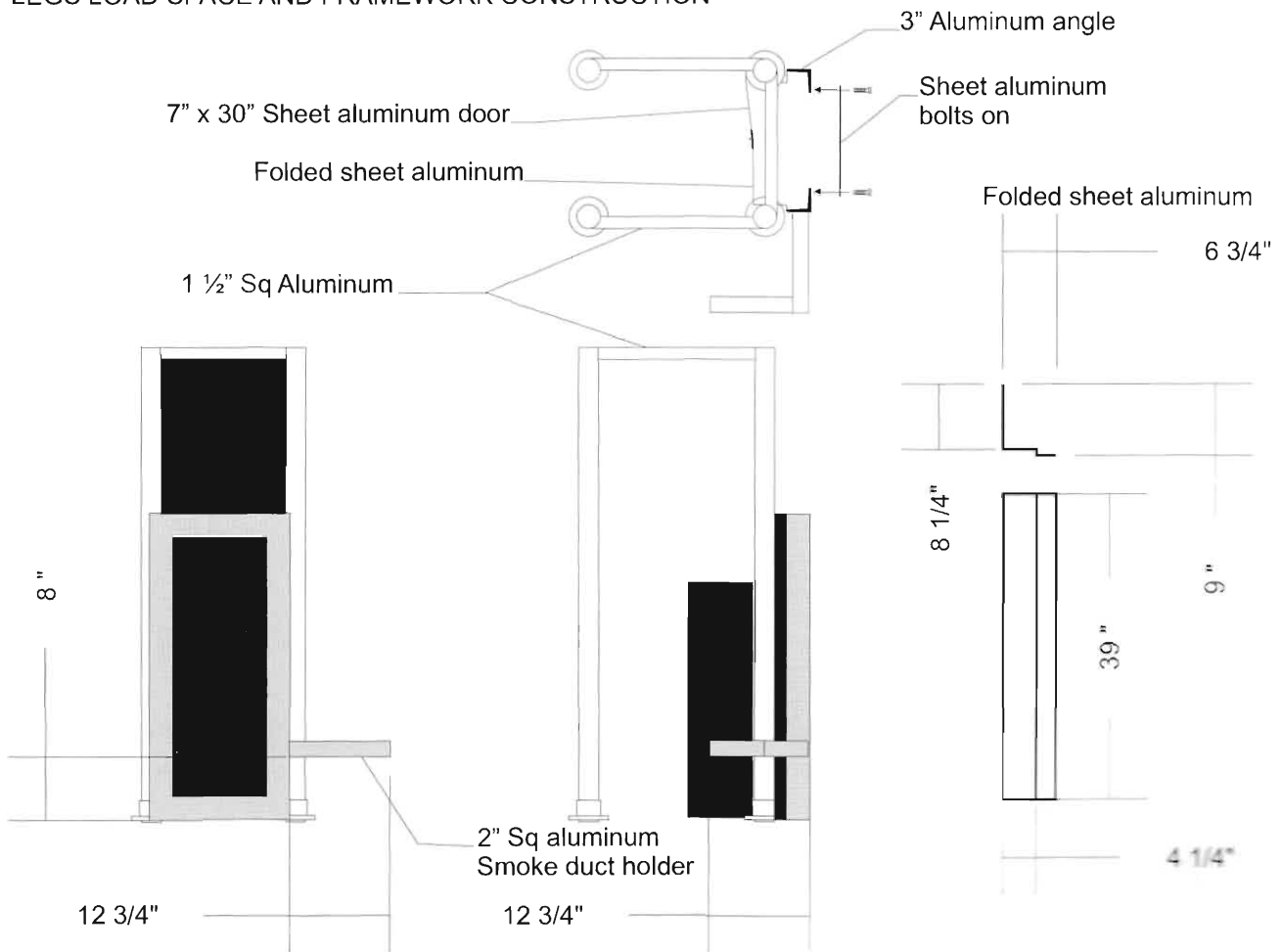


ALIEN ABDUCTION

ROLLING BASE



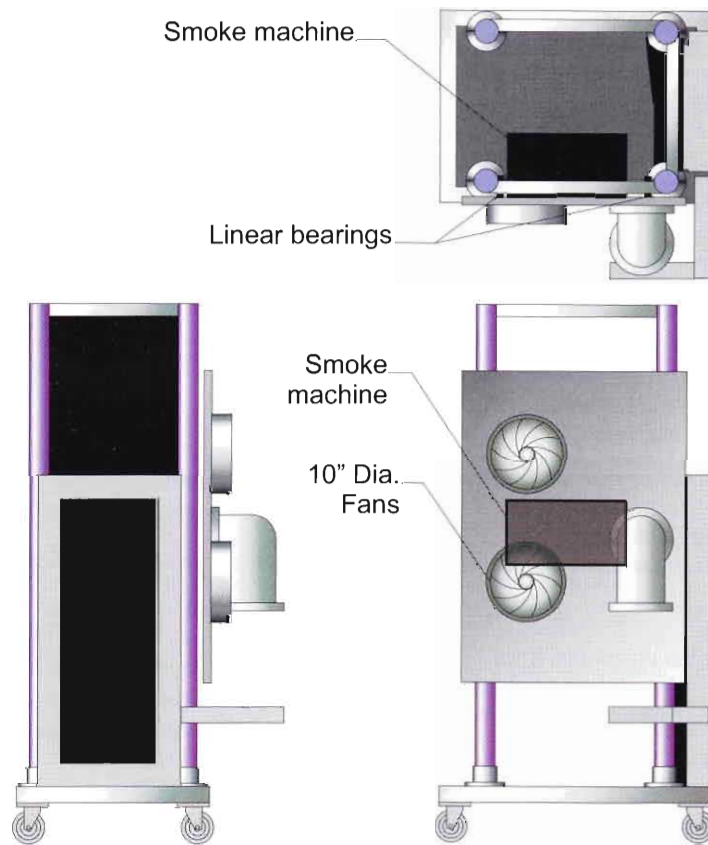
LEGS LOAD SPACE AND FRAMEWORK CONSTRUCTION



ALIEN ABDUCTION

MOVING PANEL

Scale $\frac{1}{2}" = 1'$



NOTES

CONSTRUCTION DRAWINGS

These drawings show some basic dimensions of the illusion.

BASE DETAILS

The base is thicker under the tank and thinner where the lights pole is (10 ½" and 6 ½").

The downstage front edge of the base sticks out further than the back, as this prop is not designed to be spun around. The greater the difference in depth (up and downstage distance) between different levels of the base, the harder it will be for a person to be in a position to see all the thicknesses at one time.

PARTS DESCRIPTION

This diagram shows the names of the parts of the prop I will go into further detail on.

LOWER LEGS

I do not anticipate these legs really taking much weight structurally, however, they serve as a good visual way to conceal more base depth with a meaningful piece of structure.

ROLLING BASE

The plywood on the top of this sets in so it finishes flush with the 2" sq aluminum frame edging. The plywood is covered in black vinyl, wrapped around and stapled to the underside. For artistic purposes only, I designed it to look like the main base step. The design allows the audience to draw the visual conclusion that the other base step must match it (that's the idea anyway!)

SHEET METAL PAN

The pan is folded from a single piece of sheet aluminum, then the ends welded in. The pan is covered in black velvet and bolts to the lower legs and main base step.

MAIN BASE STEP

The plywood on the top and bottom fits in flush with the 2" sq aluminum edge framing. The plywood on top is covered in black vinyl, wrapped around and stapled to the underside. The bottom piece of plywood is covered in black velvet, again, wrapped around and stapled to the topside. I always try to consider one level, or step, of the base to be the 'main step'. This part is actually the table, and the other levels of the base work around this in the design. In this case, it is the secondary legs underneath, the bottom of the lights pole and bottom of the tank.

STAIRS

These were added to visually indicate that this platform or table is used for people to walk onto at one time or another. Although not actually used in the illusion, I felt they helped visually balance against the base as another part of structure in front to add interest.

LIGHTS POLE

The lights on the pole are Par Cans with green gel in them. These could be controlled from a switch on the prop. The design reflects a standard stage lighting tripod and I see the finish on this part being different to the rest of the prop - as if the stand and lights have just been put on the table to illuminate the tank.

MAIN BASE STEP PLYWOOD

This diagram further clarifies how the top deck of plywood on the main step is cut. The hole in the top is shaped for the openings below the lights pole, tank base and the 4" section between the two. The 4" section is a continuation of the lights pole base and is covered in black velvet.

TANK BASE

Although the tank is round, I kept the base square to give more room for the performer. I have drawn this piece being built in bent aluminum flat bar with plywood, although it could also be made entirely in welded aluminum sheet (this would be slightly stronger). The top disc is covered in spandex which is folded over and stapled on the underside.

ALIEN ABDUCTION

TANK

You could either build the tank from a piece of cast acrylic tubing (this can be expensive) or by forming the frame in aluminum and bending a thin piece of plexiglass into it and riveting it into place. The only purpose of the door on the front is for the assistant (dressed as an Alien) to get into the tank before the illusion begins. The rotating roof cover is on a spring mechanism, like a bigger version of a mousetrap or a spring from a spring hinge. The spring is attached around the pivot pin for the roof section. A pin and cable release that runs down to the base releases the roof to pivot open. A fan or fans inside the tank may also be needed to 'blow' the smoke out the top of the tank.

SMOKE UNIT

These drawings show the basic dimensions of the smoke unit

LEGS LOAD SPACE

This shows how the thickness of the load space for the Magician's legs is hidden in the side of the framework. I've added an outside framing piece that holds an arm sticking out to hold the smoke duct, plus the inset black velvet and the pole leg for the total 7" space. The inner door allows the Magician to step in, then the crouching double closes it. A chain bolt latch holds it closed.

ROLLING BASE

The construction is similar to the main prop's rolling base with the plywood being covered in black vinyl.

LEGS LOAD SPACE AND FRAMEWORK CONSTRUCTION

I've shown sheet metal on the outer skin of the load chamber. This metal is covered in black velvet. The folded sheet aluminum piece is also covered in black velvet and bolts to the back of the pole leg. The 3" aluminum angle attaches to this.

MOVING PANEL

The moving panel slides up and down with a smoke machine attached to the back of it. To keep it in the up position, a slide bolt mounted on the back is engaged by the Magician once the panel is slid up. I've indicated on the drawings linear bearings to allow this panel to move. They may be a bit more expensive, but do yourself a favor and spend the money on some good ball bearing guide block and rail. Use 4 guide blocks (one in each corner) and don't use cheap draw slides - you'll look like an idiot if that thing jams on an important show.

FINISHING AND DECORATION

The pole legs have a purple scenic pattern. The tank base and roof has a green scenic pattern. The aluminum is all finished in a sanded or light grinder finish. I would finish the lights pole in a different look such as an anodized aluminum or sandblasted and clear coated aluminum. The hazard tape is just added for decoration. I would attach this to the pole legs with tabs of velcro.

ETC...

Alien Abduction is basically an industrial/space aged theme design for a Smoke Chamber in reverse. I've tried to keep the illusion fairly high tech but not too 'cheesy'. I've seen far too many 'Space age illusions of the 21st century!' that are plywood boxes covered in glitter paper and performed with a bad synthesizer version of 'War of the Worlds' theme in the background. I tried to go less 'Star Wars' and more for a man made research device.

I see this illusion working as either a slight dramatic 'playlet' routine or a comedy bit, with the Alien character being a bit more comical in appearance.

Obviously, a big part of this routine is the costuming. Alien masks can be found online from Halloween suppliers. I imagine the Alien in an all-in-one jumpsuit. For the double, the jumpsuit is covered by a matching jacket and trousers to the Magician. The double also wears an Alien mask, plus a wig matching the Magician's hair and a flesh face mask over the Alien mask (again, Halloween suppliers). The double mask does not need to be too accurate, as during the time the double is on view as the Magician, the tank is doing it's thing with smoke and the vanish, giving a slight misdirection from the double.

FINAL THOUGHTS

I hope you found the illusions and ideas in this book to be of interest. I truly hope I have not caused offence with anything I've written in this book, it was never my intention. I have simply tried to put down my thoughts and opinions.

Some of the illusions in this book may be suitable for home building, however, I feel you should take your project to a professional illusion builder. A good illusion builder (who is used to working from drawings scribbled on the back of a napkin) should have no problem building any of the illusions described.

My wife has been fantastic and very patient with me as I have spent days in the office staring at the computer screen. It has taken much longer to write this book than I thought and was much harder. She has also been a great help in proof reading and trying to make sense of my long and mixed up illusion descriptions.

If you are like me, you'll have probably looked at the story boards first before getting in depth with the plans. I love original illusion ideas and I love watching new things being performed. I sincerely hope the illusions in this book have sparked your imagination. I urge you to try something unique.

There has been a good amount of new material for illusionists produced in the last few years. I think it's very healthy for the art. Some is good and some is bad. Think carefully about what you decide to build.

I see too many Magicians who claim to be performing 'brand new high-tech illusions' and perform Modern Art (published in 1995), Interlude (I first saw Pendragons do this in 1990) and Sub Trunk (Houdini era, enough said!). They are all excellent illusions, but why not try something that is less than 10 years old?

I encourage you to try and be original in your choice of illusions and performance style. There are way too many 'Copper-clones' out there all chasing the trophy that David already holds - they will never get it.

Try and be modern, loose the mullet (even Bon Jovi has cut his hair) and above all be entertaining - that's what it's all about in the end.

Other entertainment art forms have such a wide array of presentation styles (dance, music etc.), yet, magic seems to get stuck in a one dimensional performance style. Look at the other art forms and look for new ways to present your magic.

Although I'm a Brit living in the States, I decided to write this book using American terms. If you are reading this book in the UK (or Europe) I'm sure you already know that Spandex is Lycra; Vinyl is Leatherette; I do know the correct spelling of Aluminium and in the States they wear their pants outside of their shorts.

I have already started working on the next book. Look for it next year. It will feature illusions including 'Russian roulette with cheese'; 'Armadillo from hat'; 'The kitchen sink of death' and 'Chicken soup of doom'.

Good Luck with everything you do.

RESOURCES

The internet is a fabulous tool for research and sourcing items for illusion building. The links below are to various web sites I think are useful.

Tim Clothier - Illusion Projects <i>My web site</i>	www.illusionprojects.com
Splashes Creative Services <i>Las Vegas illusion builder</i>	www.splashescreative.com
Ghost Ride Productions <i>Fake hands and feet, plus a great talking skeleton!</i>	www.ghostride.com
Nightmare Factory <i>Alien costumes, masks and props.</i>	www.nightmarefactory.com
Costumes Inc. <i>Masks, wigs and Costumes</i>	www.costumesinc.com
Manne-King <i>Mannequin bust used in Headz Up</i>	www.manne-king.com
American DJ <i>Fake flame units, smoke machines and cool lights.</i>	www.americandj.com
Alsa Corp. <i>Adhesive backed metal finishes</i>	www.alsacorp.com
Props by IDM <i>Fake CD player for Compact Deception</i>	www.propsbyidm.com
The Amazing Chicane (Wayne Rogers) <i>Inventor and manufacturer of the Appearing Ladder in Trapdoor</i>	www.nzmagic.com
Hobby Tron <i>Radio Controlled Hummer and other 1:6 cars</i>	www.hobbytron.com
The Home Depot <i>Cheap stuff - for mock-ups etc!</i>	www.homedepot.com
William Kennedy	www.wkmagic.com

154. Tim Clothier - Advanced Illusion Projects



The author displaying 'extensive illusion testing' during the writing of this book.

Tim Clothier

www.illusionprojects.com